

THE EARTH IS THE
LORD'S

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THE SAGA OF BHOODAN-GRAMDAN (LAND-GIFT AND VILLAGE-GIFT) MOVEMENT

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To the thousands of donors
who gifted their lands
and
the hundreds of workers
who toiled without any personal gain in sight

the unknown and unsung heroes
of an unfinished revolution

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Foreword

Vinoba's movement carried forward Gandhi's unfinished mission. He picked up Gandhi's broken thread much akin to a weaver continuing to weave without a break. Vinoba undertook to weave the fabric of nonviolent culture from the point where Gandhi had left it. Vinoba did what Gandhi wanted to, but could not.

According to Pyarelal, Gandhiji insisted that the wealthy should be prepared to share their wealth with the have-nots. Vinoba initiated a concerted movement of sharing. Gandhiji wanted to educate the masses to evolve nonviolent methods of solving their problems. Gandhiji's yearning came to be satisfied by Vinoba. Vinoba tried to solve the land problem, and other problems as well, through the power of love and goodwill. He demonstrated nonviolence of the brave. Pyarelal says, Gandhiji knew that the programme of developing nonviolence of the brave would not be as attractive as the fight against the British. Vinoba conducted such 'unattractive' programme across the subcontinent for full two decades. He marched ahead with a small band of workers which he could mobilise in this unglamorous mission. He motivated around 10,000 workers to continue trekking for two decades.

Jayaprakash Narayan has rightly said that had Vinoba not come on the scene, we would have forgotten the idea of nonviolent revolution, and the ideology of Sarvodaya would have become a distant and hazy ideal. Vinoba's movement took ahead Gandhi's thought of nonviolent revolution, of radical social transformation.

The saga of this historical movement has been presented with lucidity and authenticity in Parag Cholkar's book. It is the fruit of tireless labours, deep scholarship, penetrating analysis, broad perspective and clarity in understanding. A comprehensive account of this great revolutionary movement was not available

up till now. Now an authentic document has taken shape through Parag's efforts. For this, he fully deserves our praise and gratitude.

It is not merely a piece of documentation. Everything has been put in a broad perspective. In the beginning, the genesis and the history of the land problem have been reviewed. While giving some eye-opener information about the land rights, it tellingly tells how India was enslaved. In this background, we can view in the proper perspective the freedom movement led by Gandhi, and Vinoba's movement for second Independence.

When Vinoba initiated the bhoodan movement in 1951, several forces had pounced upon the farmers and village communities were breaking up. The country had become Independent, but the villages had continued to be subjugated. Vinoba embarked on a fight for their freedom. Parag has given a thrilling account of the genesis and progress of this unique movement in detail.

In the words of Jayaprakashji, Vinoba made an extraordinary attempt to instil spiritual values in the social fabric of Indian society through the programmes of Bhoodan and Gramdan. Vinoba's movement was a stupendous effort for moulding human beings and for a humane revolution.

Hundreds of thousands of individuals voluntarily donated hundreds of thousands of acres of land for distribution to the landless. Incredible as it may sound, it is incontrovertible that 2.5 million acres were distributed among the poor, the deprived and the oppressed, enabling them to earn their bread with self-respect.

When the programme of Gramdan began, it was such that we find it difficult today to believe that such a programme could be imagined and actually implemented, at least to some extent. Initially, the idea was to transfer the ownership of the land in the village to the gram-sabha (village assembly), to be followed by its equal distribution, treating the village as a family-unit. Such distribution actually took place in a number of villages. It was nothing short of a miracle—a resounding testimony to the

power of love and nonviolence. Vinoba had said that he had a vision of the Lord in those villages.

Parag has done a significant work in preparing an authentic and detailed document on this novel revolution. It presents before us a clear picture of the movement in totality. It answers many questions and dispels many doubts.

Parag has forcefully argued that Gramdan is still relevant. The last chapter is worth going through in this connection. The world is becoming one today. But the present globalisation is only a facade for turning the world into a global market. We do not want world market; we want the world to become one family. For this purpose, society would have to be re-ordered in accordance with Gandhi's concept of oceanic circles. Vinoba's movement gave a glimpse of such an order. A wholly perfect and desirable world order can stand only on the foundation of Gram-Swaraj (village self-rule).

Parag has produced an invaluable document of the Herculean effort undertaken through an unprecedented people's movement for giving shape to this order. Gandhian social activists will find it inspiring and illuminating.

— Kanti Shah

(Abridged and translated by the author from the foreword to the Hindi original)

Preface

Bhoodan-Gramdan Movement is a precious chapter, not only in the history of Independent India, but also in the history of modern world. Never and nowhere in the recorded history has land been collected for the landless on such a massive scale through nothing but moral suasion. There is no record of a bigger and better non-governmental and nonviolent endeavour for the solution of a serious and pressing, yet intricate problem. This endeavour was all the more valuable, because it sought to empower people to solve their problems rather than claiming and posing to solve those problems. This empowerment was meant to initiate radical social transformation.

In the year 2000, on the eve of the golden jubilee year of the Bhoodan Movement, Sarva Seva Sangh proposed that a history of the Movement be published to mark the occasion. I was entrusted with the responsibility of writing the history under the guidance of Kantibhai Shah.

It was near to impossible to complete the task till 2001, but I am also guilty of letting it linger on under various pretexts, some genuine and some false.

In 2008, I was invited by the Gujarat Vidyapith (Ahmedabad), a premier educational institute founded by Mahatma Gandhi, to work as a Visiting Fellow in Vinoba Studies. This presented an opportunity to pursue this work with undivided attention. The Vidyapith gave me full freedom and provided a congenial environment to make my short stay of seven and a half months fruitful. Major part of actual writing was done at the Vidyapith. I am deeply indebted to Narayanbhai Desai, Chancellor of the Vidyapith; Sudarshan Iyengar, Vice-Chancellor of the Vidyapith and their colleagues, particularly at the library and the Peace Research department. I am also grateful to the Vidyapith for publishing the voluminous tome of around 1,000 pages in 3 volumes under the title, 'Sabai bhoomi

Gopal ki' in Hindi. The present book is an abridged version of that book in English.

I am aware that this book is an elementary attempt; it is far from being a comprehensive and definitive history. Much more needs to be done to have such history, which the nation-wide Movement eminently deserves. It calls for teamwork rather than an individual effort. I am acutely aware of what should have, but could not be done by me, and entertain the hope that the book serves to generate interest in the Movement and is followed by more extensive and deeper research.

Without the support of the Vidyapith, the book might not have seen the light of day. I am obliged to them and also to Sarva Seva Sangh for initiating and helping the project. Thanks are also due to Gandhi Seva Sangh (Sevagram), Vinoba Vihar Kendra (Nagpur), Brahma Vidya Mandir and Paramdham Prakashan (Pavnar, Wardha), Sabarmati Ashram (Ahmedabad), Gokhale Institute of Politics and Economics (Pune), Swami Ramananda Tirtha Research Institute (Aurangabad), Nehru Memorial Museum and Library (New Delhi), and also to Balvijay, Gautam Bajaj, Vijay Diwan, Kanakmal Gandhi, Ranjit Desai, Shail Chowhan and many others for letting me have access to the source material in their possession. I have also been benefited from the information and insights provided by Kantibhai Shah, Sarvanarayan Das, Vasant Palshikar and many other workers in the Movement. (Unfortunately, some of them are not alive to see the publication of the English version.) Needless to say, I am solely responsible for the opinions expressed herein and also for the deficiencies in this book.

In the end, I would also like to thank Maharashtra Knowledge Corporation Ltd, Pune for arranging copy-editing of the English version and Paramdham Prakashan (Pavnar, Wardha) and Vidarbha Bhodan-Gramdan Sahayog Samiti for undertaking its publication.

— **Parag Cholkar**

PART ONE
An Overview

1. The Background

30 January, 1948. It was a fateful day, not only in the history of India, but also in the history of the world. Mahatma Gandhi, the apostle of nonviolence, was shot at from point-blank range as he proceeded to his evening prayer meeting at Birla House, Delhi. Hands raised to greet his assassin and the words '*Hey Ram*' on his lips, he fell to the ground. The prophet of nonviolence fell a victim to the forces of violence. When the newly-won Independence was not even six months old, the supreme leader of the freedom movement had met with a violent death.

It was as if an era had come to an end. Gandhi was not just a national leader—a leader of the freedom movement of a particular country. For the first time in the recorded history he had showed a novel way for revolutionary social transformation through nonviolent means. It was under his leadership that a country had fought the mighty British imperialist power with nonviolence and had won Independence. But it was not just transfer of political power which he sought; he wanted to create a new man, a new society, a new world in which love would reign supreme. And he had not only showed a way, but had also taken a few steps towards the goal. That journey was abruptly halted by three bullets. India was plunged into shock and grief.

The country was facing numerous problems. The imperialist exploitation and oppression for decades had broken the back of the country. Fighting the British was, in a way, a simple and primary step. The real fight had to start now—fight with ignorance, poverty and injustice. And the man who would have led this fight was no more. The general had been killed even before the commencement of war, leaving behind his army and the people at large in utter confusion and disarray.

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Gandhi had sketched an outline of the kind of swaraj that he wanted for India in his booklet 'Hind-Swaraj' in 1909. He did not merely want freedom for a particular country or merely a change in the colour of the skin of political masters; he wanted an end to slavery everywhere and in all its forms. This implied self-reliance. For him, self-government meant 'continuous effort to be independent of government control, whether it is foreign government or whether it is national.'¹ However, as he conceded in 1921 while referring to 'Hind-swaraj', his corporate activity was "undoubtedly devoted to the attainment of Parliamentary Swaraj in accordance with the wishes of the people of India."² Now that it had been attained, time had come to work for real 'Hind-swaraj' which was the 'consummation devoutly to be wished'.³

Moreover, the Indian experiment in collective non-violence had attracted the world's attention. The potentialities in nonviolence for conflict-resolution needed to be explored and demonstrated before the world, which was shaken by the terrifying violence in the World Wars.

Gandhi had long back put forth 18-point Constructive Programme for social reconstruction of India. For him, it was the 'truthful and non-violent way of winning Poorna Swaraj (complete Independence)'.⁴ These programmes were intended to remove the inertia, sloth and ignorance of the people, to conscientize and enlighten them, to motivate them to stand on their own feet and work with mutual co-operation, and to organise and empower them. These programmes were Gandhi's instruments for building alternative social, economic and political structures. He had also created all-India organisations for carrying out those programmes.

It had been Gandhi's refrain that those engaged in constructive work should not take part in politics. In 1937, he did advocate an opposite line,⁵ when office-acceptance by the Indian National Congress in some provinces, where it had gained majorities in the recently-held elections, had become a controversial issue. But he soon retraced his step, conceding that the experiment had failed. Till the end, it remained his firm conviction that constructive work must be kept separate from

politics, both from practical as well as ideological reasons.

During his incarceration in 1942, Gandhi deeply felt the need for reorientation, revitalization and integration of constructive programmes so that they could withstand the kind of onslaught they had to face during the 'Quit India' movement (and were found wanting) and play their proper role. After release from the prison, he took initiative to give radical reorientation to the All-India Spinners Association. But it did not make much headway. The communal holocaust preceding and accompanying the Partition of the country presented such a challenge that all the energies had to be directed towards it. The flames of communal violence subsided only after the sacrifice of Gandhi's life.

Even when he was engaged in dousing the fires of communal violence, constructive work was on his mind. A conference was proposed in February 1948 at Sevagram to think over the role and nature of constructive work in Independent India, and Gandhi was to reach Sevagram on 3 February for this purpose. But 30 January was to be the last day of his life.

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Gandhi's choice of Vinoba Bhave as the first satyagrahi in the Individual Satyagraha campaign in 1940 brought Vinoba in the limelight for the first time. Vinoba had come to Gandhi in 1916 at the age of 21. A patriotic youth with spiritual yearning, Vinoba was a genius in the true sense of the term. After coming to Gandhi he devoted the best years of his life to the experiments in constructive work which was, for him, a means in the spiritual quest. Concerned with everything having bearing on the advancement of the individual and the society, he had carved a niche for himself in the realm of constructive work and village-service. No wonder, he was being looked upon as Gandhi's heir in this realm.

In an informal meeting attended by leading Gandhians including Kishorlal Mashruwala, Appa Patwardhan, Shrikrishnadas Jajoo, Raghunath Dhotre and Vinoba himself, a day or two after Gandhi's death, Jajoo told Vinoba that they

were all looking up to Vinoba for guidance and leadership. Vinoba said,

“My services are always available to you. But although I have been keeping an eye on the events in the country, I do not have enough acquaintance with the workers. In this situation, I would do whatever is possible for me.”⁶

He neither desired leadership nor considered himself ready to shoulder the burden of leadership. It was necessary that he got to know the people and the people got to know him.

For Vinoba, Gandhi's death was a challenge to non-violence, whose dynamic and powerful forms needed to be discovered, for violence could be vanquished by nonviolence alone. This necessitated introspection and continuous effort to purify one's life. He also stressed renewed efforts to serve the villages. This, he hoped, would show the way forward.

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With Gandhi gone, what should the constructive workers do? What should be their role and the nature of constructive work in the changed situation? Should the constructive work institutions work together or should they be merged together into a single entity to make them more effective? How should be the relations of Gandhian constructive workers with the government led by their former colleagues, who were no more wedded to nonviolence? Was a new organisation necessary to work for nonviolent social change that Gandhi envisioned? The questions before Gandhi's men were many. It was decided to meet at Sevagram between 13 and 15 March 1948.

Around 500 workers along with Prime Minister Pandit Nehru and Deputy Prime Minister Vallabhbhai Patel were invited. Nehru attended for a day, while Patel could not make it due to indisposition. The Conference was attended by most of the leading lights in the field of constructive work, including Dr. Rajendra Prasad, Maulana Azad, Vinoba, J.C. Kumarappa, Kishorlal Mashruwala, Kaka Kalelkar, E.W. Aryanayakam, Ashadevi Aryanayakam, Pyarelal, Shankarrao Deo, P.C. Ghosh, Shrikrishnadas Jajoo, Dr. Zakir Hussain, J.B. Kripalani, Devdas

Gandhi, Bibi Amtus Salam, Thakkar Bappa and Jayaprakash Narayan.

Different organisations dedicated to different constructive programmes had been working in their respective fields. It was Gandhi who was a link between them. Gandhi's view was holistic, but these organisations did not necessarily share it, at least in practice. It was a challenge to redesign their set-up in order to bring out the revolutionary dimensions of constructive work. It was a still bigger challenge to organise those who believed in Gandhi's vision and were dedicated to nonviolence in all its aspects. Everyone present felt the need for such an organisation; it was about its form that opinions differed. Vinoba stood for an organisation without membership, control and discipline—a fraternity rather than an organisation. That, in his view, was how a truly nonviolent organisation should be.

No wonder, his idea was opposed by some workers. However, ultimately it prevailed. It was decided to establish 'Sarvodaya Samaj' in keeping with Vinoba's line of thought. The term 'Samaj' was preferred over the term 'Sangh', which connoted a limited group. The term 'Sarvodaya' had been used by Gandhi as the title to his paraphrase of Ruskin's book 'Unto this last'. Sarvodaya means rise of all irrespective of any differences. The programmes specified for Sarvodaya Samaj included Gandhi's constructive programmes with a few variations.⁷

The workers apprised Prime Minister Nehru of their expectations from the government about some issues. But Nehru gave no concrete promise. He conceded that 'his thinking was not clear about those issues'⁸—and apparently he had no time or even inclination to pay attention to them. He said that industrialisation 'to at least some extent' would be necessary for the security of the country. On the whole, it became fully clear that he saw little role for Gandhi's constructive programmes in the project of national reconstruction that he was going to embark upon, and was influenced by the 'modern' thinking. Of course, he had frequently made known his differences with Gandhi during the latter's lifetime. Gandhi's work had little

space on the agenda of the Government of India, which owed its position in no small measure to Gandhi.

Vinoba, however, did not like articulating any expectations before the representative of the government in this manner. He rather wanted to know what the government expected from the constructive workers in that hour of crisis. Rather than seeking aid from the government, he wanted Gandhi's men to aid the government and advance their revolutionary work mainly on its own steam.

The establishment of 'Sarvodaya Samaj' was historical in many respects. After the demise of a great man, his followers normally found sects in his name. In this Conference too, some workers wanted to have Gandhi's name associated with the new organisation, but ultimately they fell in line. Gandhi had said that 'organisation is the test of nonviolence'. 'Sarvodaya Samaj' was an attempt to create a nonviolent organisation.

Steps were soon initiated for the amalgamation of constructive work organisations. Representatives of 11 organisations met at Mumbai on 27 April 1948 and resolved to form 'All-India Sarva Seva Sangh' as an umbrella organisation for 10 organisations, viz A.I. Spinners Association, A.I. Village Industries Association, Hindustani Talimi Sangh, Go-seva Sangh, Harijan Sevak Sangh, Hindustani Prachar Sabha, Navajivan, Nature Cure Trust, Paschim Bharat Adivasi Karyakarta Sangh and Hindustani Mazdoor Sangh. On 14-15 November, the constitution of the Sangh was prepared and a 15-member committee was appointed. It was decided that the Sangh would give advice to constituent organisations and organise Sarvodaya conferences.

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Partition of the country had displaced millions. It was a shocking spectacle of the degradation brought about by communal bigotry. Rehabilitation of the refugees had to be the first item on the national agenda. The Sevagram Conference was aware of the seriousness of this problem and had made an appeal for taking up rehabilitation work. Vinoba had offered

help to Nehru in this task. In this connection, he reached Delhi with a few fellow-workers on 30 March 1948.

Vinoba and his team worked tirelessly for the refugees. Vinoba put emphasis on the self-sufficiency of refugee camps as regards basic needs, but red tape frustrated his initiatives. He worked a lot among the Meos, whose problem was peculiar. The Muslim Meos had migrated to Pakistan after Partition; but being basically a farmer community with attachment to their lands, they had come back. However, their homes and lands had in the meantime been occupied by refugees from Pakistan. Their restoration to the Meos was a tricky and sensitive problem beset with the possibility of communal flare-ups. But Vinoba made this possible. This was a creditable achievement. However, his experience led him to conclude that such relief work could not become the starting point of nonviolent revolution, of the establishment of Sarvodaya society.

Many landowners had come to India as refugees. The government's policy was to give them land in proportion to the land they had owned. Vinoba proposed that some land be given to the displaced landless labourers also, particularly Dalits. He suggested to Dr. Gopichand Bhargava, the Chief Minister of Punjab, that allotment of land to the bigger landowners be reduced by 5% and the landless be given 2 acres each. The government accepted this in principle, but later backed out. When satyagraha was contemplated in this regard, Vinoba advised against it, in view of the delicate situation in the country. But, as he later said, "I could not so easily dismiss the matter from my mind; deep down, there was an urge that some way must be found of letting the landless have some land."⁹

Vinoba subsequently toured North India. It was a sort of 'pilgrimage for peace' in the atmosphere vitiated by communal passions. He visited the famous Ajmer dargah, where Muslims welcomed him with great affection. It was the first time in the history of the dargah that a non-Muslim conducted prayers and led *khutba-e-namaj*.¹⁰

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The first Sarvodaya Samaj Conference was held in March 1949 at Rau in Central India under the chairmanship of Dr. Rajendra Prasad. The memorandum and byelaws of Sarva Seva Sangh were approved.

A fund named Gandhi Memorial Fund (Gandhi Smarak Nidhi) was being set up in Gandhi's memory. Vinoba believed that no amount of money could keep alive Gandhi's memory; what was required was to follow his principles. But he did not openly oppose the move.

His 'Pilgrimage for Peace' in North India also did not suggest to Vinoba anything that could serve as the starting point for nonviolent social change. But his work for communal amity did attract attention, including that of the national leaders. Hyderabad state had been freed from the clutches of Nizam in September 1948 through Police Action. Muslims were demoralized and were bearing the brunt of the reaction in the Hindus, who had been oppressed for decades by the Muslim rulers and had been tyrannized in the recent past by fanatic Razakars opposed to Hyderabad's accession to India. Governor-General C. Rajagopalachari suggested to the Home Minister Patel that Vinoba be requested to tour the state to create communal goodwill.¹¹ Vinoba toured Hyderabad state in March-April 1949, appealing to the people to bury the past.

The monthly journal 'Sarvodaya', started for propagation of Gandhi's thoughts in 1938, had ceased publication during 1942 movement. It was decided to restart it as the mouthpiece of Sarva Seva Sangh, and Vinoba was persuaded to become its editor. Vinoba accepted the responsibility, but made it abundantly clear that

"Some people regard me as a representative of Gandhi's ideology. But nothing can be more erroneous. I have indeed learnt much from him, but I have learnt from others also, and have accepted the thoughts which appealed to me. So, I am a man with my own thoughts."¹²

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The Congress government was rapidly moving away from

what Gandhi stood for. In fact, many constructive work organisations had been formed by the Congress party's resolutions or with its active backing, although constructive work had kept itself away from politics. It was a natural expectation that the government would actively help it. However, Congress had never accepted Gandhi, the thinker; it had accepted Gandhi, the political leader, as that was the need of the time. Shankarrao Deo, General Secretary of A.I.C.C. was committed to constructive work and tried in his own way, but the party had little interest in it. While token material help was being offered, the government felt no need to seek the views of constructive workers in formulating policies. It was happily emulating the Western model.

How far had it moved away from the philosophy of constructive work was demonstrated by the issue of vegetable *ghee* (hydrogenated oil). Go-seva Sangh had strongly objected to the production of so-called '*ghee*' by hydrogenation of vegetable oils, which was harmful to health and provided unhealthy competition to pure *ghee*. At its instance, Congress Working Committee recommended, with overwhelming majority, that this '*ghee*' be coloured to distinguish it from pure *ghee* and no new licences be issued for its production. But the government vehemently opposed this proposal. After a fruitless meeting at Delhi at the Government secretariat in this connection, Vinoba declared, "This is not my place. My place is among the people. I have come for the first time in the Secretariat, and it may be taken as the last time."¹³ Government's adamant stand forced even a gentle personality like Kishorlal Mashruwala, a leading Gandhian thinker, to write, "This incidence shows that there is only a facade of democracy. This government does not represent the principles of that Congress in whose name it is ruling."¹⁴

The idea of planning for development was in the air. In December 1949, 200 constructive workers met in Sarvodaya Economic Conference, deliberated on the Sarvodaya Plan and aired their views. But the government paid no heed to them.

The World Peace Conference was held at Sevagram in December 1949. Inaugurating it, Vinoba emphasised the need for

service and said that the true form of nonviolence was constructive work for the service of humanity.¹⁵

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The term 'Sarvodaya' represented the essence of the Gandhian philosophy. But its different aspects and implications needed to be explained to the people. An objection had been raised at the Sevagram Conference (1948) that the term was not intelligible to the masses, whereupon Vinoba had said that the terms signifying particular meanings could be difficult, but then

"I get the opportunity to reach the heart of the masses to explain them.- - - It will certainly be objectionable if I use difficult words while explaining them. But I will use such words as can be easily understood by the people."¹⁶

Vinoba therefore set out to explain the word and unfold its meanings and potentialities.

In Rau (8 March 1949), he said,

"Sarvodaya is a word so full of meaning that the more we reflect on it and put in practice, the more would we understand it. Its meaning would not be intelligible at the outset; it would gradually unfold before us. But one thing is clear. As God has created this world, it cannot be His intention that interests of one should clash with those of the other. No father wants that the interests of his children should be antagonistic to each other. There can be differences of opinion; such differences are, in fact, necessary to arrive at the truth. But there should not be conflict between interests."¹⁷

When interests are in harmony, it is obvious that caring for each other would be beneficial to all. One's welfare lies in the welfare of others. Imagining conflict between the interests of different people and aiming for 'greatest good of the greatest number' is senseless. Sarvodaya thus directly refutes the doctrine of utilitarianism. It proclaims faith in the unity of life and is, therefore, bound to work for strengthening this unity and to oppose anything that incites divisions and dissensions.

Vinoba put it this way:

“The philosophy of Sarvodaya is, on the whole, harmonising and synthesising. Syncretism is an integral part of the Indian culture and civilisation. It can reach its logical end through Sarvodaya. Sarvodaya cannot be in opposition to anyone. But it is certainly opposed to all those who seek the good of a particular caste or class and believe that some people should have pre-eminence and should hold power, to the exclusion of others.”¹⁸

Merely verbal propagation of thoughts would serve no purpose. It was necessary to do something concrete on the ground. After returning to his Pavnar ashram in January 1950, Vinoba started the *Kanchan-mukti* (freedom from money) experiment, for he believed that money was the root cause of much of the pollution in social life and needed to be completely eradicated from human intercourse.¹⁹

Rishi-kheti (farming like the sages of the yore: working with the hands only, without taking help from machinery and even the bullocks) was a part of this experiment. The intention was to ascertain how much land did a farmer need to attain self-sufficiency. The outcome of this experiment was encouraging although it did test the mettle of the participants. For Vinoba, this experiment had great significance:

“This experiment offers a partial solution to the problem of unemployment. It can be used by farmers who lack inputs and means for farming. It gives scope for intensive and thoughtful experiments in agriculture; and it is a boon for *nai talim*.²⁰ It also incorporates the far-sighted vision of nonviolence.”²¹

Being engaged in this experiment, Vinoba did not attend the Second Sarvodaya Samaj Conference, held at Anugul in Odisha in April 1950. Presided over by Kaka Kalelkar, it was attended by about 1,000 workers. Workers engaged in different constructive programmes like khadi, village industries, basic education, cow-service etc. met separately at the venue. Wide-ranging discussions, however, failed in evolving any concrete programme. Workers, particularly the younger ones, expressed their dissatisfaction for not getting expected guidance. Need for

a strong organisation was felt, and strengthening of Sarva Seva Sangh was discussed in this connection.²²

There was not yet clarity about the exact nature of Sarvodaya Samaj and Sarva Seva Sangh, and their respective roles. Vinoba wrote in 'Sarvodaya' with reference to the discussions at Anugul:

"Sarvodaya Samaj is an ideological fraternity while Sarva Seva Sangh is an all-India organisation of experts for planning and execution (of work). It is supposed to advise and help those belonging to the Sarvodaya Samaj. It is an organisation, but of a different type. It is not an organisation of men, but of work. It will organise Sarvodaya *melas* (congregations), coordinate the work of Charkha Sangh (A.I. Spinners Association), Gramodyog Sangh (A.I. Village Industries Association), Talimi Sangh etc., publish literature, and do many more kinds of work. It will not be associated with any political party. This is my idea in this regard."²³

The first general election in Independent India was around the corner. Sarva Seva Sangh, in its meeting on the 11-12 October 1950, resolved that 'no office-bearer and full-time worker—both paid and honorary—will stand for any elective post in a political party or government machinery, nor will they accept any post without election and will not take active part in an election campaign.'²⁴ Obviously, there was no bar for supporting any political party, or even for becoming its ordinary member.

Formalities for merger of different constructive work organisations were meanwhile being pursued.

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It was decided to hold the third Sarvodaya Conference at Shivarampalli in Hyderabad state in April 1951. Vinoba, being engaged in the *Kanchan-mukti* experiment, was not inclined to attend it. However, he was prevailed upon to change his mind. Vinoba consented to attend, but declared that he would go on foot.

The idea of *Kanchan-mukti* did imply that no expense should be incurred on travel. Vinoba's decision was prompted by many other factors also. It was a result of deep reflection. He believed that only a walking tour could acquaint him with the ground reality in the country, and the message of Sarvodaya could be conveyed to the masses only through direct contact with them.²⁵ In his first address to the Conference, he explained his position further:

"I have been vigorously thinking about how we should advance, what path we should take after achieving Independence, particularly after Gandhiji's departure. I travelled by train, but kept on thinking whether such travel could give a momentum to nonviolence. Was it conducive to the social change that we wanted to bring about? How was the railway conceived and developed, wherefrom the money for our travel came—all these thoughts would also come to my mind. Could such speedy means of travel, which gave little scope to serious thinking, be useful for propagation of nonviolence? Could we ever reach the masses through such means? All these thoughts would come to my mind."²⁶

In fact, Vinoba's health did not permit a walking tour. He suffered from stomach ulcers. His colleagues were, naturally, worried by his decision. But Vinoba was firm on it.

On 8 March 1951, Vinoba set out on foot from Pavnar. He perhaps had an intuition that it was going to be a long march. Perhaps he was ready for self-sacrifice, for he was going to an area where there was every likelihood of facing danger. Telangana, the region wherein Shivarampalli was situated, had recently witnessed armed revolt by Communist insurgents. They had hoped to make it the starting point of the Indian Communist revolution—Telengana was to be its Yenana. And although the revolt had been crushed by the army, the situation was far from normal. In the meeting at Wardha, Vinoba said, "I am leaving today. I do not know when I would come back. Who can say whether I will come back or not?"²⁷

2. The Land Problem: History and Nature

The land problem was decidedly one of the most serious and complex problems faced by Independent India which needed urgent attention. In fact, it was a major problem in almost all the countries which had gained Independence after the Second World War. Gunnar Myrdal had rightly said, “The struggle for long-term economic development in South Asia will be won or lost in agriculture.”¹ And this was inextricably linked to unequal distribution of land. It was also necessary for the advance of the newly-Independent countries towards social and economic freedom. Different countries were adopting different methods for this. India too had to grapple with this problem in her own way.

Centuries of slavery, particularly under British colonialism, had destroyed the traditional land and social system. Therein lay the roots of the problem.

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There are bound to be different opinions about the rights of the State and the peasant over land in ancient India, because of the often conflicting evidence. But it can safely be said that the modern concept of private ownership of land was non-existent at that time. Peasants worked on their lands and paid a portion of the produce to the State as tax. Traditional rights of peasants were never tampered with by the State. According to Manu, the King was the ‘lord paramount of the soil’², but “his ultimate ownership consists in his reversionary right to the property of all private owners who die without lawful heirs” and subject to these rights of overlordship, the people could acquire rights through different lawful methods.³ The Mimamsa mentions that in a Visvajit sacrifice, a king has to give away all his belongings. The natural question is, ‘What a man can legally give as his own?’ Jaimini says that a king cannot give land, for it belongs equally to all. Shabarswami explains that ‘land is not

to be given, because men are found enjoying lordship over fields, and not over the whole earth' and that the paramountcy of the king only means that "by virtue of his protecting the rice and other crops that grow on the earth, he is entitled to a share of them as his remuneration, but not to the lordship to the soil."⁴ Madhavacharya holds that all the living creatures have right over land.⁵ In fact, the earth was looked upon as the mother; claiming ownership over it was sacrilegious. The peasant did have some rights, but they were only to ensure that he got due return for his labour.

The peasant's rights were linked to his membership of the village community. It was the responsibility of the village community to pay revenue on the village lands to the State and recover the share of each peasant, based on his production. This responsibility and the power that emanated from it were the backbone of the village community. Land could not be transferred without the permission of the village community. A.S. Altekar notes, "It is interesting to note that in the Vedic age even the king was permitted to gift a piece of land only when the adjacent residents agreed to the proposal."⁶

Everyone who contributed to the village's communal life was entitled to a specific share of the agricultural produce. The king also discharged a function (of protecting the people and dispensing justice), and therefore was entitled to a fixed share. He could 'donate' (transfer) his right, not the land. There is evidence that in some villages at least, agricultural produce used to be equitably shared by all; and in some villages, even the land used to be redistributed periodically. There was thus no question of the sale of land.

Different Smritis (bodies of the traditional law) give different figures of the king's share, that is, the portion of the agricultural produce which the king can claim as the land tax. It appears that the rate varied depending on the conditions, and it was normally one-twelfth. And this was, as has been asserted, the portion not of the gross produce, but that of the surplus.⁷ The land tax was fixed at one-sixth of the share by Kautilya in the Maurya period.⁸

The tax was a part of the produce, independent of the area of land, and was not to be paid in cash. Non-payment did invite punishment; but, as Altekar notes, the Smritis nowhere refer to the State's right to confiscate the land.⁹

On the whole, the State could not claim more than its fair share in the agricultural production, and everyone had stake in the prosperity of the peasant.

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This situation changed in the Middle Ages. Muslim conquests brought with them an alien concept of sovereignty of State over the soil. A pyramid-like feudal structure with intermediaries like the zamindars and the jagirdars emerged. The land tax was greatly enhanced to half or even more of the produce.¹⁰ This was bound to result in the exploitation and oppression of peasants. However, Muslim rulers appear to have struck a compromise with the traditional land system. Azizul Huque claims that Mughal emperors had to purchase land for their needs, which means that they were not sovereign owners. He quotes Ghulam Hosain Khan, a renowned historian: When asked why Mughal emperors had to purchase land, he had said, "The Emperor is proprietor of the revenue; he is not proprietor of the soil. He is entitled to revenue only"¹¹

Irfan Habib has quoted a Muslim jurist, c. 1745,

"I assert that some of the acts and measures of the (past) kings show that this land of India is the Estate of the Treasury, owing to certain reasons. First, the established custom of kings, past and present, in most territories is that they take half the produce from the subjects, and by other cesses and imposts take (something) out of the other half as well. If we regard this as exaction of the (legal) tax, the king will have to be held at fault for it is unlawful to take in tax more than half of the produce, as we have mentioned. - - - Thus the exacted produce is really not tax, but rent. - - - Secondly, it is established of old that - - - tax is demanded from the cultivators - - - the demand for it is not made on the zamindars. From this it is clear that the zamindars are not the proprietors. - - - Since the peasant cultivators do not

lay claim to the ownership of the tilled land, the land must be the Estate of the Treasury. - - - Thus the produce taken from the cultivated land of the peasants is rent, not tax.”¹²

The logic is interesting. More than permissible portion of the produce is demanded, and on that ground sovereignty over soil is asserted!

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The British came from a very different milieu. Neither had they any understanding of the land system and social structure here, nor were they interested in a healthy land system; they were here to fleece India as much as possible. This naturally resulted in appalling exploitation of peasants and destruction of indigenous industries.

The Britishers, Henry Maine opines, inherited from their Muslim predecessors the idea that “all the soil belonged in absolute property to the sovereign, and that all private property in land existed by his sufferance.”¹³ The idea was not alien in their land, and it also suited them.

The Britishers’ greed was insatiable. They steeply enhanced land tax. It was no longer land tax, it was land revenue. This revenue was now payable not on the produce, as was the earlier practice; it was payable on the land-holding; as such it was payable even when crops failed. And it had to be paid in cash, not in kind, as was the earlier practice. If not paid, it would be mercilessly extracted, using all kinds of means.

The East India Company took over administration of Bengal in 1769-70, and within a few years the province witnessed terrible famine wherein, according to government’s figures, almost one-third population perished. But there was no laxity in extraction of revenue which was, in fact, further enhanced. “Notwithstanding the loss of at least one third of the inhabitants of the province, and the consequent decrease of the cultivation, the nett collections of the year 1771 exceeded even those of 1768”, wrote Warren Hastings to the Company’s Court of Directors on 3 November 1772, patting himself on the back.¹⁴ Hastings started auctioning of the revenue demand, whereby

unscrupulous elements with no attachment to land came on the scene. They squeezed the peasants even more. Muslim rulers also claimed an enormous land tax; but they do not appear to have fully realised it, while the British rulers realised with rigour what they claimed.

The spread of the Company's tentacles marked the spread of famines as well, each one as terrible, if not more, as the previous one. Still the tyranny for revenue-collection did not subside. And how was the revenue collected? The facts that were submitted at the famous impeachment of Warren Hastings are hair-raising:

"It was stated that the defaulters were confined to open cages. It was stated that fathers were compelled to sell their children - - - Large masses of the people fled the country and troops were employed to prevent their flight. At last a great rebellion broke out - - - and then followed horrors and executions."¹⁵

This was the situation that led to the Permanent Settlement of revenue over a large part of the country.

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Lord Cornwallis introduced Permanent Settlement in Bengal in March 1793. Ostensibly, it was a measure conceived in 'a pure spirit of generous humanity and disinterested justice'¹⁶ But it was clearly a move to create a class which would be loyal to the rulers and would control the peasants on their behalf. The zamindars under the Mughal regime were rent-collectors; the zamindari was an office and not a proprietary right on land. The British considered them owners and the peasants were deemed to be their tenants, putting the latter at the mercy of the former.

Because this was to be the 'permanent' settlement, the revenue rates were again steeply enhanced. In Bengal under the Muslim rulers, in 1764-65, the land tax receipt was 8,18,000 pounds. The Company enhanced it to 14,70,000 pounds in the next year, when it took over the administration. In 1793, while making permanent settlement, it was further enhanced to

30,91,000 pounds.¹⁷ Estates of those who could not pay such huge amounts were auctioned, whereby a large number of moneylenders etc., who had little connection with the countryside and little reverence for the rural customs and traditions, became zamindars. They were interested only in encashing their position.

Revenue was settled permanently, so the rents payable by the peasants should also have become permanent. The Court of Directors of the Company did assert their authority, as sovereigns, of making regulations 'to prevent the raiyats being improperly disturbed in their possession, or loaded with unwarrantable exactions.'¹⁸ However, steps were instead taken to strengthen the position of zamindars. Distraint Act was passed in 1799. It gave almost unrestricted power to the zamindars to distraint the crops, cattle and other personal property of the tenants, and even to seize their persons without reference to the courts. It was later withdrawn in 1812, but only after causing much havoc; and even after its repeal, many other similar regulations followed. One of them was that if the tenant made groundless complaints against the zamindar, he would be punished with fine and imprisonment!¹⁹ When the tenants were poor, illiterate, unorganised and at the mercy of the zamindars, it was clearly not difficult for the latter to misuse such provisions.

In Britain, the landlords used to pay 5-20% of the rental to the State. In Bengal the tax was fixed at 90% of the rental.²⁰ From the margin of 10% the zamindar was expected to bear collection expenses and invest for the betterment of agriculture! But this was of little import to the zamindars when they were free to make both legal and illegal exactions. For example, in Bengal in 1936-37, the government's revenue demand was Rs. 31.2 millions as against Rs. 170 millions extracted as rent, although it should have been only Rs. 34.3 millions.²¹ As for the illegal exactions, called Abwabs, the Administration Report of 1872 says:

"The modern zamindar taxes his raiyats for extravagance or necessity that circumstances may suggest. He will tax them

for the support of his agents of various kinds and degrees; for the payment of his income tax and his postal cess; for the purchase of an elephant for his own use; for the cost of stationery of his establishment; for the cost of printing the forms of rent receipts; for the payment of his lawyers. The milkman gives the milk; the oilman his oil; the weaver his clothes; the confectioner his sweetmeats; the fisherman his fish. The zamindar levies benevolences from his raiyats for a festival, for a religious ceremony, for a birth, for a marriage - - - he imposes a fine when he settles their petty disputes - - - The Abwabs pervade the whole zamindary system.”²²

Peasants were thus left at the mercy of landlords; and the State not only turned a blind eye to the latter's tyranny, but also actively supported it directly or indirectly.

While the Permanent Settlement created a class loyal to the British masters, revenue demand froze. Hence it was not extended to many areas. In Central and South India the Ryotwari Settlement was preferred, wherein revenue was collected directly from the peasants. As Henry Tucker, a Director of the Company unabashedly declared, the object was to obtain ‘the utmost that the land will yield in the shape of rent.’²³ Ryotwari Settlement could also have been, but was not made permanent. The revenue rates continued to rise in such areas to an unbelievable extent. It was almost impossible to challenge the revenue settlement. When in 1873, Bombay High Court decided a suit against the settlement officer in a case, a bill was immediately introduced in the Bombay Council to exclude the jurisdiction of the High Court and of all Civil Courts in matters relating to land assessment.²⁴

Not only were the revenue rates atrociously enhanced, the revenue demand was rigorously and cruelly enforced. “Neither Native nor European agriculturist can thrive at the present rate of taxation,” wrote Bishop Heber in 1826. “I am personally acquainted with instances where the revenue assessed upon certain lands has actually exceeded the gross produce.”²⁵ John Briggs, an authority on land tax, wrote in 1830 that the “land tax like that which now exists in India - - - was never known

under any government in Europe or Asia.”²⁶ In 1818, the Cuttack (Odisha) Collector observed that the rent ‘apparently absorbed the whole produce.’²⁷

What else then could the consequences be, except pauperization of the peasantry and ruination of the villages? The rates did decrease to some extent after a time, but the peasant’s back had been broken. Interestingly, Royal Commission on Agriculture, appointed in 1928 ‘to make recommendations for the improvement of agriculture and to promote the welfare and prosperity of the rural population’, was directed ‘not to make recommendations regarding the existing system of land-ownership and tenancy or of assessment of land revenue and irrigation charges’!²⁸

No intermediaries between the peasant and the State were envisaged in the Ryotwari system. But several of them did arise in the course of time, adding to the burden on the actual tillers.

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Mahalwari Settlement was made in some areas of North India—settlement was made village by village and estate by estate. But it was not settlement with the village communities. The only difference was that the village heads were responsible for revenue-collection. Village communities had been traditionally discharging the function of assessing individual lands. Some British officers were in favour of settlement with the village communities, but they were overruled. Deprived of their traditional function and powers, the village communities inevitably decayed.

Sir Charles Metcalfe, then a member of the Governor-General’s Council and later Acting Governor-General of India, described the village communities vividly and picturesquely in his famous Minute in 1830:

“The village communities are little republics, having nearly everything that they want within themselves, and almost independent of any foreign relations. They seem to last where nothing else lasts. Dynasty after dynasty tumbles

down; revolution succeeds revolution; Hindu, Pathan, Moghal, Mahratta, Sikh, English are masters in turn; but the village communities remain the same. In times of trouble they arm and fortify themselves, a hostile army passes through the country; the village community collect their cattle within their walls and let the enemy pass unprovoked. If plunder and devastation be directed against themselves (sic) and the force employed be irresistible, they flee to friendly villages at a distance, but when the storm has passed over they return and resume their occupations. If a country remains for a series of years the scene of continued pillage and massacre, so that the villages cannot be inhabited, the scattered villagers nevertheless return whenever the power of peaceable possession revives. A generation may pass away, but the succeeding generation will return. The sons will take the places of their fathers; the same site for the village, the same position for the houses; the same lands will be reoccupied by the descendants of those who were driven out when the village was depopulated; and it is not a trifling matter that will drive them out, for they will often maintain their post through times of disturbance and convulsion, and acquire strength sufficient to resist pillage and oppression with success.

“The union of village communities, each one forming a separate little State in itself, has, I conceive, contributed more than any other cause to the preservation of the people of India through all revolutions and changes which they have suffered, and it is in a high degree conducive to their happiness and to the enjoyment of a great portion of freedom and independence.”

Therefore, Metcalfe pleaded:

“I wish, therefore, that the village constitutions may never be disturbed, and I dread everything that has a tendency to break them up. I am fearful that a revenue settlement with each individual cultivator, as is the practice in the Ryotwari Settlement, instead of one with the village community through their representatives, the headmen, might have such a tendency.”²⁹

Metcalfe's fears were proved right. Shorn of their functions

and powers, the village communities 'fell like trees whose roots had been severed.'³⁰

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What the mediaeval rulers extracted from the subjects was expended in the country itself; and so the people did gain something, albeit indirectly. But the British mostly siphoned off to Britain their plunder. In his celebrated book 'Poverty and un-British Rule in India' Dadabhai Naoroji had computed (in 1905) that every year Britain was draining away 34 million pounds, that is, 515 million rupees from India.³¹ In fact, the ways deployed were so numerous that it was almost impossible to make a fair estimate.

The British also took over the forests on which the rural folk depended for food, fodder, firewood, building materials etc., thereby depriving them of the basic necessities of life. Exploitation of forests for commercial gain began, which was bound to result in depletion of the forest cover and, in turn, degradation of soil, to which use of dung for fuel also contributed. Slaughter of the cattle also increased to an alarming degree. Irrigation facilities became defunct as traditional arrangements for their development and maintenance collapsed.

Deliberate de-industrialisation of the country also increased the burden on agriculture. Political power was used to strangle indigenous industries. While import duties on British goods, particularly cotton and silk goods, were minimal, export duties were unduly high. Oppressive taxes were imposed on spinning wheels and other implements used by artisans. As a result, exports declined, imports grew and the indigenous textile industry decayed. Weavers were compelled to weave imported yarn at rates decided by the Company's agents. To escape from this oppression, weavers cut off their thumbs. Many fled to forests and other areas. Dacca's population, according to a report in 1840, fell from 150,000 to 30-40,000.³² Lord Bentinck wrote in 1834 that "the misery hardly finds a parallel in the history of commerce. The bones of the cotton weavers are bleaching the plains of India."³³

And this was not the lot of the spinners and weavers alone; the plight of other artisans and craftsmen was no different. Great Britain's rapid industrialisation had India's wealth and blood at its base. Loss of employment in industry inevitably meant additional burden on agriculture. The population dependent on agriculture increased dramatically, further escalating exploitation of the peasants and labourers.

Traditionally, the farmers and artisans fulfilled each other's needs, mostly through barter. Exorbitant revenue, compulsion to pay it in cash and at inconvenient times made debt inescapable. In fact, the economics of agriculture is such that the peasant has to borrow money. That did not hitherto result in the peasant losing his land. But in the British regime, land became private property, and therefore alienable. The helplessness and illiteracy of the peasants, coupled with exorbitant rent, inadequate return on the produce and frequent famines landed them in the debt trap, whereby many of them lost their lands to moneylenders. According to an estimate, in Bombay province alone, between 1917 and 1943, about 5 million acres of land passed out of the hands of small peasants into those of urban absentee landholders, moneylenders and traders.³⁴

Transfer of land had hitherto been limited mostly within the village itself. The village community had an important role in regulating such transfers. This was one factor, which sociologists believe, had significantly contributed to the stability of rural society and culture in India. It has been asserted that the ease with which land could be bought and sold was one of the main reasons why America did not develop a rural culture except in the South.³⁵ Unrestricted alienation of land entailed devastation of rural life. R.C. Dutt laments:

"The saddest change (brought about by the British rule) is the virtual extinction of the old forms of self-government and the disappearance of those ancient village communities of which India was the first home among all the countries of the earth."³⁶

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All this resulted in the rise of a class of landless labourers

hitherto almost unknown in India. Thomas Munroe, Census Commissioner had written in 1842 that there was no such labourer.³⁷ Such labourers, without any land, were certainly rare. Now their ranks swelled; many of them even became bonded labourers, that is, virtual slaves.

Employment in agriculture, moreover, was not available all the year round, particularly because of lack of irrigation facilities. And the wages lagged behind real incomes. For example, daily wage in 1842 was one *anna* (one-sixteenth of a rupee), which increased to 4-6 *annas* in 1922; but during this period the cost of rice rose from 40 *seers* a rupee to 5 *seers* a rupee (1 *seer* = 0.93 kg.). Thus, practically there was decline in real wages.³⁸ As the labourers' ranks were swelling and they were helpless, nothing else could be expected. Meagre wages were hardly sufficient for food, so taking care of health and education of the children was ruled out; and so was any possibility of their coming out of the trap. Farm labour was hardly an occupation, if occupation is defined as a chosen means of livelihood; as the Report of the National Commission (1976) noted, it was just another name for the helplessness and misery of the peasants and artisans deprived of their traditional occupations.³⁹

The 1882 Census had shown the figure of landless agricultural labourers as 7.5 million; it rose to 21.7 million in 1921 and to 33.5 million in 1931.⁴⁰ Estimate of the Congress Agrarian Reforms Committee (1949) headed by J.C. Kumarappa was 35 million; and if their dependents were to be counted, the figure was almost 100 million!⁴¹

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The plight of the landless labourers was pathetic; so was that of small and marginal farmers. As the peasant leader Swami Sahajanand Saraswati noted,

“Lands of at least 80% of the peasants are such that they can at best fill half or quarter of the bellies of their family members, and that too with coarse grains. Uneconomic holdings thus threaten to ruin the peasants. These 80% of the peasants—90% at some places—are in such a state of destitution and ruin that one is ashamed of calling them

even labourers; a labourer at least gets a fixed wage, whatsoever it may be.”⁴²

The labourer was at least free to sell his labour; he could be mobile.

Landlords, government and moneylenders were not the only ones to appropriate portions of agricultural produce—the fruit of the peasant's labour. While part of it went legitimately to the labourers, there were many other claimants. Artisans and others fulfilling useful functions in the village were traditionally assigned portions of the agricultural produce, in return for the services rendered. Some of the functions became redundant; as the arrangements of yore collapsed, there was none to ensure that the expected services were rendered, yet claims continued to be made on the peasants' produce for quite some time till the whole system ultimately gave way. T.N. Aatre, in his authentic tract 'Gaongada' (1915), describes the situation thus:

“Partitions have fragmented the fields. So, the peasant cannot now bear the responsibility of providing for the whole world. He has to feed whole localities of Mahars, Ramoshis, Bhils, Kolis and Mangs (*communities which are now part of scheduled castes and scheduled tribes*). They claim to do the work of the government, but make claims on the peasant. He has to feed the army of beggars. When the sea and the forests were accessible and there was no ban on keeping arms, these people and the nomadic tribesmen survived to some extent on the forests, hunting and salt, and killed the creatures harming the crops and the cattle. - - - It is learnt from the peasants and the artisans that about 22 to 25% of the main agricultural produce goes to the *balutedar* artisans (artisans with fixed entitlements), not to speak of other grains, vegetables, grass etc. It would not be wrong to conclude that the *balutedars* and the beggars must be taking away around one-third of the produce from the peasant, directly or indirectly; and a part of the produce is also lost through thefts.”⁴³

This was besides what was being taken by the State. How could then agriculture have any surplus, and how could there be investment for its betterment? Aatre's description pertains to

Maharashtra, but there is no reason to believe that the situation was different anywhere else.

Jawaharlal Nehru writes in his autobiography after first-hand experience of the conditions in United Provinces (1920):

“I listened to their innumerable tales of sorrow, their crushing and ever-growing burden of rent, illegal exactions, ejectments from land and mud hut, beatings; surrounded on all sides by vultures who preyed on them—zamindar’s agents, money-lenders, police; toiling all day to find that what they produced was not theirs and their reward was kicks and curses and a hungry stomach. - - - The land was rich but the burden on it was very heavy, the holdings were small and there were too many people after them. Taking advantage of this land hunger the landlords, unable to enhance their rents beyond a certain percentage, charged huge illegal premiums. The tenant, knowing of no other alternative, borrowed money from the money-lender and paid the premium, and then, unable to pay his debt or even the rent, was ejected and lost all he had. This process was old and the progressive pauperisation of the peasantry had been going on for a long time.”⁴⁴

Economic recession in the late twenties also took its toll. Prices of agricultural produce nosedived; but rents remained the same, inevitably driving many peasants into the ranks of landless labourers.

Concentration of land in the hands of absentee landlords with little interest in the improvement of agriculture resulted in loss of fertility of the soil and reduction in the area under crops, making this so-called ‘predominantly agricultural’ country dependent on imports for its food. Second World War affected imports; and the consequence was a terrible famine wherein 3.5 million people perished in Bengal alone; 1.2 million died in the subsequent epidemics. It also caused transfer of 0.7 million acres of land from the peasants.⁴⁵

The whole land and village system thus lay in shambles when the country became Independent.

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The picture on the eve of Independence was extremely complex. While there were 'zamindars' with land less than an acre, there were many landlords in the Ryotwari areas too. Sharecroppers—mostly unprotected—formed a sizable chunk of the population engaged in agriculture. There was a large number of intermediaries and the intermixing of features of two or more systems had added to the complexity. In native states, jagirdari system had its own peculiar features.

Fifty seven percent of the privately-held land was under the Zamindari, 38% was under the Ryotwari settlement and 5% was under the Mahalwari settlement. Zamindari system prevailed exclusively in United Provinces, Bihar and West Bengal. It was predominant in Odisha too. Ryotwari system was predominant in Central and Western India and also in the North-East.⁴⁶

According to an official study, agricultural landowners were 22.2%, tenants 27.2%, agricultural labourers 30.4% and non-agricultural labourers 20.2% in the rural society.⁴⁷

Concentration of landownership was staggering. As figures for early fifties show, 1.5% of the zamindars held 58% of the land in Uttar Pradesh—804 biggest landowners held 25% of the land. Inequality was equally staggering in Ryotwari areas. In Bombay province, in 1952-53, landholders with land upto 5 acres constituted 53% of the landholders and owned 14% land while those having 25 acres or more land constituted 8% of the landholders and owned 40% of the total land.⁴⁸ A sample survey in 1950-51 found that the fields upto 2.5 acres, which could broadly be considered uneconomic, were 38.4% of the total number, and covered 6% of the land under cultivation; while those over 25 acres were 5.4% in number but had 34% of the land.⁴⁹

On the eve of Independence, India was partitioned. As a result, 32% of the irrigated land in undivided India became part of Pakistan, thereby reducing the percentage of the irrigated land in the total cultivated land in India from 21.6% to 17.6% after Partition. Food shortage consequently became more acute. Food imports in 1951 were 4.7 million tonnes.⁵⁰ A 'predominantly agricultural' country was living literally 'from ship to mouth'!⁵¹

Ruin of the land system was only one part of the havoc caused by colonial rule. Village communities not only lost their economic power and political independence, they lost judicial functions as well. Administration of justice was an important function of the village community; it was one of the foundations of its strength. Colonial masters imposed their legal system, which was totally alien to the ethos of this country. As Sir William Sleeman said bluntly, the British legal methods ‘wrought more harm than all other evil agencies together’.⁵² Village communities used to look after the education of village children also; their collapse naturally marked decline in education.⁵³

Shell-shocked to the core, society withdrew into its shell, resulting in accentuation of caste differences, untouchability and social inequalities. Total slavery inevitably led to total decay. As Vinoba succinctly said, under the Mughal regime India was a slave country consisting of independent villages; under the British regime it became a slave country consisting of slave villages.⁵⁴

The country had become Independent, but what about the Independence of the villages? Their social, moral and economic independence, as Gandhi noted in what came to be known as his ‘Last Will and Testament’, was yet to be attained—and the political independence too, if the term ‘political’ is taken in the right and broader sense. While setting out for the Shivarampalli Sarvodaya Conference, Vinoba had said the same thing: “The country has become Independent. But the villages have yet to attain Swaraj. A tougher battle will have to be fought for it.”⁵⁵

Gandhi had initiated this process in his own way. Now it had to be taken further. He had not touched the problem of land; it was imperative to tackle it in right earnest after the attainment of Independence. Confronting this problem could have been the starting point in this impending battle.

3. The Land Problem: Search for Solution

Whenever oppression became unbearable, peasants rose in revolt against the landlords, the moneylenders and the government. But they were doomed to fail, as the great Empire over which the sun never set was all set to crush them with all its might.

In the era of national awakening, attention of the nationalist leaders was naturally attracted to the pathetic condition of the peasants and of the agriculture. They criticized from time to time the land policy of the Raj which was responsible for that condition. They realized that the burden of land revenue was on the peasants was excessive. Writing in 1879, Justice M.G. Ranade squarely blamed revenue policies for the destitution of the country and warned that there was no hope of improving the agriculture unless this burden was reduced. In his view, concentration of ownership over land in the hands of the landlords and the Raj, and their unbridled prerogative of enhancing the land rent and revenue were the main impediments in the path to prosperity.¹ R.C. Dutt, writing to Lord Curzon in 1900, called for reduction in land revenue to such a level that the peasant could have some saving, he could provide for bad monsoons and have wherewithal to make necessary investment for the improvement of agriculture. He advocated ceiling on the enhancement of revenue.²

Nationalist leaders criticized the government not only for the uncertainty and baselessness in revenue demand, but also for its inopportune timing and unnecessary rigour in its collection. In view of the uncertainty in demand, they called for permanent settlement of revenue with the peasant, and not with the zamindar. They thus advocated permanent Ryotwari settlement. This demand was raised from time to time in the annual sessions of the Indian National Congress since 1888.

Justice Ranade, Lokmanya Tilak, Surendranath Banerjee, Subramaniam Aiyar—all of them stood for such settlement.³ Peasant was never fully absent from the Congress agenda.

Nationalist newspapers voiced, from time to time, opposition to the injustices of Zamindari system, including evictions of the peasants, and called for reforms in the revenue regime and appropriate concessions to the peasants in difficult circumstances. In 1901, a few members of the Bombay Legislative Council walked out in protest against anti-peasant provisions in the revenue reform bill, perhaps for the first time in the history of Indian legislatures.⁴

The demands, however, were not backed by the organisation of peasantry. Organisation of peasants came on the agenda of the Congress when it assumed the form of a mass movement under the leadership of Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi. The 1918 session of the Congress at Delhi, attended by peasants in large numbers for the first time—around 700 peasants attended it—decided to form Kisan Sabha.⁵

Gandhi's satyagrahas in Champaran, Kheda and Bardoli roused the peasants and attracted attention of the country to their plight. Gandhi contended that if revenue administration was reformed and freed from corruption, it would be as good as having three-quarters of Swaraj!⁶ Karachi Congress in 1931 called for substantial reduction in land revenue and rent and full waiver for non-viable lands. The Congress was, however, careful not to antagonise the zamindars, whose support it wanted in the freedom struggle, and therefore clarified in its Working Committee resolution in January 1932 that it had 'no design upon any interest legitimately acquired and not in conflict with the national well-being.'⁷

The Faizpur Congress (1936), the first Congress session in a village, which was publicized as the 'Kisan Congress', drew up an agrarian programme, which included, inter alia, reduction in rent and revenue, exemption of uneconomic holdings from payment of revenue or rent, lowering of irrigation rates, abolition of feudal levies and forced labour, liquidation of arrear rent, fixity of tenure for tenants, removal of rural debt and

provision of living wages and suitable working conditions for agricultural labourers.⁸

In 1937, Congress ministries assumed office in some provinces, and peasants hoped for a better future. Kisan rallies were held at several places. Provincial governments, during their short time in office, did announce some concessions and took some steps for the amelioration of the peasants' condition. In 1945, National Planning Committee, constituted by the Congress under the presidentship of Nehru, recommended collective and co-operative farming and abolition of intermediaries between the State and the cultivators. This was reiterated in the Congress manifesto for the 1945-46 elections. The Nehru Committee constituted by the Congress in 1947 for framing the Congress economic policy, advocated ceiling on landholding besides zamindari abolition. These suggestions were accepted by the Congress in 1948.⁹

After Independence, Congress appointed the Agrarian Reforms Committee with J.C. Kumarappa as the Chairman in December 1947. For the first time after the labours of the Royal Commission on Agriculture in 1928, this Committee made a detailed survey of agrarian relations in the country and studied the conditions in depth. Radical recommendations of the Committee, led by the staunch Gandhian, were perhaps too much for the Congress to digest! It did not officially accept the recommendations, but sent them to the provincial governments for consideration; and these were soon forgotten.

The Committee stated unequivocally in its report that "in our scheme the right of cultivation will belong to the cultivator, but he must be subject to the control of the community", that rights in land would be distributed between the cultivator and the village community only with no role for the State; and said, "Our aim should be to reinstate the village community to the position in the rural economy which rightfully belongs to it."¹⁰ The Committee spelt out the following governing principles for the agrarian policy of the country: (1) The agrarian economy should provide opportunity for the development of the farmers' personality; (2) There should be no scope for class exploitation;

(3) There should be maximum efficiency of production; and (4) The scheme of reforms should be within the realm of practicability. It recommended abolition of intermediaries between the farmer and the State and declared that land must belong to the tiller. It also called for ceiling on landholding at three times the economic holding.¹¹

The land policy of the state governments in Independent India and the land reforms carried out by them will be discussed later in a separate chapter. Suffice it to say here that the state governments had too many limitations. It was too much to expect revolutionary steps from them; but essentially such steps were needed. Moreover, the governments were enamoured of the modern industrialisation; enthusiasm for it was soon to take the form of a mad rush. And wherefrom money for industrialisation was going to come? Sufficient savings could not be expected in a developing economy. Foreign aid and loans and the exploitation of agriculture were the only ways open. Perverted priorities of the governments also posed a problem. Land reforms was a state subject in the Constitution, and that added to difficulties. It was also a fact that vested interests were powerful in the governments, in the administration and even in the judiciary. Political will sufficient enough to overcome these problems was severely lacking, given the compulsions of the election-based democratic set-up.

The land reforms initiated by the State were, therefore, progressing in Independent India at a snail's pace. Impatient people had two more ways before them for radical restructuring of land relations—the Marxian way and the Gandhian way.

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Vinoba had said that if the world was going to witness an ultimate fight, it would be between Communism and Sarvodaya ideology; other powers would not last long, because only these two ideologies had some substance, and therefore can attract the people¹²:

“Gandhian thought has a spiritual aura while Communism is backed by a scientific terminology. Gandhian thought has

extricated itself from the charge of impracticability by winning Independence for India. Communism has proved its virility by rejuvenating the grand old China.”¹³

Communism came in India in the early days of the 20th Century. Not just guided, but directed by Soviet Russia, solution of the land problem for the Indian Communists was the same as was tried in that country—capture of power and then collectivisation and nationalisation of land. Organisation of the peasants was, for them, a strategy for capturing the State and not for redressal of their grievances.

When India was on the threshold of Independence, the Communists started an armed struggle in the Telangana region of the Hyderabad state. And it was in Telangana that Bhoodan was born. But it was not meant to counter the Communists, as Vinoba repeatedly contended. A brief overview of the Telangana struggle is in order here in this context.

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Telangana was a part of Hyderabad, the largest native state in India and a big bastion of feudalism, which was being ground down under the despotic and capricious rule of the Nizam dynasty. It had an area of 82,313 square miles and a population over 6.3 millions as per the Census of 1941.¹⁴ The Nizam was bent upon insulating the state from progressive currents. Spread of education was negligible. While political activities were totally banned, even social and cultural activities were looked upon with suspicion and discouraged.

Nizam himself was the biggest landlord in the state, with 10% of the land in the state earmarked for his private expenses. Jagirdars possessed 42% land; bigger ones among them were virtually independent autocratic rulers with their own administration for revenue and justice. Rents, like in British India, were exorbitant. Peasants, like elsewhere, were trapped in debt; interest thereon was almost equal to the rent payable.¹⁵ As a result, land was getting rapidly transferred to moneylenders, malguzars and the patels. Tenants were at the mercy of the landlords. Recession in 1929 worsened the situation, and famine

devastated large areas of the state in 1946. Drinking habit was alarmingly widespread—overwhelming majority of the male population was in the clutches of that evil, and liquor worth thousands of rupees was being consumed annually. All in all, Telangana in the middle of the fifth decade of the 20th Century was a fertile ground for Communist rebellion.

The Communist Party was formed clandestinely in Hyderabad in 1939. Many Communists were earlier active in Andhra Mahasabha, a broad platform of nationalists. Ravinarayan Reddy, who later led the armed struggle, had worked in the Andhra Mahasabha and the State Congress. He had participated in the Salt Satyagraha (1930), started khadi work in the state and was first Secretary and then President of Harijan Sevak Sangh. He joined the secretly-constituted Party and was expelled from the Congress in 1945 along with some other Communists.

The Communists started agitation against the tyranny of Vishnur jagirdar in December 1944, and the struggle spread quickly. Besides looting grains from the landlords, the peasants were encouraged to seize their lands. Nizam's police force was too ill-equipped to face the challenge. Nizam, therefore, sent army, but it also failed in containing the struggle. As a result, Nizam administration was almost paralyzed in a few areas like the Nalgonda district, where village committees were formed by the Communists in around 1,000 villages, and they began to 'try' tyrannical landlords through what they called 'People's courts'. Many, particularly bigger landlords, fled to Hyderabad, the capital city. Their land was distributed by the Communists, mostly to their supporters.

The peasants indeed needed justice. The State Congress was also concerned with their plight and wanted to mobilise them for redressal of their grievances. It was led by Swami Ramanand Tirtha, the *sannyasi* patriot. Swami was opposed to the Communist strategy, which was resulting in the poor peasants getting scorched by the flames of violence from both the sides.

Attitude of the Communists towards the freedom struggle was ambivalent. At times, they would join it; at times, they

would support the Nizam; and at times, they would support independence of Hyderabad, even while opposing the Nizam. Evidently, its policy was dictated by Soviet Russia through Comintern, as was the practice in those days. The Communists first welcomed the Independence of India, but in December 1947, declared it as sham. B.T. Ranadive, the new Secretary of the Party, called for armed insurrection for true freedom and democracy. Party's adventurist actions resulted in it being banned in several provinces.

Agitation against the Nizam's autocratic rule became more intense after Independence of British India, resulting in still more repression of the people. Razakars, with active encouragement from the Nizam, unleashed a reign of terror against the majority Hindu population. But they could not turn the tide. Hyderabad was freed in September 1948 through Police Action. The new government took some steps for the amelioration of the lot of peasants; it abolished jagirdari and provided protection to the tenants.

The Communists, however, continued their struggle, which was now directed against the popular government of Independent India. It was clearly against the current. Moreover, they had now to deal with the well-equipped forces of Indian government and not with the ill-equipped, inefficient and unpopular Nizam government. Nizam's army lacked modern weapons—even telephone and wireless facilities were inadequate. The Communist struggle, which was fast losing the people's support, was unlikely to hold on against the Indian army. It was a fatal blunder to continue the strategy in the changed circumstances, but the adventurist leadership, under the spell of the Chinese Revolution, persisted with it. Later, the Communists admitted their blunder. C. Rajeswar Rao wrote in 1972:

“People in the country were in no mood to sympathise with the continuance of armed struggle in the state. If an objective and realistic estimate of the political and military situation in the country is made, one will naturally come to the conclusion that the continuation of the armed struggle was

impossible and a change of policy to safeguard the gains of the heroic armed struggle and its reorganisation using the new possibilities were urgently needed.”¹⁶

Ravinarayan Reddy, leader of the guerilla struggle, too conceded later, “It was a historic blunder on the part of the Party that we should also fight against the Indian army.”¹⁷ And this blunder not only led to its defeat but also to demoralisation and depletion in its ranks: “People’s role in struggle diminished after the Police Action - - - and, as a consequence, the movement - - - degenerated into individual terrorism by a few squad members.”¹⁸

Indeed, role of the common man in an armed struggle is bound to be peripheral. Violence can never be the weapon of masses. In fact, it is an anti-people weapon. Violence in the name of the people ultimately becomes violence against the people. And the counter-violence of the State that it provokes adds to their suffering. This happened in Telangana too. As Swami Ramanand Tirtha noted,

“Atrocities committed by both the army and the Communists were heart-rending. I saw in public places corpses of the people killed by the Communist guerillas. That was the fate of the commoners who dared to disagree with them. The jagirdars against whom the fight was were safe in the distant capital city.”¹⁹

Ranadive’s strategy isolated the Communists. As discontent against him gathered strength, he was removed from the post of the Secretary in June 1950, but the strategy remained unchanged. Leaders like S.A. Dange revolted against this line and prevailed upon the Soviet leaders to change it. As directed by them, the entire Politbureau resigned and Ajoy Ghosh was made Secretary. Party officially withdrew the armed struggle in October 1951. When Vinoba was in Telangana, the announcement had not come, but normalcy was gradually getting restored. In a dialogue with the Communist prisoners on 15 April 1951, Vinoba exhorted them that even though they did not have any moral objection to violence, they should abjure it in the changed circumstances as a matter of policy.²⁰

The Communist struggle had no constructive dimension. Drinking was a major problem in Telangana. It was a major means of exploitation of the peasants. But the Communists did not oppose the evil seriously, honestly and consistently, allegedly because of pressure from the liquor lobby. They did not hesitate in setting fire to grain reserves in villages. It is also interesting to note that the Party initially fixed the ceiling of 500 acres while seizing the lands, which, as P. Sundarayya concedes, was due to the political necessity of not antagonising a few big landlords who were supporters of the Party.²¹

The Communists did make contribution in arousing the peasants, but they fought 'for' the people, not 'with' the peasants; so their struggle could not build the peasants' power. It remained restricted to its cadre and ultimately fizzled out.

Why, after all was the struggle waged? Rajeshwar Rao says that it was for giving land to agricultural labourers, peasants and tribals, and concedes that this aim was not fully realised, but "it greatly helped in eliminating forced labour, illegal taxes and oppression of various types by feudal lords. It greatly helped in eliminating the jagir system at one stroke."²² This is clearly an overestimation. There was almost a consensus on the abolition of intermediaries and a widespread sentiment against feudal oppression, and steps had been initiated throughout India in that regard after Independence. Peasants had been considerably conscientized during the freedom movement. The Communists did have a share in their awakening, but the results of the armed struggle were certainly questionable. Rajeshwar Rao says that 1 million acres of land was distributed,²³ while V.D. Deshpande, who was later leader of Opposition in the Hyderabad Assembly, says that 0.5 million acres were distributed through the struggle of Andhra Mahasabha and the Communists—not just the armed struggle.²⁴ Jayaprakash Narayan believed that the figure was not more than 30,000 acres.²⁵ It may also be noted that Party supporters were allegedly preferred over the real needy while distributing the land. Moreover, such lands were later restored to the original owners, as there was no legal sanction behind that distribution. A peasant cannot have permanent and heritable title to land without approval from the State.

In all probability, the figures given by the Communists are exaggerated. For example, Rajeshwar Rao says that there were 50,000 soldiers of Indian army in Telangana; however, a Police report in December 1949 gives the total figure of army-men as well as police, both local and other, as 9,873.²⁶

The Communists did not touch landholdings over 500 acres in the beginning. They also allegedly did not touch the landlords who financed them. Many leaders of the struggle, including Ravinarayan Reddy were themselves big landlords—although Reddy must be commended for distributing 500 acres of his land to the peasants. All in all, the landless labourer, the last man on the social ladder, benefited little from the struggle.

The Communists participated in the first general election in 1952 in alliance with a breakaway group from the Congress and some leftist groups. They had come out of jails as heroes. Congress was plagued with groupism. Muslims and feudal elements were sore with the Congress, and so was the bureaucracy. Excesses by the army had also alienated public opinion to some extent. All these factors favoured the Communists, who were also accused of terrorising the voters. All these factors led to their electoral success, particularly in Nalgonda district where they won all the 14 Assembly seats—their total tally was 45 out of 175 seats.²⁷ Bhoodan work had progressed little in Telangana after Vinoba's departure. Bhoodan workers had mostly remained aloof from the elections.

It must also be mentioned that support for the Communists went on dwindling thereafter. In 1962, they won 8 seats in the Parliament out of 43, and in 1967, only one seat.

Telangana struggle demonstrated the futility of armed insurrection. The Communists subsequently chose the way of democratic politics, whose limitations were already becoming apparent. The only alternative that remained was that of Gandhi—that of nonviolence.

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John Ruskin's book, 'Unto this last', convinced Gandhi that 'a life of labour, i.e. the life of the tiller of the soil and the

handicraftsman is the life worth living'.²⁸ And for Gandhi, conviction meant immediate action. So, he soon established Phoenix settlement.

Gandhi's earlier satyagrahas in India (Champaran, Kheda, Bardoli) were mostly for the peasants. In fact, India's freedom struggle was essentially a struggle for the emancipation of peasants. As Gandhi said in 1931,

"The Congress is essentially and pre-eminently a kisan organization. It endeavours to represent the zamindars and the propertied classes, but only to the extent that the interests of the kisans are not prejudiced thereby. The Congress is nothing if it does not represent the kisans."²⁹

Gandhi was well aware of the tyranny of zamindars and the exploitation of kisans; he was against zamindari system, but hoped to convert the landlords and exhorted them to become trustees. At the same time, he wanted kisans to become aware of their rights and powers and assert the same. He believed that organisation of the peasants would be unassailable and it would neutralize the evils of zamindari.³⁰

However, in the context of the freedom movement, problems of the kisans had to be handled carefully and prudently. Freedom from foreign rule was the first requisite for amelioration of their lot. Steps had to be taken in a proper sequence. For Gandhi, the first step was to organize the kisans through constructive programme: "When they (the kisans) become conscious of their nonviolent strength, no power on earth can resist them."³¹

We find Gandhi articulating more and more radical thoughts as freedom became more and more imminent. In June 1942, when asked by Louis Fischer what his programme was for improvement of the lot of peasantry, he said, "The peasants would take the land. We would not have to tell them to take it." "Would the landlords be compensated?"—queried Fischer. Gandhi's reply was: "No, that would be fiscally impossible."³²

In December 1942, Gandhi told Pyarelal,

"I have not given full thought to the problem of land. Without

land reform, the spinning wheel and other village industries cannot remove the poverty of the masses. But I do not have a clear picture as to how the land problem will be solved.”³³

In July 1943, when Miraben sought his opinion on land redistribution in free India, he told her,

“The legal ownership will vest in the State. But in practice land will belong to the man who ploughs it. Government will help the tiller in every possible manner. - - - When public opinion is ripe for it and the bulk of the owners have been converted to the trusteeship idea, free India will legislate so that land can be taken away from those who do not wish to become trustees.”

When Miraben said that education of the public opinion would have to be the first step, Gandhi’s reply was that such education had already been done and the public opinion was almost ready.³⁴

Gandhi thus admittedly had not given deep thought to the question of land, but he pinned hope on his theory of trusteeship and on the efficacy of nonviolence. He did expect that the government of free India would be pro-kisan, but if it failed, the kisans ‘will, of course, have the sovereign remedy of civil disobedience and non-cooperation.’³⁵

For Gandhi, an ideal economic constitution required control of the masses over the means of production of the elementary necessities of life: “These should be freely available to all as God’s air and water are or ought to be; they should not be made a vehicle of traffic for the exploitation of others.”³⁶ It clearly meant that land should belong to the tiller. And this had to be brought about through nonviolence. But Gandhi could not give a concrete blueprint for the same. It was left to his successor to give an effective nonviolent programme for the solution of land problem.

And after Gandhi’s departure, everyone was looking forward to Vinoba for giving a lead in taking up Gandhi’s unfinished agenda.

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For Vinoba, Independence was meaningless if landlessness persisted in the country. In 1932, he had told so plainly to Sane Guruji.³⁷ In 1945, when asked about his opinion on the idea of trusteeship, he upheld the concept and added that nobody could cultivate hundreds of acres of land; they had to take help of the kisans. The kisans should refuse to work for more than reasonable time and take less than reasonable wages.

“Then the landlord will relinquish the land on his own if there is no surplus. If the landlords want to guide the peasants, I would not mind if the land is under their control. I will utilize their managerial abilities. They will manage the estates on behalf of the government. But if their intentions are suspect, land will be taken over from them.”³⁸

But, who would own the land? When this question was asked, Vinoba replied,

“The question itself is wrong. Neither the peasant is immortal, nor the landlord. They pass away, but the land continues to exist. In fact, it is the land which owns us. Who owns air? But, if a reply has to be given, it can be said that the land belongs to one who serves her. Nobody can own the land. Hence there is no question of anyone holding more than necessary land and of talking about its ownership. I will not say that land should immediately be expropriated. I am ready to give reasonable rent to the landlord. If that does not satisfy him, I will ask him to work in the fields. If he refuses, his land will be vested in the government and will be redistributed to the people according to their need.”³⁹

A question followed, “Gandhiji says that the tiller is the true owner of the land. How can this be brought about through nonviolence?” Vinoba replied,

“This declaration by Gandhiji’s is indeed revolutionary. People will say, ‘Land belongs to the villagers. We will all work and share the fruit. If someone claims to be an owner, we will ask him to work with us.’ The landlord presently keeps a major portion of the rent with him. This is wrong. - - In fact, the national government (in free India) will be the people’s government; and so the land will belong to the

people. Its distribution will be done by the government, that is, the people. Whatever needs to be decided will be decided by the government, that is, the people.”⁴⁰

So, it was clear that land rightfully belonged to the kisans; in fact, to all the villagers. Reference to government action has to be understood in the context of time. Vinoba always stood for freedom from the State. And when he grappled with the land problem, he did come out with a concrete programme for nonviolent land redistribution through non-governmental action and transfer of ownership—rather, management as he was opposed to the very idea of landownership—of the land to village communities rather than to the State.

It was on the background of a violent effort for the solution of the land problem that Gandhi's heir proceeded to the bruised Telangana in March 1951. He was searching for a programme which could become the starting point for the nonviolent total revolution that Gandhi dreamt of. But there were no expectations as such: “To meet the good people who come across, and to see if something could be done to remove difficulties of the people—that is the only thing in my mind.”⁴¹

4. Bhoodan: the Beginning

The ‘*Sarvodaya Yatra*’¹ (pilgrimage for Sarvodaya) from Pavnar to Shivarampalli proceeded for 31 days, from 8 March 1951 to 7 April 1951, and covered around 542 km.

Vinoba’s message to the people was, in general, commitment to labour and self-reliance. He also advocated payment of wages to farm labourers in grains. He knew the condition of the villages. Still, their plight which he again saw at close quarters moved him. People in free India were looking to the government for everything. Vinoba explained to them the true meaning of swaraj (self-rule) and Sarvodaya and exhorted them to gird up their loins for nonviolent battles to attain true freedom for the villages:

“If we depend on the government for everything, can that be called Independence? Or, is it slavery? Peace in the village, food and clothing for the village, sanitation and education in the village—it is for the village to work for all this. The villagers should establish self-government in their village. Independence at Delhi or Adilabad is of no use to them. It is Independence at the level of their village that matters to them.”²

Vinoba met local workers at different places, and inspired and motivated them to work for nonviolence in the changed context.

On 23 March, the District Superintendent of Police offered police protection to the tour party. It meant that the tour party was now entering the danger zone—the area affected by Communist insurgency. Vinoba declined to allow armed and uniformed police in the tour party, but allowed plainclothesmen to accompany them.³

Questions were naturally asked to Vinoba in the context of the insurgency. At Ramayampet he was asked, “The landlords harass the tenants. The tenants cannot stand against the

landlords' power. So they seek help from the Communists. What should be done in this situation?" Vinoba's reply was: 'Go to the masses and serve them and resort to satyagraha if need be.'⁴ He did not mince words in criticizing the Communists for being anti-poor and anti-village in practice and for preaching hatred.⁵

On 6 April, Vinoba was accorded a grand reception at Hyderabad. The prayer meeting in the evening witnessed a crowd of around 10,000 persons. Vinoba told the gathering that Hyderabad state was verily India in miniature, and 'if we solve the problems here, we would get the key to solve the problems of not only India, but of the whole world.'⁶ When Vinoba proceeded to Shivarampalli from Hyderabad, people joined him in such a large number that it became impossible to control enthusiastic crowd; so Vinoba started running!⁷

People's response to Vinoba led the organizers of the Sarvodaya Conference at Shivarampalli to announce that the delegates and the visitors should bring their own ration, as it would be impossible for the organizing committee to arrange catering for all of them!⁸

The Conference started on 8 April. In his message, Prime Minister Nehru said that darkness had enveloped the whole world, and Sarvodaya could contribute significantly in the search for light.⁹ The world was indeed facing an unprecedented crisis. A new era had begun with the end of the Second World War. While colonialism was getting liquidated, imperialism was taking on a new garb. Expansionism of the U.S.S.R. and the recent Chinese revolution had presented new challenges. India, the newly-Independent nation plagued with umpteen problems, divisions and dissensions, was standing at the crossroads.

At the Conference, Vinoba pleaded for more attention to agriculture, which implied grappling with the land problem. However, as for land redistribution, he had nothing else to suggest except legislation and said that Kashmir had shown the way¹⁰—the state had recently imposed land ceiling of 22.75 acres, acquired 0.45 million acres of land without compensation and given rights to tenants over 0.23 million acres.¹¹

While returning to Pavnar on foot, Vinoba intended to visit areas affected by Communist insurgency. Before beginning the tour, he met Communist prisoners in Hyderabad jail and appealed to them to renounce the path of violence, at least as a matter of strategy. But he did not receive any concrete assurance; and expectedly so, as it was their central leadership which had authority to reconsider the Party line. From Hyderabad, on 15 April, Vinoba started his return journey and entered Nalgonda district, the most affected area, on 18 April. The first halt was Pochampalli. It was here that destiny willed an incident that was to prove a new ray of hope, not only for a novel solution to land problem in India, but also for nonviolent revolution in the world.

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The tour party reached Pochampalli at around 7-7.30 a.m. after traversing 16 km of hilly and forest tracts.¹² The village had been thoroughly cleaned and people welcomed Vinoba singing devotional melodies in a serene atmosphere. Pochampalli was a big village with 700 households and a population of 3,000 out of which 2,000 were landless. Weavers, numbering 643, formed a major portion of the population, while Dalits numbered 219. There was a school, but it was practically without a teacher. Drinking *sindi*, the local brand of liquor, was as prevalent as elsewhere in Telangana. According to an estimate 2,000 persons in the village consumed liquor worth Rs. 150 daily. The village had been an important centre of Communist activities and had witnessed four murders. A posse of armed police was still camping there.

At 9.15 a.m. Vinoba set out for a round of the village, starting with the Dalit locality. Inhabitants gathered round him, and discussion on their problems ensued. Poor Dalits were articulate about their grievances. They wanted land, which alone could ensure food and a dignified livelihood.

“How much land do you want?”—queried Vinoba. The group of labourers deliberated for a while and their leader replied, “Eighty acres will be enough—forty acres irrigated and forty acres non-irrigated.”

“Will that be sufficient?”—Vinoba asked.

“Yes; we do other work also.”—They replied.

“Will you cultivate the land collectively?”—Vinoba asked. At that time, collective agriculture was being seen as a panacea for the ills of agriculture in some quarters; and although Vinoba was no great champion of the idea, he was certainly for co-operative action on the part of villagers.

The Dalits readily agreed. It may be mentioned here that the Dalit labourers and the washermen of the village were traditionally doing their work collectively and distributing the grains or wages they received among themselves.¹³

Vinoba asked them to write an application to the government which he would follow up. But that could take indefinite time, given the ways of bureaucracy. Suddenly, Vinoba asked the villagers whether something could be done by the villagers themselves. And instantly a man rose and said humbly,

“It was the wish of my late father that some land be given to these brethren. So, on behalf of me and my five brothers, I donate 100 acres—50 irrigated and 50 non-irrigated—to them through you.”

The man was Ramchandra Reddy.

Nobody had thought that something like this would happen. Everyone was startled; there was silence for a few seconds, everyone was gaping at the man standing in their midst.

Vinoba asked Ramchandra to record his resolve in writing. Ramchandra readily did the same. The paper was read aloud and four witnesses put their signatures on it—three were from the village and the fourth was Konda Venkat Ranga Reddy, a Congress leader from Telangana, who had accompanied the tour party. Bhoodan had begun.

Someone suggested that only those who undertake not to drink henceforth should be given land. Vinoba, although a great champion of prohibition, declined to make it a pre-condition. But the Dalits themselves resolved to abjure drinking.

The evening meeting saw a crowd of around 5,000 persons; people of neighbouring villages—Revanpalli, Bhivanpalli, Guskonda etc.—also had come. Vinoba dwelt on the situation in Telangana, his talk with the Communist prisoners, and asked the villagers—the rich and the poor—to live together with unity and co-operation. He then described the incident in the morning and asked Ramchandra Reddy to stand up. Reddy stood up with folded hands. Vinoba said,

“This gentleman, who has promised to donate 100 acres of land, is standing before you. If he retracts, he will be a criminal before God. But if he gives land, it will be the responsibility of the Harijans¹⁴ to cultivate it together with love and co-operation.”

Perhaps he was finding it difficult to believe what had happened. Ramchandra reiterated his resolve. Thunderous clapping followed his declaration. Vinoba continued,

“If we could have such noble people in every village, the Communist problem will be a thing of the past. Let it be abundantly clear that it will not be possible for the rich in India to continue to hold on to big landholdings.”¹⁵

In the night, Vinoba conferred with the workers and the village leaders about the legal transfer of land. Ramchandra Reddy had suggested formation of a trust in his gift-deed. Vinoba accepted this suggestion and constituted a trust of five members—two members of the Dalit community, the village patel, Ramchandra Reddy and Venkat Ranga Reddy, President of the local Congress Committee.¹⁶

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Who was Ramchandra Reddy? He was a well-known educated landlord of the area, and brother-in-law of the Communist leader Ravinarayan Reddy. Ravinarayan later claimed that the wish expressed by V. Narasimha Reddy, father of Ramchandra and father-in-law of Ravinarayan, was the result of the Communist struggle!¹⁷ For Ravinarayan, Ramchandra was a good-natured but gullible man. Congress tried to encash the goodwill he had earned as the first Bhoodan donor by making

him a candidate of the Party in 1957 elections. He stood for the election despite Vinoba and JP's advice to the contrary, and lost.

Ramchandra, although his first offer of land was in keeping with his father's wish, donated land whenever asked thereafter also. No Bhoodan worker who came to him went back empty-handed. By 1955, he had donated 400 acres and was left with only 70 acres of land for his big family; as many as 54 acres being non-irrigated. When Damodardas Moondada met him in 1955 and told him about gramdan, he expressed his willingness to join it.¹⁸

Roderic Church has contended that Reddy did not want to give the land to the Dalits directly; merit could be had only if it was given to a Brahmin and a religious figure; and that Vinoba had probably realized this: "- - - he could see that if he was not involved as an intermediary, the Harijans might go without their land."¹⁹ This seems to be a far-fetched conjecture. The land was not offered to Vinoba, but through him to the Dalits for their benefit. Anyway, bhoodan was later given to all sorts of workers, and expressly for the landless; so there was no question of earning merit by donating to a religious figure.

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Pochampalli incident was unexpected. It did cause excitement in the people. But was it just an isolated incident in a particular situation, or had it some unforeseen import? Witnesses to events that later change the course of history often fail to realize the full import of what they had been witness to. It is only the revolutionary genius that understands hidden potentialities in such events.

Vinoba, characteristically, does not appear to have been carried away by the incident. But as he brooded over it in the night, as he himself admitted later, he could not sleep. What was the significance of the incident? The landless had become articulate. He had casually asked for land and got it. Can land be so asked for and obtained? Reddy was honouring the wish of his late father. Will landowners part with a portion of their land without such background? And that too in such a large

measure that land hunger of millions in India could be satisfied? It would need, as he calculated, 50 million acres of land—one-sixth of the entire cultivable land in the country. Can so much land be obtained; and that too by a man without any kind of power or backing of a big organization? Rational thinking clearly pointed towards impossibility of this idea. There was no use discussing it with anyone. Nobody would have believed that such an idea could possibly work.

But then, here was a nonviolent technique that could perhaps be, if tried, a starting point for the total social transformation that Gandhi dreamt of and which India sorely needed. And that had been Vinoba's quest too since the departure of his master. Who could think that an ordinary thing like salt could shake the entire nation and dig the grave of an empire on which the sun never set? To the 'rationalist' doubters, Gandhi had simply suggested: 'Give it a try.' Now that a possibility of a nonviolent solution to a problem had presented itself, what was needed was 'to give it a try'. As Vinoba said later,

"I thought that there cannot be a partial scheme in nature. The moment a child is born, it feels hunger; and at the same time there is milk in the mother's breast; such is the way of God. So I realized that the power behind the working of the universe wants to do something new. - - - If I do not grasp the import of this incident, I should say goodbye to my faith in nonviolence or become a pessimist. But I was not ready for either."²⁰

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The news of the land-gift spread instantly. The next day, on 19 April, Vinoba received second donation of land, while on way to Tangalpalli. To the villagers, who had come to greet him at a village in the way and had offered sweets for breakfast, he asked for land instead and got 25 acres.²¹

In a way, it was the first bhoodan; it was the first time a gift of land was specifically sought for the landless and was given. Ramchandra Reddy had honoured his father's wish; here there was no such motivation. It is also noteworthy that the gift was not given at a halt, so there was no question of Vinoba's

addressing the people there and appealing to their reason or heart. Perhaps the time of the idea had come.

As Vinoba said later, “Euclid has taught that a line is formed when two points are joined. A line had been formed by these two gifts.”²² Now that line needed to be extended. Vinoba moved ahead, extending the line. Bhoodan-Ganga had emerged.

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At Tangalpalli, the next halt, 90 acres of land were donated; the major chunk of 50 acres came from Venkat Reddy, host of the tour party in the village. The phenomenon had now grabbed the imagination of the people. Communists had only made tall promises; the nonviolent way was giving concrete results. At Sarvel, the second halt, on 20 April, the figure of bhoodan was 200 acres. The stream was gradually widening day-by-day.

But, will such relatively small donations from the big landlords be sufficient to make a dent on the problem? Was not legislation the real answer? These questions were asked by the sceptics and the critics—and they continued to be asked even when repeatedly replied. Vinoba’s answer was:

“Be patient. If somebody is giving 100 acres out of 5000 acres, I take it. The rest 4,900 acres too are mine. When they (the landlords) see that they get love from the poor in exchange for the land, they will give more. - - - I am not naive, as the Communists think; I know my trade. Let atmosphere be created first, then legislation is bound to follow. And then it will be acceptable to all. This bhoodan is like a wedge on which the hammer of law will ultimately strike. Communists too want legislation in the end. But they start with the stick and the loot, and I start with love and charity.”²³

A new thought had germinated. Vinoba’s genius blossomed in realizing and explaining its various facets and implications.

On 22 April, at Sivannaguda, local villagers made many complaints against land-grabbing by a landlord. Vinoba took up the issue in his public meeting, which resulted in the peasants getting back their land. Such dispensation of justice, which was

free, quick and satisfying to all the concerned parties and was conducive to the peace and unity in the village, became a regular feature of the Telangana tour hereafter. Vinoba probably used the term '*yajna*' for the first time at Sivannaguda.

Redistribution of land was necessary, but not sufficient, for the solution of land problem. Irrigation was a vital need. At Turpalli (26 April), Vinoba made an appeal for the construction of wells at the time of marriages.²⁴

At Pedamungal (29 April), he appealed to small landholders also and received 53 acres from them. After all, this was a *yajna* in which everyone should contribute. It was not just a matter of transfer of land; it was a movement for the total reconstruction of society. The idea was not to increase the number of landowners; it was the socialization, or rather villagisation, of land that Vinoba had in mind: "The village is one single family. The villagers should become one and realize that land—in fact, every kind of wealth—belongs to all; to the whole village."²⁵

Vinoba walked on, hearing the victims of the Communist and the police violence, consoling them, appealing them to discard fear and give up drinking, which were the main causes of their plight, and calling upon all to discharge their duties. Through dusty roads, hills and forests, Vinoba's party went on walking, going from village to village, spreading the message of peace and love.

Vinoba continued to impress upon the Communists the futility of violence, particularly in the changed circumstances, and called upon them to discard violence and participate in the first general elections.²⁶ The Communists, on the other hand, distributed a pamphlet, appealing to the people not to help bhoodan. Vinoba also put the grievances of the people before the government officials and saw to it that justice was done in as many cases as possible. He also appealed to the faction-ridden local Congress to take part in bhoodan; warning them that they would not otherwise be able to stand against the Communists who had gained sympathy of the poor, and 'would meet their end in Nalgonda'.²⁷

By now, the news of this novel campaign had spread beyond the boundaries of India. Correspondent of 'Times' met the touring party at Chandupatla (14 May). Many more correspondents, Indian and foreign, were to follow. And many more people from different walks of life from different parts of India and the world were to come and join the pilgrimage to see at close quarters what was happening. Prime Minister Nehru, impressed by this, conveyed his appreciation to Vinoba. Referring to bhoodan in the Parliament on 16 May, he paid tribute to Vinoba's accomplishment, which 'even a strong contingent of army could hardly have been able to achieve'.²⁸

At Kalladi (27 May), a landlord offered 100 acres on the condition that it should be used for collective farming; otherwise he was ready to give only 50 acres. Vinoba refused to agree to the condition.²⁹ He had talked of collective farming At Pochampalli, but now he had come to realize that it would lead to exploitation of peasants unless they were educated and enlightened. Later, he told R.K. Patil, a member of the Planning Commission, that government-driven experiments of collective farming had failed.³⁰ He, however, had no objection if the peasants themselves so desired. The landlord ultimately gave not 100 but 125 acres!

Vinoba did not beg for land; he asked for it as the right of the landless to land. So, every landholder was expected to give irrespective of their landholding. Charity, in fact, is the duty of all and for all the times. Everything that one possesses—be it land, wealth, intellect, time, capacity for labour—should be shared with others. It is not sufficient to hold what we have as trustees; it has to be surrendered to the society.³¹ Charity does not mean obliging anybody: "Our scriptures define charity as equal sharing—*danam samvibhagah*. Charity implies equal distribution in the society."³²

Vinoba always held that the traditionally accepted and revered terms should not be discarded; they should rather be infused with new meanings. For him, that was an integral part of the process of nonviolent transformation:

"Those who understand the essence of words do not discard

the old words. If we do so, we shall lose our weapons one by one. We should keep intact the power in old words and reinforce them with new vitality. As far as the word '*dana*' (charity) is concerned, there is really no need to give it a new meaning. But we lack intellect and education and an understanding of our culture. The Gita teaches the ingenuity of giving new meanings to old words. We too should enhance the power in old words."³³

Vinoba now began to exhort the people to consider the *daridranarayan* (God in the form of the poor) as a part of their families; normally a family has five members, so he should be considered the sixth member and one-sixth of the land should be donated in bhoodan. He had already calculated that one-sixth of the cultivable land needed to be transferred to the landless for the solution of the land problem. Big landowners were, of course, expected to donate more, but even the smaller ones were called upon to give something in the spirit of sacrifice. Again, charity was not to be a one-time affair; it should become a part of life and should become the starting point of the process of transformation of life—otherwise it was of no use.

Vinoba also continued to explain the idea of *yajna* in various ways:

"Whenever peace gets disturbed, the wise here initiate a *yajna*. When I saw the disturbances here, I thought that I should also undertake a *yajna*. I realized that the time needs sacrifice of the animal in the form of greed. So I started bhoodan - - - Those who get land should work on it and increase production; that will be *yajna* for them."³⁴

For Vinoba, he was just an instrument of the Time Spirit. Bhoodan was not something that had merely to do with the solution of a problem; it was a work of revolutionary character, an experiment in nonviolence. That was why the figures of gifts received had little importance to him; what was important was the extent of transformation brought about in the people's lives, the extent to which the good in the society got organized, the number of selfless workers arisen through this movement. For that was what mattered in the long run.³⁵ And moral elevation

was clearly in evidence. For example, when Kodanda Reddy gave one-fourth of his share in the ancestral land (at Suryapat on 13 May), his elder brother was hurt: Why had he not given one-fourth of the entire land?³⁶

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On 7 June 1951, workers in the Hyderabad state met at Mancherial. The walking tour was evaluated. Addressing the conference, Vinoba said,

“I knew that I was going into a territory full of dangers. I had thought that if a solution could be found, well and good; if I had to face the danger myself, that too would be good, as a peaceful solution would then naturally come to mind. But, by the grace of God, the whole atmosphere got changed.

“I can say this much that I did my utmost to reach the hearts of the Communists. I told them that their claim had never been successfully validated anywhere. Secondly, even if violence may not be ruled out under any circumstances, they must have put down arms after the attainment of Independence and the grant of adult suffrage.”

He continued,

“This (the land problem) is world-wide in scope, and if we could solve it in a peaceful way, it will have to be considered a great discovery. If we can do it—and I believe that we can do it—the world will find a way to liberation - - - This work has seeds of the world revolution in its womb.”³⁷

Therefore, just inflating the figure of gifts was never in view: “Whenever I had any doubt about the purity of motive behind the gift, I declined to accept it.”³⁸

By this time, around 9-10,000 acres of land had been received. It was necessary to make arrangement for its distribution. Vinoba constituted a committee comprising of Ummetul Keshava Rao (Convener), Sangam Laxmibai and Kodand Ram Reddy. He called it a ‘*shoonya samiti*’, implying that it would keep itself in the background and work with the cooperation of all. All the three were Congress workers and had been associated with the campaign. Senior Congress leaders

Swami Ramanand Tirth and K.V. Ranga Reddy assured full co-operation to this committee.

However, the government thought of undertaking the distribution of bhoodan lands and appointed a committee for this purpose. But Vinoba wanted this work done through bhoodan workers, as people had given lands in bhoodan, not to the government. It was certainly not advisable that the government machinery should undertake distribution of the gifted lands obtained through a voluntary initiative, although lands were getting legally vested in the government after the gifts. The donors also would not have liked it, as they had given lands in response to Vinoba's moral persuasion. The government, to its credit, beat retreat and accorded official recognition to the committee appointed by Vinoba.

Mancherial Conference also discussed the conditions for allotment and the modalities for distribution, and resolved to collect 1,00,000 acres in the state within one year. Distribution was soon started. Communists had given lands to their followers and sympathisers, which were now reverting to the erstwhile owners. In bhoodan, the landless were getting permanent title to land with official approval. As Keshava Rao reported to Vinoba after distributing 12 acres to 3 Dalit families:

"The landless were finding it hard to believe what was happening—was it just a dream? Nobody had heard or seen anything like that. A wave of surprise was passing through the village and the neighbouring villages. Revolutionary transformation was being actually experienced."³⁹

Telangana tour proceeded till 14 June. The fact that it was greeted by crowds upto 10,000 to 12,000 persons even in villages was a testimony to the hope and enthusiasm it had aroused. The tour lasted for 58 days and yielded gifts of 12,201 acres.⁴⁰

Vinoba's open court was a noteworthy feature of the Telangana tour. Villages were plagued by disputes, particularly those relating to land. Eviction of tenants was on the rise as of land reform acts were being talked about. Police excesses were an irritant. It was impossible for the poor to approach the courts of law. Vinoba's court settled many disputes. Vinoba, needless

to say, had no legal authority; it was his moral stature that made all the concerned parties to accept his verdicts. Even government officials and police personnel would attend Vinoba's court, carry out his directions and report the action taken to him. In this court, one was not supposed to accuse anyone, but tell where one erred. An estimate put the number of cases settled in Vinoba's court at 500.⁴¹ The Communists also used to hold 'people's court', but that was more a means to terrorize the people than an attempt to solve the disputes. Settlement in Vinoba's court was aimed at promoting harmonious relations in the villages.

Vinoba naturally received co-operation from the Congress. Communists could not be expected to do so, and no other political party had sizeable following. Congressmen and constructive workers had worked together for years and naturally had close relations. Congress ranks could still boast of selfless constructive workers. Hyderabad Congress, moreover, was led by Swami Ramanand Tirtha, a *sannyasi*. Yet, Vinoba does appear to have taken care that this close co-operation did not lead to the identification of bhoodan work with the Congress.

M.K. Vellodi, Chief Minister of Hyderabad, in his letter dated 20 June, expressed his 'grateful thanks for the very noble effort in helping in the solution of a problem which has been, perhaps, the most difficult problem before the government.'⁴²

Damodardas Moondada pithily sums up the tour:

"It was an area where thousands had been killed in the name of service and equality. Life was under threat. Military and Police were at the end of their tether. Then, there were no bhoodan committees. Neither was there any organization nor any well-laid out strategy. Staying arrangements and programmes were not planned beforehand. One had to go from house to house to meet the people and comfort them and fortify their spirits. For a fraction of an acre, thought had to be explained patiently and thoroughly. Vinoba did all this—without having the advantage of knowing the language and staking all the power of his reason and other capacities and his genius."⁴³

5. Bhoodan Gathers Momentum

While returning to Pavnar from Telangana, Vinoba was not keen on appealing for bhoodan, still some land was received. Vinoba now wanted to concentrate again on his experiment of '*Kanchan-mukti*' (freedom from money). On reaching Pavnar, he said on 27 June:

"People expect me to ask for land, but I have no such intention. The experiment to be conducted here is more arduous and more fundamental. - - - Bhoodan, undoubtedly, is a great idea; but the most important idea before me is to find out how difficulties of every kind in the society, and in the life of the individual, may be overcome by nonviolence. That is my chief task; and that is why I went to Telangana. - - - I do not intend to do bhoodan work here, although I do want it to go on in Telangana, if possible."¹

Vinoba had tried to have a dialogue with the Communists in jails, but rather than having ideological discussions, they had only complained about prison conditions. S.A. Dange, a veteran underground Communist leader, wrote a long letter to Vinoba on 7 June. He appreciated Vinoba's goodwill in visiting Communist prisoners and said that their Party also wanted restoration of peaceful conditions in Telangana:

"In Telangana, the main question is not whether we are violent or nonviolent. - - - You have shown, I believe, an appreciation of the fact that the main problem is that of land and without solving it, the problem of our country cannot be solved.

"If that is your conclusion, let me assure you that I agree with you, and so do my friends. For all these years, the Telangana struggle has been fought just for that main purpose."

Dange repeated the Communist stand that violence was not their creed; it was the situation that had forced them to resort to it, and wrote, "If you think, I can be of service for the solution of the Telangana problem in such a way as to bring

happiness to the people there, I am at your service.”²

Vinoba, in his reply, expressed regret that Dange had to remain underground and reiterated the need to discard violence and change their policy in the interest of the poor and also also of Communism.³

He put the essence of the outcome of the tour in the following words:

“When I consider what words I should use to describe my experience, the only word that suggests itself to me is ‘*sakshatkar*’ (direct vision). In the Telangana tour, I had, in a way, direct vision of God. I worked in the faith that the human heart has goodness in it and that could be called out, and God let me see that in accordance with my faith.”⁴

On 15 June, a day after the departure of Vinoba, Hyderabad Congress Committee expressed gratitude towards Vinoba and made an appeal to Congress workers to continue bhoodan work. All-India Congress Committee too, in its Bangalore session on 15 July, expressed satisfaction about Vinoba’s tour.⁵ Socialists too appreciated Vinoba’s work. Veteran Socialist leader Jayaprakash Narayan met Vinoba at Pavnar and had extensive discussions with him.

The nation was embarking on the experiment of planned development. Planning Commission had been constituted and the First Five-Year Plan was being drafted. Prime Minister Nehru sent R.K. Patil, a member of the Commission, to meet Vinoba and discuss the Plan with him. Patil had detailed discussions with Vinoba on various matters including agriculture, employment, village industries, education, family planning, land distribution and the ban on cow slaughter. Vinoba severely criticized the Draft, and insisted that a plan must ensure full employment and food self-sufficiency. He also called for taking up land distribution irrespective of the difficulties.⁶

When Patil apprised Nehru of this, Nehru thought that it would be better if Vinoba could discuss the Plan in detail with the entire Commission. In the newly-Independent country, perhaps it was the need of the rulers to consult, and if possible,

propitiate the Gandhians even while pursuing 'modern' development! So Nehru invited Vinoba to come to Delhi. Vinoba knew that the direction of the Plan was wrong and perhaps had little hope of its rectification, but he decided to take this opportunity to apprise the planners of the Sarvodaya approach. He accepted the invitation and set out for Delhi—but on foot. He wanted to have first-hand experience of the conditions in the country, and also to see whether the bhoodan way could be tried in regions other than Telangana.

On the eve of the commencement of his tour on 12 September, Vinoba said:

"Tomorrow morning, I shall proceed to Delhi. One main work before me during the tour will be to give lands to the poor. It is not good that those who can toil on the land do not possess land. It is adversely affecting production and accentuating inequalities and discontent. Everyone toiling in the fields should, therefore, get land. How is this possible? One way that we find in history is expropriation of the landowners. But this is against humanity and is not creditable. It will accentuate enmity and hatred in the society; it will not lead to peace and happiness. We should, therefore, try to persuade people to part with land voluntarily in a spirit of love and co-operation.

"I have called the work I had started, not merely bhoodan but Bhoodan-Yajna. Only the rich can give land, but everyone can participate in a yajna. We want to build up the spirit of giving throughout the country and create an atmosphere that would be conducive in this respect. If land-gifts had been received in Telangana solely because of the Communist disturbances, we better give up any hope for nonviolent revolution in India. But I do hope that if people understand the basic philosophy behind bhoodan, they will, with concern for the poor, give me lands."⁷

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And people started giving land. Even before starting the journey, residents of Wardha gave him 600 acres. At every halt, land-gifts poured in. In a week, the gifts had touched the figure

of 2,000 acres.⁸ The tour party was enthusiastically welcomed everywhere—despite lack of planning and preparation.

Vinoba was not only asserting the right of the landless, he was also questioning the very idea of owning the land—it was not only wrong to claim ownership on land, which should, like air, water and sunlight, be freely available to all, it was a sin: “The Gita has called them demons who claim lordship over something which rightfully belongs to God.”⁹

Discovery of a new mode for nonviolent transformation had injected a new zeal and power in his words, and it had also changed his nature dramatically:

“I have been a wild animal by nature, without the least awareness of etiquette. I am hesitant to meet eminent persons. But now I go to anybody without the least hesitation.”¹⁰

A recluse by nature, Vinoba was now meeting all kinds of people, explaining his ideas, answering doubts and criticisms. And gifts were being received not only at his halts, people were also coming to him from afar and offering lands.

At Sagar, on 2 October, Gandhi’s birth anniversary, Vinoba put forth the demand for 50 million acres—one-sixth of the land under cultivation in the country—which, according to his estimate, was necessary to satisfy the land hunger of the landless and bring about equitable redistribution of land.¹¹

The tour yielded 6,400 acres in the Central Provinces.¹² Workers in the province resolved to collect 1,00,000 acres. Seth Govind Das and Thakur Niranjana Singh, main leaders of Congress, although opposed to each other, pledged co-operation to bhoodan. Vinoba constituted a committee comprising of Dadabhai Naik, Appaji Gandhi and Rajendra Malpani to look after bhoodan in the region. In Vindhya Pradesh, he entrusted this task to the committee of Banarasidas Chaturvedi, Lalaram Vajpayee and Chaturbhuj Pathak.

Zamindari abolition laws were being enacted in different states. They provided for payment of compensation, as right to property was a fundamental right in the Constitution. Vinoba appealed to the landlords to give land in bhoodan and forego

compensation.

On 16 October, Vinoba entered Uttar Pradesh. At Chirgaon, he received the blessings of the great poet Maithilisharan Gupta. At Jhansi, a lady named Kanak Kunwar gave away 500 acres—her entire land. At Gwalior, he met jagirdars of the region, who were up in arms against the impending jagirdari abolition bill in the state Legislative Assembly. Acharya Kripalani, one of the leading apostles of Gandhi and the patriarch of constructive work in the state, called on the people and the constructive workers in the state to extend full co-operation to bhoodan.

A conference of constructive workers in the state at Mathura, on 2 November, resolved to collect 5,00,000 acres in the state. By this time, 12,000 acres had been received in the state. It was an indication of growing enthusiasm and hope. Vinoba made a fervent appeal to the workers to leave other work and concentrate all their energies on bhoodan for a few years, because “all the programmes proposed by Gandhiji are in danger if nonviolence does not succeed in solving the present problem. If it does, then khadi, service of Harijans—everything will make progress.”¹³ At Mathura, Vinoba explained at length the concept of *samyayoga*, his philosophy of life.

An important outcome of the Mathura conference was the dedication of life to bhoodan by Baba Raghavdas. Born in Maharashtra, Baba had lost his family in an epidemic at a tender age and then roamed all over the country in search of spiritual solace. He finally settled in Uttar Pradesh and became a leading light of constructive work and freedom movement in the state. When Vinoba was touring the state, he was a member of the state Legislative Assembly and was connected with scores of institutions.

On 13 November 1951, Vinoba reached Delhi. In a couple of months, he had received land-gifts of 19,436 acres.¹⁴ The conjecture that land-gifts might have been received in Telangana because of Communist disturbances had been decisively refuted.

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Before reaching Delhi, Vinoba had sent a short message to

Delhiites: "I am coming not to beg (*bhiksha*) but to initiate you into the performance of a sacred duty (give *deeksha*)."¹⁵ It was going to be his refrain thereafter.

Many Delhiites walked 11 km to welcome Vinoba. A hut was erected for him near Gandhi Samadhi at Rajghat. From commoners to high officials and ministers and even the President of the Republic met Vinoba in that hut, removing their shoes before entering. This was an intriguing sight for foreign correspondents.

In the evening meeting on his very first day at Delhi, Vinoba said that he was searching a way whereby a serious current problem could be solved through nonviolence—a way that was in consonance with Gandhiji's teachings and the Indian culture; a way which could set off nonviolent revolution and the establishment of Sarvodaya: "I could get hold of such a thing in Telangana - - - I have now found a mission."¹⁶ Dr. Rajendra Prasad, President of the Republic, offered to Vinoba as much of his land in Bihar as Vinoba wanted.

Discussions were held with the Planning Commission for three days. Prime Minister Nehru, who was also the Chairman of the Planning Commission, attended some meetings despite his busy schedule. Vinoba reiterated his criticism and said that his opinions had been reinforced by the experiences during his journey to Delhi.

In his public speeches, Vinoba pleaded for a labour-oriented society and planning for full employment: "Full employment should be the basic postulate of national planning. If the majority is denied work in the name of efficiency, it is no national planning; it is rather partial planning."¹⁷ Later, he had commented that if planning had to be partial, 'let partiality be for the poor!'¹⁸ He pointed out limitations of power, distinguished it from strength and observed that after Independence, pure social service had become the source of strength rather than politics. Emphasising the need for a band of workers free from party affiliations, he proposed a five-fold programme for them: self-purification, study, service—particularly of the neglected sections of the society, pointing out

wrongs in governmental actions and, if need be, satyagraha—that is, seeking non-violent solutions to social problems.¹⁹ He, of course, explained different facets and implications of bhoodan: “I seek triple transformation—first that of hearts, then of lives, and thereafter, of the society.”²⁰

During his stay, Vinoba interacted with different strata of the society. In a women's meeting, he supported the Hindu Code Bill, which had generated much heat, and declared that nothing in it was against Hinduism.²¹ He caused to remove restrictions on the movement of Sansis, an allegedly ‘criminal’ tribe. He also addressed a conference of Congress workers and two press conferences. During the 11 days of his stay 1,200 acres were received in bhoodan.

Vinoba left Delhi on 24 November. But he was not going to return to Pavnar. Now his feet were going to traverse the whole country—the historic pilgrimage on foot was to continue for 13 years.

24 November was the last date for filing nominations for the first general elections. Election fever was catching on. Fearing that workers would be busy in election work and people too would not be receptive to bhoodan's message, Vinoba was advised to suspend the tour for some time. But he declined. Political workers were naturally displeased with this decision. Even in the politically surcharged atmosphere, crowds of thousands continued to be throng Vinoba's meetings. It may be mentioned that Congressmen were particularly unhappy, as Sarva Seva Sangh had not supported the Congress.

Bhoodan was beginning to attract attention of the foreigners too. Anarchist weekly ‘Freedom’, in its issue dated 15 December, commented on bhoodan, noting particularly that the land-gifts indicated that the belief of the haves in the justifiability of their privileged positions was being shaken, which, as history shows, was often the starting point of revolution.²²

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From Delhi, Vinoba proceeded to Uttar Pradesh. On 28 November, M.S. Golwalkar, chief of Rashtriya Swayamsevak

Sangh met him at Meerut and expressed support.²³ At Kaladungi (31 December), an old woman came at the halting place of the touring party at night and waited throughout the night to offer land-gift. At Itawa, president of the District Board gave away entire 10 acres of his land. At Mainpuri, Communist leader Baburam Paliwal gave bhoodan. A 9-year old boy offered donation of 70 acres, while Sayyad Hussain, an eminent citizen of Bangalore, sent gift of 1,000 acres. Such was the goodwill being created. That a human being has goodness in him and it could be drawn out was no more merely theoretical proposition; several incidents were actually testifying to its truth.

Results of the general election were out in February 1952. Congress got only 45% votes, but secured overwhelming majority in Parliament and in all the state Assemblies. Socialist party led by leading lights of the freedom movement like Narendra Dev and Jayaprakash Narayan and Kisan Mazdoor Praja Party led by veteran Gandhians Acharya Kripalani and T. Prakasam fared much below their expectations. Vinoba made an appeal to all to apply themselves to the service of the poor, as elections were over; and said that bhoodan was such a programme of service wherein all the parties could work together.²⁴

Uttar Pradesh Congress Committee expressed support for bhoodan and observed 'Bhoodan fortnight'. At Balia, Communists presented a scroll of honour to Vinoba. The scroll contained a statement that the land problem would not be solved without organization of the poor. Referring to it, Vinoba said that his work was for the organization of poor:

"In reality, the poor are not only landless, they are also voiceless. I am pleading their case as best as possible. I do not beg for land; I ask for it as the right of the landless. I accept one or even a half bigha²⁵ from an owner of 5 bighas, but decline a gift of 100 acres from an owner of 10,000 acres. I have returned many such gifts. It is true that gifts are given with all possible motives, but when I find that the motive is not pure, I tell the donor that I will accept his gift only if he considers me a member of his family and concedes the right of the landless. You will, therefore, appreciate that my work is that of organization of the poor."²⁶

It was beyond the imagination of the people that an asset like land would be voluntarily gifted in response to a moral appeal. While a few tried to understand the phenomenon through first-hand experience, bystanders interested only in picking holes assumed and even proclaimed as a fact that such land was barren! Vinoba pointed out,

“I must say that I have not yet met a single man who had deliberately donated barren land. A gentleman gifted 1,000 acres in Hyderabad, but when our workers found out at the time of distribution that 500 acres were uncultivable, the donor immediately replaced it with cultivable land.”²⁷

Another objection was that it would take many years to solve the problem by this technique. Firebrand Socialist leader Dr. Ram Manohar Lohia said that it would take 160 years. (The figure was wrongly reported as 300.) It clearly betrayed the lack of understanding of the process of revolutionary transformation. Vinoba quipped that he had calculated that it would take 500 years, but as Lohia was talking of 300 years, it meant that Lohia was going to help him and thus expedite the work!²⁸ Lohia wrote a letter to Vinoba (on 15 April) putting forth his appraisal of bhoodan. He said that the work was indeed good, but had limits and ultimately legislation or satyagraha would have to be resorted to.²⁹ Vinoba replied that arithmetical calculations do not apply to such work. Referring to Lohia's contention that change of hearts and that of society, both had their own limits, he said,

“It may be so. But so long as that limit has not been reached, why should I let that affect my heart? Rationally I may accept that such a limit exists, but why should I give a place to that idea in my heart? Why shouldn't I believe that God, who has convinced me about a particular thing, would not convince others as well? I am nursing my sick father. Shouldn't I nurse him with the hope that he would recover, although rationally I may accept the possibility that my efforts may be of little or no avail? - - -

“I have never said that recourse must not be taken to legislation and satyagraha even when needed. I am not blocking legislation; in fact, I believe that my work would

create an atmosphere conducive to good legislation. - - -

“About satyagraha, I hold certain opinions. I have some experience in this regard and have a particular approach. If in the context of all the three, satyagraha appears inevitable to me, I hope I would not procrastinate. But I do not look upon it as a pressure tactics.”³⁰

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Fourth Sarvodaya Conference was held at Sevapuri (Varanasi) between 13 and 16 April 1952 in Vinoba's presence. This was the first Sarvodaya conference after the advent of bhoodan. Sarva Seva Sangh had already expressed full support to bhoodan and in the meeting on 22 January 1952, it adopted the programme and undertook the responsibility of its propagation and organisation.³¹ At Sevapuri, it resolved to collect 2.5 million acres within two years.³² Work started by Vinoba on his own personal initiative now received the backing of a nation-wide organization of Gandhian fraternity.

The Conference was presided over by Shrikrishnadas Jajoo and inaugurated by Acharya Kripalani. Gulzarilal Nanda and R.K. Patil attended it as Nehru's emissaries. They did try to assure that changes would be made in the Draft Five-Year Plan in the light of the objections raised by Vinoba, but the direction the policies of the government and the ruling Congress Party were taking was already becoming evident. To give an example, workers from Santhal Pargana (tribal region in Bihar) told the Conference that the ruling Congress Party was opposing the movement for prohibition and the President of the Party had even threatened disciplinary action against the workers participating in the movement; and that the state government had started selling bulbous roots, which was a staple food of the tribals, to the contractors.³³

Touching incidents were reported by the workers in the Conference. At Choudahapur, a blind man named Ramcharan had come at night at a halting place in Vinoba's trek and waited throughout the night to gift 12 bighas. At Rudhauri, a Dalit with a family of twelve that lived on grains extracted from dung, insisted on gifting something out of 2.5 bighas; and a gift of one

decimal had to be accepted. Such incidents were giving a glimpse of the morally-surcharged atmosphere.

In the Conference, Vinoba dwelt on several topics and explained the working of bhoodan. To the objection that it enhances prestige of the donor but lowers the self-esteem of the poor recipients, he said, "It could have been so, had I given him (the poor) ready food. But now he is getting land on which he would have to labour." Accepting the criticism that he was stoking land hunger which could lead to rebellion, he declared, "Yes, I want to avoid a kind of revolution and bring about another kind of revolution. I want to stand in the way of violent revolution and bring about nonviolent revolution."³⁴

By this time, the figure of bhoodan had crossed the figure of 1,00,000 acres. Not only was it being received by Vinoba, but workers in different parts of the country had also started getting it. Besides constructive workers and political workers, new blood was also joining the work, which was now taking the form of a rapidly-growing movement.

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When Vinoba resumed his tour on 20 April, the tour party had a French lady and a Chilean lady with it. At Tikardih (22 April), where there was no halt, all the landowners, most of them poor, gifted a part of their land and the land gifted was sufficient for all the twelve landless families in the village. The donors also gave seeds and other inputs, and after doing all this, they came to meet Vinoba.³⁵

On 23 April, the halt was at Jaunpur. The ex-Raja of Jaunpur was the chief of Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh in Uttar Pradesh. Not only the R.S.S. welcomed Vinoba, Raja Yadavendra gifted 2,000 acres.³⁶ Vinoba, in his speech, delineated salient features of Indian culture and explained the essence of the *varna* system:

"Equal right to spiritual liberation irrespective of the vocation, equal monetary remuneration for all sorts of work and absence of any feeling of high and low—this is the essence of *varna* system."³⁷

On 28 April, Vinoba issued an appeal to the countrymen to participate in what he called '*Prajasooya Yajna*'³⁸:

"I have a triple claim to make for this work. First, it is in consonance with the Indian culture; secondly, it has seeds of economic and social revolution in it; and thirdly, it can help in the establishment of peace in the world."³⁹

On 1 May, the labour day, Vinoba described bhoodan as a labour movement—a movement of the landless, inarticulate, unawakened and unorganized labourers: "It is natural for Sarvodaya and nonviolence to take up the issue of the lowliest."⁴⁰

Vinoba reached Lucknow, the capital of Uttar Pradesh, on 8 May. At Lucknow, Chief Minister Govind Ballabh Pant, ministers, political leaders, bureaucrats, press correspondents, panchayat officials and many others called on him. Legal arrangements about land distribution were particularly discussed. Uttar Pradesh became the first state to enact Bhoodan law.

On 9 May, the birth anniversary of Gautam Buddha, Vinoba termed his movement '*Dharma-chakra-pravartan*' (setting the wheel of *dharma* in motion), a term used by Buddha, underlining the deep spiritual significance of the movement.⁴¹

At Kanpur (13 May), 10,800 acres were presented to him as against the target of 10,000 acres. To those who were advocating satyagraha for the solution of land problem, he said,

"If necessitated, I shall certainly resort to it. Even today, I am doing satyagraha. Satyagraha means putting forth your perception of truth, insist on it, create conducive atmosphere for it, try to enter with love the hearts of those who have pitted themselves against you. It is like entering into the bodies of others."⁴²

Later he was to repeat it again and again.

On 18 May, Vinoba inaugurated land distribution in Uttar Pradesh at Pukhraya. Only 10 bighas were available; they could be given to only two families, but the landless families

numbered 10. So, Vinoba asked the landless who were the poorest among them. That prompted some of them to withdraw in favour of the poorest ones. Vinoba then appealed to those present to gift land again, and many came forward. A refugee of Partition, who had been given land there, gave away his entire land—more than 15 bighas.⁴³

While the trek was passing through Bundelkhand region, residents of the village Mangroth came to see Vinoba on the banks of river Betwa, as no halt was proposed in their village. To them, Vinoba gave a message: 'All land belongs to God'. Their leader set his heart on this message. And the villagers did something that was going to add a new revolutionary dimension to Bhoodan-Yajna, and to political science as well.

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Diwan Shatrughna Singh, a prominent landlord of Mangroth, was a pro-poor nationalist despite his upbringing in a feudal family. He participated in the satyagraha struggles in 1920, 1930 and 1942 and went to jail. He also relinquished his right on the ancestral land. His wife Rajendrakumari also took part in the freedom movement, cast aside *purdah* and donated her ornaments to the Congress. The Diwan naturally became the undisputed leader of the region and earned the title 'Bundelkhand-Kesari' (Lion of Bundelkhand) from the people.

He attended the Sarvodaya Conferenve at Sevapuri where Vinoba had expressed the desire to see all the landholders of a village giving bhoodan. Diwan Saheb was fascinated by this idea. He urged the villagers to give their entire land in bhoodan. At last, on 23 May, everyone of the landholders agreed and signed gift letters. On the next day, in the noon, Diwan Saheb went pedalling his bicycle in the scorching heat to Rath, where Vinoba was halting, and put all the gift declarations at Vinoba's feet.

"What? Land of the whole village?"—Vinoba asked with amazement, and patted Diwan Saheb, tears flowing down his cheeks. With his voice choked with emotions, he said,

"Never had I thought that a village would gift all of its land. It has given me a new insight. Mangroth is indeed a blessed

village! Just as Bhoodan-Ganga originated with Ramchandra Reddy's gift, now the Gramdan-Ganga has originated, thanks to Diwan Saheb."⁴⁴

Karanbhai, a senior worker from Uttar Pradesh, later recounted:

"I remember the scene at that time. Vinoba did not speak in the prayer meeting that day. He said nothing for two days. On the third day, he said, 'I had not imagined that the Lord would admit of such a thing; now no power on earth can stop the revolution.'"⁴⁵

Mangroth was a heterogeneous village with 107 families belonging to 22 castes. Out of 5,188 acres of the village land, 2,428 acres were in cultivation. But the residents of Mangroth owned only 828 out of these 2,428 acres; the rest had been grabbed by outsiders during the 1930 Movement. There were no irrigation facilities. Out of 107 families, 67 had land; the rest were landless. The land, in general, was of poor quality. The village forest of 2,500 acres had been entirely despoiled.

Creation of a new land system was both a challenge and an opportunity, and Vinoba and his colleagues continued to ponder over the issue along with the villagers.

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From Hamirpur district, Vinoba came to Banda district. In the public meeting at Banda, Jayaprakash Narayan expressed the hope that 'the Bhoodan-Yajna movement will cause the confluence of the streams of Gandhism and Socialism like that of the rivers Ganga and Yamuna, and the unified stream will contribute to the country's progress.'⁴⁶

At the public meeting at Allahabad, thousands listened to Vinoba, sitting on the rain-soaked ground. Bhoodan of 15,000 acres was presented to him. Purushottamdas Tandon, Congress patriarch in the state, consented to preside over the State Bhoodan Committee and joined the walking tour.

Uttar Pradesh Zamindari Abolition Act came into force on 1 July. It gave ownership rights to tenants. "But what about the

landless, who have been deserted by all?”, asked Vinoba while welcoming it.⁴⁷ He also expressed the opinion that while the landlords could be given what was necessary for their living, “it is not necessary to pay compensation in proportion to the land acquired.”⁴⁸

The walking pilgrimage took a break at Varanasi during the rainy season, from 4 July to 11 September. Vinoba addressed many public meetings there. He exhorted the citizens to keep their city clean. Raja of Kashi had already given 7,500 acres; he now gave 1,500 acres more. At Kashi, Vinoba met Mata Anandmayi, a renowned spiritual master. Chief Minister Pant met him there again, commended his moral influence and eulogized his efforts to inculcate the spirit of self-reliance.

Kishorlal Mashruwala, one of the main apostles of Gandhi and editor of ‘Harijan’ passed away on 9 September. Paying tribute to him, Vinoba called him ‘a perfect example of a man who had enmity for none’, and said that he was ‘in the same category as that of Lord Buddha.’⁴⁹

On 11 September, his birthday, Vinoba expressed his resolve not to return to his ashram till the land problem is solved:

“How can I rest before finishing the Lord’s work? Pondering over it, I came to the conclusion that I should make some sacrifice. So, I have decided not to return to the security of ashram. - - - Now I have become ‘an arrow in Lord Rama’s bow’ in its true sense.”⁵⁰

“Vinoba has his hands on the pulse of the people”, vouched Acharya Narendra Dev, veteran Socialist leader. “So long as the land problem is not solved, none of the other problems of the country could be solved. Vinoba’s remarkability lies in realizing this and taking up this issue.”⁵¹

When heavy rains poured during Vinoba’s prayer meeting at Sayyad Raja, the last halt in Uttar Pradesh (13 September), some persons opened their umbrellas. Vinoba asked them to close the umbrellas and ‘let the God’s grace touch them directly’. Immediately the umbrellas were closed.⁵²

Uttar Pradesh tour covered 6,000 km. and halted at 257

places. Twelve thousand donors gave 2,95,054 acres.⁵³ Distribution work was also started. State Bhoodan Committee was constituted. The state administration responded positively. Steps for legislation were initiated. (Bhoodan-Yajna Act, 1952 was later passed by the state legislature in December 1952-January 1953.)

It is worth mentioning that the Act provided for the nomination of the members of the Bhoodan Board, to be constituted under the Act for distribution of bhoodan lands, by Vinoba. Giving such an authority to an individual, who was in no way connected with the government, was something unprecedented. Later, other states followed this precedent. Sympathetic approach of the U.P. government was also evident in its order that the land which was given in bhoodan before the enactment of Zamindari Abolition law would continue to be under the control of the Bhoodan Committee, even if it might be fallow or forest land, although forests had been taken over by the government and management of fallow lands had been entrusted by the state government to the local committees.⁵⁴

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Bhoodan was gaining momentum in other states too. Conferences were being held, workers were setting out on walking tours and Bhoodan committees were being constituted.

Tamil Nadu Bhoodan Conference was held on 21-22 June 1952. A committee comprising Vedratnam Pillai, Jagannathan, Subramaniam, Ramaswami Reddiyar, V.V. Giri etc. was formed. A target of 1,50,000 acres was set for the state. Kerala state conference on 23-24 June resolved to collect 25,000 acres. Shankarrao Deo, Jayaprakash Narayan and Kamraj Nadar toured the state. Punjab state conference was held on 19 July and Lala Achintram set out to propagate bhoodan. Maharashtra conference was held on 4 July. A committee comprising Firodia, former speaker of the state Assembly, Socialist leader S.M. Joshi and others was formed. A target of collecting 1,00,000 acres in one year was set. Shrikrishnadas Jajoo and Tukdoji Maharaj started touring Vidarbha region. Shankarrao Deo toured Rajasthan. The state government announced gift of

1,00,000 acres. Entire land of the village Jamua was donated.

Gujarat conference was held at Bardoli on 27 February 1952. It was revealed there that Harivallabh Parikh had already started the work and collected bhoodan of 1,530 acres. The conference resolved to collect 75,000 acres in two years.

Conferences were held in Bihar and Bengal as well. Socialist leader Charuchandra Bhandari set out on a walking tour. Walking tours were started in Madhya Bharat and Himachal Pradesh. In Hyderabad state, Shankarrao Dev's tour yielded bhoodan of 11,313 acres in 28 days. Atmosphere created by bhoodan stopped eviction of tenants in Himachal Pradesh.

A churning had started in the whole country.

Most of the political parties welcomed and supported bhoodan and their workers were taking active part in the Movement. However, Peasants and Workers (Shetkari Kamgar) Party, a leftist regional party in Maharashtra, passed a resolution to oppose it on the ground that it sought to dissuade peasants from a fight against feudal elements. Vinoba reacted sharply:

“What can one make of this resolution of the Party? Does it mean that people should not gift lands in bhoodan? People have been after acquisition; now if they are inclining towards sharing, who is going to lose? Well, it may be said that nobody should donate out of self-conceit. But I myself am saying that. Does the resolution mean that the landless should not take lands given to them? What will they gain thereby? It may be said that they should not become submissive; but that too I am already saying. Does the resolution mean that token gifts from big landlords should not be accepted? I concur with this, and that has been my practice. Is there an apprehension that this Movement will obstruct the path of a progressive legislation? I have never blocked the way of legislation; in fact, the atmosphere created by Bhoodan Movement is sure to expedite such legislation.

“Is there an apprehension that bhoodan will blunt opposition to injustices? I hold that the opposite is true. I have called upon peasants to oppose eviction nonviolently. And I have

found that this has lifted their spirits.”

He ended with saying, “If some doubts still persist, they should discuss them with me and convince me or get convinced.”⁵⁵

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As bhoodan was gaining momentum, the process of economic development through Five-Year Plans, and the Community Development Programme had also been set in motion. For the former, Soviet Russia was the model, while the latter had behind it the ideas and aid of U.S.A.

Professedly, the Community Development Programme was for building the spirit of self-reliance and co-operation in the rural people, but its content and the manner of its execution was disconcerting for Sarvodaya Workers.

On 5 January 1952, Nehru signed technical co-operation agreement with the Ambassador of U.S.A., providing for the setting up of 55 project areas each consisting of about 300 villages and a population of about 2,00,000. U.S.A. agreed to give 10% of estimated expenditure. Although this was a minor contribution, U.S.A. had been given wide powers.

A gentle and balanced thinker like Kishorlal Mashruwala warned,

“The agreement could prove to be a chain of bondage - - - dangers are not only economic, but political and psychological too. - - - To put it plainly, Panditji’s (Nehru) thinking about economic programmes appears to me to be muddled.”

Predicting that it would give an opportunity to U.S. to gain foothold here, he expressed fear that it would pull India into the politics of Cold War.⁵⁶

J.C Kumarappa thundered,

“American aid is two annas in a rupee (that is, around 12%), but the reins are in their hands. Why should we have begged for their help for such a meagre aid? We should rather have

reduced the number of project areas by 12%.”

But the question was not just of money, it was mainly of attitude: “It appears from this scheme that the Prime Minister does not have faith in the capability of our countrymen.” He also pointed out that the problem of villagisation of land was the most important one in the villages, which the scheme did not touch at all.⁵⁷

Sarva Seva Sangh also noted its objections in its meeting on 24 July and rued that although Gandhian constructive programme was there and it was suitable and useful for the country, the government was neglecting it.⁵⁸

Vinoba opined:

“Although the object of the programme is good, it has not appealed to me much. Raw materials in villages should, as far as possible, be processed in villages with their resources to produce things the villagers need. Villages should, as far as possible, be self-sufficient in food and clothing. I do not find this in the programme.”

He ended with the comment that the object being good, it may be tried in a few regions, avoiding reckless spending of money.⁵⁹

In fact, the need was to arouse and organize the nation's energies and channelize them for national reconstruction. Gandhian Constructive programmes backed by land reform through bhoodan provided a useful model. But the ruling elite had its heart set on the pursuit of ‘modern’ development.

Community Development Programme predictably failed to evoke any popular initiative. In the name of closely working with the people, it strengthened the dominant sections in the villages, thereby accentuating inequalities and deepening fissures within the villages. As Prof. S.C. Dube pointed out, it had nothing for the poor agriculturists, agricultural labourers and artisans,⁶⁰ and its benefits went basically ‘to the elite and to the more affluent and influential agriculturists’⁶¹—both economically and politically. And more disturbingly, it helped spread tentacles of the centralised State in the countryside.

6. Bihar as a Laboratory

The itinerary after the Uttar Pradesh tour had not been decided beforehand. Workers from Bihar had pressed Vinoba at the Sevapuri Conference to come to Bihar, promising to collect 2,00,000 acres. But, by now, experience had spurred Vinoba to try to concentrate on solving the land problem in a particular region. So, he asked the workers to up the target to 4,00,000 acres, that too as the first instalment, as a pre-condition for his coming to Bihar. Workers were not confident about even 2,00,000 acres, but they were keen on bringing Vinoba to Bihar. So they agreed to the condition and Vinoba turned to Bihar.

Bihar was a citadel of feudalism. Zamindari Abolition Act had been passed, but the zamindars were waging a protracted battle against it. The landless were totally depressed, unorganized and powerless. Constructive work was in shambles. Political workers were immersed in power struggle. The situation was thus out-and-out adverse.

But bhoodan's message had reached Bihar's countryside. Sarvanarayandas recounts an incident: He once heard a conversation between two villagers in a remote area. One of them was saying, 'A saint is asking for land-gifts. He is saying that land too is God-made like air, water and sky. It belongs to God.'¹ This startled Sarvanarayandas.

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On 14 September 1952, Vinoba entered Bihar and received a rousing reception. Immediately he spoke about his desire for the complete solution of land problem in Bihar and asked for 5 million acres.² Such an attempt needed to be made as 'time was moving at a rapid pace': "Otherwise our programme would give relief to the people, but it would not become a means for revolution." And why Bihar? "It is a middle-sized state. People are good-natured. The land, where Buddha gave the message of nonviolence, is likely to be better disposed towards

nonviolence.”³

Wherever Vinoba went, people thronged his meetings to hear him, to have a glimpse of the walking saint. They would hear him even in heavy rains. Continuing the tour in the rainy season was quite an ordeal: walking through muddy tracts in the early morning darkness, passing through streams of rivers and rivulets, often in waist-deep waters. Shoes or slippers had to be removed on getting wet and one had to walk barefoot. Gravel and thorns on the way would then pierce the feet and cause blisters. But Vinoba and the workers, fired with a purpose, continued the trek. Patricia MacMahon, a young American lady had also joined the touring party in September 1952. She had resolved to fast on the days that passed without a single land-gift. She was bearing all hardships as she considered herself lucky ‘to observe one of the most successful attempts in applied social psychology of the age’.⁴ Organisation of a walking tour was a new thing; the workers had little experience in the matter. Consequently, the tour party had to walk upto 25 km on some days.

At Kudra, the river Durgavati had to be crossed. Both the Congress and the Socialist workers had kept ready small decorated boats to take Vinoba to the other bank. Insisting that Vinoba should oblige them and not the other party, they began to quarrel with each other! Political rivalries had reached even the villages in the state, vitiating the atmosphere there.⁵ It was bhoodan, which was bringing workers of all the parties together in a common endeavour.

Because of the *purdah* system, the women would not come to public meetings. They would come in the night and often return disappointed on finding Vinoba asleep. Vinoba would chide them: “Are you thieves or robbers to wander in the night? Discard the *purdah*, move fearlessly.” On being told that male members of the household would not let them go anywhere during the day, Vinoba would ask them to rebel.⁶ A revolution never remains restricted to a single aspect; it shakes the society in entirety.

Vinoba had asked for 5 million acres—at least 5 acres from

each village—being one-sixth of the land in the state. But it turned out that one-sixth of the cultivable land in the state amounted to 3.2 million acres. Vinoba accepted this and then continued to harp on the demand for 3.2 million acres. For this purpose he was ready to give as much time to Bihar as needed.

But, although rural Bihar heartily welcomed Vinoba and thousands attended his prayer meetings, the rate of receipt of bhoodan was initially quite low. In the Saran district, only 1,000 acres were received in 15 days, although Dr. Rajendra Prasad, President of India, who hailed from Saran, had issued an open appeal for bhoodan. But the lukewarm response did not dishearten Vinoba, for he had faith that ‘we cannot measure the power generated through continuous repetition of truth’.⁷

Zamindars in Bihar were fighting a legal battle against Zamindari Abolition Act 1949. When the court stayed operation of the law, government repealed it and enacted new land reform law in 1950. Zamindars challenged it too, and the court struck it down. It was then that the Constitution of India was first amended to keep land reform laws out of the purview of the courts. Zamindars challenged the amendment too on some grounds. When finally they lost the case and the law became operative with a few amendments, they did not give land records to the government. The government had to reconstruct the whole records. Moreover, employees of the zamindars, who were under their thumbs, were absorbed in the revenue department on ‘humanitarian’ grounds! All this led to faulty records. The wave of evictions that followed, and the domination of feudal elements in the countryside in general, worsened the situation; and atrocious subsequent settlements made it near-anarchic. Bhoodan could not escape the repercussions of this situation. But that is another story. It may be added that zamindars also tried their best to delay actual handing over of the land to the government. Such is the result of compulsory expropriation. Bhoodan, on the other hand, was eliciting warm response.

It has been alleged on this background that zamindars gave land when they saw that they were going to lose it in any case. But figures tell that a large number of small landholders also

gave land. Secondly, the zamindars giving bhoodan were foregoing claim on compensation they were entitled to. That it increased the probability of distribution of such land in a better manner can also not be overlooked.

Communists had published a pamphlet attacking Vinoba and asking people to beware of him. Vinoba dealt with their objections at Baksar (24 September) and told them that revolution does not follow a predetermined pattern; it depends on the time and place and situation. "You ridicule the idea of change of heart, but you yourself demonstrate the truth in it. Karl Marx's book has converted you." He also denied that bhoodan started because of Communist insurgency: "Bhoodan-Yajna did start in Telangana, but not because of the Communists."⁸

On 25 September, Raja of Dumrao gave one-sixth of his land. In the public meeting, Vinoba tore a gift letter of 5 acres from an owner of 300 acres.⁹

He stoutly opposed evictions of tenants in the wake of State-driven land reforms. He advised tenants not to leave their land and asked workers to stand behind them. He appealed to the landlords to stop evictions and declared that if he came to know that a donor had evicted his tenants, he would not accept bhoodan from such an owner. Calling for bhoodan of the land from which the tenants had been evicted, he announced that he would allot such land to the rightful tenants, so that the 'sin of eviction could be washed off'.¹⁰

He explained his approach towards the elected national government:

"The people in the government are our friends, not enemies. Strengthening freedom is the most important thing today. We should not do anything that could put it in jeopardy. That is why I severely criticized the Planning Commission, but did not raise banner of revolt against the government. As the people's power will get built, it will go on influencing the government more and more. I have faith in the people's power alone."¹¹

On 23 October, Vinoba entered Patna, the state capital. Christian missionaries met him there and wished him well. When the zamindars met him and asked him to prevail upon the government not to enact land laws, Vinoba quipped, "If you promise to remove landlessness in Bihar, I could talk to the government. If you give bhoodan liberally, there will be no need for the land laws. Grasp the spirit of Time. It is in your interest to give bhoodan."¹²

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Declaration of the *sampattidan* (gift of wealth) scheme was a significant event during the Patna stay. Vinoba had consistently refused donations in terms of money. But there was need to have scope for the participation of those having no land. A few of such individuals had even purchased land and offered them in bhoodan! It was certainly necessary not to give a number of programmes in the initial phase. But now the time was ripe for adding other dimensions. Moreover, allottees of land, who were invariably poor, needed to be provided inputs like seeds and bullocks. It was necessary to arouse the spirit of charity in society and channelise it towards them. The growing Movement and its workers also needed financial support. So, Vinoba enunciated the idea of *sampattidan*. No, he was not going to collect a fund. Practical problems apart, that was against the spirit of the Movement. The scheme was indeed a stroke of genius:

"In *sampattidan*, a donor will give a portion of his wealth to the society every year. I shall take only the promise letter. The donor will spend the amount as per his conscience. This is my strange way. If I choose to collect a fund, I shall have to keep the accounts and that will take all my time. But what I want is revolution. I want everyone in India to give one-sixth of what he has. How can I keep accounts on such a massive scale? So, it is up to the donor. - - - I want not only money but talent and intellect too. If someone gives me a donation, that binds me; I shall be accountable to him. But I want to be free and bind the donor. We can give advice about the spending of their *dana* amount. The donor may spend the amount for a good cause and give me its account.

With the idea of sampattidan, my work is complete.”¹³

Like Vinoba's other ideas, facets of sampattidan too went on getting refined and developed. Vinoba put forth the idea, but proceeded cautiously. As he later put it, “when the work of sampattidan spreads, latent power in non-possession will be revealed”¹⁴ and “the main object of sampattidan is dissolution of the ownership of wealth.”¹⁵

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Perseverance began to yield results. Bihar Congress resolved to collect 4,00,000 acres upto February 1953. Praja Socialist Party too adopted the programme. Institutions of constructive work dedicated themselves fully to this work.

When asked why he was accepting gifts from the poor farmers, his reply was: “I am raising my army. When a nonviolent battle becomes imperative, these poor donors will be our soldiers. However, I feel that there will be no need for such a battle.”¹⁶

Vinoba entered Gaya district on 28 October. Gaya had been a sacred place for Hindus and Buddhists. Here, he thought of collecting 1,00,000 acres in the district. The workers accepted the challenge. Workers from other regions in the state and also from other states converged at Gaya. Sarva Seva Sangh shifted its central office to Gaya.

Jayaprakash Narayan (popularly known as JP) joined the campaign at Gaya. He had already been attracted towards the Movement. Now his experiences convinced him of its truth and efficacy. Jayaprakash had the aura of leading the underground movement in 1942. His mastery over Marxism and Socialism was second to none. But he joined freedom movement and rose to become an important leader. He established Congress Socialist Party within the Congress and tried to give leftist orientation to the Congress. After Independence, the group had to leave Congress. Socialist Party fought the first general elections under his leadership, but could win only 12 out of 489 seats in Parliament, getting 10.6% share of the votes polled.¹⁷

Experience of Soviet Russia and the working of Stalin set him thinking about Marxist theory and practice. In search for an alternative, he was fascinated by bhoodan. In the Pachmadhi Conference of the Socialists, he called Vinoba 'the spark of the revolutionary power of Gandhism' and called for close co-operation between the Movement and the Socialists. The Conference passed a resolution, declaring support for bhoodan.¹⁸ Later, JP himself joined the bhoodan work.

Conversion of a towering leader of the Socialist movement like Jayaprakash into a dedicated Sarvodaya worker had far-reaching consequences. While he proved to be a great asset to the Movement, his ideas decisively affected the Movement in more than one ways.

In Gaya campaign, Jayaprakash received 7,000 acres within one week. But it was not just the figure, it was his experience that convinced him of the potential in the bhoodan approach. Two incidents are worth mentioning here.

At one place, a man announced a gift of 6.5 bighas; but when JP was told that it was all the land the man had, he appreciated the spirit behind the gift and returned 5.5 bighas as the man had no other source of income. But the man felt aggrieved and said that he would fast if the gift was not accepted fully! At another place, an individual gifted all of his 3 acres. A gentleman stood up and told that the individual had sacrificed his all in the freedom movement and only 3 acres of land was all that he had to provide for his family; and as that had now been gifted, he was giving 5 bighas to the donor.¹⁹

Vimala Thakar, a witness to these incidents, comments,

"I witnessed miraculous scenes while touring with Jayaprakashji. When JP would stand up after his lecture to seek gifts, not only scores but hundreds would stand up and announce gifts. And while announcing gifts, their faces were radiant—as if they were getting a new life."²⁰

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Vinoba's *yatra* then proceeded through Jharkhand. His 'walking university' was disseminating knowledge, spreading

revolutionary ideas even in remote corners of the country.

At Daltonganj, he explained the ideological basis of Sarvodaya:

“Sarvodaya means that the good of all is inherent in the good of one individual. Interests of individuals are never antagonistic to each other. Such a presumption is erroneous. If my health improves, it is in your interest too. If antagonism between interests is imagined, the very idea of interest would prove fallacious.”²¹

At Lohardaga, he explained the strategy of nonviolence:

“I am presently asking for one-sixth of land. People ask, would it be sufficient? But I am not going to leave untouched the rest five-sixth part. What I am doing now is like driving a wedge. If an engineer wants to take you to a height of five thousand feet, he does not construct the road with a steep gradient. We traverse the road and reach the top without realising it. That is how nonviolence works. I would go on asking for one-sixth share of the land till the whole land gets redistributed.”²²

He objected to the term ‘aborigines’ for the Adivasis:

“I do not differentiate between man and man. All those who came and settled in India with love belong to this country. We ultimately seek to unify the whole world.”²³

At Chandil, on 15 December, high fever forced Vinoba to stop. He had caught malignant malaria, the dreaded disease, known to kill 80% of its victims. It took him almost to the doorsteps of death. Yet, he refused to take medicines, and that naturally caused widespread concern and anguish. Shrikrishna Sinha, Chief Minister of Bihar, rushed to Chandil and ultimately prevailed upon Vinoba to take medicines. Medicines had dramatic effect on the body which was not used to them; but it took three months for Vinoba to recuperate.

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The fifth Sarvodaya Conference was held at Chandil on 7-8-9 March 1953. Presided over by Dharendra Majumdar, it was

attended by Dr. Rajendra Prasad, President of the Republic and R.R. Diwakar, Governor of Bihar, besides over 2,000 delegates.

Vinoba's address at the Conference was truly historic. Hailed as the 'Manifesto of the Sarvodaya Movement', it cast a spell on the listeners. Mohammed Shafi of Kashmir exclaimed, "He who has not heard this address is indeed unfortunate; he has as if not heard anything at all in his life!"²⁴

In this address, Vinoba spelt out the mission of the Sarvodaya Movement and explained its method of working:

"We have to manifest *lokshakti*—power of the people, which is opposed to the power of violence and differs from *dandashakti*—coercive power of the State. The latter power has been given to the State by us. It does have an element of violence in it, but the State has been given this power by the whole community; so I would not like to call it pure violence. It is our duty to create such conditions whereby occasion for exercise of even this coercive power does not arise. If we can do that, it would mean that we have understood and discharged our true duty. If, on the other hand, we hanker after the service that could be done through that coercive power, we would fail in doing the distinctive work expected of us."²⁵

Regarding land-redistribution through legislation, he said,

"I am not blocking legislation. Rather I am facilitating its passage by creating favourable atmosphere for it. But my *dharma* calls on me to believe that we can evoke such a spirit in the hearts of the people that they would distribute the land of their own accord, regardless of the law. - - - If, in spite of experiencing the power of love, we go on insisting on legislation rather than having courage to develop social dimension of that power, we would fail in rendering that help to the State which it expects from us—that of building people's power. That is why we seek building of people's power, which is opposed to violence and differs from the coercive power of the State."²⁶

This concept of third power is Vinoba's original and remarkable contribution to political science as well as to the

theory of revolution. Communists and Anarchists also seek dissolution of power. But the Communists contemplate withering away of the State after its unprecedented strengthening—the fallacious idea has ultimately led to the downfall of Communist regimes throughout the Soviet bloc and Eastern Europe. Anarchists became irrelevant because of their impatience and lack of understanding of the true nature of violence. Gandhi had sought creation of people's power and given constructive programmes, essentially for this purpose. Building on that base, Vinoba was now developing the science of nonviolent revolution and refining its strategy.

He also explained two elements of the method of working: *vichar-shasan* (supremacy of reason) and *kartrutva-vibhajan* (decentralisation of power and capabilities):

“Ideas should be clearly understood and expounded. Nothing should be accepted without understanding the ideas involved. It should be a matter of regret for us when someone accepts our ideas without understanding them. We should be content with explaining our ideas without imposing our will on others.- - - It then follows that sustained dissemination of ideas becomes an important aspect of our work. Secondly, all the capacity should not be centralised at one place; it should be generated in every village. That is why we want every village to have the power to take decision about import and export of goods in it. - - - National planning should essentially mean village planning; only that which needs to be done to help village planning should be done at Delhi. Whatever we do is for progressively increasing *kartrutva-vibhajan*. Hence we seek land distribution in villages.”²⁷

Vinoba reiterated his appeal for distribution of 50 million acres of land by 1957, at least mainly, if not wholly, through people's power. At the end, he enjoined Sarvodaya workers not to form a separate sect, but merge themselves in the masses for the creation of people's power.²⁸

JP narrated his experiences during bhoodan campaign, made an appeal to the youth to leave schools and colleges and give one year to it.²⁹

Attitude towards Community Development Programme was a live issue. Vinoba advised against getting involved in it and also cautioned not to dissipate strength in its criticism:

“The programme devised by a Government, which is based on coercive sanctions and which cannot go much beyond status quo, will never be fully consistent with our programme. I consider it my duty, as a believer in nonviolence, to express our concurrence with the good element in it, and see that people’s faith in it remains intact. At the same time, we should also put forward our programme before the people.”³⁰

In this connection, he also cautioned workers against getting involved in the Government-sponsored ‘Sarvodaya’ scheme in the Bombay state.

Distribution of gifted lands was an urgent question on the agenda. Vinoba pointed out the enthusiasm in the people and the dearth of workers and advised all to concentrate on obtaining land-gifts. “Distribution is a difficult problem; it could prove counter-productive. We should avoid haste. The donor is supposed to continue cultivation till the distribution of land gifted by him. We would undertake this task in due course.”³¹ Perhaps the experience of political rivalries within Bhoodan Committees was one of the reasons for Vinoba’s hesitation.

The question of land ceiling was in the air. Vinoba opined in the meeting of Sarva Seva Sangh,

“I want not ‘ceiling’, but ‘roofing’. You should first accept the principle that every family should get five acres; then you may do whatever you want with the rest of the land. If the ceiling is low, the quantum of compensation would be substantial; if it is high, it will serve no purpose. We, therefore, say that all lands of the village should belong to the village community. Ceiling would create small robbers in the place of big ones. That would result only in swelling the rank of robbers.”³²

Vinoba spelt out the steps that needed to be followed:

“Obtaining one-sixth of the land is a minor part of Bhoodan-

Yajna. The land will have to be distributed. Necessary inputs will have to be provided to the donees. They will have to be settled on the allotted lands. Programmes of khadi, village industries, basic education etc. would have to be undertaken in villages where lands are gifted, for establishment of gram-swaraj therein. New villages will have to be established where large chunks of cultivable wasteland have been and would be obtained. The idea of sampattidan will have to be propagated so as to make it a collective and life-long conviction.”³³

By this time, bhoodan figures were as under³⁴:

	<i>Target (till 1954)</i>	<i>Land obtained (acres)</i>
Assam	25,000	256
Andhra	1,00,000	7,097
Orissa	1,50,000	5,102
U.P.	5,00,000	4,76,218
Karnataka	---	595
Kerala	25,000	5,800
Gujarat	75,000	5,501
Tamil Nadu	1,50,000	6,976
Delhi	10,000	1,124
Punjab/PEPSU	1,00,000	1,045
W. Bengal	2,00,000	102
Bihar	4,00,000	5,50,027
Vidarbha, Mahakoshal	100,000	15,042
Madhya Bharat	1,25,000	2,491
Maharashtra	1,00,000	5,000
Mysore	1,00,000	143
Rajasthan	2,00,000	22,072
Vindhya Pradesh	40,000	2,382
Saurashtra	50,000	3,000
Himachal Pradesh --		1,006
Hyderabad	1,00,000	42,177
TOTAL	25,50,000	11,53,356
	X	X

Almost all political parties had supported bhoodan. Workers of most of them were active in it to some extent. However, they had an attitude to use it for political gains. They would obtain land-gifts, but wait for their leaders to submit gift declarations to them in public functions, although both Vinoba and Jayaprakash discouraged this trend. Anyhow, their co-operation was forthcoming. However, the Peasants and Workers Party of Maharashtra had voiced its opposition to it. Bombay provincial committee of Dalit Federation too complained, in its meeting in January 1953, that there being no information about the Dalits getting bhoodan lands, why should they support it? Such was the level of ignorance! In fact, bhoodan had its origin in the demand of Dalits and the Dalits were being given priority in distribution. This objection continued to get raised in spite of repeated clarifications.³⁵

A conference of Parliament members on bhoodan was held at New Delhi on 27 March 1953. It was inaugurated by Pandit Nehru and presided over by Dr. S. Radhakrishnan, Vice-President of the Republic. Speaking at the conference, Nehru said,

“I give utmost importance to Bhoodan-Yajna. It is our duty to understand fully this Movement and help it in every way in achieving success. This Movement of Acharya Vinoba is undoubtedly a strange way to solve an important and intricate problem. It is a way which learned economists cannot explain, and perhaps cannot even understand. However, it touches the hearts of the people. Bhoodan-Yajna has shown a way to solve the land problem without bloodshed and through peaceful, nonviolent co-operation.”³⁶

He, however, added that the Movement cannot be an alternative to legislation and government would have to discharge its responsibility.³⁷

The conference, in its resolution, appreciated the Movement and expressed hope that the people and the parliamentarians would help the Movement reach its target. To implement the resolution, a committee comprising of Dr. Radhakrishnan (Chairman), Sucheta Kripalani and Radharaman (Conveners),

Pandit Nehru, Kaka Kalelkar, Purushottamdas Tondon, Kelappan, Shriman Narayan and Krishnan Nayar was constituted.³⁸

Bhoodan was being watched with interest in other countries as well. Foreigners had started coming to India to join Vinoba's touring party from time to time to observe this intriguing phenomenon from close quarters. Pat McMahon, a young student of social psychology, travelled over 3,200 km with Vinoba. Hallam Tennyson joined the walking tour for some time and later gave a talk on the B.B.C. London in April 1953, narrating his experience. Referring to a gift of a tiny plot of only one-fifth of an acre by an untouchable at one place he said,

"Scenes like that arouse an atmosphere of almost evangelical fervour. People start trying to outdo each other in generosity. But Vinobaji is careful to canalise the flood of emotion. He sits by as level-headed as ever; garlanded like an emaciated and reluctant Caesar."³⁹

He ended his talk, saying that Vinoba's message was not limited to India.⁴⁰ London Times made an editorial comment on bhoodan in its issue of 14 April⁴¹, while the 'Time' magazine published Vinoba's photograph on the cover of its issue of 11 May and devoted 11 columns to bhoodan.⁴²

Prominent leaders and workers were touring different parts of the country: Tukdoji Maharaj, Dada Dharmadhikari and Vimla Thakar in Maharashtra; Baba Raghavdas in Uttar Pradesh; Seth Govind Das in Mahakoshal; Santbal in Saurashtra; Swami Sitaram in Andhra; Gopabandhu Chaudhari in Orissa; Gokulbhai Bhatt in Rajasthan; Manmathan in Kerala; Thakurdas Bang in Vidarbha. Shankarrao Deo was moving all over the country.

Acharya Kripalani gave permission to the workers of Gandhi Ashram, the most prominent khadi organisation, to devote as much time as they wanted to bhoodan. He regretted that it had not been possible for him to give time to it, but he wanted to make up for it.⁴³ Senior Socialist leader Asoka Mehta supported bhoodan and pointed out that gifts by small farmers were creating a new outlook about ownership of land and

wealth; and as land prices were falling because of this Movement, the question of compensation was getting eased.⁴⁴ Japanese Socialist Yoshiki Hoshino hailed bhoodan as a novel way of revolution.⁴⁵

C. Rajagopalachari, a prominent apostle of Gandhi, was Chief Minister of Madras state. He was observing the Movement sympathetically; however, he had no occasion to see it from close quarters. Tamil Nadu Bhoodan Committee invited him to preside over a land distribution function at Archalur (17 May), where he distributed 250 acres to 55 landless labourers.⁴⁶

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Vinoba resumed his walking tour after the Chandil Conference, although he had not fully recuperated. Such was his sense of urgency.

The *yatra* entered Hazaribagh after Manbhoom. There the Raja of Ramgarh gifted 1,00,000 acres. At Bermo (29 March), the town of mines, Vinoba eulogised the contribution of voiceless labourers and asserted that “voice of the labourers in cities is heard to some extent, but labourers in villages have neither land nor voice. On their behalf, I am making their voice heard.”⁴⁷ At Pakri Barwan (21 April), he declared: “I want not just distribution of land and wealth, but of religion as well”—religion should not be confined to temples and monasteries, nor should it be limited to a handful of spiritual aspirants.⁴⁸

On 3 May, Bihar unit of Indian National Congress, the ruling party, resolved to work for the fulfilment of the bhoodan target of 3.2 million acres for the state, although the Party High Command was reportedly against such a concrete resolution. Vinoba congratulated Bihar Congressmen. In this connection, he requested the Chief Minister to lend services of an able worker; and the latter chose his close associate Baidyanath Prasad Chaudhary. Chaudhary immersed himself in bhoodan work, left party politics, and soon became one of the pillars of the Movement in Bihar.

On 29 May, Vinoba had a meeting with Raja Girivar Prasad of Ranka. The Raja had already gifted 13,500 acres. To Vinoba,

he promised to give as much as asked for. Vinoba said, "Give me all the fallow land and one-sixth of the cultivated land." Raja asked, "What will you do with the fallow land?" "What will you gain by retaining it?"—Vinoba counter-questioned. Raja gave what was asked for—in all 1,02,000 acres. Before this, Rajas of Ramgarh and Dhanbad had gifted 1,00,000 and 1,01,000 acres respectively.⁴⁹ Later, on 14 June, Raja of Palkot followed suit with gift of all the fallow land and one-sixth of cultivated land, totalling 44,500 acres.⁵⁰

Till now, Vinoba himself used to sign gift letters as a sign of acceptance; but now the number of gift letters had so swelled as to necessitate some other arrangement. So, Vinoba authorised Ramdev Babu for this purpose.

In Hazaribagh district, organisation of the tour had been entrusted to Raja of Ramgarh, a bitter opponent of Congress, which displeased Congressmen. One of them commented that this would cost the Movement the co-operation of Bihar Congress. Vinoba's response was so strong that the Chief Minister himself rushed to Vinoba and assured full co-operation.⁵¹

In Gaya district, zamindars formed a committee to help bhoodan work and started propagating it.

Bihar state government prepared a bill on bhoodan, which provided for vesting of gifted lands in the government. Vinoba opposed this move and said that if the government persisted in this attempt, he would return all the gift-declarations to the donors and tell the people of Bihar that their government did not want bhoodan. The government, however, retraced its step.⁵² Such was Vinoba's moral stature.

On 18 September, Vinoba reached Deoghar, known for its famous Shiva temple. When Vinoba was told that Dalits did not have access to it (although the Constitution of the country had abolished untouchability in all its aspects), he declined to visit it. However, he was assured by the chief priest that everyone had access, and Vinoba was welcome to visit the temple. The next day, Vinoba went there with his associates, but was

attacked unexpectedly and ferociously. Workers did their best in protecting him and took the blows on themselves, but his left ear did receive a blow (which made him deaf in that ear) while many workers were mercilessly beaten till a couple of them became unconscious. The incident sent a wave of anger and indignation throughout the whole country. Vinoba, true to his nature, said, in a statement issued on 20 September, that the attackers should not be punished as they had acted out of ignorance about religion, but recurrence of such incidents must be prevented.⁵³

7. Bihar: Second Phase of 'The Tour of Joy'

Bhoodan had now come to stay. Bhoodan Act was passed in C.P. and Berar and a Bhoodan Board was constituted with Shrikrishnadas Jajoo as Chairman. Laws were also enacted in Uttar Pradesh, Saurashtra and Odisha.

Charuchandra Bhandari, a M.L.A. from Praja Socialist Party in West Bengal, resigned from the Party and the state Legislative Assembly, and joined bhoodan mission. Four main churches in Kerala welcomed bhoodan and appealed to the Christians to extend co-operation to it. Ravishankar Maharaj of Gujarat was diffident in the beginning, even though he was entrusted with the work in Gujarat. In village Boriyavi, an old lady asked him why he was not becoming active; she herself wanted to give land. Ravishankar Maharaj then set out to propagate bhoodan and found how it had evoked hope and enthusiasm in the people. That was the experience of every worker. Even ordinary workers were getting bhoodan. Gandhi Smarak Nidhi had volunteered to give financial aid of its own accord. While big landlords were giving thousands of acres, even small and marginal farmers were vying with each other to offer whatever they could at the altar in this unique yajna.

At Kursaila (District Purnea) on 19 November, Vinoba was welcomed with 3,334 gift-declarations totalling 13,614 acres. Kameshwar Singh, Maharaja of Darbhanga, met Vinoba there and gifted 1,28,000 acres, giving full details of the land, and assured that if there was any error about any piece of land, he would give another land in its place.¹

The Bihar Government had initiated a survey of land in the Purnea district, and speculation was rife that sharecroppers cultivating the land for more than one year would be protected. This had naturally resulted in increase in evictions. Vinoba criticized the rumoured measure. Socialists were advising

sharecroppers of landowners with less than 30 acres land not to reveal their status as sharecroppers. This was a tactic for not losing the sympathy of small landowners. Vinoba criticized this and also castigated those who were inducing sharecroppers to lay claim on the land they were not cultivating. The landowners were, of course, concealing the facts. Vinoba warned, "The whole atmosphere is reeking with falsehood. When there is falsehood on such a scale, satyagraha is impossible."²

What was important was the way, not just the goal:

"There is no need for Vinoba or Bhoodan-Yajna or a walking tour to solve land problem. This problem will certainly be solved in some way or the other. We have to be concerned with ethical means. We have to create a new human being who is in tune with the new age."³

For him, bhoodan was meant to free the people in true sense, to make real the freedom that was only on paper.

At Raniganj (4 December), he exhorted workers to resolve not to rest till the goal was achieved. It was important for the workers to give even more than one-sixth share of their own land and wealth.

"It is the actual practice that gives inspiration, that influences the world. No one must be reviled. When the Lord is prompting us to ask for land, He is also bound to motivate the people to give. We should go to the potential donors with humility and love, and also with respect. Then we would surely get land."⁴

In Purnea district, 28,480 acres' bhoodan was received from 8,649 donors in 19 days. Vinoba then travelled through Saharsa, Darbhanga and Muzaffarpur and reached Patna again on 10 January 1954. In a meeting of zamindars, he was given gift-letters of 5,00,000 acres.

From there, he proceeded to Gaya, where intensive work was going on, but desired results were not in sight. He urged workers to intensify efforts. Breakthrough was ultimately achieved.

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Sixth Sarvodaya Conference was held at Bodhgaya from 18 to 20 April 1954. It was presided over by Ashadevi Aryanayakam and attended by the President, the Vice-President, the Prime Minister of India, and over 5,000 delegates.

While bhoodan was striving to unify society, party politics was rupturing the social fabric and introducing many undesirable things in national life. Gandhians had a special responsibility to halt this process, and national leaders needed to do serious rethinking in this regard. Vinoba opened his heart in the presence of Prime Minister Nehru:

“This year, I have ventured to invite Pandit Jawaharlalji. It was my experience of bhoodan work, which impelled me to do so. - - - We have always strived to keep it free from party politics and power; so we sought and received co-operation from all our brothers belonging to the great family of Gandhians, now in different parties. However, I feel that although bhoodan has certainly helped in bringing their hearts nearer to each other, there still remains a distance. - - - Our hearts should become one in view of the present situation, when basic necessities of life of a large body of people remain unfulfilled.”⁵

He pointed out harmful consequences of the election system, which had accentuated caste differences, was causing huge wastage of time, strength and money of society and increasing dissensions within it, and called for rethinking in this respect and the need for a common programme which could bring together at least the good individuals irrespective of ideological differences. Bhoodan had the potential of becoming such a programme.

He also said that spinning should be an essential ingredient of education in India and demanded that the government should make it a compulsory part of education. He touched upon several issues about which he felt strongly and sought Nehru's response.

Nehru's response was, however, lukewarm; it was similar to his response at the Constructive workers' Conference in 1948. Even while agreeing with Vinoba's criticism of elections, he said

that the faith put in the system had been vindicated; naturally, he gave no promise about its reform. About bhoodan, he said that if people in the government got involved in it, it might affect the nature of the Movement. About spinning, he said that education was a state subject and the states would have to be convinced in this regard.⁶ However, at that time, Nehru had complete hold over the party and the government; all states were ruled by the Congress; and Nehru was not hesitating to impose policies in other spheres irrespective of which subject belonged to whom. Nehru's comments betrayed lack of commitment to Gandhian values and programmes.

Vice-President Radhakrishnan, while addressing the Conference pointed out that the agrarian revolution brought about by bhoodan would also help eliminate the differences of caste and out-caste which were polluting and corrupting the atmosphere.⁷

Jayaprakash Narayan expressed regret that the target for Bihar (3.2 million acres) had not been fulfilled, and expressed confidence that if Congress and Praja Socialist Party sincerely took up this work, it would certainly be fulfilled. He also said that his experiences were continually strengthening his faith in the Movement: "My experiences have convinced me that this process has the potential to solve not just the land problem, but also all problems in life, all problems of society." In the end, he mentioned his call in the Chandil Conference to the youth to give one year to the Movement and said,

"But this is a Movement for which a year or even five years would not be sufficient. It calls for *jivandan* (dedication of the entire life). This Conference should make an appeal to the workers for *jivandan*. I make such an appeal. I, too, am fortunate to have my name in the list of such workers."⁸

Vinoba picked up the thread of JP's appeal and reaffirmed his dedication. The next day, he sent a note to Jayaprakash:

"In response to your appeal, I dedicate my life to nonviolent revolution having Bhoodan-Yajna as its foundation and village industries as its mainstay."

Jayaprakash was overwhelmed. He sent this note to Ashadevi, President of the Conference, with his own note addressed to her:

“One who has inspired all of us is communicating his resolve to a worthless man like me! What can one say about it! I must say that I am unfit to accept his *jivandan* (gift of life). We have to give *jivandan* in the name of the Lord, to Baba (Vinoba) alone.”⁹

Ashadevi read out both the notes in the next session and announced her *jivandan* too. A wave of enthusiasm and revolutionary fervour swept through the enthralled audience. Delegate after delegate stood up and announced *jivandan*. Those announcing *jivandan* numbered 707.

In his public speech, Nehru reiterated his apprehension that involvement of government machinery would have adverse effect on the Movement, but said that government servants should help it in individual capacity.¹⁰

These observations were clearly off the point. No one was expecting government servants to ask for bhoodan, neither in individual capacity nor as government servants. They were expected to do what they should and could do as government servants. That they were not doing. When land was being obtained through a voluntary effort, why was government not promptly simplifying legal formalities regarding the transfer of land and completing them expeditiously? Why was it not preparing schemes to provide inputs and credit to the bhoodan allottees who were the poorest of the poor and for making gifted wastelands cultivable? That Nehru—in fact, the whole political class in India—should signally fail in taking advantage of the atmosphere created by bhoodan and exerting political will, which could have changed the course of history of Independent India, underlines the nature of the forces of status quo.

Acharya Kripalani, in his public speech, reiterated his opinion that Sarvodaya workers would have to take the reins of government in their hands to take the Movement to fruition.¹¹ Vinoba gave his reply in the Conference on the next day: “There is no need for me to wield power; it should suffice if it obeys

my will. There is no need to take the trouble of taking power in our own hands.”¹²

He suggested that meetings of the landless be held in villages first to ascertain their demand, which should then be put before landowners, and thereafter village meetings should be held to deliberate over it. It was important for the villagers to realise that it was ultimately their responsibility to solve the problems of their villages. He reminded the workers,

“Let us be clear that the main thing we want to achieve is dissolution of the sense of ownership and the ownership itself on the land. And we have to achieve this solely through propagation of ideas and purity in our lives.”¹³

By this time, gifts of 28,15,101 acres had been received through 2,37,079 gift declarations by this time. The number of donors was also important. In fact, Vinoba specifically asked workers to fix targets for the number of gift letters as well. Out of the land received, 55,899 acres had been distributed to 13,738 families. The target of 2.5 million acres fixed at the Sevapuri Conference (1952) had been fulfilled. Although many states had failed in achieving targets, Bihar had more than made up for the shortfall—bhoodan received there was more than 1.5 million acres as against the target of 0.4 million acres.¹⁴

Sarva Seva Sangh expressed satisfaction for having achieved the goal, and exhorted workers to work with renewed vigour, cautioning at the same time,

“It is not our object to achieve the target by any means. We have to sow the seeds of the fundamental thought behind bhoodan in the minds of the people and create a society free from exploitation and coercive power of the State.”¹⁵

About targets, Vinoba cautioned the workers:

“Had we not made a resolve initially, the Movement would not have taken off. We would not then have got an idea of the extent to which we could mobilise the nation’s energies; and also of our own strength. Hence, we first made a small resolve, although we had the goal of obtaining 50 million acres before us. But we must not get trapped in figures.

Means must be pure. Otherwise we would lose the essence.”¹⁶

He also laid stress on the distribution of land. The Conference deliberated the issue and issued detailed guidelines. Vinoba warned the workers:

“We have to do this work with urgency, but not in haste. Rules in this regard must be scrupulously followed, so that land is given to the most deserving man, without any partiality, and no one raises any objection. Proper distribution would give momentum to gifts also.”¹⁷

S. Jagannathan of Tamil Nadu perhaps gave vent to the feelings of many activists when he talked of organising the landless and resorting to non-cooperation. Vinoba, while addressing workers from southern states, patiently explained:

“It is natural that such an idea crosses your mind. But one should not entertain this idea at the present juncture. Time for this would come after we have done all that we could. But I do not think that we have done enough. In Gaya district, there are two and half lakh (2,50,000) landowners. I have sought two lakh gift letters. If this practical programme is fulfilled and yet the goal is not achieved, I will go to every village, meet the landless to know what they want; and then meet the landowners and present the demands of the landless before them. Then I will hold a common meeting and explain their responsibilities to them. If all this proves to be in vain, then only non-cooperation can be contemplated. But all this will mobilise public opinion in our favour to such an extent that non-cooperation will not be necessary.”¹⁸

In the meeting of Sarva Seva Sangh, he reiterated that time for an agitation by the landless had not come.

“You should first propagate that the very idea of landownership is wrong. As long as we have not done this, I do not think that we would get land by mobilising a few landless; nor do I believe that it would be possible to mobilise them at all—for, that too would need reaching every village. How many villages have we reached so far?”¹⁹

Impatience is a sign of violence. The way of nonviolence is bound to be different—that was what Vinoba continued to impress upon the workers. But the way of working of nonviolence is difficult to comprehend. The demand for more militant strategy continued to be raised from time to time.

An important event during the Conference was the foundation of Samanvaya Ashram to bring together different religious traditions.

Vinoba's genius was always at work in putting forth different arguments in favour of bhoodan. At the Conference, he observed that *bhoomi-seva* (working on the land with a sense of devotion to it) was the best means of serving the Lord:

"I say this on the basis of my own experience. I have followed different means like *japa*, *tapa*, *jnana*²⁰ for this purpose to some extent; but have found that labouring on the land helps more in the purification of mind than all those means. So, it does not matter if Harijans (Dalits) are denied entry in temples, for there are other and better means of devotion to the Lord. But the landless must not be deprived from *bhoomi-seva* (service of the land), the best means for the purpose."²¹

After the conclusion of Conference, *yatra* was resumed on 26 April.

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At Gaziapur in U.P., an individual gifted 2,000 acres. But it was pointed out in the meeting that the land was in the bed of river Ganga, and Vinoba was being duped. Vinoba thereupon commented that mother Ganga would change her course and give the land; and asked the workers to distribute it immediately. It turned out that after a few years, Ganga did change her course, and fertile land became available for cultivation.²² Change in the course of rivers is by no means rare in U.P. and Bihar, and land in the river-bed becomes very fertile.

From Gaya, Vinoba headed towards north, passed through Shahabad and Saran districts and entered Champaran, famous for Gandhi's satyagraha.

Acharya Narendra Dev, veteran Socialist leader, had recently said that bhoodan was good, but did not appear to have any philosophical foundation. Hurt with this remark, Vinoba said at Vrindavan (26 June) that had it been so, he would have got tired by now:

“But my feet have become stronger. Work progresses faster when there is deep philosophical foundation. Then it continues to get fresh impetus and blooms with new shoots. You see that bhoodan was followed by *sampattidan*, *shramdan* and now *jivandan*. This work would, in course of time, take into its ambit all the constructive programmes and even all the moral dimensions of social life. This would not have happened without the foundation of a powerful philosophy.”

Narendra Dev had said that change of hearts would not suffice; class struggle was inevitable. Vinoba countered,

“For the deluded people, change of heart is needed, while thinking of good individuals needs to be changed. These two together constitute the process of revolution; and that is our programme. On one hand, we explain our ideas and on the other, seek change of heart through our penance.”²³

The *yatra* entered Muzaffarpur district in incessant rains. At Manaain, Communists presented a scroll of honour to Vinoba. Addressing *jivandani* workers at a camp, he asked them to be ready for trial and warned them,

“When the true nature of our work is revealed, it will surely prick some people. Violence would not be able to tolerate nonviolence; not only that, it would oppose nonviolence vehemently. We would face stiff opposition. Those who are our friends, and whose friendship we desire, would then no longer be our friends.”²⁴

That was Vinoba's insight. Nonviolence does not imply naivety. Having faith in the goodness in human being does not mean credulousness. Vinoba did envisage opposition, and therefore struggle, at a particular stage in the Movement. However, this was conveniently overlooked and Vinoba was castigated time and again for avoiding struggle!

Wrongful evictions of peasants had become a grave problem in Bihar, particularly because of faulty land records and government's unwise policy. When the government announced survey of just one district, it led to conflicts, even murders, and courts were inundated with cases. Vinoba strongly raised his voice against evictions. He persistently appealed to landowners to refrain from this practice, and exhorted the peasants not to leave their land, whatever hardships they might have to suffer. He permitted workers to devote themselves entirely to this problem if they so desired. He also asked Bhoodan Committees to consider it their responsibility to stop evictions: they should go into the complaints and prevail upon the landowners to desist from evicting tenants, and if that proved to be in vain, file law-suits and seek *buddhidan* from lawyers (request them to work without any fees) to fight those cases, although he had reservations about the process of law: "Courts go by the papers presented to them. I believe that these papers have vitiated mutual relations. It is better to set them on fire. That will do no harm; rather it will be for the good."²⁵ But if the landowners refused to come to their senses and the courts too failed to give justice, what should be done? Vinoba held that agitation should still be avoided as political parties were likely to exploit it. Later, however, he permitted workers to resort to satyagraha if need be. He also rejected gifts when he was advised that the donor was guilty of evicting peasants.

Bihar Bhoodan-Yajna Committee later constituted an enquiry committee in July 1954, which met all the concerned parties. It found that reforms in the tenancy act, made in 1937-38, too had not been implemented. Evictions had increased also because the peasants had become aware of their rights.

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Floods had devastated North Bihar. Still, the *yatra* continued. Vinoba and his co-workers had to wade across rivers, often through chest-high water, with luggage on their heads. But people would come in thousands, often in boats, to hear Vinoba. When Vinoba was urged to halt for some time because of floods, he refused:

"The floods are proving clearly that land belongs to God. So I want gift of entire village lands now. Unless the village community owns all the village lands, proper help cannot be provided to the poor."²⁶

Vinoba started a novel practice now: he started returning token gifts from big landowners, noting refusal on the gift letters! His argument was that it would tarnish the donor's reputation; people would think that he was duping Vinoba.²⁷ This practice naturally caused sensation.

He used to ask for one-sixth share of land. Now he began saying that he should be considered a member of the family and given his share—that could be one-third or one-tenth or anything else.

A dam was planned on the river Kosi, known for changing its course frequently. Gulzarilal Nanda, Central Minister for Planning, and concerned officials met Vinoba and had a discussion. L.N. Mishra, Member of Parliament from the region, also met Vinoba in this connection. Vinoba said that the farmers who would lose their land should be given land in exchange. When Mishra pleaded government's inability to do so, Vinoba said that bhoodan land could be given; and in view of this, target for bhoodan for the region should be fulfilled.²⁸

Yatra passed through the region bordering Nepal. Many in Nepal wanted Vinoba to come to Nepal. But the visit could not materialise. Vinoba did get one land-gift from Nepal. On 28 October, when he was at Sukhani, he entered a small village in Nepal during his morning walk and was welcomed there. That was his first foreign visit!²⁹

At Islampur, Vinoba warned the workers,

"We have come to a difficult point in our ascension. This is testing time for us. The public is waiting to see how the land is going to be distributed in a proper manner through people's power. If we succeed in such distribution, it will mark the beginning of freedom from the State. - - - We are at such a juncture that if we apply our entire strength and achieve success, victory will be ours. But if we do not apply

our entire strength and fail, there is every risk of collapse -
 - - Our condition is like that of Abhimanyu.”³⁰

Predominantly tribal Santhal Pargana (now part of Jharkhand) was the last leg of Bihar tour. Vinoba reminded the people that dissolution of ownership was an idea in tune with the tribal tradition. Progress of bhoodan was hampered in the region because of the propaganda by some vested interests that the land gifted by the tribals would be given to non-tribals. However, innocent Santhals could not help being touched by the spirit of the Movement.

Suresh Ram recounts an incident:

“We were at village Boria in the Santhal Parganas. Vinoba was returning to his camp after the evening prayer. On the way, several Santhali people greeted him and one of them said, ‘*Baba, zameen lo! Zameen lo! Hum zameen denge!*’ (Baba, take land! We shall give it!)’ Vinoba stayed for a while and said, ‘Give! I have come to take! Distribute all land! Finish this collecting business. Distribute and share as in a family.’”³¹

Vinoba also asked the Santhals to put an end to the hereditary *mukhia* (headman) system and choose *panchas* (representatives) by consensus.³²

Vinoba's last halt in Bihar was Dheksila on 31 December 1954, where 55,000 acres were presented to him. Shrikrishna Sinha, the Chief Minister, could not attend the farewell function, but sent a letter expressing his heart-felt gratitude. For Vinoba, what was most important was that ‘he had an open vision of the Divine Love.’ “I experienced profound peace and great bliss. Hence I call this tour ‘the tour of joy.’”³³

Vinoba was in Bihar for 839 days, halted at 694 places, walked 11,000 km. The total bhoodan received was 22,32,474 acres through 2,86,420 gift letters.³⁴ It was a stupendous achievement by any standard. While inviting Vinoba to Bihar, local workers were not sure of obtaining 4,00,000 acres. The land actually received was more than 22,00,000 acres. On one day, Vinoba received as many as 1,000 gift letters!

Not only constructive workers, politicians and administration were also galvanized to some extent. Response of the people was overwhelming. The tour transformed the whole atmosphere in rural Bihar. People were now coming forward to give land without being persuaded. The foundation of landownership had been severely shaken. There was significant reduction in land transactions and land-related suits. Vinoba had said long back, around six months ago, that his work in Bihar stood finished; it was now for the workers to take advantage of the atmosphere and achieve the target.³⁵

JP said at the farewell function on the state border that Vinoba had honoured Bihar for making it a laboratory and added, "I think the situation is opportune for the state to put the seal of legislation on public opinion as far as gift of one-sixth land is concerned. I hope the Bihar state would do this."³⁶ He told Krishnavallabh Sahay, Revenue Minister of Bihar, "No people's movement can achieve more. Time is perfectly opportune. It is for the government now to take advantage of it." Krishnavallabh agreed that the atmosphere in Bihar was indeed favourable, but remarked that the atmosphere in Cabinet was not so!³⁷

The political class once again failed to exert political will at the opportune time; to strike when iron was hot. But could it be expected to behave otherwise?

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Activities including walking tours, training camps, propagation of literature, besides collection of land-gifts, were going on throughout the country. A fortnightly journal was started in Karnataka. Efforts were being made to start periodicals in different languages, as dissemination of ideas was the main vehicle of the Movement.

At Gagode, Vinoba's birth-place, the land gifted by his family was distributed at the hands of B.G. Kher, Chief Minister of the state. Kher said, "I have done a lot of things in my public life; but I do not remember whether any of them was as pure as this work of land-distribution."³⁸

Janakidevi Bajaj was concentrating on '*koop-dan*'—gift of a well. The programme was conceived by Vinoba who had made an appeal to donate cost of constructing a well at the time of marriage. His calculation was that this would result in digging 100 to 150 million wells in 40 to 50 years, which would provide for sufficient irrigation for increasing agricultural production.³⁹ Janakidevi would visit ladies in their homes and ask them to part with their ornaments for this purpose.

Official Bhoodan Committee, in terms of the Bhoodan Act, was formed in Bihar with the Chief Minister as a member.

By December 1954, the figure for bhoodan had touched 36,63,974 acres, out of which 1,06,474 acres had been distributed.⁴⁰

8. In Bengal and Odisha

Vinoba entered West Bengal on 1 January 1955. Bengal tour had not, in fact, been planned as public mind there was not thought to be favourable, nor were there many Gandhian workers. Still, Vinoba passed through Bengal en route to Odisha and spent 25 days in it. And he received enthusiastic welcome there too.

While entering Bengal, Vinoba naturally recollected that when he left home, one of the places he wanted to go was Bengal, the land of revolutionaries. Now he put before Bengal the path of nonviolent action:

“Many spiritual geniuses were born in Bengal. Both Lord Buddha and the Vaishnavas spread their messages here. The Vaishnavas did inspire devotion in the people, but it was inactive. However, the country needs activity and a motivation to act. Activity in Bengal took the path of violence. That violence caused, in my opinion, deterioration instead of augmentation of strength. We have to blend Vaishnava’s nonviolence with activity of the youth; we need to take the path of nonviolent action which bhoodan symbolises.”¹

Vinoba’s words about the Vaishnavas created misunderstanding, which the media fanned, as is its wont. At Vishnupur (10 January), Vinoba expressed regret about the hurt caused to the sentiments of Vaishnavas, but pointed out the need for modification in the way of devotion.²

At Vishnupur, Ramakrishna Paramhans was said to have attained *samadhi*—the state of union with the Supreme. Sitting at that particular spot, Vinoba put forth the radical concept of collective *samadhi*:

“It is for the servants like us to give social dimension to the experiences of great individuals. Several conflicts and clashes are presently going on in the world. If we could get over them, we could experience the peaceful contentment of

collective *samadhi*.”³

Bhoodan Committee had been constituted in West Bengal after Sevapuri Conference (1952) with Charuchandra Bhandari as the convener. Some district committees had also been formed. Bhoodan had not, however, made much headway. A particularly adverse factor was that the state government had imposed land ceiling and it announced, when Vinoba arrived in the state, that bhoodan could not be given out of the land declared surplus under the Ceiling Act. Had it not done so, it could have saved a lot of compensation amount.⁴

Vinoba was invited to the Avadi (Tamil Nadu) Session of the Congress. While conveying his inability to attend, he expressed the hope of receiving co-operation from the Congressmen. The Session welcomed bhoodan. Shriman Narayan, General Secretary of Congress, later wrote to state committees to form separate cells for bhoodan and have Sarvodaya workers in them.⁵ Throughout the Bengal tour, Atulya Ghosh, President of the state Congress accompanied Vinoba.

In Bengal, Vinoba met renowned litterateurs including Tarashankar Bandyopadhyay and sought *wak-dan* (gift of words—that is, undertaking to spread the message of bhoodan through their writings) from them. Tarashankar expressed the hope that bhoodan would help raise the standard of Bangla literature, which had lately come down.⁶

The government had imposed land ceiling, but it was not expected to yield much land. Vinoba was blunt in underlining limitations of legal measures:

“The government does not have the capacity to seize land and distribute it, because it has many landowners within its ranks. It is not possible that they would cut the branch of the tree on which they are sitting. Bengal Government has made a law to obtain 4,00,000 acres out of 12.5 million acres in the state. It only means that it intends to maintain the status quo.”⁷

In West Bengal, 1,851 acres were received from 1,170 donors in 25 days. For Vinoba, the greatest benefit of the tour

was that 'it greatly strengthened love in my heart'.⁸ He therefore termed the tour '*Prem-yatra*'—the tour of love.

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In Odisha, Vinoba was welcomed on 26 January with bhoodan of 1,20,000 acres and 93 gramdans. Chief Minister Nabakrishna Chaudhari was present on the occasion. Bhoodan had already gathered some momentum in the state due to the efforts by Gopabandhu and Ramadevi Chaudhari, who had already completed a walking tour of the state for eight months.

In Odisha, Vinoba started talking of land revolution right from the outset:

"Land revolution is the next task. Merely giving land to the landless is not enough. Private ownership of land is to be abolished now. When people put this idea in practice, Bhoodan-Yajna would achieve its fruition."⁹

As he explained, gramdan—abolition of private property in land—was the pinnacle, and he wanted to try this experiment in Odisha. Why? His answer was:

"Poverty in Odisha is unparalleled even in India. If the poor do not renounce ownership, who will? The poor have to renounce ownership; ownership of the rich will then come to an end as a matter of course. India is fortunate to have a few rich ready to renounce ownership. But this should not make us over-ambitious. Demanding more from them could be counter-productive. Hence, we should gain as much sympathy from the rich as possible and try to succeed in the attempt to induce the poor to renounce ownership. That is the right way to vanquish the fortress of property. Odisha was particularly favourable for making such an attempt. - - - I, therefore, decided to try the luck of Sarvodaya in Odisha."¹⁰

Avadi session of the Congress resolved to establish 'socialistic' pattern of society in India. Vinoba said,

"I prefer instead the term '*samyayogi*'. - - - Nonviolent socialism is nothing but *samyayoga*. It would be established when the State power gets decentralised and distributed in villages."¹¹

Babulal Mittal, a member of Uttar Pradesh Legislative Assembly, had met Vinoba in 1952. Now he renounced his political career, came to Vinoba and became a dedicated Sarvodaya worker. Bhoodan was producing many such workers.

On 26 February, Vinoba came to Manpur, the first gramdan village in Odisha and the third one in India. This village, with a population of 620 and 600 acres land, had gifted all its lands on 30 January. On 17 May 1954, its land had been redistributed, keeping 44 acres for collective farming. It had been unanimously decided by the villagers that every individual should get minimum 0.67 acre and maximum 1.5 acres to begin with, and complete equality in landholding be achieved by 1957. That such a thing was happening in the 20th Century was indeed incredible! Collective spinning and collective prayers were being held there regularly. Vinoba had congratulated the villagers and had declared, "The idea of bhoodan will pick up in the international sphere also. Manpur will invade Australia!"¹² He could not control his emotions while speaking to the residents of Manpur.

On 15 March, Vinoba addressed members of the state Legislative Assembly and asked them never to forget that they were representatives of the poor. On 20 March, he entered Jagannathpuri, known for the temple of Lord Jagannath, the venue of annual Sarvodaya Conference.

At Puri, when he went to the famous temple along with his entourage, entry was denied to a French Christian lady accompanying him, whereupon Vinoba refused to enter the temple and expressed his anguish:

"I have studied with devotion the religious tradition of India from RigVeda to Ramakrishna Paramhans and Mahatma Gandhi, and it is my humble claim that I have been practising Hinduism as I have understood it. Had I gone inside, leaving the French lady, that would have been unrighteous on my part. - - - This is a painful event for our country and our religion."

He emphasized that Hindu temples and sacred texts should be open to all and a religion like Hinduism, which is essentially

all-inclusive, catholic, liberal and devoid of rigidity, should not be interpreted in a narrow and obscurantist manner.¹³

The land received and distributed as on 15 March 1955 was as under¹⁴:

<u>State</u>	<u>Bhoodan</u> (Acres)	<u>Donors</u>	<u>Distribution</u> (Acres)	<u>Donees</u>
1. Bihar	22,42,222	2,88,165	15,000	8,812
2. Uttar Pradesh	5,22,206	17,590	87,897	26,777
3. Odisha	1,28,464	57,814	945	105
4. Assam	1,950	--	--	--
5. Andhra	21,411	692	16	38
6. Karnataka	2,803	538	--	----
7. Kerala	28,113	1,200	--	----
8. Gujarat	37,578	8,426	3,235	1,011
9. Tamil Nadu	32,467	5,865	530	161
10. Delhi	9,245	249	90	25
11. Punjab	11,421	2,615	75	16
12. Madhya Pradesh	85,666	17,367	21,720	4,005
13. Madhya Bharat	51,987	5,014	311	----
14. Maharashtra	28,000	4,500	1,001	----
15. Mysore	5,962	2,442	--	----
16. Rajasthan	3,45,816	4,058	7,762	1,511
17. Vindhya Pradesh	5,984	1,103	645	253
18. Saurashtra	41,000	15,000	26	7
19. Himachal Pradesh	2025	66	--	--
20. Hyderabad	1,05,833	3,878	30,488	6,542
21. W. Bengal	9,303	4,307	921	740
22. Bombay	123	6	--	----
<u>Total</u>	<u>37,19,579</u>	<u>4,40,875</u>	<u>1,70,662</u>	
	X	X	X	

The seventh Sarvodaya Conference began at Jagannathpuri on 25 March. Presided over by Ravishankar Maharaj, it was attended, among others, by President Dr. Rajendra Prasad. An apostle of Gandhi, he was now the supreme commander of the armed forces of the nation by virtue of his position. He regretted that both the numbers in and the expenditure on the armed forces had increased after Independence.¹⁵

Vinoba, in his inaugural address, dwelt at length on the concept of the State-free society. He said that although coercive power had a role in the existing situation, it was necessary from the point of view of nonviolence to have the biggest institution in the country devoted to selfless service. In this context, he wondered whether Congress could prove to be the biggest impediment in the way of nonviolent reconstruction of the country—it being primarily election-oriented. He also mentioned Gandhi's proposal of Lok-sevak Sangh in this connection and said that, had it been implemented, power would have become subservient to service. He added,

“It needlessly reposes on us the responsibility of forming a new organisation - - - an organisation which would have to render service and also acquire strength necessary to control political power through that service.”¹⁶

He also dwelt on satyagraha which was being misinterpreted and the term was being misused on a wide scale. He pointed out that while satyagraha had to be negative during Gandhi's times because of foreign rule, it had to be positive in a free country under democratic set-up, although the contention that satyagraha had no place in democracy was patently wrong. Reiterating that bhoodan was a constructive satyagraha, he appealed to all to devote energy to it for two years:

“Bhoodan is being carried out in a nonviolent way; but it is not the only nonviolent way. If we try it fully and see the result, we can then think of a more effective form of satyagraha. But if we fail to do so, we would not be worthy of attempting any refinement in satyagraha.”¹⁷

Speaking at the Conference, Kumarappa pointed out that bhoodan was not only about land; it was a Movement of

sharing. He emphasised that mere collection of land was not enough; its proper utilization had to be planned, and therefore "we should have agrarian reform colleges".¹⁸

Sarva Seva Sangh, in its meeting, expressed its opinion about ceiling laws being enacted in several states:

"Experience tells us that these Acts have done little to provide land to the landless. In fact, big landholders have distributed land among their relatives and friends and thus fortified their ownership. As ceiling limits are quite high, these Acts have hardly any impact on the inequality in landholding; rather, the laws have put seal of approval on that inequality. Estimates of the state governments about the surplus land have proved wrong. Exceptions have been made in some states for mechanised farms. - - - Altogether, these Acts have resulted either in maintaining status-quo or accentuating inequality in landholding."¹⁹

Timely distribution of gifted lands was also stressed in the deliberations. Vinoba reiterated that future of Sarvodaya depended on the successful completion of this task.

The matter of earmarked gifts was also discussed. In Vinoba's opinion, although such gifts were not fully in keeping with the Movement's spirit, they were not harmful to the Movement. It was decided that such gifts could be accepted provided the donee belonged to the same place, was landless and the land gifted was sufficient for his family's livelihood.²⁰

In his last address, Vinoba exhorted all to work for establishment of State-free society by 1957. He again deliberated upon the science of satyagraha and said that satyagraha should go on becoming gentler and gentler in keeping with the process of nonviolence; only then would it go on becoming more and more powerful and effective. He asked the workers to go to the people and ask for land not only for the solution of land problem, but for ending all the States who could not limit violence, and establishing nonviolence and peace in the world.²¹ That was the aim of the Movement; it was not for piecemeal solutions of material problems, although such problems were bound to be solved in its wake. That was why

Vinoba was always emphasising its spiritual and revolutionary dimensions.

Sarva Seva Sangh decided to discontinue publication of the monthly 'Sarvodaya' and make the weekly journal 'Bhoodan-Yajna' its mouthpiece.

In response to Vinoba's appeal, Baba Raghavdas and Ravishankar Maharaj vowed to undertake walking tour for two years. Inmates of Sevagram Ashram decided to close the ashram for two years and work for bhoodan.

The problem of eviction of peasants was serious. When a peasant was evicted by a landlord in a village in Bihar, bhoodan workers and landless labourers sat on a *dharna*. Vested interests charged that bhoodan workers were spreading discontent and rebellion. Vinoba was of the opinion that the workers should give statements and go to jail rather than fighting the case, but the workers had already been released on bail. It was decided at JP's instance that the case should be fought, as refusal to fight the case would put the government in an awkward situation. So, the case was fought, but it lingered on. Sarva Seva Sangh passed a resolution on the evictions, asking the peasants to remain firm irrespective of the difficulties.²²

The *yatra* was resumed on 1 April after the Conference.

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With only two years to fulfil the resolve for land revolution, workers geared themselves up for the task. Sarva Seva Sangh prepared a draft of 'Land Revolution resolve' and asked the workers to hold meetings all over the country on 18 April, the anniversary of bhoodan.

The message of bhoodan was touching all the segments of society, as was evidenced by a letter Vinoba received in which the writer informed him that he had given houses on rent, but had now gifted them to the tenants in keeping with the spirit of bhoodan.²³

The conference of Afro-Asian countries at Bandung was an important initiative for world peace, and Pandit Nehru had a

prominent role in it. Vinoba welcomed this initiative.

All-India Congress Committee's meeting was held at Berhampur on 9 May, when Vinoba was camping there. This was the first time Vinoba attended A.I.C.C. meeting. He dwelt upon the history and significance of bhoodan and made an appeal to the Congressmen to devote two years to this work. He also asked the Congress to take up the issue of evictions.²⁴ Odisha Congress Committee resolved to collect bhoodan of 2 million acres.

To take radical, novel and profound ideas to remote villages was perhaps the most unique contribution of Vinoba's walking tour. He was always appreciative of the institution of *parivrajak sannyasi* (one who renounces the world and moves about educating the people). Such *sannyasis* had carried spiritual ideas and concepts to even the most remote corners of the country. Now Vinoba was following in their footsteps.

His talk at Digapahandi (14 May), for example, was a significant elaboration of his political philosophy:

"We want that good government should replace anarchy, and then good government should make way for a State-free society. A State-free society will not be devoid of order; order will be there, but it will be distributed over all the villages. These days, there is talk of socialist society, but that is about good governance only, not about freedom from the State. - - If freedom from the State is our ultimate goal, we should see to it that good governance does not become impediment in the way of that goal. - - - And on the other hand, we would have to continue efforts to organise people's power for achieving that freedom."²⁵

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On 19 May, Vinoba gave title-deeds to the villagers in Akili, a gramdan village, where land had recently been redistributed equally with the consent of all. In this village, 15 out of 31 families owned land, but now all families got land according to the number of members in each family—one acre per head—and the rest was earmarked for collective farming. Overwhelmed

with emotions, Vinoba said,

“Such gifts of entire villages would undoubtedly be considered miraculous in the history of the world. - - - I believe that what such villages have done can lead to establishment of peace throughout the world. People see the power hidden in an atom, but gramdan is more powerful than atomic energy. While atomic explosion pollutes the environment of the world, a single gramdan purifies the environment of the world”²⁶

The era of gramdan had begun. Now there was not just the question of collecting land from landowners and distributing it to the landless; land of a village was now to be shared by all the villagers and held by them in common. This was harbinger of an era of equality—and that too without shedding a drop of blood, and only through the power of love and reason. Villages began to come forward to declare gramdan even without hearing Vinoba.

Efforts of Chaudhari family were behind this atmosphere. Gopabandhu was known as the ‘Gandhi of Odisha’. His wife Ramadevi was also active in constructive work. His younger brother Nabakrishna was Chief Minister of the state, but his heart lay not in power politics, but in selfless service. Nabakrishna’s wife Malatidevi had dedicated herself to the service of tribals and done much to arouse and educate them. Their son Manmohan accompanied Vinoba throughout Odisha tour and translated his speeches in Oriya. His sister Annapurna Maharana helped him in the publication of the Movement’s literature, while her husband Sharatchandra Maharana was convener of the state Bhoodan Committee. Nabakrishna’s daughter Uttara was also an active worker and had married Narayan Desai, a leading worker from Gujarat.

On 27 May, Vinoba entered Koraput district, where he received striking response. *Yatra* continued in this malaria-infested region, full of hilly tracts and thick forests, in incessant rains and floods, testing the mettle of workers. This district, populated by backward tribes and with mostly unfertile land, became the laboratory of gramdan. As Vinoba continued his

trek, declarations of gramdan and redistribution of land followed in its wake. He spent 122 days in the district.

The philosophy of gramdan evolved gradually. The term did not, in fact, give a clear idea of the full import and inherent potentialities in it. When all the lands in Mangaroth were gifted in bhoodan, the word 'gramdan' was used. As all lands now stood socialised, possibility of creating a new and equitable land system presented itself. Equitable redistribution of land was the first natural step. Secondly, there was no question of creating ownership again. The Movement had always stood for dissolution of private property and community's control over the natural resources. Gramdan provided an opportunity to create a framework for institutionalization of such control and a springboard for moving ahead towards village self-rule, which was the ultimate goal of the Movement. The villagers, who had agreed to share their assets with others, could be expected to work together for the economic development and social progress of the community.

Potentialities in bhoodan blossomed in the form of gramdan. Bhoodan, apparently, was a programme for the alleviation of a material problem. It was a programme not for dissolution, but for distribution of ownership. Gramdan, on the other hand, was a revolutionary programme.

Vinoba's genius was now in full bloom in unfolding potentialities of gramdan.

In Sundhidhamini (5 June), he explained its benefits:

"The first benefit of abolishing private ownership in land is the advantage it will offer for increasing wealth of the village. All the villagers will deliberate together and plan what should be sowed, where and how much. They will think how agriculture should be improved and what portion of the produce should be sold outside. People will not take loans individually. In fact, a treatise could be written on the benefits of gramdan. In short, it can be said that it will help in bringing material prosperity; or in other words, in securing economic freedom.

“The second benefit of making the whole village a family is that it will enhance mutual love, and life will be happier. When we share each other’s happiness and sorrows, happiness increases and sorrows get reduced. Happiness is the outcome of mutual aid. We can call this a cultural benefit.

“A great benefit will be that the moral level of the people would rise. Quarrels, clashes, thefts etc. would get reduced. Nobody steals in his own home.

“When an individual is self-centred, he gets trapped in attachment. But when he renounces everything, that is a prelude to true liberation. When a person feels that whatever he has and he himself belong to the village and the village belongs to him, he gets liberated easily.”²⁷

Now Vinoba began to focus on village Swaraj and its aspects like rural industrialisation, rural education, rural sanitation and freedom from courts and evil habits.²⁸

It had always been his practice to learn local language and even dialects, study spiritual literature therein and interpret it in the current context and also explain the significance of bhoodan and gramdan in terms of its teaching. In Odisha, he would frequently refer to Jagannath Das’ Bhagavat.

At Dumripur (30 July), he noted five stages in the Movement. The first stage was the Telangana tour, when a new idea emerged. The second stage was the Pavnar to Delhi tour when the idea attracted attention of the country. In the third stage, targets were set and achieved, thereby strengthening faith in the workers. The fourth stage was the intensive work in Bihar, which resulted in bhoodan by about 3,00,000 persons. “Now the fifth stage has begun in Odisha. It will provide foundation to the progress towards village swaraj. This is the last stage of Bhoodan-Yajna.”²⁹

His talk at Kotipam (9 August) was a further elaboration of his political philosophy. Freedom from the State had now become his refrain. When asked how it was consistent with the government’s aid to bhoodan, he was quick to reply that he wanted to destroy the State with the aid of the State, just as one

could cut a tree with an axe having a grip made from the wood of the same tree!³⁰ He was emphatic in pointing out that Sarvodaya was not aloof from politics; it had a politics of its own—it wanted to transform power politics into *lokniti*:

“It is a misconception that we have nothing to do with politics. No; we do not just stand for mere humanitarian service. We have a political aspiration. We want to transform politics into *lokniti*.”³¹

Anarchists and others had talked of ending the State, but had failed in formulating a concrete strategy in tune with their principles. Vinoba's concept of *lokniti* was a distinctive contribution in this context.

It had been demonstrated in Bihar that thousands could give land, and it had been demonstrated in Odisha that people could renounce private property in land. The world had seen an alternative path. Now it was for it to choose the same or not. Vinoba remarked, “My work is finished now. What more can one individual do? I would henceforth move about freely, spreading knowledge.”³²

This was the role in tune with Vinoba's nature and which he preferred. He had said time and again that had Gandhi been alive, he would not have stirred out of his ashram. But destiny, in a way, pushed him to a position of leadership. A movement arose and he had to lead it. But neither was organisation in his blood nor did he believe in the principle of leadership—that was what nonviolence demanded. This fact did influence the nature of the Movement, its strategy, its progress—and its fate too.

Independence Day witnessed firing on a mob of students at Patna. Vinoba condemned it unequivocally. On the same day, a batch of unarmed workers tried to enter Goa, which was still being ruled by Portugal. The barbaric treatment it received, which resulted in the death of some workers, also pained him and he condemned it.

By 11 September, Vinoba's birthday, number of gramdans in Koraput district had touched 469. They included not only tribal hamlets, but other villages also. And complete

redistribution of land was an essential feature almost everywhere. At Chandrapur, Biswanath Patra, who owned 4,500 acres, got 30 acres in redistribution, while Damodar Patra, owner of 200 acres, accepted 24 acres in redistribution.³³ At Garanda, Vinoba himself redistributed land of seven gramdan villages. When the headman, owner of 180 acres, got only 7 acres, villagers tried to persuade him to take a few acres more, but he protested, "Why should I? As the headman, it is my duty to feed others first and eat afterwards."³⁴

This was the spirit gramdan was generating. Individuals were merging their self-interest into the wider interest of community. That was why Vinoba was asserting that gramdan had no place for the conflict between individual and community, which was a creation of Western sociologists and philosophers, and "those who are accepting gramdan are creating a new ethics and a new sociology."³⁵

By 29 September, number of gramdans in Koraput had risen to 605. It was seen as an opportunity to create a model of alternative development. Sarva Seva Sangh entrusted responsibility for the same to Annasaheb Sahasrabuddhe, its Secretary. Vinoba was not, however, enthusiastic about the proposal. He believed that it was for the villagers to work for their economic development, and the State and various institutions of the civil society should help them, but the Sarvodaya workers should not undertake this responsibility. However, he did not oppose the initiative, but did caution the workers that such work should not depend too much on outside help and power of the local people should be the foundation of economic development being sought; and secondly, it must not be forgotten that moral uplift was more important than economic development.³⁶

At Jagannathpur (30 September), the last halt in Odisha, Vinoba called Odisha tour '*shakti-yatra*'—the strengthening tour. Eulogising the local people, he said,

"It is said that peace cannot be established in the world as long as inequalities and injustices are not removed. But I want to say that as long as the power of peace is not

manifested, injustices will not end. - - - The villagers here have discovered the power in peace.”³⁷

The outcome of Odisha tour was: 2,57,222 acres bhoodan by 95,757 donors, distribution of 37,822 acres to 2,200 families and 812 gramdams.³⁸

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The Movement was spreading throughout the country. In C.P. and Berar, 40 teams undertook walking tours and received 16,400 acres. Walking tours were going on in most of the states. Tukdoji Maharaj of Vidarbha attended World Conference of Religions in Japan and told about bhoodan there. Tamil Nadu Congress Committee resolved to collect 2.5 million acres. In Tamil Nadu Sarvodaya Conference, C. Rajagopalachari distributed land and said,

“None ever expected before that such a thing could happen in this *Kaliyug* (era of darkness). - - - I do not know what *punya* (merit) I have done to enjoy this scene before me.”³⁹

Some state governments offered government lands to Bhoodan Committees for distribution—obviously they had more faith in them than in their own machineries. Sarva Seva Sangh, however, felt that the governments should do their own work; although that should preferably be in accordance with the rules stipulated by the Movement.⁴⁰

9. In Andhra and Tamil Nadu

The *yatra* entered Andhra on 1 October 1955.

Congress under Gandhi's leadership had always supported linguistic reorganisation of provinces so that their administration could be run in the people's languages. Soon after Independence, people became restless for it, but national leaders thought that time was not ripe in view of the post-Partition scenario. There was also an apprehension in some quarters that it would have negative impact on national integration. Dar Committee, constituted in 1948 to find out its advisability, advised against it. It was followed by JVP (Jawaharlal Nehru, Vallabhbhai Patel and Pattabhi Sitaramayya) Committee, which too recommended postponement of linguistic reorganisation. This led to widespread disturbances, often violent. Swami Sitaram, a senior Gandhian, started an indefinite fast in August 1951 for the creation of Telugu-speaking Andhra state. He, however, terminated it after 35 days in response to Vinoba's appeal.¹ Later, Potti Sriramulu started indefinite fast on 19 October 1952 and died after 58 days. His death triggered off strikes and violence, which forced the Central Government to yield to the demand. Creation of Andhra state was followed by election in the state.

Bhoodan had not made much headway in this background. Still, Vinoba was enthusiastically welcomed there. Gandhi's atheist disciple Prof. Gora (Goparaju Ramachandra Rao) actively took up the work.

Creation of Andhra, as was expected, set the ball rolling. States Reorganisation Commission was constituted in August 1953 and it submitted its report in October 1955. It recommended linguistic states with the exception of Bombay and Punjab provinces. Andhra tour was taking place on this backdrop. Vinoba had to appeal often against the rise of narrow-minded provincialism.

Violence, particularly for linguistic provinces, was disquieting for him, for it showed that bhoodan and gramdan, contrary to his expectations, had failed in establishing a peaceful atmosphere, particularly in urban areas. The principle of linguistic reorganisation was indeed sound; in fact, it enjoyed almost universal support. But petty provincialism was posing a threat to national unity and integrity and tempers were running high for trivial matters. Villages in the border areas between two states had everywhere become bone of contention. "What harm is there if some people speaking a particular language stay in another state? That would rather help integration of different traditions and values."—Vinoba opined.²

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On 22 October, Shrikrishnadas Jajoo, a veteran Gandhian worker and a staunch supporter of bhoodan, died at the age of 75.

Gramdan, that is, village self-rule had now become the focus; and Vinoba was now continually harping on freedom from the State—its advisability, inevitability and the process. At the same time, he was also making suggestions for the betterment of democratic system. But the goal was clear: "There is nothing more dangerous than the State. So long as we do not get rid of the States, there will be no peace in the world."³ Dissolution of private property was *sine qua non* for this consummation; and that was also his refrain. He also had to take every opportunity to explain nonviolent techniques and nonviolent methods of working: "Conflicts and collisions result in destruction, while churning produces butter. We do not subscribe to conflicts and collisions; we believe in churning,"⁴ he said at Vijaywada.

Pace of the Movement was naturally getting affected due to the vitiated atmosphere. Bhoodan was still being received, but in a trickle. And gramdan had not gathered desired momentum. This was disquieting for independent observers as well. Ramvriksha Benipuri wrote in 'Bhoodan-Yajna' of 27 January, 1956:

"I remember how surcharged the atmosphere was with revolutionary fervour during Vinoba's Bihar tour. No

movement had stirred people's hearts to such an extent after 1921. A wave of revolution was surging in Bihar. Where is that wave now? Appeals are repeatedly being made, purses of Sarva Seva Sangh and Gandhi Smarak Nidhi are open; yet there is dearth of workers. Those who had been drawn towards that wave appear to be moving away from it."

Benipuri's diagnosis was that there was contradiction between the words and conduct of the leaders, those associated with ashrams and institutions could not feel the pulse of people, association with government had undermined the foundation of the Movement, and doubts were rising about the effectiveness of Vinoba's leadership.⁵

Vinoba was certainly not unaware of the situation. He was doing his best to enthuse the people, to put before them new and refreshing ideas and achieve breakthrough.

He had always sought active participation of donors in the Movement. First donors' association (*daata sangh*) was formed in Khammam, and within two months there were more than fifty such associations.

Walking tours were taking place throughout the country. Sushila Nayyar started her tour from Kanyakumari (Tamil Nadu). Vimala Thakar also undertook tour in Tamil Nadu. Gopabandhu Chaudhari had started his tour immediately after Vinoba's departure from Odisha.

Shriman Narayan, senior Gandhian and member of Planning Commission, met Vinoba to discuss the draft of Second Five-Year Plan. Vinoba asked what amount was going to be spent on villages with population less than 2000, and how much was going to be spent for improving the condition of the most backward like the sweepers. He was concerned about *antyodaya*—unto this last, while planners were concerned about large-scale industrialization and increase in gross national product.

Nehru met Vinoba at Madhavraopalli on 6 March 1956. Several issues were discussed. Vinoba reiterated his criticism of the elections and pleaded for indirect elections. Nehru said that

general elections were around the corner and time was not appropriate for drastic changes in the system. At Bodhgaya (1954) he had evaded the issue, because elections were far away!

The *yatra* entered Andhra again on 11 March after spending a few days in Telangana. Chief Minister Gopal Reddy welcomed Vinoba in Kurnool, the state capital. Vinoba also addressed members of the state legislature. At Kurnool, Central Minister A.P. Jain met him and discussed land reforms proposed in the Second Plan.

With the advent of Ambar Charkha, khadi production was likely to receive impetus, although there were many risks too. Vinoba supported Ambar Charkha for regional self-sufficiency. He exhorted weavers to link themselves to Ambar Charkha and vehemently attacked the government's policy of encouraging powerlooms and killing handlooms and other rural industries: "The rulers of India are muddle-headed. If weavers here are not fully protected, it is a crime on the part of the government."⁶

Sarva Seva Sangh executive committee met at Adoni (22 March). Sangh's role in the coming elections was discussed. It was Vinoba's firm and consistent stand that as the system of elections was faulty and anti-poor, Sarvodaya workers should have nothing to do with it.⁷ This was his consistent position, but many Sarvodaya workers had attraction for politics, and with every approaching election they would think of mulling over their role in it.

At Adoni, a meeting was also held to discuss the Five-Year Plan. Jayaprakash criticized control of industries by the government, while Kumarappa attacked the type of industrialization being pursued.⁸ In an address to traders, Vinoba made an appeal to them to take up work necessary for the fulfilment of *bhoodan*, reminding them of their role contemplated in our tradition.⁹

A weekly journal in English, titled 'Bhoodan', was started on 18 April with Raosaheb Patwardhan as the editor.

Workers in C.P. and Berar had resolved to collect 1,00,000 acres in about an year. Under Thakurdas Bang's stewardship,

groups of them undertook walking tours; they received 75,000 acres in 10 months and distributed 15,000 acres.¹⁰

The Bihar Agricultural Lands (Ceiling and management) Bill was presented in the state Assembly. Vinoba's proposal for land levy had not found any place in it. JP and other Sarvodaya leaders criticized this omission, objected to the high ceiling limit and expressed the fear that there was hardly any likelihood of getting surplus land.¹¹ This fear was vindicated—the Act did fail in securing any land.

Caste differences was a burning issue in South India and Vinoba had to deal with it frequently. He severely attacked caste differences for being neither in tune with India's tradition nor with the era of science.¹²

In Andhra, 62,634 acres bhoodan and 20 gramdans were received.¹³ Vinoba left Andhra on 13 May and entered Tamil Nadu.

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Efforts for bhoodan had started in Tamil Nadu since 1952. On 2 October, Raja of Ramnad offered 10,000 acres. Shankarrao Deo started walking tour of 45 days on 2 October and received 3,000 acres. Jagannathan walked from Kanyakumari to Madurai and received 1,000 acres. Wayalur became the first village in the state to be declared gramdan (on 2 October 1955). Vinoba's arrival gave a boost to these efforts. Gandhigram and Gandhi Niketan, two of the biggest constructive work institutions, took up the work of bhoodan.

While gramdan had received good response in the tribal heartland of Odisha, it was yet to be sufficiently tested how it would fare elsewhere—particularly in Tamil Nadu, where the situation was particularly adverse. The Dravidian Movement had created markedly anti-Hindu, anti-North India and anti-Congress sentiments. Yet, even from the outset, Vinoba continued to express the hope of fulfilment of bhoodan and establishment of gram-swaraj in Tamil Nadu. He declared that he was ready to give as much time as needed for the purpose.

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Eighth Sarvodaya Conference was held at Kanchipuram, a famous pilgrimage centre in Tamil Nadu, from 26 May to 3 June. It was presided over by Appasaheb Patwardhan and attended by over 9,000 delegates. President Dr. Rajendra Prasad also attended it. By March, bhoodan stood at 41,07,491 acres (through 5,06,485 gift letters), out of which 3,70,352 acres had been distributed to 4,30,257 families.¹⁴

Vinoba was now anxious to give a more revolutionary dimension to the Movement. He had always desired—and worked for in his own way—to make the Movement a people's movement: then only would it be a truly revolutionary movement. It should not remain confined to bhoodan committees. He opened his heart before the workers.

Vinoba's two addresses in the Conference were historic. He appealed for discouraging the leadership principle and advocated what he called '*gana-sevakatva*'—neither individual leadership, nor collective leadership, but what could be called 'collective servanthship':

"Bhoodan works in such a way that leadership is necessarily local; or, rather, it is better to say that it throws up local servants, rather than local leaders. It is so because you will get land only if you go to the people as selfless workers, not as leaders."¹⁵

A conference of donees had recently been held in Madhya Pradesh and the participants had resolved to donate a part of their produce. Vinoba, mentioning this, averred that it gave a fitting reply to those who wondered how the Movement sought to change the hearts of the landless and bring about their uplift.¹⁶

Referring to the violence for linguistic reorganisation of provinces, he underlined the need to build the power of satyagraha and develop its science. He also called for complementing bhoodan work with khadi and village industries, village self-sufficiency and eradication of caste differences. In this context, he also undertook fast for three days, solely for spiritual nourishment.

In his concluding address, he asserted, in the context of the impending general elections, that dissolution of the State and of politics was the core of Gandhi's thought and the mission of Sarvodaya:

"I repeatedly say that those having faith in nonviolence should concentrate their energies on the establishment of lokniti. That is to say, we should engage ourselves in the task of ending *raj-niti* (power politics). The words '*raj*' (power) and '*niti*'³⁷ (morality) contradict each other. When '*niti*' makes its appearance, '*raj*' (political power) automatically collapses; and when '*raj*' (political power) reigns supreme, '*niti*' (morality) breaks down. We do not want the State; we want a people's political order—not *rajya*, but *prajya*. We do not know how long it will take, but it is the work that is worth doing for us. However, a lot of Gandhiji's colleagues are suffering from an illusion. They think that they are obliged to wield political power. I agree that if we did not want to shoulder the responsibility of administration, why should we have worked for Independence? We did achieve Independence, but that was specifically to start working for the dissolution of power immediately after taking hold of the reins of power."¹⁸

Speaking to workers, he pointed out that efforts to spiritualize politics had failed. Insisting that Sarvodaya was not aloof from politics; rather it was working for a different kind of politics, he said that establishment of lokniti involved breaking of politics.

About reconsideration of strategy, he opined that time was not opportune for a militant programme:

"Such a programme would not give you land. When I feel that the work (with this strategy) has reached its limit and an aggressive programme has become necessary, I would myself take up such a programme and you will get a signal."¹⁹

He also said that while land distribution should continue, the stream of land-gifts should not be allowed to dry up.

A group of young men, including a 14-year old boy, had

come for the Kanchipuram Conference from Mumbai, traversing the distance of over 1,400 km on foot. On the way, they had received bhoodan of 750 acres. Such was the atmosphere created by the Movement.

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The *yatra* was resumed after the Conference. On way to Kalkatur, Vinoba met the Shankaracharya of Kanchi Kamakoti. When the latter expressed his worry over the spread of atheism, Vinoba said that true faith in God implied love and compassion; and it was lack of compassion that was at the root of all the conflicts and atheism.

His usual practice was to walk to the next halt in the morning hours and stay there for the day. Now he started walking twice and taking two halts in a day, which meant walking during the noon—more than double the exertion for his frail body afflicted by ulcer. When an apprehension was expressed that this would affect the work adversely, his reply was: “If I walk twice a day, I would come across more people. And more work would be accomplished thereby.”²⁰

This decision naturally worried the workers. Charuchandra Bhandari, however, interpreted it as an initiative to make the satyagraha ‘gentler’. Vinoba said that such was not the intention, but desire to make satyagraha gentler and gentler was surely there.

“An individual cannot put in the same efforts in half a day as he can in a full day. One gets hardly half an hour to talk with the villagers. Hardly anything else can be done except putting forth the ideas. Any question of pressure does not come in the picture.”²¹

Such is the way of the working of nonviolence.

On 8 and 9 July, Vinoba was at Pondicherry, and ‘for two days, Pondicherry resonated with his presence.’ He met Mother, Sri Aurobindo’s spiritual collaborator and successor, and the spiritual aspirants at Sri Aurobindo Ashram. Mother blessed him with flowers and a copy of Sri Aurobindo’s spiritual epic ‘Savitri’. When Vinoba pleaded for her words of instructive wisdom, she

said that he was doing fine work and did not need any advice. But when Vinoba insisted for the same, she gave the message, 'Aspire for the Divine, live for the Divine, act for the Divine.'²²

This was exactly what Vinoba was doing.

Vinoba suggested that a branch of the Ashram be opened in a village, where an experiment of working with the villagers, on the basis of the village's resources, be made, although working with the people was not a necessary ingredient in the kind of spiritual practice in the Pondicherry Ashram.²³

Pondicherry was earlier under French rule, but the French had voluntarily relinquished their power in 1954, a few years after India's attainment of Independence from the British. Vinoba exhorted the Portuguese, who were still holding on to their colonies in India, to follow the French.

Tamil Nadu had a large population of the weavers. The government was pursuing the policy of encouraging powerlooms, purportedly for increasing the income of the weavers, but oblivious of the fact that it would throw most of the weavers out of the profession, besides killing the ancient art of weaving. Vinoba vehemently attacked this policy:

"The art of weaving is 10,000-years old. The government is working to destroy it. It means that it is continuing the work started by the East India Company. It is spending money on powerlooms, though it need not have to spend a farthing on the art of weaving."

He asked the weavers to raise their voice against this policy unitedly, and called for a boycott of powerloom goods.²⁴

Executive Committee of Sarva Seva Sangh demanded ban on powerlooms in its meeting on 4 August.²⁵ The committee also discussed its role in the next election. While reiterating its policy of not supporting any party, the resolution noted that the workers who would like to vote 'would, of course, not prefer to vote for candidates believing in communalism or violence.' Did not this, in effect, mean an indirect support to Congress and the Socialists? Vinoba again explained the concept of lokniti in this connection.

In Tamil Nadu, Vinoba resolutely opposed the Arya-Dravid controversy and continued his daily recitation of Ramayana. At Morupparu (1 August), he answered in detail the objections to the Ramayana.

Tamil Nadu Congress Committee supported bhoodan and resolved to collect 2 million acres in the state.

Bhoodan-Yajna bill was introduced in Punjab Legislative Assembly on 24 August. There was a provision, as was in the Acts in other states, to authorise Vinoba to nominate members of the Bhoodan Board. Comrade Harkishansingh Surjeet opposed this provision on the ground that it was anti-democratic to give such an authority to an individual outside the government. The provision, however, stayed. Replying to the discussion, the Revenue Minister said that the government had nothing to do with the Bhoodan Movement; its only object was to see that there were no legal hurdles in the gifts of lands and their distribution. The bill was passed on 27 August.²⁶

A Communist worker asked Vinoba at Selam, "The government is now supporting you. But what if it opposes you tomorrow?" Vinoba replied,

"It is not the way of nonviolence to make such speculation. We presume that the government cannot oppose those who have a high moral stature. It is true that some landowners are in the government. But they will not be able to oppose the Movement. They will either delay necessary legislation or flout it. But our work does not wait for legislation; for we want peaceful revolution through people's power.

"If the government opposes it, its moral prestige will decline. In a democracy, no government can afford opposing a moral power. And how would it oppose it? Will it bully the donors or the allottees? Will it stifle my voice? It is not in its power to do so. Yet, if confrontation becomes inevitable, let it be."²⁷

It clearly shows that Vinoba was fully aware of the inevitability of confrontation, which would inevitably arise in the course of building up gram-swaraj, after the declaration of gramdan. He was neither afraid of it nor avoiding it. As he told

the villagers of Purkadvur (11 September), who had resolved to make their village self-sufficient:

“When you take the Name of Lord Rama, the resolve to stand up against the demons is implicit in it. You say that you would look after your affairs. But there are people who want to look after your affairs. So, a struggle becomes inevitable.”²⁸

Such struggle against the State and the vested interests was bound to be protracted and Vinoba knew it. Critics have repeated *ad nauseam* that Vinoba avoided confrontational satyagraha, overlooking such statements. This criticism, to say the least, betrays ignorance of not only the mind of Vinoba but also of the working of nonviolence.

In Vidarbha region of C.P. and Berar, workers drew up an ambitious plan of distributing 15,000 acres in 1,000 villages on 2 October, Gandhiji's birth anniversary. Thirty one camps, fully funded by the people, were organised for the training of workers. The plan was remarkably successful.

Vinoba now suggested that the villagers themselves should take initiative in distribution of bhoodan lands. Bhoodan Committees should only keep records, give advice, and propagate ideas through literature etc.²⁹ Experience had demonstrated that it was beyond those committees to accomplish this task expeditiously.

At Tirupur (16 October), a famous centre for textiles, Vinoba repeated his stringent criticism of the misconceived powerloom policy and called upon the weavers to lodge protest against it forcefully. He also elaborated the concept of swadeshi. At Mudupaleyam, weavers decided to weave only handspun yarn.

Vinoba also continued to harp on the theme of State-free society and lokniti. But it was difficult to comprehend and appreciate what he was saying. When a foreign delegate to the Asian Socialist Conference remarked that as he was asking the best individuals to keep aloof from politics, government would be in the hands of bad elements, Vinoba explained,

“The best persons normally do not participate in elections, because they are meditative in nature, not action-oriented. I believe that they can exert more influence on the nation by remaining outside the Parliament than by being inside it. - - We should realise that the State is an unmixed evil. There cannot be peace in the world so long as the States are not eliminated.”³⁰

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Vinoba had always wanted that the Movement should become a people's movement: it should be conducted by the people themselves on the strength of their own resources. He was also realizing that the structure of Bhoodan Committees was proving to be an encumbrance. He had, therefore, been mulling over getting rid of such structures (*tantramukti*) and also of external financial aid from funding agencies (*nidhimukti*), and discussing the matter with his colleagues. At Palni (November 1956), he finally succeeded in prevailing upon them. Sarva Seva Sangh resolved to disband Bhoodan Committees at all the levels by January 1957, discontinue the financial aid from Gandhi Smarak Nidhi (which was giving such aid of its own accord) and other funding agencies and rely on sampattidan, *sootanjali* (gift of self-spun yarn), and the sale of literature. It, however, provided that the aid from funding agencies and the government could be taken for developmental works in villages.³¹

Organisations always seek to strengthen themselves and try to obtain aid from funding agencies. Here an organisation was seeking to dismantle itself; it was refusing to take financial assistance which it was receiving unsought. *Tantramukti* and *nidhimukti* were truly revolutionary decisions; and they did have far-reaching consequences on the fate of the Movement.

Bhoodan Committees were disbanded, but the workers were expected to continue working with redoubled zeal. They could form local committees constituting donors, donees and others, wherever possible. It was decided that every district would have a *nivedak* (literally, communicator) who would advise progress of the Movement in his district to Vinoba and Sarva Seva Sangh. Now the workers would have to fend for themselves. It was

going to test them severely, particularly as most of them came from lower and lower middle classes. With even the skeleton organisation gone, it was not clear how the work would be carried on. Vinoba's reply was:

"We shall tell the Lord that this Movement spread in these six years. If You want it to spread further, You would awaken Your other devotees. If You do not want this, we cannot do anything."³²

Vinoba had taken a great risk; he was aware that this step, although meant to give momentum to the Movement and the building of people's power, might result in the collapse of entire work. Still he felt that it was worth taking even then, for it was in tune with the science of revolution:³³

"A historian writing on the development of evolution of human ideas would give a lot of importance to this idea. In fact, that history is a true history, which delineates progressive development of human ideas."³⁴

He continued to explain the significance of this step. For the livelihood of workers, he suggested eight sources: (1) If one of the brothers in a family is working for this cause, other brothers should take care of his expenses, (2) Constructive workers, who get honorarium from institutions, should work for bhoodan also, (3) Citizens sympathetic to the cause should support the workers, (4) Teachers should contribute to support the students working in the Movement, (5) Farmers should give a part of produce to local workers, (6) Donors should take up this work, (7) Political parties should spare some of their workers and support them financially, (8) Businessmen should also help the workers.³⁵ It was easy to enumerate such sources, but would they actually work?

Palni decision was going to have serious implications for ordinary workers, and it could be said that it was taken by them; but it was essentially Vinoba's decision to which everyone consented. As Ostergaard and Currell rightly say,

"It was a decision whose likely consequences were neither fully thought out nor thoroughly discussed by other top leaders. It

was almost, if not quite, as much a surprise for them as it was for the ordinary *loksevak*s. At the same time, the decision was formally taken by the Sangh; any single *loksevak* could have prevented the decision by voting against it. If it was an autocratic decision, it was autocracy by consent.”³⁶

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Dalit leader Dr. B.R. Ambedkar died on 5 December. Vinoba had met him at Wardha long back. Like him, Vinoba was also working for the liberation of Dalits in his own way; bhoodan lands were being given to Dalits on a large scale. At Devdanpatti, Vinoba paid tribute to the departed leader.

People had apprehensions about the success of gramdan in Tamil Nadu. But Vinoba thought otherwise. For him, atmosphere in Tamil Nadu was more favourable to gramdan: firstly, villages there were centred around temples (“which shows that there is a sentiment that the land and the wealth in the village belong to God and all the villagers are there to serve Him”); secondly, Tamil literature was replete with sentiments against landownership; and thirdly, “Indian culture in its pristine form is found in Tamil Nadu.”³⁷

Vinoba's genius was unfolding different facets of gramdan in different ways, with arguments which were insightful, innovative and convincing. At Kaduvilarputti (18 December), he asserted that gramdan was an extremely pure religious idea, a most modern economic idea and a wholesome scientific idea:

“Religion says that if someone is suffering, all others should share his grief. In gramdan work, there is direct manifestation of compassion. Today, there are mounds of wealth at some places, while there are pits somewhere else. Production is hampered in such a society. Production will increase where there are no such mounds and pits, and there is sentiment of equality and co-operation. - - - Village affairs would be smoothly conducted and the village would progress along with every family, when the villagers consider their village as one family. Gramdan can bring this about.”

And, “If we do not co-operate with each other, we would not be able to carry on in the era of science.” In short,

“Religion teaches us compassion, economics teaches how to increase production, and science tells that co-operation is the foundation of strength. Science pursues strength, economics pursues wealth and religion seeks purification. All the three can be had through gramdan.”³⁸

At Chingkatle (23 December), he opined out that as the government was not giving protection to village industries, contrary to Gandhiji’s expectations, people should protect them:

“For this, villages should resolve to plan for their development. Gramdan leads to such resolve. This will empower the people. Khadi and other constructive programmes would blossom and bear fruit on the foundation of gramdan.”³⁹

Gramdan was thus essentially a resolve for self-reliance.

Gradually, the atmosphere started becoming favourable. When Vinoba entered Madurai on 30 December 1956, thousands were waiting for him on the approach road. At Madurai, Vinoba announced formation of Sarvodaya Mandal with Jagannathan as the convener. Other members included Guruswami Nadar, G. Ramachandran, G. Subramaniam and Aryanayakam. The prayer meeting was attended by over 75,000 persons. After the meeting, 2,000 persons lined up in a queue to have Vinoba’s autograph on his ‘Talks on the Gita’. Giving autographs to them took four hours.⁴⁰ After seven months of consistent efforts, gramdans started in a trickle, and it soon became a flow. Workers became confident enough to attempt *taluka-dan* (gramdan of all the 267 villages in the tehsil) of Tirumangalam.

It is worth noting that Vinoba continued to speak in Hindi, despite strong anti-Hindi sentiments. Not only this, he exhorted the Tamil people again and again to learn Hindi.

Rev. Keithan, an American missionary who had made India his home and had established an ashram at Kanawayapatti, took up gramdan work. He told his fellow Christians, “If we do not keep up with the times and take up this work, the religion of Lord Jesus would be as good as finished.”⁴¹

The Dravidian movement was on the rise at that time. It

was accentuating North-south divide and denouncing Hindu deities by attributing all the vices to them, and eulogizing the demons by ascribing virtues to them. Vinoba, in his inimitable style, pointed out that the Dravidian movement was only using a different language; it also extolled virtues and deprecated vices. He met Ramaswami Naicker, supreme leader of the movement, for two hours. Later, he had this to say about the meeting,

“I found that we agreed on 20-25 issues and differed on only 2-3 issues. I commended his work for the elimination of caste differences, but advised him to be gentle. He said, ‘Had I been a young man, I would certainly have worked in a gentle way. But I am an old man. I want to see caste differences eliminated before my death, but see no signs thereof. That is why I speak agitatedly.’ Persons with such a restive mind are indeed wonderful! He blessed my work, but said that he could not join it, as his priority lay in working for the removal of caste differences.”⁴²

With the second general elections around the corner, Vinoba continued to delve deeply into the concepts of State-free society and lokniti with redoubled zeal. “Welfare State is, in reality, an ill-fare State, for concentration of power in a few hands cannot lead to welfare,” he declared at Dharapuram.⁴³ At Palni, he was critical of delegation of religious duties to priests and of political power and duty of public service to a few representatives, for such delegation would result in the loss of vitality in life.⁴⁴ He held good governance risky, as the very idea of rule of a few over others was detestable.⁴⁵ For him, the very idea of serving the people through political power was illusory.

“Service, service and service alone; and through it, dissolution of political power—that is the way of building people’s power. This is what we mean by lokniti.”⁴⁶

But even leading Sarvodaya workers had not accepted this wholeheartedly. JP issued an appeal to the people enjoining them to vote, vote without fear and not to sell the vote. Not only this, the appeal called for ‘ending the monopoly of power being enjoyed by the ruling party, in the interest of democracy,

good governance and people's interests'.⁴⁷ Pandit Nehru angrily retorted that JP should better join politics rather than attacking the Congress from time to time irresponsibly. JP had quoted Lord Acton's famous saying, 'Power corrupts, and absolute power corrupts absolutely'. Nehru shot back, 'Irresponsibility corrupts and limitless irresponsibility corrupts absolutely.'⁴⁸

Elections were held and they expectedly witnessed malpractices on a wide scale. Vinoba lamented, "If people are not disillusioned by observing all this, they will never be disillusioned!"⁴⁹ The setback received by the Movement on account of elections, which stoked casteism and other differences, was disquieting for him. And that made him more impatient for gramdan:

"If we obtain thousands of gramdans, people would carry out different experiments at different places according to their lights. Then an appropriate way for the development of a village would be found. Thus a science would get shaped. - - Is it only the Sarvodaya workers' responsibility to work in gramdan villages? Our job is not to solve problems. We will certainly present a model in a few villages. But our main task is to obtain gramdans; let the country then grapple with the problems."⁵⁰

In response to JP's call to give one year to the cause of land revolution, about 100 students from Vidarbha discontinued education and joined the Movement. Hundred and twenty five workers decided not to visit their homes for one year, treating this as a prison term in the 'Lord's jail'. Hundreds came forward to spare some time for the Movement.

The *yatra* reached Kanyakumari, the southernmost tip of India in April 1957. On 15 April, Vinoba went to the sea-shore in the early morning. Sitting on a rock among the surging waves, he solemnly re-dedicated his life to the cause of gram-swaraj:

"The sun was rising. The ocean was washing the feet of goddess Kanyakumari. In the presence of all those present, I vowed to work for gram-swaraj: My body will continue working till swaraj gets transformed into gram-swaraj."⁵¹

10. In Kerala and Karnataka

Gramdan gets support from nation's leaders

Vinoba had told the workers at Palni, "Exert yourselves and distribute all the (gifted) lands." When legal difficulties were pointed out, he had said, "Do whatever is possible through law; and the rest without it. Some problems will arise, but do not bother about them." Accordingly, the workers made plans to distribute the lands by 18 April next year.¹ However, only 45,558 acres in 3,228 villages could be distributed. By that time, the figure for land distribution in Bihar was 1,67,592 acres.² Admittedly, it was just a fraction of the gifted lands. But the landless in Bihar were getting land only through bhoodan.

1957 was supposed to be the year of land revolution. 836 students and 500 citizens in Bihar responded to Jayaprakash's call to give one year to bhoodan.³ Many more in other parts of India followed suit.

In April 1957, number of gramdans in the country stood at 2,509. 1,792 were from Odisha, Koraput district accounting for 1399 gramdans.⁴ Redistribution of land had taken place in 568 gramdan villages; 89,839 acres had been redistributed to 12,293 families. While mostly equal redistribution had been effected, in many villages big landowners had been given somewhat higher share by common consent.⁵

In Gujarat, Ravishankar Maharaj's walking tour for two years had yielded bhoodan of 20,906 bighas and 3 gramdans besides donation of agricultural inputs and other assets.⁶ In Tamil Nadu, most of the villages in Tirumangalam tehsil had opted for gramdan.

Khan Abdul Gaffar Khan said that bhoodan was needed in Pakistan as well, and could be obtained provided the government was favourable.⁷

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On 18 April 1957 Vinoba entered Kerala, the state which had a democratically-elected Communist government—for the first time in history. The government's attitude was not hostile, if not positively sympathetic. Chief Minister Namboodiripad welcomed the *yatra* and expressed the hope that Vinoba's tour in the state at this juncture 'will be of great help to change the mental attitude and approach of the people as far as the land problem is concerned.'⁸

People of Kerala had ousted one party from power and given an opportunity to another one. Vinoba cautioned them that mere change in the ruling party was not enough: "The problem will be solved only when every village becomes a family."⁹

Rural Kerala had a peculiar structure. There were 2 million houses spread over the state, which the revenue department had divided in 4,615 clusters or 'villages' for administrative convenience. There was nothing like a village in Kerala. So, for the purpose of gramdan, a geographical area with at least 20 houses was considered equivalent to a village.

Shankarrao Deo had toured the state first in 1952 and Jayaprakash had visited it in 1954.

Kerala had a sizable Christian population. Some of them opposed gramdan on the ground that it was against private property, which the Christian tenets hold sacred. Vinoba countered that private property was indeed sacred, but its voluntary surrender was even more sacred;¹⁰ and that no religion could be against voluntary sacrifice.¹¹ Later, many churches supported bhoodan.

At Alwaye, Vinoba addressed thousands of *sannyasis* of the sect founded by Narayan Guru and exhorted them to spread the idea of gramdan, which was in tune with the true religion.¹²

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On 8 May, Vinoba reached Kaladi, the birth place of Shankaracharya. Annual Sarvodaya Conference was held there on 9 and 10 May in the presence of around 10,000 delegates.

The Conference was presided over by Dada Dharmadhikari. Dr. Rajendra Prasad, President of the Republic, was always keen to attend Sarvodaya conferences, but being unable to make it this time, sent a message expressing solidarity with the workers.

Addressing the Conference on the backdrop of the call for land revolution, which had generated great enthusiasm, particularly in the workers and also in the people at large to some extent, Vinoba said:

“Millions of Indians are expecting something special to happen this year. It is such pious hope which heralds Divine intervention - - -

“We have reached a point in our ascent where circumstances are getting favourable. When this work began, people were curious, but had several doubts as well in their minds, which was natural. The doubts dissolved gradually, and individuals and organisations began supporting us one by one. Today we have good wishes of all the countrymen for this cause. Everyone is desirous of its fruition. When bhoodan culminated into gramdan, all the people have become sympathetic - - -

“Let us have faith that God wants something to be done, and we are His instruments. We should henceforth avoid refuting anyone. Refutation is sometimes necessary while presenting a new idea. That phase is over now. Now refutation has become unnecessary. Workers should, therefore, do nothing except propagating ideas in their pure form. It will strengthen us greatly.”¹³

The Chief Minister could not attend the conference because of the Assembly session, but he expressed his regret and sent his good wishes through Krishna Iyer, the Law Minister. In his letter, he said that he believed that the ideas that Vinoba was developing about organisation of rural people on the basis of mutual co-operation would help in the practical solution of important problems like land relations, village industries, rural education and public health in the countryside. He ended his letter with the hope of having meeting and discussion with Vinoba so that co-operation between Bhoodan Movement and

the Communist Party of Kerala in the field could be given a concrete shape.¹⁴

Communist leader S.A. Dange too sent a message to the Conference, declaring that everyone was convinced about the urgent need for land revolution, although there could be difference of opinions about the way and the means, and his services ‘of whatever value they may have, are available to Vinoba for this cause.’¹⁵

Krishna Iyer, while addressing the Conference, supported bhoodan:

“The idea, that ownership of land is wrong, should spread widely. If we work to spread this idea from Kanyakumari to Kasargode (southern and northern tips of the state), there would be no difficulty in legislation. I do not think that legislation would be sufficient, if the minds of men do not change.”

Pattam Thanu Pillai (who later became Chief Minister) of Praja Socialist Party also addressed the Conference and said that the Movement had proved its practicability, and its success alone would solve the land problem.¹⁶

The focus of the Movement had now naturally shifted to gramdan. Bhoodan had blossomed into gramdan, which not only guaranteed the solution of land problem, but had also in its womb the seeds of rural reconstruction. Land revolution, in a sense, had already taken place in the people’s consciousness; now all energies needed to be focused on gramdan. However, it was not easy to convince the workers, who were looking for concrete results—and the target of collecting 50 million acres of land was far away; not to speak of distribution, which was nowhere near the mark. Jayaprakash pleaded,

“Now that 2,500 villages have embraced gramdan and the idea of dissolution of landownership has reached millions of villages, we will decelerate the Movement if we continue to engage ourselves exclusively in obtaining land-gifts and distributing the obtained land. We have to concentrate on the work of gramdan now. That does not mean that we are

abandoning the goal of removing landlessness from every village.”¹⁷

Sarva Seva Sangh noted the same thing in its resolution:

“We have reached a critical stage in our ascent; revolutionary implications of this Movement have become clear even before achievement of the goal of obtaining bhoodan of 50 million acres for the 10 million landless families in the country. Two thousand five hundred villages in the country have accepted gramdan and ended private ownership of land. After this achievement, the goal of collecting 50 million acres of land naturally gets merged in the goal of dissolution of private ownership of land throughout the country. We have, therefore, to dedicate ourselves fully to the work of gramdan.”¹⁸

It was surely not the intention that bhoodan should be forgotten; Vinoba did caution in this regard. Speaking to the workers in Andhra, he castigated them for failing to distribute the gifted lands.¹⁹

But it was gramdan that he saw as the ‘defence measure’, and therefore felt an acute sense of urgency. In a workers’ camp at Kaladi (12 May) he said,

“I accept that Gramdan is an enduring idea and programme, valid for all the times, and therefore can, and will, develop gradually. I, therefore, could have advocated a ‘go-slow’ policy, as there is nothing wrong in the gradual spread of a fundamental idea. But you see that I have become somewhat impatient. Impatience, however, must not make us do what should not be done; we should refrain from bogus work. That would be our undoing. But my impatience stems from the realization that we will be saved only if we work expeditiously; otherwise we will be nowhere.”

He added,

“Gandhian planning demands emphasis on gramdan and village industries. But that apart, food stock sufficient for two years in every village is essential to save national planning and the nation itself; this is possible only when the villagers unite and plan for the village. For such planning, gramdan

is imperative. As long as private ownership of land exists, there cannot be heart unity between the villagers; and without such unity, there cannot be a village plan. And without village plans, villages cannot become self-sufficient. Gramdan is thus necessary as a defence measure.”

Therefore, the situation demanded bold steps from the government:

“Official planning must be based on the principle of gramdan. I would even dare to aver that we should not mind even if it entails a bit of coercion. Such words from the lips of a votary of nonviolence would sound dangerous. But when defence of a country is involved, some coercion cannot be avoided. This coercion should not be such as to induce people to oppose it. When people realize that such coercion is because of the fact that the government is strongly in favour of gramdan and considers it essential for the defence of the country, my mind can come round to endorsing that coercion in such a situation.”²⁰

What Vinoba meant was that the government should not hesitate in making gramdan compulsory through legislation, taking advantage of the favourable atmosphere. By ‘coercion’ Vinoba clearly did not mean violence. But official planning does involve legal coercion to some extent, and the latter is inescapable in times of crisis. This was Vinoba’s advice to the government; he was not asking workers to pressurise the government in this regard—that was not the way of nonviolence.

The government failed to take advantage of the psychological moment. But, can anything else be expected from the defender of the status quo?

Experience of deep-rooted casteism, particularly in Tamil Nadu, made Vinoba emphasize tackling of that problem all the more: Gramdan would otherwise fail to make headway. But any effective programme to combat casteism does not appear to have been undertaken. And expectedly, this did affect the progress of gramdan.

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The *yatra* was resumed, as usual, after the Conference. In the Communist-ruled state, Vinoba often explained the difference between Sarvodaya and Communism.

On 11 July, Vinoba put forth the idea of Shanti-Sena: a corps of dedicated workers, one per population of 5,000, who would serve the people, prevent any outbreak of violence, and sacrifice their lives to quell the violence, in case it erupts.

In fact, the idea was not new. Gandhi had visualized such a corps in the context of communal disturbances. He could not take the idea to fruition, but it can be said that he did make a beginning through the peace initiative in Noakhali and through the sacrifice of his life. The subject had been broached in the Constructive Workers' Conference at Sevagram in 1948. Vinoba had talked about it at the Shivarampalli conference (1951) also. In July 1951, Sarva Seva Sangh had asked Kaka Kalelkar to prepare a plan for the organisation of Shanti-Sena. However, with the advent of bhoodan, other issues naturally got put on the back burner. Now that bhoodan and gramdan had made some headway, a new programme could be added—not as an alternative, but to strengthen the Movement by broadening the programme base. Gramdan visualized withering away of the State; and it was important that people should take over defence also, which is one of the key functions of the State:

“I continue to repeat that the State should be ended. That goal should always be before our eyes. People should defend themselves. The power to defend should be built at every place. This is what Shanti-Sena means.”²¹

Like other concepts put forth by Vinoba, the concept of Shanti-Sena also evolved gradually; its different facets got unfolded through Vinoba's speeches. For Vinoba, Shanti-Sena was a model of nonviolent organisation or, as he pithily put it, 'military service of nonviolence'.

There was no question of getting distracted from the programme of gramdan. The question of distribution of bhoodan lands was also not to be lost sight of. As Bhoodan Committees were not able to distribute the lands expeditiously, Vinoba now

suggested that the donor should himself identify the recipient, gift-declarations with the recipient's signature should be obtained, and the concerned land should be given to the allottee then and there.²²

Shanti-Sena was formally established at Manjeswaram, the last halt of Vinoba in Kerala, on 23 August. Eight persons took oath before Vinoba—K. Kelappan, E. Warrior, Janardan Pillai, Rajamma, Divakar Karta, S. Govindan and Damodaran Nayar.

Kerala tour's outcome was: 1,571 acres' bhoodan from 224 donors and 301 gramdans.²³

At Mahe, a former French colony, Vinoba appealed to the Portuguese to take a lesson from the French, who had voluntarily withdrawn from their colonies in India.

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On 24 August, Vinoba entered Karnataka. The all-Party conference convened by Sarva Seva Sangh at Yelwal, about 13 km from Mysore, on 21-22 September, was the most important event during the Karnataka tour. It was attended by 22 leaders representing the entire spectrum of national life: President Dr. Rajendra Prasad, Prime Minister Nehru, Home Minister G.B. Pant, Planning Minister G.L. Nanda, Community Development Minister S.K. Dey; Chief Ministers of Bombay, Madras, Kerala, Mysore and Orissa viz Morarji Desai, Kamaraj Nadar, E.M.S. Namboodiripad, S. Nijalingappa and Harekrishna Mehtab; Communist leader Z.A. Ahmed and President of Praja Socialist Party Gangasharan Singh; U.N. Dhebar, Bhaktavatsalam, Y.B. Chavan, S. Chennayya, Sucheta Kripalani and Shriman Narayan of the Congress; Gandhians Pyarelal and Jayaprakash Narayan; R.R. Diwakar, Governor of Bihar and Pranlal Kapadia of Khadi and Village Industries Commission. The leaders were invited in their personal capacity, not as representatives of their parties. Dr. Lohia, objecting to the exclusion of Jana Sangh leaders, did not attend. Acharya Kripalani could not attend as he was out of the country.

Addressing the conference, Vinoba explained the foundation of bhoodan and gramdan. During two days'

discussions, everyone praised gramdan and unequivocally declared their support for it. The communiqué issued at the end was as under:

At the invitation of the Sarva Seva Sangh, a Gramdan Parishad (Conference) was held on September 21 and 22nd, 1957, at Yelwal in Mysore state. The Rashtrapati graced the Conference with his presence. Other invitees, from all over India, deeply interested in this movement, were also present.

Acharya Vinobaji explained to the Conference how he came to adopt the non-violent technique for the solution of socio-economic problems, specially the land problem. Beginning with voluntary land-gifts, the movement developed and reached the stage of Gramdan, that is, the gift of entire village to the village community. More than 3,000 villages have thus far been voluntarily offered as Gramdan to the village community by the people concerned, who have renounced their private ownership in land.

The participants in the Conference welcomed this Gramdan Movement and expressed their high appreciation of the objectives underlying it. This would lead to a fuller development of co-operative life and effort in the village concerned and would also result in the economic betterment of the people of these villages and all round progress and development. It would further create the psychological climate all over India for the solution of the land problem and for the furtherance of co-operative life. The essential feature of this movement was the non-violent technique adopted and its voluntary character. Thus the ethical approach was combined with practical economic advantages and the development of a social order based on co-operation and self-help. Such a movement deserves every kind of help and encouragement.

The members of the Central and State Governments, who were present, while expressing their full appreciation of the Gramdan Movement and their desire to help it, pointed out that the Governments concerned would have to proceed with their schemes of land reforms which were based on the abolition of all intermediate interests in land, the limitation of holdings, and the promotion of the co-operative movement

in all its phases with the consent of the people concerned. This Governmental approach was not in conflict with the Gramdan movement and would indeed be helped by it.

It was further pointed out that closest co-operation was desirable between the Community Development movement and the Gramdan Movement.

At the conclusion of its two days' deliberations, the Conference expresses its high appreciation of Vinobaji's mission and his efforts to solve national and social problems by non-violent and co-operative methods, and appeals to all sections of the Indian people to give this mission their enthusiastic support.²⁴

Commenting on this joint statement, Vinoba likened it to the nation's resolution for complete Independence at Lahore (in December 1929) and even to an Upanishad for this age.²⁵ He said that the participants had noted two features in our work—nonviolence and co-operation:

“Nonviolent technique is based on the experience of oneness of the Self, while co-operation is based on science. Thus, the leaders have realised that there is confluence of science and spirituality in Sarvodaya. I hold that this Conference denotes the best outcome of six and a half years of this Movement. - - - This communiqué also says that co-operation between the Community Development Project and gramdan is desirable. It means that you (Sarvodaya workers) should spread in all the villages in which they (the government machinery) are present; then only you can extend co-operation to them.”

He expressed the desire that schemes like Community Development should be influenced by the Sarvodaya ideology.²⁶

Pandit Nehru said that gramdan had come to stay. Dr. Rajendra Prasad said that he had signed 239 bills about land reforms in the last five years; but ‘what we want cannot be accomplished by legislation alone.’ Z. A. Ahmed said, “There is concurrence about the goal. We all agree that this Movement is providing moral impulse which is necessary for the solution of an important problem.”²⁷

Gramdan thus received recognition as a viable alternative. Influencing government's development policies and programmes became a distinct possibility. The Movement now faced the challenge of taking advantage of the opportunities in the favourable climate.

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S.K. Dey, Central Minister for Community Development, had narrated to Vinoba his experience in a gramdan village he had visited, and commented that Community Development Programme could not take off unless a community was in existence, and that gramdan was creating community; so 'Community Development Programme can be fruitful only in gramdan villages.' Vinoba had told him categorically that he wanted nothing from the governments except some sympathetic gesture like preparing a scheme to provide credit (to gramdan villages).²⁸

No such step was taken. However, after a series of meetings between Sarvodaya workers and the officials of the Community Development Ministry, the objective of Community Development Programme was changed 'so that there could be no clash between the ideals of gramdan and Community Development'. The objective now was:

"a) To develop a spirit of community life among the people by promoting co-operation and mutual sharing, leading ultimately to voluntary community ownership of the basic means of production, such as land, and fulfilment by the village community of responsibility for the welfare, employment and livelihood of all members.

b) To make the village self-sufficient in the primary needs of life, such as food, clothing and shelter and to promote the development of each village along with the development of the local area of which it forms part; and

c) To develop self-reliance in the individual and initiative in the community, so that people are able to manage and run their affairs themselves and make the village self-governing units of the larger Indian democracy."²⁹

That the government should change objectives of its programme to bring it in tune with the goals of a voluntary movement was truly historic. Vinoba hailed this as a revolutionary step.

However, little was done to actually redesign the programme. Yet Yelwal Conference and the following developments led to the identification of Sarvodaya Movement with the government in the public eye; and the false impression had serious repercussions on the progress of the Movement.

Vinoba looked upon the Yelwal communiqué as an expression of national will for the extension of gramdan movement. He was hoping that with the declaration of unanimous support by the political community in the nation, climate would become more favourable for making the Movement a people's Movement in the true sense. Nothing of that sort happened. When Nehru was asked, after returning to Delhi from Yelwal, about the future programme, his reply was that there is no need for the same: "The work is going on. The question of help will arise only if there is any obstruction."³⁰

That Community Development Programme would help gramdan remained a pipe dream. Balwantrai Mehta Committee, appointed for the evaluation of the programme, criticised its bureaucratisation and recommended democratic decentralisation, which resulted in the formation of Panchayat Raj institutions. Later, in 1966, Prime Minister Indira Gandhi disbanded the Community Development ministry, and the programme met with a silent death.

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With gramdan coming to stay, Vinoba began to emphasize the need for Shanti-Sena, the corps of 70,000 Shanti-sainiks (soldiers of the peace corps), one for every 5,000 people. These volunteers would be selfless servants, who had risen above all sorts of differences and affiliations, be they of any caste, sect, religion or political party. In this context, Vinoba also felt the need to have people's explicit consent for the service rendered by the Shanti-sainiks:

“Our government raises an army. What is the spiritual and material basis for that army? It is the vote given by the people. Otherwise, there would be no difference between that army and a robbers’ gang. It is true that this foundation is weak. In reality, those who come in power have the backing of minority only. Still, the army has some sanction behind it. Thus far, we have undertaken several programmes—khadi, village industries etc.—but did not seek people’s consent for them. We do have the right to serve the people if we want to; but as Shanti-sainiks we would lack strength if we do not have consent of the people we serve.”³¹

Consent was necessary, because the work was against the current. What was being sought was total transformation of the society—and to attempt it without people’s consent would have been patently anti-people and against the revolutionary spirit and human values. Vinoba had suggested *sootanjali* (gift of hanks of self-spun yarn) for this purpose, but it had made little headway.

Gramdan demanded total redistribution of the entire village land. It was difficult to prepare people’s minds in this regard everywhere and speedily. It was therefore decided to introduce the concept of *gram-pariwar* (village family) wherein a group of people in the village would pool their resources, farm collectively and distribute the proceeds on the basis of family size. They could make an immediate beginning without waiting for all the residents. It was a step in the direction of gramdan. It was also decided that if 50% of the land was received and 80% donors and all the landless accepted gramdan, it should be recognised as gramdan.³²

Vinoba also suggested that the gramsabha, consisting of those ready for gramdan, could be made functional, and that the government could legalise it. We find herein seeds of what later came to be known as *sulabh* (simplified) gramdan.

During Karnataka tour, Vinoba put forth the idea of Vishwaneedam Ashram at Bangalore. At Kadwa (1 November), he gave, for the first time the slogan—or what he called ‘mantra’—‘*Jai Jagat*’ (Victory to the whole world). A few years

ago, some members of the Azad Hind army³³ had come to meet him and had greeted him with '*Jai Hind*' (Victory to India)—that was the patriotic slogan popularised by them. Vinoba, at the time of parting, bade farewell to them with '*Jai Hind, Jai Duniya, Jai Hari*' (Victory to India, victory to the world, victory to the Lord). What he meant was that parochial nationalism could be dangerous, and spiritual values as well as the coming era of science had made imperative thinking in terms not of a nation but of the whole world.

Baba Raghavdas, a towering figure in the field of constructive work in Uttar Pradesh, who was on a continuous walking tour, died at Seoni in Madhya Pradesh on 15 January 1958. Born in Maharashtra, Baba had wandered since childhood in search of spiritual solace and ultimately settled at Barhaj in 1913. He rose to become a prominent freedom fighter and constructive worker. After Independence, he became a member of the state Legislative Assembly. However, he resigned from his membership as well as from scores of institutions, most of which he himself had founded, and dedicated himself to bhoodan. At Vinoba's instance, he started a walking tour on 13 April 1955 which continued till his death. Within two years of tour in Uttar Pradesh alone, he had visited 1,660 villages and collected bhoodan of 43,190 acres from 9,588 donors.³⁴ Death of such a worker was a great blow to the Movement.

Vinoba was aware of the bottlenecks in the Movement. Wherever he would go, a morally-elevating atmosphere would be created, but it would not last long. Workers of the Movement were failing to take its advantage and consolidate the Movement. Neither land distribution nor the spread of ideology was progressing at a desired pace. There was acute dearth of workers, and they lacked adequate training. The Movement was failing to keep pace with the expectations of the people in gramdan villages. As Vinoba said, "Land-gifts of 50 lakh (5 millions) acres and 3,500 gramdans is no mean achievement. That should have brought about psychological revolution in the whole country." Why was this not happening? Vinoba's answer was—still more purity of heart was needed.³⁵

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At Dharwad (1 February) Vinoba put forth the idea of *Sarvodaya-patra*. This was a result of his quest for people's consent for Sarvodaya ideology and programmes, particularly Shanti-Sena. The idea was that those in their favour should keep a pot in their homes; every day, the youngest child in the family should put one handful of grains in it before dinner. The grains so collected would be used for Sarvodaya work, including provision for the sustenance of workers. Just as the number of votes show the extent of support to a political party, number of Sarvodaya-patras would show the extent of support to Sarvodaya ideology and programmes, as well as to the cause of peace in the world. This would, in fact, be more significant than votes, as putting grain in Sarvodaya-patra would be a daily affair; it would denote readiness for doing something regularly, rather than voting once in five years and then doing nothing. Moreover, it would implant the value of sharing in little children; they would be taught that before eating, they should provide for others. That is why handful of grains from a child was asked, not from an adult, although that would fetch greater quantity. The programme was simple, yet its widespread adoption had great potentialities. Vinoba, therefore, exclaimed, "When the idea of Sarvodaya-patra occurred to me, I felt that I have become a *rishi* (sage)!"³⁶ He called it the best idea propounded by him till date.³⁷

To those who thought of it as an ordinary programme, and as a climbdown, Vinoba explained,

"People say that this man started from ordinary land-gifts, then asked for one-sixth share of land, then talked of gramdan, dissolution of private ownership, village self-rule—every thought on a higher plane than the preceding one; and now he is talking of Sarvodaya-patra! That means, after completing post-graduation, he has started learning the alphabet! I tell them that the process so far has been of *jnanayoga*, not of *karmayoga*.³⁸ We propagated the idea of dissolution of private ownership, and were taking from the people an acknowledgement of acceptance. Ending the British Rule was easy. We were running their government; what needed to be done was to give up that, and nothing else. Still

that took several years. How can then it be expected that a great consummation like dissolution of private ownership would take place in a short time? But the idea has been accepted. Leaders of the nation have given acknowledgement of this acceptance. Now, actual working towards that end has to start.”³⁹

However, not all the workers were convinced. They had dreamt for land revolution—dissolution of private property in land—by 1957. Many saw the programmes of Shanti-Sena and Sarvodaya-patra as distractions, as programmes put forth because of failure on the front of bhoodan and gramdan. Moreover, *nidhimukti* had brought to an end even the modest financial support, putting their families in dire straits. Thinning of the Movement’s ranks was an inevitable result. It was important to address the problem of the workers’ livelihood. Sarvodaya-patra was a programme in this context too. Vinoba looked upon it as a pure means, which would purify the workers as well. And many workers did take up this programme enthusiastically.

Karnataka tour of about 11,000 km yielded bhoodan of about 1,000 acres; 800 acres were distributed. Thirty six villages accepted gramdan.⁴⁰

11. In Maharashtra and Gujarat

Appeal to the land of birth and the land of the master

When Vinoba entered Western Maharashtra, provincial sentiments stoked by biased and opinionated press had reached a high pitch of excitement and intolerance on the issue of formation of the Marathi-speaking state. People in Western Maharashtra were obsessed with the idea of having such a state. They expected Vinoba, a Maharashtrian by birth, to lend his voice in support of this demand. Vinoba fully supported linguistic reorganisation of states; but not parochialism and the loss of balance and a sense of proportion. Moreover, for him, the land-hungry poor came first. When the protagonists of the Marathi state could not extract from Vinoba explicit support for their cause, Vinoba became the butt of ridicule and a target of malicious and vicious propaganda. It was in his own state that efforts were made to create disturbances in his meetings; once he was not even allowed to address a public meeting.

By 1956, linguistic reorganisation of states was almost complete in the country, but Marathi-speaking state was not formed, particularly because of the contentious issue of Mumbai (then called Bombay). It was geographically within Western Maharashtra, but Marathi-speaking people were in a minority there and this financial hub of the country was mostly controlled by Gujaratis. In January 1956, three-state formula was announced: Maharashtra and Gujarat states were to be constituted and Bombay was to be made a Union Territory. As the agitators wanted Mumbai in the Marathi state, this announcement led to widespread violence. People even attempted to torch the ashram of Appa Patwardhan, one of the greatest Gandhian workers, who had selflessly served them for years, when he pleaded that a father would keep a contentious piece of property under common control, and there was no

injustice on or insult of Maharashtra in the proposal.¹

When Nehru met Vinoba on 6 March 1956, this matter was discussed. Leading Sarvodaya workers discussed it at Adoni on 24 March. Vinoba favoured a joint state of Gujarat and Maharashtra, including Bombay.² Such a state, named Bombay state, was eventually formed in August. But it did not satisfy popular feelings. Agitations continued both in Gujarat and Maharashtra. There were disputes about border areas; public opinion in Maharashtra was particularly sensitive about the inclusion of Belgaon in Maharashtra.

Vinoba continued to speak of restraint, balance and a wider perspective:

“Look, the borders between countries are getting obliterated. Egypt and Syria are coming together. In this era of science, wide and inclusive perspective is imperative. Problems like that of Belgaon are no doubt there, but they are minor. - - - It matters little whether you live under the government of Nijalingappa or of Chavan. What we should seek is gram-raj (village self-rule).”³

So long as the centralised State apparatus was in place, its dismantling should be the focus; what was needed was to work for Swaraj.

At Nipani, the last halt in Karnataka, Marathi people obstructed reading of the report of Karnataka tour in Kannad. Vinoba walked out of the meeting. He came back only after one and a half hours, when peace was restored. Thereafter, the public meeting proceeded smoothly.

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On 23 March Vinoba entered Maharashtra at Khadakewada. He was welcomed by Chief Minister Y.B. Chavan and other leaders. He explained his stand at a press conference, reiterating that there was no basic injustice involved in a bilingual state and made an eminently reasonable suggestion that the decision of Parliament without participation of Marathi and Gujarati members should be accepted as the will of the nation; and said that agitation in this regard would vitiate the

opinion about Maharashtra in the rest of the country.⁴

Opening his heart in the first public meeting in Maharashtra, he declared, "I have ideas, not opinions. You are welcome to convince and convert me, or get convinced by my ideas. - - I want to enter the heart of Maharashtra." He reiterated his call for a wide perspective and a universal spirit.⁵

Bhoodan work had begun in Maharashtra in 1952. An all-party Bhoodan Committee had been constituted with Annasaheb Sahasrabuddhe as the convener. Shankarrao Deo had undertaken a walking tour in August 1952. Gramdans were also being received since 1956.

Vinoba continued to harp on the theme of gramdan, unfolding its potentialities. What was important was the widening of the family spirit.

"People ask, will gramdan lead to increase in production? In a non-gramdan village, if one has to starve, he has to starve alone. In a gramdan village, everyone would starve if need be. People in gramdan village will decide whether to starve or steal or beg or increase production. But whatever they do, that will be their own decision, taken through consensus. It cannot be said that production will definitely increase in a gramdan village. But if the intellects of all the villagers are pooled together, production is bound to increase."⁶

Gramdan was for him a truly religious work:

"People do not understand the true significance of bhoodan and gramdan. They feel that it is just a means to solve the land problem. But that is only symbolic. This is really a work of the establishment of true religion. So far, many attempts had been made in this regard, but a true religion is yet to be established."⁷

Panchayat Raj institutions were being established in the country in pursuance of the recommendations of Balwantrai Mehta Committee. Introducing so-called democratic decentralisation in the midst of glaring inequalities was bound to accentuate exploitation. Vinoba warned that the system would be harmful when landownership was intact. Later, he frequently

explained the difference between gramdan and Panchayat Raj system.

Gopabandhu Chaudhari, one of the greatest sons of Odisha in recent times, died on 30 April. Within a week, the Movement suffered another jolt with the death of Laxmibabu of Bihar on 8 May, while on a walking tour. Bihar workers started a continuous walking tour in the state in his memory. Started on 16 August, this walking tour eventually went on for five years and traversed a distance of about 20,000 km.

In May, Jayaprakash went to Europe to acquaint the people there with Sarvodaya work. Besides important European countries (U.K., France, Germany, Switzerland, Netherland, Denmark, Belgium, Norway, Sweden, Austria, Italy, Greece, Poland and Yugoslavia), he also visited Israel and a few Arab countries. He addressed public meetings and seminars; met prominent political leaders, thinkers and writers like Albert Camus, Niels Bohr and Ignazio Silone. Narrating his experience, he said,

“After seeing the material progress of the West, I am convinced that Gandhiji’s path is the best in the world. Vinobaji is following that path. The whole world would have to come on this path eventually. Had Vinoba not started this Movement eight years ago, we would have got nothing worthwhile to tell the world.”⁸

Walking through Southern Maharashtra, Vinoba came to Pandharpur, a famous centre of pilgrimage known for the temple of Lord Pandurang. The 10th Sarvodaya Conference was held here.

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Vinoba, the great devotee, had not been able to visit the celebrated shrine as entry of Dalits, considered untouchables, was barred there before Independence. Now the temple was open to them. But it was not clear whether non-Hindus would be allowed in or not. The ferocious attack on Vinoba and his entourage at Deoghar (Bihar) was still fresh in memory. At Jagannathpuri and Guruvayur, entry had been denied to his

non-Hindu companions. The trustees of the Pandurang temple had invited Vinoba with due respect when he was approaching Pandharpur. About entry of his companions irrespective of caste and religion, they relented after persuasion and gave a written invitation:

“We are indeed fortunate that a great saint like you is coming to Pandharpur. An apprehension has been expressed about whether the temple trustees have objection to the entry of non-Hindus accompanying you. We would like to assure you that this is not the case. We wholeheartedly invite you to the shrine and would feel blessed by your visit.”⁹

On 29 May, Vinoba went to the shrine. It was a historic occasion. Moved to the core and overwhelmed by emotion, with tears flowing down his cheeks, he embraced the idol of the Lord.¹⁰ He called it ‘a golden letter day in the history of India.’¹¹ In the evening meeting, he said,

“I will be moving about in Maharashtra for four more months. I may or may not receive any bhoodan or gramdan during this period, but Maharashtra has already given me the maximum that it can. This event is, to me, unprecedented in the annals of Sarvodaya Movement.”¹²

The Sarvodaya conference began on 30 May. It was presided over by Ramadevi Chaudhari of Odisha and attended by more than 15,000 delegates. In his message to the Conference, Pandit Nehru had again eulogised Vinoba, saying that ‘nobody else represents Gandhiji and the spirit and tradition of India as much as him.’¹³

Addressing the Conference, Vinoba expressed the hope that it would be a *sneha-sammelan* (a gathering marked by *sneha*). Elaborating what he meant by *sneha*, he defined it as ‘*pratirodhi*’ love, that is, love that takes initiative, and is not a response to the love expressed by others. The latter kind of love, he said, was ‘*anurodhi*’, that is, reciprocal. The former kind of love implies returning hatred with love. It was this kind of love which was needed for building the power of love.

Vinoba had invited Pyarelal, Gandhi’s secretary during his

last days, in the context of his recently published book 'The last phase', in which he had welcomed gramdan. In the Conference, he described bhoodan as a movement based on Gandhi's concept of trusteeship, which had no place for ownership. In his book, Pyarelal had stated,

"Donation of villages or gramdan thus provides an opportunity, especially where donated villages form solid blocks, to try out all the techniques devised by Gandhiji from time to time to enable the toiling masses in the villages to retain and enjoy their full share of nature's bounty and the fruits of their toil against any combination of vested interests, however well-entrenched and powerful, and to realise on a regional scale the full picture of a nonviolent, non-exploiting egalitarian society."¹⁴

There were people in the ranks of Gandhians who were against gramdan, holding that Gandhi stood for trusteeship and not for the dissolution of ownership, which Vinoba was advocating. The assertion from Pyarelal, the man who knew Gandhi's mind during his last days more than anyone else and was also a witness to the origin and development of the trusteeship scheme, was a refutation of this misconception.

After the Yelwal declaration, there was some confusion about co-operation with the government, particularly as the Movement unambiguously stood for freedom from the State. Talking to the workers, Vinoba clarified,

"The government has its own schemes. We may criticise them, point out what is wrong in them, but we have to believe that there is good intention behind them. If we do not believe this and doubt the government's intentions, then we must not co-operate with them. Have we come to this final conclusion about the present government, just as Gandhiji had about the then government at the time of the Non-cooperation Movement? If not, then I must say that non-cooperation with the government in the passionate ardour for freedom from the State will be height of incredulity. Freedom from the State is an ideal. It will be realised through concerted efforts by all. But if we get carried away by the idea and non-cooperate with the government, we

would delay that consummation rather than hastening it.- -
 - Of course, we have to think how the co-operation should
 be.”¹⁵

In this context, he again pointed out the difference between violence and coercive power of the State.

“Some people say that enactment of bhoodan and gramdan laws will lead to the domination of the government. They seem to think that the seal of legal approval has tarnished our Movement. No, this is not a retreat for nonviolence; this is rather an aggression by nonviolence. When law is getting favourable, non-cooperation will be harmful to us.”¹⁶

Referring to the demand for a change in strategy, he explained,

“Some say that the Movement has come to a halt. If that is so, then what we need is inner purification. There is nothing wrong in the present programme which warrants any programme of resistance or civil disobedience. That is all idle parroting. One should see things in the right perspective, on the background of international situation. - - - Concentrating on the few gramdan villages is not enough. There is subtle ego behind such an idea, which presumes that we are capable of causing their advancement. This may not always be true. Only the people in gramdan villages can accomplish it. This does not mean intensive work in any village should be ruled out even if a good worker is available.”¹⁷

He also emphasised the need for distribution of bhoodan lands.

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Vinoba was continuing his march. Wherever he went, the change in the atmosphere for the better was distinctly visible. But it was disquieting that it would prove to be short-lived. A distinctly-visible radical change in the society was missing. Even in areas where thousands of acres were gifted, life in general would appear after a few months as dull and static as it was earlier. That was the context for a call for change in strategy. Even senior leaders like Dhirendra Majumdar were mulling over

this. "A stage in the Movement has passed and the next impetus is yet to be received," said Dhirendrabhai.

"The intervening period should be used in the way Gandhiji followed: creation of cells of constructive programme, in as many places as possible, as a preparatory step for revolution. If this phase is not properly planned, the strength gained so far would get dissipated. In this context, I have to suggest that all leading workers should choose some area for intensive work and plant themselves firmly there."¹⁸

As an alternative, he also suggested continuous walking tours.

As the Conference came to an end, Vinoba resumed his march. As at elsewhere, he was linking the concepts and programmes of Sarvodaya with the eternal message of the local saints.

In Maharashtra, Dalits had embraced Buddhism in large numbers under the influence of Dr. Ambedkar. Vinoba welcomed this development. In this context, he reiterated the need for confluence of Vedanta (the philosophy of the Upanishads) and Buddhism. He called Dr. Ambedkar 'a great gift for Hinduism' and said,

"A man like me works for curing a blister from within, while someone like Ambedkar prefers to do a surgical operation and bandage it. When treatment is being carried on in both the ways, the blister (of caste differences) is bound to get cured."¹⁹

Removal of untouchability and caste differences was now his recurrent theme. His stand was that caste differences should not be regarded as an integral part of Hinduism—that would strengthen them instead of weakening; that was an excrescence, and should be treated accordingly. For him, the system of elections had given them a new lease of life, and that system therefore needed modification. Rather than concentrating on a particular section of society, he advocated selfless service of all those who were in need of it, with a spiritual approach.

He repeatedly emphasized the potential in the seemingly

simple and innocuous programme of Sarvodaya-patra. The programme was taken up enthusiastically at several places in his route.

In the dense forests of Satpuda hills, tribal hamlets embraced gramdan in large numbers. 153 villages in Akrani Mahal area were declared gramdan on 15 August. On his birthday (11 September), Vinoba was offered gramdan of 64 villages in Akkalkua area. Satpuda Sarvodaya Mandal was constituted to work intensively in Akrani-Akkalkua under the stewardship of Thakurdas Bang. (The responsibility was later taken over by Damodardas Moondada, who worked there till his last.)

In July 1958, Bhoodan Act passed in Madras (Tamil Nadu) state came into force.

On 22 September, Vinoba entered Gujarat at Songarh. The Maharashtra tour of 184 days had resulted in 432 gramdans. The number of Sarvodaya-patras had reached the figure of 10,000.²⁰ But what Vinoba treasured most was his visit to the holy shrine at Pandharpur with people belonging to various castes and religious communities.

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Gujarat was the land of Gandhi, his master—the man who was responsible for his spiritual rebirth. His expectation from Gujarat was to popularize gramdan: “It has to be impressed upon the people that it deserves to be welcomed by all. This work is yet to be done. I hope that Gujarat will accomplish it.”²¹

As far as bhoodan was concerned, the situation in Gujarat was peculiar. The state had a web of institutions for Gandhian constructive work, and most of the senior workers were engaged in—rather entangled in—that work and had little time to spare for bhoodan. Most of them were closely associated with the Congress and did not like Vinoba's policy of equidistance from all political parties. Thirdly, being predominantly conservative at heart, they did not appreciate Vinoba's insistence on the revolutionary programme for dissolution of private property; they believed that Gandhi stood for trusteeship and not for

dissolution of ownership. Vinoba had to exert himself to allay apprehensions about gramdan. It is noteworthy that first gramdan in the state was received after full 82 days of walking tour in the state. Gramdan made some headway later mostly on the strength of a band of young workers.²²

Vinoba continued to harp on the theme of Shanti-Sena. For him, it was Gandhiji's true memorial. "We should not be worried about khadi, we should be concerned with nonviolence; if we could build up the power in peace, then only the spinning wheel can work in conjunction with it," he averred at Mangrol (10 October).²³

In South Gujarat, Harivallabh Parikh had immersed himself in bhoodan and gramdan and had also created a strong base in the tribal region through his selfless service.²⁴ A Gramdan Conference was held at Rangpur on 15 October. On 19 October, at Sagtala, Vinoba reiterated that gramdan should receive warm welcome in the tribal belt.

At Borsad (2 November), known for satyagraha, Vinoba explained in detail the concept of satyagraha. He opined that the form of satyagraha should change in the context of Independence, establishment of a democratic set-up and the advent of the era of science;

"Satyagraha should now be founded on compassion. Satyagraha should be such that it should be instantly welcome and acceptable, and should evoke high regard. Its form cannot be the same as it was in Gandhiji's time."²⁴

At Bocharan (3 November), Vinoba met leading constructive workers and called upon them to reflect over why Gandhian institutions had failed to inspire the people. For him, the reason was obvious: they had failed to identify themselves with the people. It was for them to take corrective steps; bhoodan and gramdan were presenting an opportunity in this regard.

At Rajkot on 21 November, he again harped on the theme of Shanti-Sena. Peace, to him, was imperative for the success of the project of social reconstruction initiated by bhoodan and gramdan. It was not enough to condemn violence, what was

essential was to prove the efficacy of nonviolence.²⁵

The *yatra* proceeded to Kutch where he advised the Sindhis—the refugees of Partition who had been settled there—to merge themselves in the life of local people like sugar in the milk: sugar dissolves in the milk, loses itself and sweetens it.²⁶

After touching the westernmost tip of India, Vinoba turned eastwards. On 17 December at Gangad, Pandit Nehru came to meet him. In the public meeting, he said, “The mission of Vinobaji, one of the great sons of the soil, presents a distinct picture in the world which is witnessing terrible stockpiles of nuclear weapons.”²⁷

Vinoba entered Ahmedabad on 20 December. The attendance at his evening prayer meeting was over 3,00,000. On 21 December, he paid homage to Gandhiji at Sabarmati Ashram where he said that his walking tour had its roots in the action-oriented spiritual quest at the Ashram. The *yatra* continued in Gujarat till 14 January 1959.

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The definition of gramdan was undergoing modifications in the light of experience in different states and on-going deliberations. Vinoba suggested some modifications during the Gujarat tour as well. Sarva Seva Sangh deliberated over the matter and decided that two criteria must be satisfied: (i) All the landholders should surrender landownership to the village community (gramsabha), whose name should be legally registered as owner in government records. (ii) Gramsabha should undertake responsibility of providing work to all the villagers—in industries if adequate land is not available. If it could not provide work, it should undertake responsibility to feed all. One of the following two criteria also had to be satisfied: (i) At least one-sixth of the village land should be set apart for the landless. Bigger landowners should give more; smaller ones may give less. (ii) Every family should be given at least half an acre land near their homes to work on.²⁸

Bhoo dan was now coming in a trickle, land distribution had not picked up, and the same was true of gramdan. Programmes

of Shanti-Sena and Sarvodaya-patra were also not progressing satisfactorily, although whatever was being done was certainly unique and commendable. Shanti-sainiks worked to quell riots at Mudukulnur in Tamil Nadu and at Ahmedabad and Baroda. First all-India camp of Shanti-Sena was held at Sevagram in October 1958.

Another noteworthy event was Dada Dharmadhikari's tour of Nepal, at the instance of Tulsi Meher, who had been engaged in khadi work since 1925. Dada was heartily welcomed. He spoke at different places. While one of his public meetings was chaired by Communist leader Tulsilal Amatya, another one was chaired by Rana Suvarna Shamsheer Jangbahadur, Chairman of the Council of ministers.²⁹

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Ramon Magsaysay awards were instituted in Philippines in 1958 for exemplary work in Asia. Vinoba was the first to be selected for community leadership. The citation read as follows:

“Seven years ago, seeing the force of a simple act of human generosity—one man's voluntary gift of land—in the solution of a bitter village conflict, Vinoba Bhave dedicated himself to the propagation of a new kind of social revolution in India.

“The vehicle he originated for this work, known as the Bhoodan Movement, has as its primary tangible objective ‘land for the landless.’ Its intangible implications are even more significant. Emphasizing a voluntary giving, first of land and more recently also of cash, kind, labour, intelligence, life and of whole villages, he has sought to bring his people to a fuller realization of man's nobler nature.

“Many among his countrymen have responded to his abiding faith in the basic goodness of human character and the tempering effect of human conscience. In them, he has awakened a consciousness of inner strength and nurtured a social morality. Thus, in his seven years of walking to the villages of India, he has laboured to create with gentle persuasion the climate for social reform wherein, by ways he has proposed, needed change could be accomplished voluntarily.

“He has sought nothing for himself, least of all recognition of his achievements. Rather, his has been a life selflessly devoted to finding and conveying to his people an approach to the problem of poverty that is within the means of every man. He, in his way, as our late President Ramon Magsaysay did in his, has given himself humbly and unstintingly in service to his people.

“In electing Acharya Vinoba Bhave to receive the first Ramon Magsaysay Award for Community Leadership, the Board of Trustees recognizes his furtherance of the cause of arousing his countrymen toward voluntary action in relieving social injustice and economic inequalities.”³¹

Vinoba accepted the award ‘most humbly’ and conveyed that he would have been happy to attend the presentation ceremonies, but his *padayatra* must continue ‘until the land problem of India is satisfactorily solved.’

In January 1959, resolutions for co-operative farming and ceiling on landholdings came up for discussion at the Congress session at Nagpur. C. Rajagopalachari and farmer leaders N.G. Ranga and Charan Singh stoutly opposed them. Some leaders left the party and subsequently formed Swatantra Party, a rightist party. Speaking about these proposals, Vinoba commented that the concerned resolution was worthless:

“I do not understand why some people are so much enamoured by it and some are raising their voice against it. After eight years of our Movement, ceiling is now being talked about. But clever landholders have already distributed lands among their kith and kin. So, the government is going to get little land through ceiling. It would have been better if they had proposed ‘flooring’ instead of ceiling—giving everyone minimum required land, and then letting landholders have the rest. The second resolution on co-operative farming—which is to be voluntary—is so dilute that it is difficult to understand why people speak against it. In my opinion, Nagpur resolution is a cord which is looking like a snake: it is neither charming nor fear-arousing.”³²

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Figures for bhoodan and gramdan as in December 1958 were as under³¹:

<u>State</u>	<u>Bhoodan</u> (acres)	<u>Distribution</u> (acres)	<u>Gramdans</u>
Assam	23,196	225	127
Andhra	2,41,950	83,090	481
Odisha	4,24,635	1,11,785	1,960
U.P.	5,87,630	77,758	59
Kerala	29,021	2,126	553
Tamil Nadu	70,823	2,349	254
Delhi	396	157	-
Punjab	19,929	5,653	1
Bihar	21,68,857	2,94,448	130
Bombay	2,28,348	68,493	935
W. Bengal	12,681	3,463	26
M.P.	1,78,816	62,450	178
Mysore	14,164	1,152	66
Rajasthan	4,26,488	69,362	49
H.P.	1,568	21	-
<u>Total</u>	<u>44,28,502</u>	<u>7,82,532</u>	<u>4,819</u>

12. Message of Love

Tour of Rajasthan, Punjab and Kashmir

Vinoba entered Rajasthan at Rastopal on 15 February, where he was welcomed by more than 10,000 people including Chief Minister Mohanlal Sukhadia, his cabinet colleagues and the President of State Congress Committee. Fifty five gramdams were presented to him on this occasion. Replying to the welcome, he appealed for 3,000 Shanti-sainiks from the state, 'the land of heroes'.

Bhoodan work had already progressed well in Rajasthan and state Bhoodan Committee was working under the leadership of Gokulbhai Bhatt. By the end of 1958, bhoodan of 4,26,488 acres had been received and 69,362 acres had been distributed. Forty nine gramdams had been received.¹ Two new settlements had been founded on big tracts of bhoodan lands, and named Gandhigram (Dist. Tonk) and Bhoodanpura (Dist. Banswara). At Chhatargarh, 2,85,000 bighas had been gifted.

Vinoba's emphasis in Rajasthan was going to be on Shanti-Sena and Sarvodaya-patra. At Hatundi (21 February) he said,

"In Yelwal conference, Gramdan Movement became '*lokmanya*' (it was accepted by people); now we have to make it '*lokpriya*' (popularize it). Workers are needed for this purpose. Sarvodaya-patra will provide spiritual and material support to them. We should therefore devote one year exclusively for Sarvodaya-patra work."²

The 11th Annual Sarvodaya Conference was held at Ajmer on 27-28 February and 1 March. Kelappan, a veteran freedom fighter, active since the famous Vykam satyagraha, was in the chair. When Vinoba was in Kerala, he had left Praja Socialist Party of which he was a prominent leader; and his decision had prompted Vinoba to exclaim that his Kerala tour had indeed succeeded! He was the first to enrol in Shanti-Sena. President and Prime Minister and Communist leader Z.A. Ahmed had sent

their messages for the conference, while Congress President Indira Gandhi and Sikh leader Master Tara Singh were prominently present.

Inmates of Ajmer jail had voluntarily constructed Vinoba's hut at the Conference site. They also gifted their week's wages amounting to Rs. 101 to Vinoba. Such was the goodwill created by the Movement.³

But there was uneasiness in the workers, as they were not witnessing the results they had hoped for. It was bound to get reflected in the deliberations at the Conference. Vinoba, therefore, put things in proper perspective in his inaugural address:

"This is a year of introspection for us. We have experience of working (on particular lines) for some time. Now, we should reflect over it. I have always said that ours is not a movement, it is an ascension. When we climb up, peaks hitherto hidden from us get revealed one after another.

"Some people say, gramdan has failed. Well, do you succeed if I fail? It is not my personal job! Manu has said that we should not feel humiliated by failure. I want to say that if we have failed, that failure is glorious. Let us not assume that we are working; we are but instruments in the Lord's hands. If we work with this spirit, then I assure you that this community of workers would act as a leaven and transform the world populace."⁴

He reiterated that bhoodan was a movement with global perspective. About Sarvodaya-patra, he said that it was a work of laying foundation: it was a programme through which the workers could reach every household. It was not an alternative programme superseding the programme for gram-swaraj; it was a programme to create conducive atmosphere for it. Vinoba told the workers that they were free to take up any programme. He pointed out that the flow of gramdans had not stopped, although emphasis had shifted to Sarvodaya-patra.

Regarding the idea to do intensive work in a few villages, he said that such work might succeed or fail; but that would not

prove whether the thought of gramdan was sound or not. "Were Vinoba to do such work and succeed, people will say that success is due to a man like Vinoba; otherwise the work would not have succeeded."⁵

Jayaprakash exhorted the workers not to be carried away by superficial factors.

"During the freedom movement, many satyagrahas took place, and it appeared that they were unsuccessful. People used to say that Gandhiji had failed. I was also among them. We used to plead for an alternative programme to bring intensity in the movement. But Gandhiji would say that he had nothing except constructive programme.

"And what do we mean by failure? We propagated good ideas, millions listened to them. Vinobaji has shown how one should lead one's life. There have been bhoodan, gramdans, sampattidan, jivandan. So where is the question of failure? Can truth and nonviolence ever fail? It is true that we have still not reached the goal, but that is another matter. The work is stupendous; we have to swim against the current. Rather than crying over failure, we should work with redoubled vigour. This is not a work that can be completed in a few years. I am of the firm opinion that the Movement is moving forward."⁶

There were individuals like Gokulbhai Bhatt who had faith in the Sarvodaya ideology, but did not want to leave their political parties. Vinoba consented to admit such persons in the Shanti-Sena. The condition of remaining aloof from elections remained unaltered.

Congress President Indira Gandhi also addressed the Conference. She said that she had come to see how Vinobaji was creating an atmosphere. Sikh leader Master Tara Singh said,

"I had heard that Vinoba was distributing poverty. I did not think that this could be faulted. When we have poverty, how can wealth be distributed? Distributing poverty means distributing love. The teachings of the holy Granth sahib are being implemented here. My sympathies are with this Movement."⁷

British industrialist Ernest Bader, who was running an enterprise on the basis of trusteeship, also addressed the Conference.

Addressing the men and women of letters, Vinoba expounded his concept of three powers:

“The power of science has come to our help now and the power of Self-knowledge (spirituality) has already been there in our land. I have become aware of another power. I call it ‘*vishwas-shakti*’ (the power of trust). It is essential in this era of science. - - - World today needs peace and prosperity, and they are possible through these powers only. They could save the world.”⁸

On 1 March, Vinoba visited the holy dargah at Ajmer with around 10,000 persons. On 2 March, 870 Shanti-sainiks accompanied Vinoba in the trek from Ajmer to Gagwana. Martin Luther King, the celebrated leader of black Americans, also walked some distance with them. He had a meeting with Vinoba at Kishangarh on 3 March. Questioned about satyagraha, Vinoba elaborated, “Satyagraha is to let truth take care of itself. We often become an impediment ourselves and hinder truth from playing its role.”⁹ If we allow truth to work its own way, i. e., if we do not allow our mind to interfere, that will be true satyagraha. From time to time, Vinoba kept on dwelling on satyagraha, explaining its nuances and underlining its nature and form in the changed context.

An important event during Rajasthan tour was an all-India conference at Sikar on cow-service, a cause that had always been dear to Vinoba’s heart. He inaugurated the conference. Declaration of opening of Brahmavidya Mandir, an ashram exclusively for collective spiritual pursuit of women, at Kashi-kabas on 13 March, also deserves mention. Rajasthan government decided to entrust cultivable government land in gramdan villages to their gram-sabhas.

The Rajasthan tour, which lasted for 76 days, yielded 171 gramdans (112 in Dungarpur district alone). 234 persons joined Shanti-Sena and Sarvodaya-patra was established in 18,700 homes.¹⁰

A commentator wrote;

“People in Rajasthan had only heard Gandhi's name; they had not seen him. They looked upon Vinoba's arrival in the state as Gandhi's arrival.”¹¹

On 1 April, the *yatra* entered Punjab.

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At the state border Vinoba was received by the Chief Minister and the Governor of the state.

Punjab was beset with problems, particularly because of the intrusion of politics into religious affairs. Management of gurudwaras had become a contentious issue. The demand for a separate state of Punjabi-speaking people was also a live issue. Vinoba offered his services for the solution of conflicts affecting Punjab. He found queer the application of ‘democratic’ principle, i. e., introduction of elections and decision-making about religious affairs on the basis of majority. This was bound to result in conflicts. When these ‘political’ methods were creating problems in the arena of politics itself, there was all the more reason for shunning them in the field of religious affairs. “Just as you take out your shoes before entering gurudwaras, you should take out the shoes of politics as well,” urged Vinoba.¹² In his meetings with the Chief Minister and Sikh leaders Master Tara Singh and Jnani Kartar Singh, he impressed on them the need to take decisions about gurudwaras by consensus.

At Rajpura (27 April), he met Bibi Amtus Salam, a devoted Gandhian. Sarva Seva Sangh had a meeting at Rajpura. Vinoba suggested that Hindustani Talimi Sangh, the organisation looking after basic education, one of Gandhi's pet projects, should merge into Sarva Seva Sangh, which should take up that work. A conference on basic education was held there. Talimi Sangh responded to Vinoba's suggestion by resolving on 20 May for such merger.

A dam was being constructed at Bhakhra Nangal. It was being trumpeted as a grand monument of India's ‘development’ on the modern lines. Pandit Nehru had called it ‘a pilgrimage

centre of modern India'. The big dam was supposed to irrigate thousands of acres of agricultural land. At Ropar (5 May), Vinoba said:

"Pandit Nehru calls Bhakhra Nangal a place of pilgrimage in the modern era. It is said that it would irrigate ten million acres. Production will increase five to six times. Had I been in power, I would have asked the landowners to part with one-sixth of their land for the poor, as production is going to increase. Had they refused, I would not have given them water. Why should they have benefits which the other Indians do not have? They would lose nothing by parting with one-sixth of their land. One-sixth of ten million acres means more than 16 lakh (1.6 million) acres. Sixteen lakh families can be settled on that land. If this happens, the dam would have blessings from the poor. Then it would truly be a place of pilgrimage."¹³

On 12 May, addressing the Working Committee of Akali Dal (Master Tara Singh faction), he exhorted them to work for bhoodan with religious spirit. Concurring with their demand that the government should not interfere in religious affairs, he averred that government should not interfere in the affairs of any village. Asserting that the teaching of the gurus of the Sikhs was more important than the administration of gurudwaras, he appealed them to follow that teaching.

"Then the conflicts will end of themselves. Otherwise, the religion for whose dignity the community of Sikhs stands will not be able to show its lustre. That religion essentially means sharing, unity and love. I do not hold that solution of practical problems is unnecessary. That is also necessary, but that will elude us so long as we are not focused on the core."¹⁴

Recitation of the religious text 'Japuji' was a part of prayers during the Punjab tour. Vinoba also gave talks on that text and presented the timeless message of the Sikh faith to the world.¹⁵

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The 'Land Revolution Day' (18 April) was celebrated throughout the country. A noteworthy event was the offering of

bhoodan of over 1 lakh (0.1 million) acres to Pandit Nehru at Yavatmal in Maharashtra.¹⁶ Nehru again praised bhoodan for facilitating government initiatives including land reforms, even while conceding that he had not understood how villages would be reorganised through bhoodan and gramdan.¹⁷

In Himachal Pradesh, Mahant Udhodas had gifted 5,000 bighas—his entire jagir. Bhoodan Act had been passed in the state in 1955 and Bhoodan Board had been constituted with Dharamdev Shastri as the Chairman. By April 1959, most of the distributable lands out of 7,730 bighas received had been distributed.

In Odisha, the Board, which was inactive for about three years after the resignation of its secretary Sharatchandra Maharana, following differences of opinion with the state government, was reconstituted in 1959 with Sadashiv Tripathi, ex-Minister for revenue, as the Secretary and the distribution work was resumed.

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After Punjab, the next destination was Jammu and Kashmir, where situation was peculiar. Ceiling on landholding had been imposed there long back, land over 22 acres had been taken over without compensation and distributed. Gandhian constructive work had not made much headway there, nor was political climate conducive for bhoodan. Kashmir had been a bone of contention between India and Pakistan. India had initially agreed to plebiscite, but Pakistan did not fulfil the condition of withdrawal of its troops, and after the state Constituent Assembly's acceptance of the state's merger in India, India took the stand that the state had become its integral part. When Chief Minister Sheikh Abdulla, an upholder of the state's merger, began talking of the independence of Kashmir, he was dismissed on 9 August 1953 and was replaced by Bakshi Ghulam Mohammed. Abdulla was arrested. He was released in 1958, but was re-arrested after three months, as he resumed separatist propaganda. When Vinoba entered the state, he was being tried for hatching conspiracy against India in collusion with Pakistani agents. Bakshi was ruling the state, but his administration was

notorious for corruption.

Entry into the state required a permit. But the provision was revoked before Vinoba's arrival in the state.

Vinoba had declared before entering the state that the programmes of bhoodan, gramdan, Shanti-Sena and Sarvodaya-patra were of course there, but what he was particularly interested in was to study the situation first-hand and see what could be done in that context through love. On his entry into the state at Lakhanpur (22 May 1959), he said,

“God willing (insha-allah), I want to do three things here: I want to observe, I want to hear, and I want to love. I want to use here all the power of love that God has given me.”¹⁸

Vinoba, as elsewhere, received enthusiastic welcome; the Chief Minister, as elsewhere, welcoming him and promising full support. The Chief Minister's offer of police protection to the tour party was, of course, declined.

In Kashmir, then, Vinoba pleaded for love consistently and insistently. The problem, he proclaimed, would be solved not through politics but through spirituality: ‘In the era of science, politics has become outdated, and the time demands confluence of science and spirituality.’ He proposed a novel equation¹⁹:

Politics + Science = Total ruin
Spirituality + Science = Paradise

As he always insisted, union of hearts was what he sought; bhoodan was only an instrument for this purpose.

The task was all the more necessary in Kashmir, so Vinoba visited the people in their homes, heard them and tried to mitigate their difficulties, just as he had earlier done in Telangana. And he received bhoodan too, in spite of enforcement of land ceiling.

In a poor Dalit home inhabited by a widow and her little son, Vinoba asked, patting the little boy lovingly, “Your clothes are tattered. How will you get money to have new clothes?” With tears in her eyes, his mother replied, “Wherefrom can we have money? We have neither land nor work.” A villager

accompanying Vinoba immediately offered land to that family.

A man gave 42 acres land in his own name. When he went back to his home, his wife expressed displeasure: Why haven't he given land in her name too? The man came back and gifted 8 acres more. A man owning only one acre gave one canal (one-eighth acre).²⁰

Poverty in Kashmir, Vinoba found, was next only to Odisha. Land ceiling had helped tenants to some extent, but the lot of the landless had hardly improved. As a token gesture, Vinoba started carrying some of his own luggage on his back!

People belonging to different political parties and communities opened their hearts before Vinoba. To the protagonists of plebiscite, he bluntly told that the talk of plebiscite was 'crude': How can majority decide about so sensitive an issue? To a question, 'To whom Kashmir belongs?', his reply was: 'To the whole world!'²¹ Therefore, the whole world would solve the Kashmir dispute. Vinoba also met Sheikh Abdulla in jail.

At Pahalgam, he called on celebrated philosopher, J. Krishnamurti and sought his blessings.

The climate severely tested the tour party. It had reached Mandi Rajpura on 3 July and had to cross the 14,000 feet high Pir Panjal mountains before entering the Kashmir valley. But incessant rains and heavy floods obstructed its way. The rains were unprecedented in living memory. It was neither possible to go ahead nor turn back. Prime Minister Nehru requested Vinoba to desist from any attempt to cross Pir Panjal in such weather and fly to Srinagar instead. But Vinoba was adamant. He told that if crossing Pir Panjal was not possible, he would walk down back to Punjab. The tour party's provisions were running out. The threat of landslides loomed large.

But the rains stopped on 9 July and Vinoba resumed his trek. Every step required an effort. After every 200 feet, Vinoba would stop for a few minutes. The trek involved walking up and down in succession. Deficiency of oxygen made the trek all the more arduous. But Vinoba and his party persisted. Vinoba

remembered the historical fact that Mahmood of Ghazni (who had invaded India to loot her wealth in the 11th Century) could not cross Pir Panjal and, therefore, could not conquer Kashmir, and commented that they would enter Kashmir tracing the same path and conquer Kashmir with love!

Reaching the hill-top, Vinoba sat in meditation and recited Vedic *mantras* (verses). Later he recounted,

“I cannot describe in words the (spiritual) experience I had there. Among such experiences which have strengthened me, this was the best ever.”²²

Vinoba spent 40 days in the Kashmir valley. ‘Unto the last’ remained his constant refrain there. As elsewhere, he emphasised the need for village unity and village industries. He also upheld the need to give incentive to the propagation of Kashmiri language and suggested publication of Kashmiri books in Nagari script.

His observations at the end of the tour were: (1) The people were gentle by nature and relations between different communities were cordial. (2) Poverty there was disquieting, and its alleviation was a pre-condition for safeguarding democracy. (3) The land problem persisted in spite of land ceiling, and so bhoodan was necessary, although it had not make much headway because of dearth of workers. (4) The problem of the state can be solved by gramdan alone.²³

At Kathua, the last halt in the state, Vinoba reiterated that all the problems in the world would be solved through spirituality alone; and gram-swaraj was a practical programme for this purpose.

According to Shriman Narayan, Vinoba believed that solution of Kashmir problem could be sought in the framework of Indian Constitution, and maximum possible autonomy should be given to Kashmir in that framework.²⁴

In Kashmir, 2,125 acres bhoodan was received.²⁵

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Reconstituted Sarva Seva Sangh met for the first time at

Pathankot on 23-24 September. The new constitution provided that primary members, who were called '*loksevak*s', would select district representatives and these representatives would constitute the Sangh. Every decision would be taken unanimously or with everyone's consent, i.e., by consensus. Vallabhaswami, a loyal disciple of Vinoba, was chosen as the first president. Formation of All-India Shanti-Sena Mandal with Jayaprakash Narayan as the President and Narayan Desai as the Secretary was also announced by Vinoba.

The work was proceeding in a sluggish way, and workers were pressing for alternative strategy and programmes. But Vinoba was worried not so much about material results; what worried him was the neglect of spiritual aspect. "These days, my mind is quite disturbed," he said, opening his mind.

"Sarvodaya work is becoming monotonous. The spirit is falling into oblivion. Gandhiji did not want the workers to get entangled in the gross aspects of programmes like khadi and village industries. He wanted these programmes to be the medium for spiritual uplift. But this aspect is getting neglected. This is disquieting for me. Such neglect would break the spine of Sarvodaya ideology. We are getting drawn more and more into the vortex of temptation to seek more and more government aid for material progress of constructive programmes. But that will prove to be our undoing. Today we lack the capability and capacity to digest government aid. Spiritual development alone can make us capable in that respect. - - - We have to serve the people and work for social transformation after purifying our minds through penance and spiritual knowledge and broadening our vision."²⁶

The programme of Sarvodaya-patra was simple, but had great potential, particularly as it could spread far and wide, contribute to the spread of ideology and generate material support as well. Consistency was the key to its progress. Wherever devoted and consistent efforts took place, encouraging results inevitably followed. Dr. Vempati Suryanarayan of Tenali (Andhra Pradesh) was a renowned ophthalmologist. Vinoba had advised him to charge minimum possible fees and use any additional amount voluntarily given for the poor. For years, the

service-oriented doctor followed this advice. The programme of Sarvodaya-patra greatly appealed to him and he worked for it in a systematic way through mobilising and training a band of workers. As a result, by 1959, there were 7,500 sarvodaya-patras in Tenali and adjoining areas, and they were contributing to the livelihood of 19 workers.²⁷

C. Rajagopalachari, one of the tallest national leaders, had supported bhoodan. But gramdan stood for dissolution of private property, of which Rajaji's Swatantra Party was a staunch champion. To know Rajaji's opinion about gramdan, R.T.P. Subramaniam met him on 13 September and sought his opinion, whereupon Rajaji clarified,

"I have no aversion or differences of opinion on bhoodan or gramdan. - - - To agree to give up the individual rights on holdings in a village as gramdan for the good of all is a grand idea. It is like that the brothers of a big family, once separated, now have come into a united family. It should be based on love. Why should I object to this big principle? But I object to the distribution of lands by means of force or legislation."²⁸

However, N.G. Ranga, another stalwart of the Swatantra Party, continued to express opposition to gramdan.

An important event in 1959 was the agitation against the elected Communist government in Kerala for imposing its ideology through school curriculum. The disturbances turned violent at many places. Shanti-Sena's Kelappan began indefinite fast to bring peace and normalcy; the fast ended when all the political parties agreed on keeping in abeyance controversial sections in the concerned Act. Dharendra Majumdar, while upholding the people's right to agitate, condemned the stoking of passions for political gains.²⁹ Shankarrao Deo asserted that the people had right to demand fresh elections as there was no right to recall in the Constitution.³⁰ Sarvodaya workers from Kerala demanded resignation of the government and fresh elections.³¹ Vinoba's reaction was that every concerned party was culprit to some extent for the situation,³² but made clear that his sympathies lay with the opponents as it was his fundamental

creed that education must be free from government's control.³³

Sadhana Kendra at Varanasi began functioning on 2 October. It was supposed to be a centre for collective *sadhana* by the workers. Office of the Sarva Seva Sangh was also shifted to its premises.

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After Jammu and Kashmir, Vinoba's itinerary included Punjab and Himachal Pradesh. At Pathankot, he put forth the idea of Prasthan Ashram. A national level meeting of writers was held in his presence at Amritsar on 11 November. At Amritsar, Vinoba thought of '*ajnat-sanchar*'—to move around without declaration of itinerary in advance. He also announced that he would henceforth speak without using loudspeaker: "I want not 'broadcast', but 'deep-cast'", he declared.³⁴ He wanted to have heart-to-heart talk with a few people at a time, hoping that those few would understand the ideas thoroughly and contribute in spreading them.

An enquiry against alleged corruption by some ministers in Punjab was going on. Vinoba welcomed it and said that the people should have started nonviolent agitation, had the enquiry not been instituted. He also opined that money-based economy was at the base of corruption, and basic reasons needed to be tackled; nonetheless the ministers had responsibility to be above board.³⁵

Dr. J.C. Kumarappa, whose contribution in systematic presentation and development of Gandhian economic thought was second to none, died at Chennai on 30 January. Kumarappa was in favour of bhoodan and gramdan, but was not happy with the emphasis on propaganda; and had not therefore taken active part in it.

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Twelfth Annual Sarvodaya Conference and the first meeting of reconstituted Sarva Seva Sangh were held from 20 to 27 March 1960 at Sevagram. For the first time after 1951, Vinoba was absent; he had deliberately chosen to be absent to

strengthen the workers and encourage what he termed '*ganasevakatva*' (collective servanthship). He did not even send a message. The Conference was presided over by Acharya Harihar Das of Odisha and attended by around 4,000 delegates. Three hundred and twenty workers from different places had come on foot.

Dissatisfaction of the workers with the progress of the Movement was bound to find expression. Jayaprakash reminded them that periodic ebb and flow was inevitable in any movement; work had, in fact, grown ten-fold during the last ten years. It was, of course, essential to look for ways to enhance people's participation in the Movement, and that was everyone's quest.

The Conference deliberated over identifying areas for intensive work. The fact that new programmes pushed the earlier ones in the background was regretfully noted and it was decided to concentrate on the integrated programme of gram-swaraj. Identification of undistributable bhoodan lands and distribution of the rest within one year was also proposed.³⁶ It was decided to found Gandhian Institute of Studies at Varanasi to serve as a bridge between Sarvodaya and social sciences.

Vinoba expressed happiness over successful organisation of Conference in his absence.

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Pandit Nehru met Vinoba at Pattikalyana on 2 April and discussed the Kashmir issue in particular.

After eight months' tour of Punjab, Vinoba entered Uttar Pradesh on 8 April 1960.

On 10 April, Richard Aluvihar, High Commissioner of Ceylon (now Sri Lanka), met Vinoba. Vinoba explained to him his concept of ABC triangle (A standing for Afghanistan, B for Burma—now Mynamar, and C for Ceylon) and proposed that there should be common citizenship in this region, holding that such a proposal had strong historical and cultural foundation.³⁷

On 18 April, Vishwaneedam Ashram was inaugurated at

Banglore. It was supposed to be an international Sarvodaya centre.

Officials of Planning Commission met Vinoba at Meerut on 12-13 April. They told him that around 7-8 lakh acres were expected to be declared surplus under various Ceiling Acts in the country. And their acquisition would, of course, need payment of compensation. Performance of bhoodan, although below expectations, was certainly a cut above it.

In Uttar Pradesh, some self-styled *go-bhaktas* (worshippers of the cow) mounted a virulent attack on Vinoba, calling him anti-cow. Posters were put up in places which he was to visit. Such opposition had also been witnessed in Rajasthan and Punjab. Omprakash Trikha wrote the book 'Go-bhakta Vinoba' to counter the propaganda.

In about 35 days, Vinoba received 1,367 acres bhoodan and 16 gramdams; 61,000 Sarvodaya-patras had also been installed.³⁸

13. The Madhya Pradesh Tour

The Chambal Miracle and Endeavour for Sarvodaya City

The river Chambal, which passes through Madhya Pradesh and parts of Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh, is known for the ravines created by its flow, which cuts the soil. These ravines had, for centuries, been a safe hide-out for outlaws. Soil erosion and lack of irrigation facilities had progressively reduced quality and area of arable land. There were hardly any industries, and spread of education was negligible. Hence poverty and unemployment were rampant, and so were exploitation and injustices, which would often drive people to dacoity and Chambal ravines would provide them safe refuge. Feudal values reigned supreme and some among the dominant sections would also take up dacoity to maintain their domination. Guns were easy to get; so, disputes would often turn violent, result in murders, and the cycle of revenge and counter-revenge would go on unabated. This had been the tale since the times of Muslim rulers. Neither they nor the British nor the native states could purge the ravines of dacoits, which called themselves '*baghi*' (rebel), despite trying to crush them with a heavy hand.

The problem continued in Independent India despite several campaigns by the police. In fact, police atrocities also contributed to the addition in the ranks of dacoits. Exploitation of the problem for petty political gains further complicated the matter. It was the lot of common people to suffer both, the violence of the dacoits and the counter-violence by the police. Elimination of dacoit gangs hardly served the purpose, as new recruits would take the place of killed or jailed dacoits. And therefore peace continued to elude the region.

It was being realised in different quarters that treating the problem as that of law and order alone was not sufficient. It was a complex social problem that needed sensitive handling. H.S.

Kohili, Dy. I. G. of Police, Madhya Pradesh, gave a suggestion to the government in 1957 that Vinoba be requested to come to the region to address the problem in a nonviolent way. Local Congress workers made a similar request to Vinoba. But what perhaps made Vinoba make up his mind to take up the issue was the letter of Tehsildar Singh from Naini jail, which reached Vinoba on 21 January 1959. Tehsildar Singh, son of the legendary 'dacoit king' Man Singh, was himself a dreaded dacoit. He had been sentenced to death six times and to hard labour for 242 years. He had written,

"I am worried about the suffering of people in the Chambal region. - - - I know that you are the only saint in India who is accessible, sinless and truthful, and could listen to my submission. I have no doubt that no government can suppress the dacoits by force. Only you can show the world that real peace can be established through nonviolent methods. I seek an opportunity to present all the facts before you in person."¹

Vinoba sent Major General Yadunath Singh, the chief organiser of his tour in Kashmir, to meet Tehsildar Singh. Yadunath Singh belonged to the Chambal region and knew the situation. He was given to understand by Tehsildar Singh that many dacoits were fed up with the fugitive life and could be prevailed upon to lay down their arms and surrender. This was reported to Vinoba who gave green signal to Yadunath Singh to go ahead in this respect. Yadunath Singh then combed the whole area, sometimes even on foot or a bicycle, without caring for his life. He communicated Vinoba's message to the outlaws: 'Abjure crime, be repentant'. For this work, Madhya Pradesh government informally gave free hand to the Major.

Before deciding to head towards the region to tackle the problem, Vinoba wrote a letter to the Chief Minister of the state, K.N. Katju, who heartily welcomed Vinoba's initiative and expressed the confidence that 'his preaching will have a salutary effect on the troublemakers'.²

Vinoba reached Agra on 5 May and stayed there for three days. During his stay, he conferred with the Chief Minister of

U.P., some ministers of U.P. and M.P. and the Central Home Minister G.B. Pant. A few days ago, Sushila Nayyar and Congress President Indira Gandhi also had discussion with Vinoba in this regard.

Referring to his visit to Chambal region, Vinoba said,

“Now we are on way to Bhind-Morena. In the morning, somebody said, ‘You are going to the dacoit region.’ I said, ‘No, I am going to the area of good human beings.’ Bhind-Morena too, like other areas, is an area of good human beings. God knows who is a dacoit or not. Some people are called dacoits. But it is not that they alone are dacoits. Others may perhaps prove to be guiltier in the eyes of God. I am not going there to solve any problem. I am moving about serving the people, as a servant of God.”³

On 10 May, a dacoit named Ram Avatar surrendered before Vinoba at Fatehabad.

At Annauta (11 May), Vinoba said,

“No one is born a dacoit. We loot others, exploit others, do not care for others. And that creates dacoits. If we love the dacoits, gather courage and make our village a family, problems will be solved on their own accord. Police cannot solve this problem.”⁴

He was going to repeat it again and again: Surrender ownership, distribute wealth, live together with love, cultivate restraint; and the problem would be a thing of the past. There was no question of escape from punishment for the crimes committed; the dacoits were expected to repent and repentance would not be complete without serving sentences for crimes: “If you get away from punishment here, God will not forgive you.”⁵

On 13 May, Vinoba entered Madhya Pradesh at Rachher. The state government, to facilitate his mission, informally allowed free access to him, directing the police not to harass anyone meeting him.

Vinoba’s assertion that the problem could not be solved by the police and his occasional criticism of the police, as could be expected, did not go well with them. Some of them believed that

they could eliminate all the dacoit gangs and claim credit, and Vinoba's mission was causing an obstruction, although they could not oppose it openly because of the support from their political bosses to Vinoba's mission. Narasingh Rao Dikshit, Deputy Home Minister of the state, who had been elected from Bhind, had taken initiative in forming Village Protection Committees and arming them, was also not happy with the peace mission. At Ambah (14 May), there was a conference of the Village Protection Committees. Addressing them, Dikshit eulogised them and said that there was nothing new in the surrender of dacoits. Vinoba did not address the conference, but expressed his opinion in the evening meeting. He questioned whether violence could succeed in overcoming violence and asked who would save the people from their protectors.

"It is said the dacoits were eliminated. Then from where the new ones have sprung up? They sprung up because the mentality was not eliminated. Eliminating dacoits with arms is not a proper solution. Arms are always in the hands of a few people, not of the masses. Village Protection Committee is not a permanent remedy. The permanent remedy is that we should become fearless, should not accumulate wealth, distribute what we have, stop fighting with each other and live with love and co-operation. As long as we are fighting, neither the police nor Village Protection Committees can protect us."⁶

Addressing a gathering of the police on the next day, Vinoba brought home to them their duty:

"Work of the police is quite difficult. It requires a soft heart and a firm hand. The task of the army is easier. They are not questioned for the excesses committed. Unlike the army, the police are taken to task if they exceed the limit."

He told them how they could help his mission:

"You should not accompany me wherever I go. Anyone should be able to meet me without fear. When anyone is handed over to you, you should not deal with him with a heavy hand. If he is fit for a death sentence, he will be so sentenced by the judge."⁷

He also had a meeting with the Chief Minister here.

While Vinoba himself walked from village to village, visiting even remote villages, in the scorching heat of May accompanied by dust storms, met the people personally in their homes, listened to their suffering and gave his message of fearlessness and love, Sarvodaya workers fanned out in the ravines on foot or by any sort of vehicle that could be procured. Constantly under threat from both the dacoits and the police, both of whom had vested interests in the continuation of status quo, they braved adverse conditions with faith and goodwill in their hearts. It was their penance and the power of Vinoba's personality that could bring about the unbelievable.

The Peace mission had to face covert opposition from all the vested interests. Gurusharan writes,

“The dacoit problem in the Chambal ravines is like a business, in which several vested interests are involved. They include the politicians, informers, suppliers of arms, and some police personnel as well. Their interest lies in keeping the dacoit problem unsolved. But the personality and prestige of Major Yadunath Singh was such that they could not oppose overtly. Still, their efforts to sabotage this initiative continued. First, the idea of change of heart was ridiculed, and then they tried to put obstacles in the way of the mission.”⁸

The peace campaign started to bear fruit soon enough. On 17 May, at Nagara, the village to which notorious dacoit Lakhan Singh belonged, three dacoits—Patiram, Shrikishan and Moharman—surrendered. (Lakhan Singh did not surrender; and was gunned down by the police after a few months.) “People ask whether my mission would be successful,” said Vinoba in the prayer meeting:

“But it is not my mission. It is the mission of the Lord. What has happened is neither because of my strength nor because of my co-workers' efforts nor because these brothers were fed up with their tribulations. It was the Lord who transformed their hearts.”⁹

At Kanera on 18 May, Lachhi Pandit, who carried a reward

of Rs. 5,000 on his head, surrendered. A fugitive from the ravines, Lachhi was living in Mumbai. He read about Vinoba's mission in newspapers, and decided to return and surrender before Vinoba. No one had approached him personally.

In the night, Lokman alias Lukka and ten dacoits belonging to the ill-famed Man Singh and Roopa gang met Vinoba. The trek from Kanera to Kadora the next day (19 May) was indeed historic. Dreaded dacoits with rifles hanging from their shoulders and top police officers including the D.I.G. were accompanying Vinoba and the members of his party. People thronged the way to have a look at this incredible sight.

On being questioned as to why they were surrendering and preferring to go to jail at the cost of freedom, their reply was:

"We took this path in the fit of rage. But when we heard of Baba's (Vinoba's) message, we began to realize that our path was wrong. Is it good to harass, loot and kill people? We are constantly living under fear and so are people. Neither can we sleep nor eat peacefully. Is it a life worth living? We thought that we have got this opportunity to mend our ways because of Baba; so why not admit our wrongs and undergo suffering for our sins?"¹⁰

In the evening meeting, Lokman, Kanhai, Tej Singh, Darelal, Ramsanehi, Durjan, Vidyaram, Bhoop Singh, Jangeet, Bhagwan Singh and Matara laid down their arms, including sophisticated guns, at Vinoba's feet; one of the rifles was worth around Rs. 17,000.

The next day, at Surpura, Ram Dayal, Badan Singh and Karan Singh surrendered. In his address, Vinoba noted four reasons behind the problem: poverty, mutual conflicts, police and political parties.¹¹ He blamed easy availability of arms, and criticized the policy of giving arms licences to the informers liberally.

The surrendered dacoits spent four days with Vinoba's tour party. On 22 May, Bhind witnessed the biggest surrender in the presence of H.V. Pataskar, Governor of the state. Time had come for the dacoits to move to jail. They were given a warm farewell

with the women workers tying *rakhis* around their wrists. Overwhelmed with emotion, the baghis said, “We shall suffer for our deeds. But we shall never forget the love you have showered on us.”¹² They then sought Vinoba’s blessings, boarded open police jeeps and went away to jail.

On 23 May, Vinoba met them in Bhind jail. He addressed meetings of political workers and government officials. He impressed upon the government officials that an experiment to test the efficacy of moral power was being made.

A ten-member committee of Shanti-Sena with Hemdev Sharma as convener was constituted.

In the evening meeting, Vinoba called for the exercise of collective will to solve the intricate problem.

In a statement regarding the Chambal experiment with nonviolence, he later said,

“Whatever happened during my peace mission in the dacoit-infested region of Madhya Pradesh was totally unexpected. Nonviolence is a potent force in spiritual matters. Mahatma Gandhi used it in the political field. Since the last nine years, it is being applied in socio-economic sphere. Its use in this so-called ‘dacoit region’ has made an unprecedented impression on me. Hard hearts melted and the whole atmosphere was surcharged with divine spirit. People for whom dacoity had become a means of livelihood repented and abandoned their former ways. It appears that God has caused this miracle to happen, dwelling in their hearts. I can only express my gratitude to that great Lord, with faith in whom I am trying to walk in the way of Truth, love and compassion.”¹³

Dr. Rajendra Prasad, President of the Republic, telegraphically congratulated Vinoba on behalf of the nation, which was keenly watching these developments.

For Vinoba, it was nothing less than ‘*sakshatkar*’ (direct vision) of nonviolence, as he said in Kachingara (24 May):

“What happened in the last ten to twelve days has moved me to the depths of my heart. I saw how the light of God shines

through all. I had accepted this in theory; now it was demonstrated in practice. I had read about (the power of nonviolence) in books; now I have direct experience of that power. Three times I had collective vision of this power: at Pochampalli, in Bihar and now here.”¹⁴

On 26 May, a dacoit named Khachere surrendered, taking the total number of surrendered dacoits to 20.

The President of India pardoned Tehsildar Singh by setting aside his sentence of death by hanging and converting it to life imprisonment. Vinoba had expressed his wish in this regard.

What had happened was indeed miraculous and amazing. Daily ‘Anjam’ in Pakistan was one newspaper to hail it. It asked in its editorial why any *maulavi* or religious figure in Pakistan was not daring to take up cudgels to eradicate evils from society through spiritual power, like Vinoba Bhawe: “That individual in India, who is not a follower of Islam and whom many monopolists of religion would brand a kafir, is truly following the teaching of Islam.”¹⁵

It must be mentioned that no promise of lenient dealing was given to the dacoits. Their surrender was unconditional. They were supposed to confess all their crimes and undergo sentences as laid down in the law. There was no question of glorifying their deeds and making them ‘heroes’. What was expected from the police was humane treatment to them in police custody and jail, and nothing more. Many dacoits confessed to crimes for which there was no evidence. That they did not revert to dacoity after coming out of jails is also noteworthy.

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Such an experiment with wide-ranging ramifications needed to be appreciated and supported at all levels. Top political leadership did have some positive approach. But vested interests stepped in to neutralize, even to deny, its achievement. They first worked surreptitiously; and later came into the open.

Rustamji, I.G. of Police of Madhya Pradesh was the first to openly criticise Vinoba’s peace mission: for him, it was

demoralising for the police. Evidently, ego of some top police officials had been hurt by the simple and self-evident assertion that the problem was not such as could be solved by the police. Rustamji's statement was clearly a breach of service conditions, which warranted disciplinary action; but the political leadership shied away from this obvious duty. He should have made his thinking known to his political masters and stopped at that. Or he could have resigned or at least requested for transfer. That he chose to vent his opinion against the State policy was a clear indication that he had the backing of influential people in the government. This became clear when the Chief Minister himself defended him.

While newspapers like 'The Statesman' and 'Times of India' had words of appreciation, a section of the press viewed the mission with suspicion. The moment should have been utilized to initiate constructive discussion about crime and punishment in the state forums, in the media and in the civil society at large. But what was witnessed instead was petty-minded and prejudiced mud-slinging.

It is interesting to add here that Rustamji later realized his mistake. In an interview to daily 'Hitavada' in March 1980, he conceded that the surrender provided lot of immediate relief to the people at the time and the situation greatly improved:

"I confess that I was slightly wrong at that time. I was furious at that time because I felt it was a tremendous setback to police morale and sacrifice of police jawans. Anyway, if the people got relief—and they got relief—I confess I was a bit wrong."¹⁶

Yadunath Singh, the prime mover in the whole saga, whose towering personality was a great deterrent for vested interests, died on 3 August. His death, coupled with Rustamji's attitude and tacit support to him by the political leadership, dramatically changed the situation. The dacoits were chained on 18 August, and the chains were removed after persistent efforts only on 18 December. They were ill-treated and humiliated. The police, which had failed to capture them, not only tried to harass them perversely, but slapped false cases on them.

The perversity went to the extent of denying the very fact of surrender, which had happened in full view of the whole world! The police told the court that they had arrested those dacoits at the gate of the jail, after being tipped by their informers!

The dacoits confessed to their crimes in court. But there were some cases about crimes they had not done. Many lawyers came forward to fight such cases free of cost. Even judges were impressed by the voluntary surrender. It would have been better to club all the cases and conduct summary trial at a single place. Even this simple step was not taken. So, the cases continued for years in district courts, high courts and even in the Supreme Court. The police did not even hesitate to produce false witnesses.

All this severely affected the work of peace mission also. The contact work in the ravines came to a full stop. Surrender of twenty dacoits could not initiate a process which could have ultimately solved the dacoit problem once and for all.

On 10 August, Vinoba declared unequivocally,

“I think the process of surrender has come to an end. It could have made a moral impact all over India and the government could have helped in sustaining this impact. But this could not occur to the government. The work did have some moral impact, but it could not take the shape of a movement. The government belied our expectations. Otherwise, much could have been achieved for the solution of the dacoit problem.”¹⁷

When all this was happening, Jayaprakash was in Europe. On his return, he learnt about the way the matter was being treated, and was naturally incensed. He hailed the surrender and dubbed Rustamji's statement as unwise. He also demanded that cases be slapped on the police officials who had denied the fact of surrender in the court, and condemned police excesses.¹⁸

Although hampered in its working by the hardened attitude of the government, Chambal Ghati Shanti Samiti continued its work of assuaging the sufferings of the victims of excesses.

Hostels were opened where offspring of dacoits and their victims started living together. Efforts were made to address irritants, which had induced many to become dacoits. By 1968, 16 out of 20 surrendered dacoits had completed their jail sentences. Their rehabilitation was particularly looked into. Some were given bhoodan lands.

However, a golden opportunity had been lost.

Not only bureaucracy and police, but social scientists also either neglected the events or did not look at them in proper perspective. A social scientist concluded after visiting a handful of villages that Vinoba could not understand the problem properly as he had moved in the area 'only for four weeks'!¹⁹ Sceptics questioned whether the dacoits had really undergone change of heart, assuming that they must have been assured leniency, disregarding all the facts.

Leaving behind all this, Vinoba moved ahead.

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Turning towards south, Vinoba set out for Indore. Sarvodaya had hardly made an impact in urban areas; and that was surely one of the reasons for the indifference and ignorance about Sarvodaya work in the media. There was need to identify issues, which could be starting points for extension of work in the cities, and work on them. Vinoba thought of making Indore a model.

Why Indore? The place, according to Vinoba, had 'a lot of vitality'.²⁰ It was centrally located and associated with the sacred memories of Ahilyadevi Holkar, a pious and sagacious ruler of the erstwhile Holkar state, who had donated liberally for the development of places of pilgrimage all over India.

Vinoba had given the target of 13,000 Sarvodaya-patras for local workers as a pre-condition of his coming to the city, when they had visited him a few months back. That condition stood fulfilled.

Vinoba reached Indore on 24 July 1960. People thronged to see him—not only they poured into the streets, but were also

on housetops and even on the tree-tops to catch a glimpse of him. The evening prayer meeting saw attendance of over 50,000 people. The day marked the onset of monsoon in that year. It rained almost every day during the whole month that he spent there; but his programmes went on as scheduled. His daily prayer meetings, even in the early morning hours, were attended by thousands despite frequent rains.

What should be the starting point? Vinoba thought of sanitation. Cities in India were, and are, notorious for filth. The programme had, in the context of India, revolutionary potential; besides being non-controversial. Everyone could participate in it. So 'Clean Indore' programme was inaugurated. People from all walks of life took part in it with enthusiasm. As Vinoba explained,

"When we ourselves do some work, we have a '*sakshatkar*' of some sort (through direct experience we realize and begin to appreciate fully all that it entails). We want that scavenging should no longer be a source of livelihood. But as long as it continues as a vocation, it is the duty of good-natured people to join them in that work."²¹

So, he too joined in doing that repulsive, abominable and un-human work. Appa Patwardhan, a reputed Gandhian worker and an expert in the science of sanitation, was specially invited to Indore to guide the programme. In seven lectures during the 'cleanliness week' Vinoba spelt out how cleanliness could lead to spiritual awakening.²²

Sarvodaya-patra was, of course, a programme dear to his heart, and it had good prospect in cities. By this time, Sarvodaya-patras had been established in 30,000 out of 80,000 homes in Indore. It was a programme that could easily be taken up by women, from whom he had great expectations. Kasturba Trust, the premier Gandhian organisation working for women, had its headquarters near Indore. Vinoba sought its co-operation. The other segment of population he had his eyes on was senior citizens—the *vanaprasthis* (belonging to the third stage of life according to the Hindu tradition): free from household responsibilities, they could spare time and contribute with their experience. Vinoba exhorted them to become free of

attachment to body, family and carnal pleasure and serve the society selflessly. Sarvodaya Vanaprastha Mandal was formed.

During his stay in Indore, Vinoba met hundreds of people from different walks of life and gave about 125-150 talks. He touched several issues having bearing on making Indore a 'Sarvodaya City'. For him this was research work:

"Whatever is being thought about and done in Indore would be looked upon as a work of research in bhoodan and Sarvodaya. New discoveries are not possible without research. Without research, we will not be up-to-date as required by the present era."²³

He appealed for eschewing politics from the municipal corporation, stressed the need for solving disputes without recourse to law and called for prohibition. On 15 August, Visarjan Ashram was inaugurated at Indore. It was supposed to be a centre for the citizens of Indore, as well as a place for training and self-study of the workers.

For the first time, Vinoba stayed in a city for such a long time. One thing that attracted his attention was indecent posters of films. Deeply pained by what he called 'free and compulsory education in sensuality', which would undermine the very foundation of society and erode the energy and vitality of the people. He wondered how the people shorn of vitality would be able to defend their independence. On 20 August, he called upon women to raise their voice against them: they had a special responsibility 'to safeguard peace and modesty'.²⁴

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Vinoba left Indore on 24 August. The issue of indecent posters soon became a rallying point for the people and the workers. Citizens, owners of cinema theatres and film producers formed a committee to decide which posters were indecent. A programme to erase such advertisements on walls with the consent of owners of the concerned houses was initiated. Vinoba even warned of countrywide satyagraha on the issue if the government and the concerned people dragged their feet: "For ten years, I have striven to avert wrongly conceived satyagrahas.

But I will myself lead this satyagraha. I am mentally prepared for such eventuality.”²⁵

On 5 November, satyagrahis, after receiving green signal from Vinoba, burnt down an indecent poster of the film ‘Lambe hath’, as all efforts to get it removed through other means had failed.

However, this issue was seen as a distraction by some workers. Sarva Seva Sangh Executive Committee, in its meeting at Bangalore, expressed displeasure over satyagraha on this issue. Siddharaj Daddha came to Indore to dissuade local workers. It was decided that the matter be discussed at an emergency meeting at Jabalpur in Vinoba's presence. Such a meeting was held on 12 November. Vinoba stoutly defended the satyagraha. The executive committee ultimately acquiesced in and permitted workers to resort to satyagraha wherever they felt the need. Still, reservations persisted. It was said that there could be difference of opinion about whether something was obscene or not; that the satyagraha was premature as public opinion had not been adequately mobilised; the process of satyagraha was not gentle; and it would perhaps cause the Movement to go astray. Vinoba explained that he had used the word ‘indecent’ and not ‘obscene’; there were agreed social norms about indecency; at Indore, a committee of respected citizens had been set up to decide whether a particular poster was indecent or not. Secondly, he had dealt with the issue a number of times, and public opinion had been sufficiently aroused. He also defended burning of posters, saying that it was an auspicious manner as against smearing them with tar, and that other ways of satyagraha could be thought. He also pointed out that the programme would attract many more people towards Sarvodaya.²⁶

People at large, particularly women, were unhappy with the aggression of indecency on their senses. Vinoba's initiative made them vocal. The issue soon became a subject of lively debate in media and even in legislative assemblies. Public meetings and demonstrations were held at a number of places. Many local government bodies passed resolutions against such posters. Bimal Roy led a delegation of film producers which met Finance

Minister Morarji Desai and assured him that the Producers' Association would see to it that such posters were not displayed. The Association conceded that the poster burnt at Indore was indecent. Roy also wrote to Vinoba assuring co-operation from the producers. At several places including Ferozepur, Lucknow, Agra, Kanpur, Patna and Allahabad, indecent posters were torn and burnt. Government of India constituted an informal committee to screen posters before display. However, film producers and distributors did try some mischief by instigating students.

The campaign against indecent posters was, in fact, a campaign against indecency in public life. It was to arouse the people from slumber and activate them for maintaining decency in public life. The effort succeeded to some extent. However, it could not be sustained for long, even in Indore. Vinoba also did not persist with the issue tenaciously. Why?

"I carried on the movement against posters for nine to ten months. Then I withdrew from it. I put a little curd in milk as leaven. If I keep stirring the milk now, the milk will not be converted into curd. If the issue appeals to the conscience of the society, it will take it up. Why should I be insistent? That will be against nonviolence."²⁷

The issue, as it turned out, did not appeal consistently to the society's conscience.

Other work in Indore also could not keep up the momentum. The workers could not maintain expected liaison with the citizens. Vinoba's desire of making the city 'a Sarvodaya city' remained unfulfilled.

Vinoba, as usual, moved ahead.

During Madhya Pradesh tour, 2,200 acres bhoodan was received in 203 villages by 458 donors.²⁸

14. In the North-East

Tour of Assam and East Pakistan

It had been a persistent complaint of the North-East that its natural resources were being exploited by outsiders; that outsiders were controlling their economy; that their languages and cultures and aspirations were being neglected. The discontent erupted in July 1960 and Bengalis were targeted. There was reaction in Bengali-majority areas. Peace did return after some time, but estrangement continued. Pandit Nehru wrote to Vinoba on 15 September that if he could go there and have a dialogue with the local people, it would immensely help normalise the situation.¹ Vinoba was already contemplating visit to North-East. So, he decided to head towards the east.

The Movement was going ahead in different states, although the pace differed. In Western Maharashtra, 41,163 acres had been received as bhoodan. However, only 6,000 acres had been distributed by the end of 1958. The state committee therefore entrusted the task of distributing the rest of the land to Babulal Gandhi, a young and dedicated worker. Babulal traversed the whole region in 15 months and distributed 26,207 acres with the help of local workers; 14,538 acres could not be distributed for various reasons. Babulal also probed the motives of donors. His book on this work is an authentic and valuable document in the history of bhoodan.²

Socialist leader and ex-Deputy Prime Minister of Burma (Myanmar) joined Jayaprakash in his Gaya tour for some time and hailed the Sarvodaya way of solving the land problem as the best one, which would eventually be followed by other countries of Asia.³

Occasional eruption of violence was a regular feature in the country, as people's expectations remained unfulfilled even after 12 years of Independence. Shanti-Sena units did whatever they could. As a few recalcitrant big landlords were hindering the

path of gramdan in Batlagundu area of Tamil Nadu, Sarva Seva Sangh permitted local workers to resort to satyagraha. Satyagraha against eviction of peasants was also given green signal 'if all other means failed'. Vinoba's prior consent was considered essential for satyagraha in both the cases.

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From Madhya Pradesh, Vinoba came to Uttar Pradesh. Chief Minister C.B. Gupta met him at Mirzapur (10 December) and discussed, inter alia, ban on indecent posters, rehabilitation of persons displaced by the Rihand dam and rehabilitation of surrendered dacoits. At Kashi (15 December) he called for making Kashi 'a Sarvodaya city'.

On 25 December, he was in Bihar again. He reminded the state of its resolve of collecting 3.2 million acres. For this purpose, he gave a new programme: '*Bighe men kattha, dan do ikattha*' (Give one kattha per bigha, that is, one-twentieth of land; and let all join in giving land):

"It is commendable for Bihar to make such a resolve. All the people put in efforts, yet the resolve remains unfulfilled. It can easily be fulfilled if everyone gives one-twentieth of his land. If this happens, stream of compassion will spring up in every village and these streams will, in no time, take the shape of a big river."⁴

An important feature of the campaign was that the donors were to distribute gifted land.

The programme was criticised on the ground that it was too dilute: Vinoba, who kept talking about dissolution of private ownership and asked for one-sixth of land as a first instalment, had made a steep climb-down. Vinoba explained,

"I have not merely asked for one-twentieth land; I have also said that the land be given by all. Will it not create a favourable atmosphere? We will now have to go to each landowner and seek land.

"Secondly, we used to take even fallow land; but now we are seeking only cultivated land.

“This time, we have asked the donors to distribute the land gifted by them. Bhoodan workers will only help them. This will do away with middlemen and unite the hearts of donors and donees.”⁵

People were listening to Vinoba in thousands, their hopes were getting aroused. But what was actually taking place on the ground was much below expectations. Could this give impetus to forces of violence? This distinct possibility was worrying Vinoba. But, as he said, he was on the move in spite of the risk.⁶ Vinoba's apprehension seems to have been proved true by subsequent events. Naxalism seems to have found more recruits in areas where bhoodan work had been intensively carried out.

Panchayat Raj institutions were being established in the country. Vinoba had held all along that such 'democratic decentralisation' without prior land redistribution, being the first step towards equality, would only intensify exploitation. Kaka Kalelkar also expressed the fear that if the dominant sections in the countryside captured these institutions, the very foundation of Independence would be undermined; to avoid this eventuality, he asked Gandhian workers to take up the responsibility of running these institutions.⁷ Jayaprakash was also of the opinion that this development should be used as an opportunity to further the cause of gram-swaraj.

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More than 100 Shanti-sainiks from different parts of the country were working in Assam after the riots. Dedicated workers like Amalprabha Das were working for gramdan, and 80 gramdans had been obtained.

Vinoba entered Assam on 5 March 1961 and was welcomed, among others, by Labour Minister K.P. Tripathi. General Shrinagesh, Governor of the state, also met him. Vinoba said that Assam was India in miniature and it should give a message of confluence of cultures to the country.⁸

A special session of Assam Sarvodaya Mandal was held in Vinoba's presence on 15-16 April. The State Congress Committee resolved on 1 May that Congressman should work to collect 5%

of the land under cultivation as bhoodan.

On the question of official language, Vinoba backed the claim of Assamese, while recommending that Bangla should also continue as a medium of education. Still, Bengal newspapers criticised him. In the context of national integration, he favoured learning of Hindi language and Nagari script.

Vinoba scrupulously avoided sermonising in the context of riots, while stressing that people should live together with love and co-operation, holding that it was better to let bygones be bygones. But he did visit the victims of riots and consoled them. As he said, he had not come to Assam to give sermons; he wanted to listen to the people.

It was his practice to study prominent spiritual literature in the state he was going to visit, quote from it profusely in his lectures there, and thus communicate his message through the time-tested words of the saints revered by the local populace. In Assam, he studied the works of Shri Shankardev and Shri Madhavdev, particularly the latter's 'Namaghosha'. He even condensed it and apprised the country of the spiritual wisdom of the great saint, hitherto little known outside Assam.

On 12 May, he entered North Lakhimpur district. He found it suitable for intensive work for gram-swaraj. Centres were established and workers combed the district. Within three months, the number of gramdans in it reached 125.

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The 13th Annual Sarvodaya Conference was held at Unguturu in Andhra Pradesh from 18 to 20 April. Sarva Seva Sangh also met there from 14 to 16 April. Vinoba was absent. But he sent a message:

"Bhoodan work has completed 10 years. Sociologists know that enthusiasm in a work gets renewed after every 10 years. It has been convincingly proved that there is no way to solve the land problem except bhoodan. I hope that Sarvodaya workers will again take up the *mantra* of bhoodan with renewed enthusiasm and arouse the country. What other message can I give? In fact, my *padayatra* is itself my message."⁹

Pandit Nehru said in his message,

“I have not always agreed with some of the views expressed on behalf of Sarvodaya, but I have always attached value to them. They represent an approach which attracts me in many ways, even though it might not always fit in with some of the policies we have pursued.”¹⁰

Nehru was always candid; he revered Gandhi and Vinoba, yet never concurred with their basic approach.

The conference was presided over by Jayaprakash. Dr. Rajendra Prasad attended it on the last day. Arrangements had been made for thousands of delegates in that little village. Railways had constructed a platform and established a new station, naming it ‘Sarvodayapuram’. Sarva Seva Sangh held its half-yearly meeting there.

Vinoba had called for continuing the same programme with renewed vigour. But the top leadership of the Movement was perhaps not convinced. With Vinoba not there in their midst, differences of opinion were expressed perhaps more freely. In the Sarva Seva Sangh meeting, Jayaprakash suggested villagisation of land by law, if 80-90% of the villagers consented to it; the rest of the owners could be paid compensation. He also advocated more involvement in Panchayat Raj, expressing the hope that it could become a means for widening the Movement.¹¹

More importantly, in his speech in the Conference, he called for reconsideration of the attitude of indifference towards politics:

“Does our indifference towards politics mean that we have nothing to do with what is happening in the field of politics or with the way democratic institutions are functioning? Even if democracy is in danger, or there is threat of anarchy or dictatorship, should we disregard that insensitively and insensibly? - - - We have been carrying out our Movement with the assumption that the situation in the country will remain normal and we will have an opportunity to continue our work without any difficulty. But when that assumption does not remain valid, that opportunity ceases to exist. - - -

And that assumption is no longer as valid as it was before a few years.”

He therefore pleaded for strengthening the foundation of democracy and said,

“We have not realised how extensive this work is. For this purpose it is not sufficient to work (for gram-swaraj) in a handful of villages, particularly when the possibility of rapid increase in their number is remote. If we fail in building a widespread movement for gram-swaraj in the near future, how are we going to address this challenge?”¹²

This loud thinking was clearly at variance, not only with the Movement’s strategy but also with its ideological foundation: the Movement was consciously ignoring democratic politics because it was fundamentally anarchist. Jayaprakash’s comments, naturally, provoked strong reactions. Shaken by them, he said,

“What have I said as to cause so much commotion, as if I have stirred up a hornet’s nest? - - - If your reaction is so strong, I will have to think whether it is right for me to speak in your community at all!”¹³

Unguturu Conference was a turning point in the history of the Movement. What Jayaprakash proposed ultimately led to the vertical split in the Movement in 1974.

Sarva Seva Sangh deliberated over its role in the coming elections. It was suggested in the resolution that people should choose candidates through voters’ councils, and a beginning be made in some constituencies. A code of conduct for the political parties was also proposed.¹⁴ Commenting on the resolution, Shankarrao Deo rightly cautioned that there was apprehension in people’s minds that the resolution on elections might cause downward slide or entanglement.¹⁵ The Conference also called for giving priority to bhoodan and land distribution.

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The stagnation in the Movement was prompting reconsideration of strategy. Looking to Panchayat Raj was one

such idea, which had attracted Jayaprakash. He took keen interest in it and even led the All-India Panchayat Parishad. Dharendra Majumdar was advocating concentration on selected pockets. In this context, he began an experiment of *sarvajanadhar* (living on the support of all the people). His quest was for finding a social technique that could be universalized, which the gramdams that had taken place so far seemed to lack, being mostly a result of external prodding.¹⁶

This needed bold experiments. Moreover, propagation of fundamental ideas needed to be kept up. At Madurai in Tamil Nadu, Jagannathan led a satyagraha against eviction of bhoodan peasants. In Wardha district of Maharashtra, workers undertook walking tours and visited 135 villages in a week. Vinoba was trying to enthuse the workers and keep up the morale of his flock, pointing towards the achievements.

Vinoba had consistently advocated adoption of Nagari script by all Indian languages (Hindi and Marathi had already adopted it) at every opportunity. Conference of Chief Ministers in August 1961 arrived at a consensus about it. National Integration Committee appointed by the Congress under the chairmanship of Indira Gandhi recommended adoption of Nagari as a common script for India.¹⁷

The year 1961 ended with the military action by the Government of India to liberate Goa. After the departure of the British, the French followed suit, but the Portuguese adamantly held on to their colonies in India, crushing all agitations. People in India were impatient for the liberation of Portuguese colonies, and so were the people in those colonies. Ultimately, military action was carried out on 17 December and the Portuguese were defeated in three days. That Goa belonged to India was never in doubt, but military action invited strong reactions in the world. In the U.N. Security Council, many countries opposed India, and she was saved from censure only because of U.S.S.R.'s veto. Pacifists the world over condemned the action. Goa's liberation was welcomed in the Sarvodaya circle, but the use of violence was regretted. "We did not give any practical assistance to the citizens of Goa to carry out

nonviolent struggle. How can we complain now?", rued Shankarrao Deo.¹⁸

Vinoba said that this was not a matter of humiliation for Sarvodaya, as some people appeared to think: If there was at all a matter of humiliation, it was the very fact that government had persisted with the army after achieving Independence through nonviolent way. Secondly, they had been consistently pursuing for the last ten years a revolutionary programme to uproot violence. Had they been inactive, it would have been a matter of disparagement for them. Thirdly, capacity of a democratic government depends on the average capacity of masses. Had a nonviolent satyagraha been tried, it would have involved so much sacrifice that public outcry would have forced the government to send the army; otherwise, its very existence would have been in jeopardy. Favourable mindset and atmosphere is a precondition for a nonviolent satyagraha.¹⁹

Sarva Seva Sangh constituted a committee to evaluate the work in the last decade. The committee recommended, inter alia, that (1) Wherever bhoodan and gramdan laws did not exist, they should be expeditiously enacted, (2) Wherever possible, the work of land distribution be entrusted to gram-panchayats, (3) Bhoodan boards should also work for distribution; government should give necessary funds for the purpose, (4) As confirmation of gift letters etc. was taking unduly long time, some way should be found to distribute gifted lands without confirmation, and that should be legally recognised.²⁰

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In Assam, the work gathered momentum. Assam became the first state in India to enact Gramdan law (in October 1961). Select Committee of the state Legislative Assembly had extensive consultation with Vinoba over the draft of the bill on 29 June. It was unanimously passed.

In the Sarva Seva Sangh meeting at Dhakuakhana (12 January 1962), Vinoba opined that dissolution of private ownership of land was 'a demand of the era' and public consciousness would not be able to oppose it. He added,

"It is true that we have not been able to mould public consciousness to the desired extent. That is because of the inadequacy of our penance. Yet, compared to our efforts, God has given us much. I find that, on the whole, we are on the firmer footing than what we were 10 years ago. So we should stick to this work, realizing that it is fundamental. We may add a few other programmes to make the Movement comprehensive, but we must not forsake our foundation."²¹

In Assam, Vinoba resumed the style of working adopted in Telangana. He met people in their homes, and took initiative in solving disputes. He was ready to give as much time as needed to Assam, the border state, which was the last stage of his circumambulation of India and where gramdan was particularly relevant as a 'defence measure'. It was an answer to the problem of infiltration, which was (and continues to be) a festering sore:

"If a village accepts gramdan and ownership of land vests in the village, land will not be sold. If outsiders do not get land, they will not be tempted to come here. This is an effective remedy for the problem of infiltration. Today, Muslims (from East Pakistan) intrude into Assam and capture land. This becomes known after considerable time, and then they are evicted. They go back and narrate their woes. People there get agitated and think that Muslims living here are being driven away, so they drive away Hindus living there. The cycle goes on. Gramdan is an answer to this."²²

Assam was important because of its peculiar situation: there were tensions between Hindus, Muslims and Christians; and between tribals and non-tribals; it had common borders with Pakistan, Myanmar, China, Tibet and Nepal. So many kinds of people had come together there because of historical reasons; it was necessary for them to learn to live together amicably. With this view, Vinoba opened an ashram near North Lakhimpur and named it 'Maitri Ashram' (5 March 1962). He wanted it to be a centre for keeping in touch with the whole world. He also looked upon it to explore potentialities for the development of women's power.

Sarva Seva Sangh met at Patna in April. Jayaprakash

reiterated that bhoodan was no longer captivating people's minds; therefore, work should be done for the solution of people's problems like corruption and exploitation. He acknowledged that every movement undergoes ebb and flow, but was worried that the Movement was continuously ebbing.²³

But what Vinoba was witnessing in Assam was just the opposite. Not only was gramdan evoking good response, its philosophy was also evolving.

Two young men—Satish Kumar and E.P. Menon—decided to tour the world on foot for world peace. When they came to Vinoba to seek his blessings, he advised them not to keep any money with them and not to take non-vegetarian food. They agreed, and stuck to this undertaking despite difficulties. The tour from June 1962 to September 1964 covered Pakistan, Afghanistan, Iran, U.S.S.R., Poland, Germany, France, U.K., U.S.A. and Japan.²⁴

Gramdan involved redistribution of the whole village land, based on the family size. That hundreds of villages were readily accepting this was nothing short of a miracle. But it was too much to expect its universalisation. The programme needed to be reshaped to make it less disturbing and easier to accept, even while keeping intact its revolutionary core—and that core was the dissolution of private property in land and villagisation of land. Vinoba was thinking in this direction, which later culminated in the scheme of '*Sulabh* (easy) gramdan'.

Vinoba spent an year and a half in Assam, and left it on 4 September 1962. The number of gramdans he received during his tour was 929.²⁵ Those present at the time of his farewell included the state's Revenue Minister, Congress President and renowned writer Nilamony Fukan.

Vinoba wrote to Chief Minister B.P. Chaliha at the time of departure that his experience in Assam had enhanced his hope for and faith in the state:

"I hope that gram-swaraj will be established in every village here on the foundation of gramdan. I am leaving Assam physically, but my heart is with you all."²⁶

Warmly reciprocating his feelings, Chaliha wrote,

“The message contained in your letter will be a source of inspiration to our people. We have no words to express our gratefulness for your kind visit to Assam and the atmosphere which you have created in our state. I can assure you on behalf of myself and on behalf of my colleagues that we will try to follow up the works and further the cause of gramdan.”²⁷

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In Bihar, the ‘Bigha-kattha’ (seeking one-twentieth part of land from all the landowners) campaign was in full swing. The campaign carried out from 25 December 1960 to 3 December 1961 yielded 1,50,070 katthas from 7,413 donors, and this outcome was offered to President Dr. Rajendra Prasad on 3 December, his birthday.²⁸ Vinoba asked the workers to continue the campaign till the 3 December next year. A special campaign was carried out from 15 April to 15 June 1962. Many workers from other states also joined in.

The Bihar Bhoodan Committee had suggested provision of land levy when the state government introduced land ceiling bill in 1955. This provision was included in the Act which was passed in 1961. It was also provided that bhoodan given after 25 December 1960 would be deducted from the levy obligation. Jayaprakash hailed it as ‘a victory of bhoodan’.²⁹ Vinoba said, “The government will take land through levy. But a nonviolent movement has its own process. So, I will ask the landowners to give land (in bhoodan).”³⁰ Of course, giving bhoodan meant forgoing compensation amount.

Needless to say, the landlords were opposed to this provision. It became an important issue in the election and pressure was mounted on the government when Congress received setback in the election. In May 1962, levy provision was suspended. Sarvodaya circle sharply reacted to this retrograde step. Baidyanath Prasad Chaudhary, a prominent bhoodan worker, termed this as a blot on Bihar government and Bihar Congress and as betrayal of Vinoba and the landless.³¹ Vinoba’s reaction was characteristic:

“Such breach of promise lowers the level of public life, and this is what pains me. As far as I am concerned, I have always pinned hope on *yajna* (sacrifice), *dana* (charity) and *tapa* (penance)—*yajna* of the poor, *dana* of the landholders, *tapa* of the workers.”³²

He appealed to the workers to continue the campaign irrespective of what happens to the levy provision and hoped that the landowners of Bihar would donate generously.

The two months’ campaign (from 15 April to 15 June) yielded only 1,32,457 katthas (6,623 bighas) from 8,007 donors, far below the expectations, although it did galvanise the workers and again took the Movement’s message to remote villages. The outcome was offered to Dr. Rajendra Prasad on 21 June 1962. Out of this land, 1,05,392 katthas had been distributed to 7,355 landless families.³³

As the next step, Vinoba advised continuation of the campaign with co-operation from the panchayats, distribution of gifted land and efforts to create atmosphere for gramdan in villages where land had been received under the campaign.

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While returning from Assam, it was convenient to pass through East Pakistan (now Bangladesh). Pakistan government gave permission for the same. And thus Vinoba visited a ‘foreign country’—for the first and the last time—where he spent 17 days.

Since Gandhiji’s days, some of his followers like Charu Chaudhary, Nikunj Bihari Goswami, Biswaranjan Sen, Jharna Chaudhary and Ranraj Kumar Dutta had continued to work in East Pakistan under extremely adverse circumstances. They heartily worked for the success of this tour.

Vinoba walked into East Pakistan on 5 September at Sonarhat, where he was received by the Dy. Commissioner of Rangpur. Thanking Pakistan Government for permitting him to enter the country, he declared, “I have come here with a message of love and peace alone.”³⁴ In the evening meeting at Bhurungamari, the first halt, about four to five thousand people listened to him. “I have come to this country empty-handed and

shall return empty-handed. But if the work of bhoodan begins in Pakistan, it will unite hearts of millions. Friendship, love, compassion and service of the distressed—this alone is the essence of all religions”, said Vinoba.³⁵

On the same day, Abdul Khaliq Munshi, a small farmer with only four acres of land, gifted one acre. The land was given then and there to Mano Sheikh, a landless labourer. The donor also undertook to pay the registration fee. ‘The doors have opened!’ exclaimed Vinoba. Five gifts were received on the second day, and on the fifth day, a single bhoodan accounted for as much as 50 bighas.

Vinoba walked on and thousands came to hear his message of love, sharing and the unity of mankind. He held silent prayers in the evening meetings, but the morning prayers including Ishavasya Upanishad were continued by the tour party.

Along with bhoodan, Vinoba dwelt upon essence of religions, village Swaraj and several other issues. How he was looked upon by the common folk is illustrated by a touching incident. Once in the darkness of early morning, a man crossed the way of tour party with a bottle of water in his hands. “My child is ailing. Kindly recite some hymn and make this water holy, so as to cure my child,” he urged Vinoba. Vinoba held his hand and said. “Do you have faith in Allah? Then be sure your child will be cured.”³⁶

The so-called intelligentsia did try to corner him. When his opinion about the ‘Basic democracy’ introduced by the then dictator Ayub Khan was sought, he opined that it could be a good beginning if looked upon from the point of view of love and compassion, not power, but “gram-swaraj cannot be ushered in merely by decentralisation of power.”³⁷ He expressed the hope that the council members under Basic Democracy would continue his work.

When asked by a lawyer whether he would ask the Government of India to give some land to Pakistan, as East Pakistan had paucity of land, he replied, “India too faces this problem. The country facing this problem will have to solve first

its internal problems through love. This is the problem of the whole of Asia.” The lawyer again asked whether he could then plead with the Government of India. Vinoba replied,

“Such thing cannot be done unilaterally. Land is in abundance in West Pakistan. So the same question would crop up there. The problem will be solved only when there is a confederation of two countries. I talk of ‘*Jai Jagat*’ (Victory to the world); that will result in world federation.”³⁸

He was also asked about communal riots at Jabalpur, Aligarh and Assam. Vinoba said that these were against his philosophy of life, and that was why he was moving from place to place to shape public opinion. He mentioned Shanti-Sena in this connection.³⁹ When asked about the Kashmir problem, he said that it was a political question and he had not come there to discuss politics: “If I have to discuss politics, I will do so with President Ayub Khan, not with you!”⁴⁰

Interest was evinced in his ‘Essence of Quran’ which was under print. While some Pakistani newspapers criticized this initiative, ‘Madina’ of Bijnore wrote,

“Vinoba has done what no one else did in the last 1,300 years. Who else put before the non-Muslims in India and in the whole world the basic tenets of Islam in the words of Quran? Muslims ruled over this country and Pakistan also came in existence; but who else thought of making the Quran known to the world with knowledge and discrimination?”⁴¹

On his birthday, 11 September, the Government of East Pakistan sent him a telegram of greetings.

His last public meeting was in ‘no man’s land’ between India and Pakistan. Bidding adieu, Vinoba said,

“I had full faith that I would get their love. But that was, in the words of Quran, ‘*ilmul yakeen*’ (reasoned belief). The moment I stepped in Pakistan, I found that the people’s hearts were surging with love and ardour. I suppose that at least one and a quarter lakh people heard me in the last sixteen days. At the time of prayer, they would sit silently and quietly. It

was a unique scene which I would never forget. This direct experience of the people's love has resulted in '*aynul yakeen*' (the belief created by seeing with one's own eyes)."⁴²

In all, during the Pakistan tour, he received 176 bighas from 37 donors, and they were distributed to 69 families. Both donors and allottees included Hindus and Muslims.⁴³ Vinoba, however, did not form an organisation to carry on the work.

On 18 September 1962, West Bengal government issued an ordinance on bhoodan, and later enacted a law. However, the rules were made only in 1966!

16. Towards Paramdham

Sulabh Gramdan Comes on the Scene

There had always been goodwill for China in India. India was the first nation to recognise Communist China. Pandit Nehru had proclaimed ‘Panchasheel’—five principles for peaceful co-existence—in association with Chou En-lai, the Chinese premier, in 1954. Border dispute was there between India and China, but it was taken for granted that it would be solved amicably and peacefully. However, the Chinese dragon had expansionist designs. In 1959, China invaded and occupied Tibet. Dalai Lama, head of the State and the supreme religious authority, had to take refuge in India. India provided him shelter, but refused to take firm stand on the independence of Tibet and did not allow Dalai Lama to form government-in-exile. Despite all this, China continued to intrude into Indian territory surreptitiously and occupied Axai Chin in 1959.

Finally it invaded Indian territory in October 1962, catching her unawares. Indian army, unprepared in every way, had to retreat. China occupied several square kilometres of Indian territory in the North-East. A wave of indignation swept the nation.

Vinoba had sensed the danger long back. In 1960, he had advised the workers to work in the border areas. He now declared unequivocally that the war had been thrust on India. What was the people’s duty in the situation? The people should forget all kinds of differences, they should not panic, and thirdly, “Every village should become strong; every village should become like a family.”¹ As he had repeated time and again, gramdan was, for him, ‘a defence measure’. It might ‘blunt the aggressive instinct of China; if not, it would surely blunt its strength for aggression’.²

What should believers in nonviolence do? Dhirendra Majumdar explained,

"They cannot co-operate with the military action. But as the government has taken the step (to fight the war) against the injustice with the backing of the nation, we cannot oppose it either. - - - It becomes our duty to organise people's power and maintain peace in the country."³

That was Vinoba's stand too.

The invasion expectedly created a war fever, gravely shaking the already fragile faith of the people in nonviolence. It was creditable for Sarvodaya workers that they did not fall prey to the fever. Sarva Seva Sangh Working Committee, in its meeting at Pipla (10-13 November) noted that creation of the capacity of offering nonviolent resistance in the people in the border areas was an important task.

The 14th Annual Sarvodaya Conference was held at Vedchhi (Gujarat) on 23-24 November 1962. It was presided over by E.W. Aryanayakam. Vinoba was absent, but he sent a message. The crisis was, for him, an opportunity:

"What the nation is facing today was not unexpected. I had apprehension about it since long; and that is why my walking tour has been going on since eleven and a half years. What we were propagating was in tune with the demand of the age, but the people's minds were not quite receptive. But I see that they have now become favourable to our ideas in the present context. Now there is nothing to hinder the Sarvodaya ideology."⁴

For Vinoba, the Chinese aggression was not only political, it was ideological as well; and the latter aggression could be countered by gramdan alone. He impressed upon the people that the clash was 'a passing phase': India and China had been neighbours with long-standing relations and common problems.

Vinoba apprised Nehru of his opinions in the context of the Chinese aggression. Impressed with his insights and understanding of the international situation, Nehru invited Vinoba for consultations 'to reinforce our strength'.⁵

The Congress governments were never serious about enforcing prohibition, despite commitment to this issue since

pre-Independence times. After the aggression, they found a pretext to dilute the policy even further for the sake of money. Prohibition in 11 districts and the pilgrimage centres of Haridwar, Rishikesh and Vrindavan, which had been in force since 1947 was withdrawn by the Uttar Pradesh government in December. Even before the aggression, Sarvodaya workers at Agra had undertaken satyagraha on this issue with Vinoba's permission. 'How can we counter the Chinese, who have freed themselves from opium, by getting drunk?'—wondered Vinoba.⁶

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Nonviolent resistance was clearly out of question, although a section of workers did advocate the same. Opening peace centres in the border area was contemplated in this connection.

The desire to do something was strong. The idea of *Maitri yatra* (trek from Delhi to Beijing, to create mutual goodwill and an atmosphere of peace and friendliness in the people of both the countries) came up in this context. Shankarrao Deo was the main motive force behind it. The *yatra* began on 1 March 1963 from Delhi. The participants included individuals from other countries as well. It was blessed by Bertrand Russell. During the trek, the participants preached futility of war in solving international disputes.

The *yatra* was clearly against 'war efforts'. It was expectedly criticised in the atmosphere created by nationalist hysteria. Question was asked in the Parliament why the participants had not been arrested for hindering war efforts. The Home Minister wondered how could preaching of nonviolence be stopped in Gandhiji's India?⁷

Chinese news agency branded the tour party as stooges of 'American and Indian imperialists and reactionaries'. China denied permission to enter its territory despite persistent efforts, and so did Pakistan and Myanmar. The *yatra* had to return from the border. The tour covered about 3,000 km. and was abandoned on 30 January 1964. China's stance was not unexpected. The tour did succeed in propagating the message of peace. The statement issued at the conclusion said,

“We placed our thoughts before millions in more than 200 towns and villages, emphasising, in particular, the need for friendship between peoples of different nations. We do not know how far we have succeeded, but people in India did welcome us heartily despite nationalistic passions aroused by the border conflict. They listened to us enthusiastically and responded to our message of friendship. We wholeheartedly appeal to the people all over the world to take up the task of solving the conflict between these two countries in the interest of Asia and the whole world.”⁸

Maitri yatra was a sincere effort, which evoked interest in pacifists in different countries. Vinoba, incidentally, was lukewarm about this initiative. He felt that it was not in accordance with the way nonviolence could work in the international arena, but ‘the very fact that such an idea arose is itself a matter of success.’⁹

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By the end of September 1962, the figures for bhoodan and gramdan were as under¹⁰:

Land gifted: 41,62,623 acres

(40,39,224 acres had been gifted by 5,30,344 donors)

Land distributed: 11,20,485 acres

(10,63,068 acres given to 3,13,866 families)

1.1 million acres had been found non-distributable after investigation. Number of gramdans stood at 5,079.

For Vinoba, bhoodan-gramdan was the panacea even in changed circumstances: “If any work is wrong or out-of-date, we may give it up. But I do not think that this applies to our work.”¹¹

On 15 December, Plassey, the place where the British had defeated the local ruler in 1757 and laid the foundation of their empire in India, was declared gramdan. When Pandit Nehru came to know of it, he was reminded of Milton's epics, ‘Paradise lost’ and ‘Paradise regained’. He met Vinoba at Nabagram in Murshidabad district (25 December) and had detailed discussions, particularly in the context of the Chinese aggression.

According to Shriman Narayan, there was much pressure on Nehru to discard the policy of non-alignment, and Vinoba's unequivocal support greatly bolstered his position.¹²

Vinoba was in West Bengal upto 9 August 1963, except a few days spent in Santhal Pargana and Purnea in Bihar.

A conference of khadi workers was held at Nabadwipadham on 5-6 February 1963. Vinoba forcefully pleaded for village-oriented khadi—commercial, government-aided khadi should give way to khadi for village self-sufficiency. He suggested that the rebate being given by the governments on khadi sales should be discontinued and the governments should instead arrange for free weaving, which would encourage spinning in villages for self-sufficiency in clothing. Khadi Commission accepted this in principle.

On 23 March, in his meeting at Guskura, Vinoba appealed to the traders to undertake not to charge interest on loans given by them, and not to sell adulterated goods. Twenty five traders instantly volunteered for the same. Vinoba hoped that “God willing, the idea will spread far and wide.”¹³

Sarva Seva Sangh met from 29 April to 2 May at Arambagh in Vinoba's presence, first time after three years. Vinoba dealt with the meaning and process of nonviolence in detail, in the context of *Maitri yatra*, and while doing this, gave a new dimension to the theory of satyagraha:

“Jesus said nothing more than ‘Resist not evil’. We interpreted it as ‘Resist not evil with evil’. That was Gandhiji's position too. That was okay. But in the present context, when there are ideological conflicts backed by arms, we should limit the sentence to ‘Resist not evil’ and should talk of not ‘nonviolent resistance’ but ‘nonviolent assistance in right thinking’. While rendering such assistance, one has, at times, to oppose or non-cooperate. One may take recourse to them, but it should be in the spirit of rendering assistance.”¹⁴

Some workers understandably raised questions in the meeting over the stand taken by the Sangh: Why did it not

condemn the War unequivocally? Vinoba supported the Sangh's stand and said that the very fact that India was caught unprepared showed that war was thrust on her. He also pleaded for the acceptance of Colombo proposals.

He again dwelt with the theory of satyagraha in his address on the third day of the meeting. He asserted that satyagrahas in Gandhiji's times were negative because of the circumstances, but Gandhiji did have positive concept in mind and the form of satyagraha should be different in a democracy. He was emphatic that his formulation was neither deviation from nor development of Gandhiji's concept; he was only elaborating Gandhiji's ideas and coining some new words so as to aid understanding.¹⁵

In the context of difficulties in land distribution, Vinoba opined that donors should have been entrusted with the distribution of land gifted by them; it was wrong not to trust them and lose an opportunity to strengthen relations between donors and donees.¹⁶

On 27 May, Vinoba reached Ganga-sagar, the famous pilgrimage centre where the sacred river Ganga merges into the Bay of Bengal. He was in Calcutta for about a fortnight. Naturally, he spoke extensively on Rabindranath Tagore, explaining how the thoughts of the great sage were in tune with Sarvodaya ideas. A votary of nonviolence, he condemned the practice of sacrifice of animals at the Kali temple, and invited the ire of traditionalist devotees and even that of a section of the press. He also expressed his deep anguish about the slaughter of cows, the backbone of India's rural economy, and demanded ban on cow-slaughter, insisting that it was neither at variance with Islam nor against the tenet of secularism.¹⁷

Jayaprakash, writing on the Arambagh meeting later, conceded that he also shared the discontent about the progress of the Movement, but referred to the response to Vinoba in Assam and West Bengal:

"We have been observing that wherever Baba (Vinoba) goes, there is an upsurge in the Movement. In a region like West Bengal, where nonviolence had not penetrated much even in

Gandhiji's time, quite a few villages have opted for gramdan. It is true that Baba is a saint and ordinary workers like us cannot have comparable impact, but I feel that it is not just a question of personality, his method of working is also significantly responsible for his success."¹⁸

During Bengal tour, land-gifts of 173 bighas and 287 gramdans were received.¹⁹

The Chinese aggression had aroused nationalistic fervour and clamour for enhancing military preparedness. The government had introduced compulsory savings scheme to mobilise funds for the same and had also introduced compulsory military training for the students. Sarva Seva Sangh opposed the moves. JP demanded that conscientious objectors should be free from this obligation. Vinoba concurred with the view.

After Vinoba's departure from East Pakistan, Ranjan Kumar Dutta and his wife Kavita of Noakhali ashram continued his work and received 23 land-gifts. Charuchandra Chaudhari also started bhoodan tour. However, he was arrested in November for being a threat to the security of Pakistan! He was freed only when Bangladesh was formed in 1971.

In West Bengal, Bhoodan Board was constituted and steps were initiated for enactment of gramdan law.

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The term 'Gramdan' was used in line with bhoodan, sampattidan etc. when all the land-owners in Mangaroth gifted all their lands as bhoodan. Many villages followed suit, and their lands were redistributed equitably in accordance with the family size and land quality, generally after setting aside some land for collective farming. It was left to the villagers to make minor exceptions, taking care that no one remained landless in the village.

The Movement also floated the idea of '*gram-parivar*' when the whole village was not ready for gramdan. It meant pooling of land, its collective cultivation and equitable distribution of income among participant families.

The main idea behind gramdan was to make the village an organic community and a unit of self-governance in the true sense. It implied that the people of the village should look after the village affairs and work for all-round progress of the village including economic development. It entailed participation of all in decision-making; it could no longer remain a prerogative of a few. And equal participation of all necessarily requires consensus as the process of decision-making. Village administration and development also need regular financial contribution by everyone, and so the idea of '*gram-kosh*' was put forward. The concept of gramdan thus continued to evolve gradually through inputs from the workers and deliberations in the policy-making bodies of the Movement—of course with Vinoba's consent. It also varied from state to state.

Complete redistribution did take place in many villages. It was nothing short of a miracle, brought about by Vinoba's spiritual charisma. But, as Dharendra Majumdar pointed out, it had been brought about by a saint's charisma; a social process capable of replication had not been discovered; and without such social process, the Movement could not spread far and wide.²⁰

Vinoba was fully aware of this. With Assam enacting the gramdan law and the need to put in place a suitable legal structure becoming urgent, particularly in the context of Chinese aggression, a simple scheme for gramdan for the whole country needed to be formulated, with due regard for the actual situation, but keeping intact the spirit. Vinoba, therefore, devised the scheme of '*Sulabh Gramdan*' in 1963. As he explained,

"The old gramdan was fully in tune with the society's aspirations, but not in tune with the self-interest in individuals to the same extent. I have been mulling over a way to reconcile the two"²¹.

Sulabh Gramdan demanded actual gift of only one-twentieth of land to begin with; the rest would remain with the owner—but only for cultivation; ownership rights would be surrendered to the gramsabha. The idea of ownership was thus given an opportunity to wither away gradually, while keeping intact the revolutionary principle of restoring control over land

to the village community. The salient features of Sulabh gramdan were as under:

1) At least 75% landowners in the village should surrender ownership over all their lands to the village community, i.e., the gramsabha.

2) The land, ownership over which has been so surrendered, should at least be 51% of the village land.

3) At least 75% villagers should give consent to gramdan.

4) 5% of the land of every landowner who has surrendered his land should be distributed to the landless in the village.

5) The rest 95% land will remain with the ex-owner, and he as well as his descendants will be able to cultivate it and enjoy the fruits of their labour, but they will not be entitled to sell it except to a resident of the village, and that too with the permission of the gramsabha.

6) All cultivators will regularly give 2.5% of the produce and non-cultivators will give one-thirtieth of their monthly income to the gramsabha to form a gram-kosh to be spent for village service, administration and development.

7) The gramsabha, constituting of all the adult villagers, will look after the village affairs and social security, plan for the village development and execute the plans. It will normally take decisions by consensus. It will have all the rights necessary for discharging its duties.

Vinoba rejected the contention that it was a step backwards. He averred that it would set in a process that would culminate in dissolution of property; moreover, a process capable of spreading widely was more in tune with the revolutionary spirit, rather than one that would remain confined to a few only.

Sulabh Gramdan was also, for him, a reply to the ideological aggression of Communism, even while learning from the experience of the Communists:

“Taking everything into consideration, it appears to me that in Sulabh Gramdan benefit has been derived from the

lessons of the failed experiments in communal ownership carried out by the Communists. We have accepted the middle way—ownership should be communal even while preserving motivation for the individual. Sulabh Gramdan thus encompasses experiences of the Communists.”²²

The initial idea, that the successors of donor should not have right over the gifted land, was also abandoned. Being against a well-settled tradition, it would not have been palatable to a large section. Concessions were made on the background of practical difficulties, but Vinoba refused to abandon the revolutionary principle of dissolution of private property in land. He was insistent about the abolition of the right to sell the land, terming it ‘an injustice’ and ‘a sin’. He explained that landownership consists of three aspects: right to cultivate, right to pass on the property to the successor and right to sell; the first two had been kept untouched in Sulabh Gramdan, and abrogation of the third was in the true interest of the peasant—it would ensure that he would not lose land, the source of livelihood for him and his descendants, in adverse circumstances: “Selling land in difficulties is like burning blanket (in cold weather to get warmth).”²³ Having control of the community over land, the basic natural resource, was an essential prerequisite for village self-sufficiency, and consequently, autonomy. That was why it was held that those owning land in the village but living outside should also surrender landownership to the gramsabha and become a part of the gramdan family. As ownership of lands in many villages had passed on to outsiders in the course of time, gramdan would have been meaningless without participation of such owners.

Eradication of landlessness was also a goal. When people in a village in Odisha found that giving 5% land would not be sufficient for this purpose, they volunteered to give 10% land.²⁴ Gramdan was not thus a merely economic programme; it was a morally-elevating phenomenon.

With the advent of Sulabh Gramdan, the Movement expectedly gained momentum. The prefix ‘Sulabh’ was eventually dropped.

Planning Commission had constituted a working group constituting of representatives of the Sangh and the concerned Central ministries in December 1958 to suggest a legal framework for gramdan. After the advent of Sulabh Gramdan, Planning Commission organised a conference on 2-3 November 1963 to consider matters related to gramdan. It was presided over by Shriman Narayan, Member (Agriculture) of the Commission. Representatives of concerned Central ministries and state governments participated in it. Jayaprakash was a special invitee to the conference. Important suggestions made at the conference included, inter alia,

(i) Gramdan laws should be enacted wherever they were yet to be made, or provision for gramdan be made in Bhoodan Acts.

(ii) The state governments should expedite verification and declaration of gramdan villages.

(iii) Special attention should be given to the formation of co-operative joint farming societies in gramdan villages.

(iv) While implementing Plan schemes, preference should be given to gramdan villages.

(v) The government should financially help Sarva Seva Sangh for training workers.

(vi) Government lands in gramdan villages should be handed over to their gramsabhas.

(vii) Panchyat Raj institutions should take active interest in the promotion and development of the gramdan movement.

(viii) Credit needs of the gramdan villages should be adequately taken care of.

(ix) The suggestion about formation of a Board or a Commission at the national level should be examined.²⁵

The Commission drafted and sent a Model Gramdan Bill to the state governments on 10 June 1964 'for adoption with suitable modifications with reference to local laws and tenures and in response to local conditions and needs.'²⁶ Acts were later passed in most of the states on the basis of this model bill.

However, the suggestion that gramdan could be included in bhoodan laws, which was followed in some states, defeated the very purpose of village self-governance.

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The government, enamoured by and keen on modern industrialisation, was happily accelerating the process of killing village industries, started in the colonial era. Promoting powerlooms at the cost of handlooms was not the only instance. In Uttar Pradesh, production of jaggery (*gur*) was banned in areas in the vicinity of sugar mills; and that too under Defence of India Rules! Sarvodaya workers opposed this absurd and outrageous diktat and went to jail. Vinoba vented his strong feelings at the Raipur Conference (December 1963):

“It cannot be the intention of Defence of India Rules to snatch away employment from the people or attack their individual freedom. This is not ‘defence of India’; it is rather an ‘offence against India’. It is completely against India’s tradition. If employment of the last man is snatched away, there cannot be peace in the land.”²⁷

In his meeting (on 8 February 1964) with Swaran Singh, the Central Food Minister, he criticised this misuse of Defence of India Rules and also called for revocation of emergency clamped in the wake of the Chinese aggression.²⁸

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The Sarvodaya Samaj Conference was held at Raipur from 27 to 29 December 1963. It was inaugurated by Amalprabha Das and presided over by Jugatram Dave. Vinoba, present in the Sarvodaya Conference after a gap of four years, proposed the three-fold programme—gramdan, Shanti-Sena and village-oriented khadi. The ‘simplification’ of gramdan had provided an opportunity for its spread, relevance of Shanti-Sena was obvious in the background of unrest in the country, and the free weaving scheme was likely to give a boost to the reorientation of khadi. The programme was heartily welcomed and adopted by the congregation.

Sarva Seva Sangh expressed its determination to take

ahead the movement towards gram-swaraj through the three-fold programme and opined that 'laying the foundation of gram-swaraj in every village in India by 1969, the birth centenary year of Gandhiji, will be a fitting tribute to his memory'.²⁹

In Vinoba's view, the three-fold programme was a nonviolent programme for defence, which would make the army redundant:

"Khadi, gramdan and Shanti-Sena together constitute a programme for nonviolent defence of the country. It would, in due course, make redundant the army, as it would no longer be needed.

Jesus had said, 'I am not come to destroy but to fulfil.' - -
- Spirituality will not destroy religion; it will take religion to fulfilment. I too think in the language of Jesus—We are not out to destroy nationalism; we are here to take it to its fulfilment. Gramdan is fulfilment."³⁰

From Raipur, Vinoba took the route to Sevagram and entered Maharashtra on 3 March 1964 where a crowd of 20,000 people along with Chief Minister Vasantrya Naik welcomed him. His public meeting at Nagpur was attended by nearly 1,00,000 people. Evidently, Vinoba and his message still retained some appeal even to the urban masses.

Persecution of Hindus in East Pakistan ignited communal riots at Rourkela in Odisha, followed by Jamshedpur in March. Shanti-sainiks rushed to bring peace and relief. Jayaprakash vociferously attacked communal tendencies, calling the riots as a blot on Hinduism, while at the same time calling Muslims to integrate themselves in the national social and political life and reconsider cow-slaughter.³¹ Vinoba too condemned attacks on the minority community as 'shameful' and 'threat to our freedom'.³²

By March 1964, Bhoodan totalled 42,27,476 acres, out of which 10,70,166 acres had been distributed. The number of gramdans stood at 6,807.³³

	<i>Bhoodan</i> (acres)	<i>Distribution</i>	<i>Undistributable</i> <i>land</i>	<i>Gramdans</i>
1. Assam	11,935	265	-	966
2. Andhra	2,41,952	1,02,033	81,224	651
3. U.P.	4,34,351	2,07,590	25,823	56
4. Odisha	1,57,460	51,102	11,221	2,405
5. Kerala	26,293	5,774	7,999	559
6. Tamil Nadu	80,433	21,519	-	254
7. Delhi	300	180	120	1
8. Punjab	14,739	3,601	3,380	6
9. Gujarat	1,03,530	50,984	27,994	164
10. Maharashtra	1,50,394	1,02,212	34,797	790
11. M.P.	4,04,662	1,39,988	1,46,087	191
12. Karnataka	20,086	3,123	53	58
13. W. Bengal	12,887	3,825	8,426	347
14. Bihar	21,32,772	2,77,660	10,46,332	121
15. Rajasthan	4,30,437	97,774	91,374	234
16. H.P.	5,240	2,531	-	4
17. J.&K.	5	5	-	
Total	42,27,476	10,70,166	14,84,830	6,807
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Sheikh Abdullah was released in April after incarceration for nearly 11 years. In a letter to Nehru in October 1962, Vinoba had suggested that Abdullah's release would help efforts towards unity.³⁴ Abdullah met Vinoba on 3 May. Jayaprakash was also present at the meeting. His advocacy of the right of self-determination for Kashmir and the need to talk to the Sheikh to find solution of the Kashmir problem drew ire of the people.

Khadi Commission started free weaving scheme on 6 April.

On the occasion, Vinoba's message was broadcast over All India Radio. The scheme had the potential of reorienting khadi. Discarding market-orientation, it sought to promote self-sufficiency in clothing for individuals and village communities. However, it had a short life of about five years only. In 1969, the scheme was discontinued and the rebate on sales was re-introduced.

In May, Pandit Nehru died, signalling end of an era in the life of Independent India. Vinoba had warm relations with him. Shriman Narayan used to act as a link between the two. After Nehru, Lal Bahadur Shastri, who had association with the Bhoodan Movement, became the Premier. When someone enquired who would be the link between Vinoba and the new Prime Minister, Vinoba commented that there was no need for a link, as Shastri was their own man! When this was reported to Shastri, he was deeply touched.³⁵

Vinoba reached Pavnar on 10 April and continued his trek in the neighbouring area. Shastri, who wanted to meet Vinoba as early as possible after becoming Prime Minister, met him at Jamni, a small village near Wardha on 16 June. However, Vinoba could not continue his trek for long. Vertigo forced him to retire to Pavnar ashram in November. Vinoba, a man of God, considered it as a signal from the Almighty. Now Pavnar, a small village in Central India was going to be his abode to the last.

Sarva Seva Sangh met at Waigai in November 1964. Issues relevant to the advancement of gramdan were discussed. Jayaprakash urged close relations with the Panchayat institutions to obtain their co-operation in the work of bhoodan, land distribution, gramdan and post-gramdan developmental work. As the leader of Panchayat Parishad, Jayaprakash was trying his best in this regard. However, given the character of these bodies, based as they were (and are) on elections, expecting much from them was bound to be futile.

In Tamil Nadu, satyagraha for land was being advocated by some workers since long. Jayaprakash, inaugurating the state gramdan conference at Batlagundu, lent his voice for the cause. Asserting that if non-residents did not gift land, it was 'an

injustice' and if all other attempts failed, satyagraha would become inevitable.³⁶

Jayaprakash visited Pakistan in September as a part of a goodwill mission, and had a meeting with President Ayub Khan.

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Nagaland in the North-East had been in turmoil since the dawn of Independence. Nagas had remained distant from the rest of the country, politically and psychologically. Therefore, they demanded freedom on the eve of India's Independence. A Naga delegation met Gandhiji in July 1947. Gandhiji upheld their demand, but also explained to them the true meaning of freedom.

The issue demanded sensitive handling. Efforts were needed to integrate Nagas in India, not only politically but also psychologically. Granting of autonomy in tune with their tradition was sine quo non for this purpose. Unfortunately, Indian political establishment, and the civil society as well, did little in this connection. Nagas embarked upon an armed struggle in 1954-55. The government tried to suppress it with armed forces. But that was no real answer to the situation. So, the government also opened dialogue with the moderate elements among Naga insurgents and granted separate statehood to Nagaland. But the struggle continued.

While in Assam, Vinoba wanted to go to Nagaland. But the government insisted on providing armed security, which he rejected. The government had no objection if the insurgents invited him. Phizo, leader of the insurgents, was contacted, but he was non-committal. So, Vinoba dropped the idea.

To bring peace to the troubled land of the Nagas, the Baptist Church took initiative and organised a conference in January 1964, which sought to involve Sarvodaya leaders Shankarrao Deo and Jayaprakash Narayan in the peace process along with Rev. Michael Scott and B.P. Chaliha, Chief Minister of Assam. Nagaland Assembly welcomed this initiative; and Peace Mission was established in April 1964 with the approval of the Government of India.

Efforts of the Peace Mission bore fruit, and ceasefire was declared in September 1964. Talks were initiated between the government and the insurgents. The efforts received backing of the powerful Church. However, chauvinistic elements could not appreciate them. The nation as a whole could not demonstrate the imagination, large-heartedness and patience that the situation called for. Jayaprakash quit the Peace Mission in February 1966. The North-East is still in turmoil.

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The year 1965 began with the agitation in Tamil Nadu over the language issue. The Constitution had accepted Hindi as the official language, but had provided for the use of English also till 1965; thereafter Hindi was to be the sole language for inter-governmental communications. However, this was resented in the South. Efforts to increase the use of Hindi were looked upon as 'imposition' of Hindi. As the stipulated period drew to a close, opposition intensified. Rajaji and D.M.K., the Dravidian party, demanded amendment to the Constitution to make English the official language. D.M.K. spearheaded the agitation, which turned violent. Firing was resorted to at several places. Army, too, had to be called in. Two ministers quit the Central Council of Ministers. Deeply pained, Vinoba announced indefinite fast from 12 February:

"Hindi was not being imposed, nor was English being done away with. There was no threat to provincial languages. As far as recruitment in the government was concerned, there was no change in the situation. Pandit Nehru had given promise in this respect, and he is still firm on it. English will continue as associate language as long as non-Hindi speaking people want it. There is no question of imposition of anything. Yet a violent agitation has ensued. I am deeply pained by the violence, and my inner voice has prompted me to undertake an indefinite fast. It will continue till the peace of my mind is restored or as long as God wishes."³⁷

He also called upon Hindi-speaking people to learn a language of the South.

For resolution of the problem, what was necessary was to

find the middle ground between vociferous advocacy of Hindi and English. So, Vinoba proposed a three-point formula:

- (1) Violence should be abjured,
- (2) Hindi should not be forced on those who were in favour of English, and
- (3) English should not be forced on those who were in favour of Hindi.

As he said, Rajaji's insistence on English as well as Lohia's insistence on Hindi, both were extreme stands; what was necessary was to find a middle way.

Bhaktavatsalam, Chief Minister of Madras state wired his concurrence of this formula and appealed to Vinoba to end the fast. Gulzarilal Nanda, Central Home Minister, reached Pavnar on 14 February. Therefrom he contacted the concerned Chief Ministers and obtained their consent for Vinoba's formula.

The violence eventually subsided and situation returned to near-normalcy. The Central ministers took back their resignations. Consensus had been reached on Vinoba's formula. In view of this, Vinoba broke his fast on 17 February. His penance for national and social integration had borne fruit.

16. Toofan: Declaration of the Last Battle

Vinoba settled at Pavnar and confined himself to the boundaries of his ashram. But the Movement continued.

He was scheduled to tour Chandrapur (Chanda) district; R.K. Patil undertook this tour from 11 December 1964 to 29 January 1965, during which 70 gramdans were declared, including that of Savali, a big village with population of 5,500. Patil's tour of Bhandara district from 18 March to 18 April yielded 400 gramdans. In Monghyr (Munger), 12 gramdans were declared during a walking tour, although the workers had not hoped for any—they had not even taken with them the forms of gramdan pledges. For Vinoba, there was, therefore, no cause of dejection—not results, but lack of adequate efforts was a matter of worry for him.

Bhoodan laws had been enacted in most of the states: Uttar Pradesh (1952), Odisha, C.P. and Berar and Saurashtra (1953), Rajasthan, Himachal Pradesh and Bihar (1954), Madhya Bharat, Vindhya Pradesh, Punjab, Delhi (1955), Madras (Tamil Nadu) (1958), West Bengal (1962) and Mysore (Karnataka) (1963). Kerala had made Bhoodan Assignment Rules under its Land Assignment Act in 1962. A circular had been issued in the erstwhile Bombay state (comprising of Eastern Gujarat and Western Maharashtra) in 1955 to legalise the land-gifts received by the Bhoodan Committee and the land distribution done by it. Gramdan Acts had been passed in Rajasthan (1960) and Assam (1962). Tamil Nadu had made provision for gramdan in its Bhoodan Act. Maharashtra enacted Gramdan law in 1964. It is interesting to note that Gujarat, a stronghold of Gandhian constructive work, which had been ruled by professed Gandhians, had neither Bhoodan nor Gramdan law; provision for gramdan had been incorporated in the Panchayat Act.

Efforts were under way for post-gramdan developmental

work. In Andhra Pradesh, Kadappa District Navnirman Samiti had been formed to take care of work in the district—512 out of 595 gramdans in the state were in this district. Assam Gramswaraj Samiti had been formed for the same purpose in Assam, where an important initiative of forming regional federations of gramdan villages was being taken. In Tamil Nadu and Bihar, Gramrajya Nirman Sangh and Gramdan Gramnirman Samiti respectively had been likewise established. Dharendra Majumdar was concentrating in Baranpur (U.P.), while Annasaheb Sahasrabuddhe had undertaken an ambitious project of alternative development in Koraput (Odisha). Harivallabh Parikh had carved out a niche for himself by his work in the tribal belt of South Gujarat. In Maharashtra, intensive work was going on in the tribal area of Akrani-Akkalkua, under the stewardship of Damodardas Moondada. Developmental work in gramdan villages was receiving assistance from Gandhi Smarak Nidhi and foreign funding agencies like War on Want. Not only developmental work, but work towards self-governance was also under way at several places.

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Sarva Seva Sangh met at Wardha in May 1965. The number of gramdans by this time stood at 7,219.¹ Vinoba suddenly threw a challenge at the workers in Bihar that if they were ready to obtain 10,000 gramdans within six months, he was ready to come to Bihar. The word he used was '*Toofan*' (typhoon). It created a sensation. The supreme leader was again making a bid to revive the fortunes of his movement. Bihar workers could not say no, although the condition of the organisation there was far from satisfactory.

For Vinoba, this was to be his last fight—the last and the best. For 14 years, he had done his best to rouse the people's power and create a revolutionary movement. It was noticeably on the wane now, while the conditions in the country were deteriorating at an alarming pace. Divisive politics and bureaucracy were spreading their tentacles in rural India, adding to its misery, and Communism was trying to take advantage of the brewing discontent. The situation demanded more concerted

efforts. On the last day of the Wardha meeting, Vinoba exhorted the workers:

“Time is moving at a great pace. You have hardly four or five years to demonstrate the truth in the ideology of gramdan-gramswaraj. Otherwise, this ideology would be consigned to cold-storage. The ideology is good, but it would be of no use to the country if it lies in cold-storage. But this ideology has the potential to save India and the world. It has great potency.”²

Sulabh Gramdan had presented an opportunity to make the thought of gramdan palatable to the people. Efforts were needed in this direction; and they had necessarily to be concentrated in a particular area in order to gain something worthwhile. Choice of Bihar, where bhoodan had phenomenal success and the Sarvodaya ideology had penetrated the countryside, was natural.

Sarvodaya had presented a blueprint for an alternative; it was necessary to obtain people’s consent for that and mobilise them to work in that direction. The Toofan was essentially for achieving this—for obtaining rapidly as many gramdans as possible by getting fulfilled the conditions for gramdan, which were expected to be incorporated in the impending law. Sarva Seva Sangh warned its workers that fulfilment of conditions must be ensured before declaration of gramdans; otherwise, the Movement’s stature would be adversely affected.³ Vinoba also cautioned that although work was to be done speedily, specified procedure should be scrupulously followed.⁴ However, the work of getting the conditions fulfilled was eventually postponed and the campaign became, in the words of Kanti Shah, ‘a sort of referendum or signature campaign’⁵—a campaign of obtaining people’s signatures (or thumb impressions of the illiterate people) on ‘Gramdan *sankalp-patras*’ (pledge letters showing readiness to adopt gramdan)—a sort of letters of intent.

Bihar workers began the work in earnest. A committee was constituted under the chairmanship of Jayaprakash. Organisations for khadi and other constructive programmes joined in. Political parties followed suit. It was decided to invite Vinoba to come on 11 September (his birthday) and greet him

with 1,000 gramdans and a purse of Rs. 1,00,000. A reception committee with Chief Minister Krishnavallabh Sahay as chairman was also formed.

Vinoba toured Vidarbha region in Maharashtra from 9 July to 23 August by vehicle; the tour yielded 242 gramdans. The call for *Toofan* was creating a wave of enthusiasm throughout the country. He set out for Bihar from Wardha on 23 August. Bidding adieu to the ashram inmates at Pavnar, he recalled Gandhi's mission in 1947. He was ready for the ultimate sacrifice. On 24 August, addressing a public meeting at Nagpur, he said,

"People of India are beginning to feel that those at Delhi cannot do any good to the villages. Everyone including the government, the planners, the ruling party and the opposition parties is clueless about what should be done for the solution of national problems. For Sarvodaya workers, a psychological moment to give momentum to the gramdan movement has, therefore, come, as Sulabh Gramdan has opened a way to establish self-rule in the villages. Such opportunities call for swift action. We should, therefore, strive to take the number of gramdans to hundreds of thousands. Through this we have to change the whole complexion of the government."⁶

En route to Bihar, Vinoba passed through Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh. On 10 September, he boarded a train to Patna from Mugal Sarai. Incidentally, name of the train was 'Toofan Express'! It was his first train journey after 1950.

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On 11 September, Vinoba was accorded a warm reception at Patna station by thousands of people, including the Chief Minister of the state. The public meeting in the evening saw a big gathering despite rains. The Chief Minister presented to him a purse of Rs. 1,47,501. Jayaprakash presented to him 779 gramdans from Bihar, while Manmohan Chaudhari presented to him 896 gramdans from the rest of the country, declared after the last meeting of Sarva Seva Sangh. The number of gramdans in the country stood at 8,994 by this time.⁷ Vinoba expressed

the hope that Bihar would witness manifestation of a new power, and if other states could follow Bihar in making similar resolves, the country would witness a great revolution. He ended his talk with the appeal: "I have come to harvest and not to sow. That work has to be done by the workers."⁸

The *Toofan-yatra* was done by car. The tour party normally had 25-30 persons and average daily travel was 80 to 100 km.

While *Toofan* was being initiated, war between India and Pakistan began. Vinoba opined that the war had been thrust on India.⁹

At Munger (Monghyr) (15 September), he made an appeal to fight three enemies: starvation, communalism and violent communism. At Khadagpur Haveli (16 September), he referred to Planning Commission's admission of inability to eradicate poverty and asked the people to take up gramdan work for the purpose. At Lakhisarai (19 September), he suggested in a local educational institute that the teachers there should release one amongst them for gramdan campaign and bear the burden of his salary. Later, he was to repeat this suggestion at several places. He was in a hurry and was soliciting workers from every available quarter. He was telling Block Development Officers (B.D.O.s) and Sub-Divisional Officers (S.D.O.s) in the bureaucracy that they should consider themselves Bhoodan Development Officers and Sarvodaya Development Officers respectively! In every speech and in every interaction with workers, he was trying to impress upon them the urgency.

The state government did not wait for the Assembly session, which was due after 3 months, to pass the Gramdan Act; it promulgated an ordinance in September. A.S. Iyengar, Governor of the state met Vinoba at Ranchi (30 September) and informed him about the same.

The tour of Gaya district resulted in 310 gramdans, while 191 gramdans were declared in Santhal Pargana.

At Forbesganj (25 October) on the Indo-Nepal border, he pointed out that gramdan was the only measure to check

smuggling across the boundary: "Gramsabha in a gramdan village can put a break on such undesirable things through control on import and export of goods."¹⁰

Vinoba's sense of urgency was increasing day-by-day. At Supaul (30 October), for example, he said:

"If you do not feel strongly about it and do not work speedily, then it would not matter whether this work gets done or not. Even if there is a death in the house, a farmer will not miss sowing. He will first complete sowing and thereafter carry out the funeral. That is how farming is done. Similarly, if gramdan work is not done in time, situation will be out of control and whatever has been achieved will be in vain. Forces of violence will gain ascendance. That is why I am so terribly keen, and trying to impress on others the need for urgency. - - -

"The government cannot free you from exploitation. You yourselves have to achieve that freedom. There is no alternative to the nonviolent programme of gramdan for this purpose. Otherwise, there will be revolt. A bloody revolution will take place, if God so wills. That would distress me, but not as much as the status quo. The exploitation of the last man, the violence being done to him is beyond endurance."¹¹

Food scarcity was haunting the country because of famine in several states. Stoppage of U.S. aid because of Indo-Pakistan war worsened the situation. Prime Minister Shastri gave the slogan '*Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan*' (victory to the soldier, victory to the peasant). Vinoba welcomed it, but castigated the government for being unmindful of the peasant for all these years:

"They were pursuing industrialisation at the cost of the peasant; and now they have realised his importance because United States has put the screws on! Big dams and big factories were built, but wells were not dug. Had wells been dug, one for every ten acres, there would have been adequate food for all."¹²

For him, permanent solution of the food problem lay in gramdan.

As the number of gramdans began to rise, Vinoba started talking of *prakhand-dans* (acceptance of gramdans by majority of villages in a block—a division of the district, created for developmental work) and *zilla-dans* (acceptance of gramdans by majority of villages in a district): only then gramdan could effectively influence socio-political life in the respective areas.

“Government’s plans cover the whole block. If 20 villages have adopted gramdans and 40 villages have not, there would be a clash. If you bring the whole block in gramdan, you can then tell the government to abandon their plan and draft new plan on the basis of gramdan.”¹³

Henceforth he was going to lay stress on prakhand-dan.

He was clear in his mind that it was not the responsibility of Sarvodaya workers to undertake developmental work, but several workers thought otherwise. He had to emphasise the point time and again.

“We can give training, but the responsibility of developmental work in the village will be that of the gramsabha—of the people in the village. We appear to be influenced by the idea that some villages should be made model ones through intensive work. But such villages cannot be called ‘model’ as there is much more investment in terms of workers and resources in such villages. They cannot be emulated by others.”¹⁴

His public meeting at Samastipur (5 November) was perhaps the biggest one during this tour so far in terms of attendance—around 50,000. Gramdan had caught the people’s attention.

At Jaynagar (8 November) Vinoba called for creation of a Sarvodaya republic through gramdan in every village, ultimately making India ‘United States of Sarvodaya Republics’ (U.S.S.R.—on the lines of United States of Soviet Republics).¹⁵

At Jaynagar, 41 gramdans were presented to Vinoba, but they were of hamlets of the landless or marginal farmers. This agitated Gaurishankar Singh, Chairman of the Bhoodan-Yagna Committee, as he felt that they would not stand the statutory

scrutiny. But Vinoba defended such gramdans too: "Gramdan is like an ocean. Rivers will come to it and so will little streams." He assured the Chairman, 'If there is success, it will be Bihar's; if there is failure, it will be mine.'¹⁶ The commander was ready to take risks in his last battle.

Within one month, the number of gramdans had touched 11,366. Sarva Seva Sangh called for creation of *Toofan* in other states also.

In Pupri (14 November), Vinoba said, "Divine Will and the Time Spirit, both are favourable to gramdan. Society is partly favourable, and the individual is in dilemma."¹⁷ The challenge was to pull the individual out of the dilemma and convince him about the necessity of gramdan. That was why Vinoba was making impassioned pleas for 'total effort'.

Fourth general elections in the country were around the corner. Vinoba had of course nothing to do with them: it mattered little who ruled; what was important was to get rid of the rulers. That was what gramdan sought. So, elections were, for Vinoba, nothing more than a negligible irritant 'like a fly disturbing you while you are engaged in serious study'.¹⁸

"Now there is no room for delay", he urged at Muzaffarpur (15 November).

"It is said that justice delayed is justice denied. I say in like manner, gram-swaraj delayed is gram-swaraj denied. That is why I am in a hurry. You cannot say what turn the situation will take. You have military regimes around you. You have strengthened the army to defend you from aggression. But if the army itself commits aggression, who will then defend you from it?"¹⁹

He had staked his all. As he himself described picturesquely, 'the candle was burning at both ends'.²⁰

He had little hope from the so-called democratic decentralisation being promoted by the government. For him, it was un-Indian—against the ethos of India. Electoral politics had vitiated Panchayat Raj institutions, adding to the conflicts. They had, so to say, 'nationalised malice'!²¹

He was sparing no one, sharply criticising government's policies. At Tehri-on-sona, he demanded that the government should be impeached, just as Warren Hastings was in England, as it had signally failed on three vital fronts: food self-sufficiency, education and defence; and also for neglecting the lowest strata of the society. "But as people have elected the government, the responsibility is ultimately theirs."²² He had never shied away from attacking the government; his vociferousness had been second to none. It is strange on this background to find critics accusing him of being soft to the government!

His will power was not allowing him to rest, but the body was nearing its capacity of endurance. Recurrence of the old complaint of fissures compelled him to stay for three months from 19 December at Jamshedpur. People continued to throng his halting place. It was here that Prime Minister Shastri came to meet him. "The work Vinobaji is doing—that of shaping public opinion and arousing confidence in the people—is what really matters", he said.²³ J.R.D. Tata also called on him.

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Linguistic reorganisation of states had been done, but demand for Punjabi Sooba—a separate state of Punjabi-speaking people—had been ignored. Sant Fateh Singh went on fast on this issue. Vinoba supported the demand.

In Tamil Nadu, lands owned by outsiders in villages were presenting problems in gramdan work. It was being demanded that such lands be given to gramsabhas on contract for cultivation. Vinoba had already given consent for satyagraha on this issue. Workers in Tamil Nadu chalked out a programme to march to Madurai in thousands to get the lands belonging to Meenakshi temple for cultivation. Jagannathan fasted for seven days. Temple authorities gave some land. Satyagraha was organised at Vilampatti as well on the issue; it was discontinued on receiving assurance in this regard from Chief Minister Bhaktavatsalam.

In Mysore (Karnataka), relaxation in prohibition was

opposed by Sarvodaya workers. Timappa Nayak fasted for 14 days in November.

Another noteworthy event in the year was the conferment of the prestigious Ramon Magasaysay award to Jayaprakash.

Sheikh Abdullah returned to India in May, and was again detained. Jayaprakash and Vinoba expressed their disapproval of the action. At the instance of Jayaprakash, Radhakrishna and Narayan Desai met Abdullah and had long talks with him. The government was duly apprised of the talks.

Indo-Pak War ended in September. It was followed by Tashkent talks in January 1966. Prime Minister Shastri met with tragic death at Tashkent. Indira Gandhi became Prime Minister. Sarvodaya's relations with the highest echelon of power continued to remain cordial.

Soon after coming to power, Indira disbanded the Ministry of Community Development and merged it in the Ministry of Agriculture. Community Development, started with much fanfare, thus met with a silent death.

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Vinoba stayed at Jamshedpur till 15 March 1966. Then he moved to Ranipatra where he stayed from 22 March to 30 June. Condition of his health had obviously limited his movements. Thereafter he had long stays at Poosa Road (18 July to 13 November), Muzaffarpur (14 November to 2 December) and Madhubani (4 December to 18 February 1967). His temporary halting places became centres of learning marked by in-depth and enlightening discussions on different matters. Every day, progress in the field was telegraphically advised to him. He often visited other places for addressing meetings there.

Sarvodaya Conference was held at Balia on 15-16-17 April 1966 after a gap of three years. Vinoba was absent. The Conference was presided over by Jagannathan. Target of 50,000 gramdans and 100 prakhand-dans by the end of 1966 was fixed. Prakhand-dan was defined as gramdan of at least 85% revenue villages in the block and consent by at least 75% people in the

block.²⁴ Sarva Seva Sangh meeting was also held. Dharendra Majumdar impressed upon the workers the need to keep contact with gramdan villages to implant radical values there:

“We have been saying that our job is to secure gramdans, not the subsequent developmental work. This is true. It is the duty of the society. But we are also a part of the society, and therefore, have a share in this responsibility. Secondly, it is also our duty to show way to the gramdan villages. We have to create in them commitment to revolutionary change. We are not doing this. We have to keep visiting the gramdan villages for the purpose.”²⁵

Not only regular contact, but continuous engagement with the gramdan villages was essential. But that had been kept on the back burner for the time being.

General elections were imminent. What Vinoba aimed at was to create a new force before the impending elections through gramdan to have decisive influence on the power structure. He knew the importance of political intervention. What he was seeking was to change the nature of polity and politics. Therefore, thinking about issues like fairness of elections and authenticity of electoral rolls was, for him, waste of intellectual energy.²⁶ However, few could understand his political acumen.

Many in Sarva Seva Sangh, his vehicle for the Movement, had different ideas. Ramamoorti's comment at the Balia meeting that “we have to think whether we should be guided by divine wisdom or collective wisdom”²⁷ was clearly an oblique quip that revealed doubts about Vinoba's line. Many of the Sangh leaders had political background, and that past did continue to visit them from time to time. So, after the announcement of every election, the Sangh's role during the elections would become a matter of debate. This time was no exception. The Sangh, while reiterating that Sarvodaya workers should refrain from taking active part in elections, called for, inter alia, formation of voters' councils in blocks that had come under gramdan. But some leaders wanted to go further. While Nabakrishna Chaudhari, ex-Chief Minister of Odisha, supported anti-Congress parties,

Jayaprakash openly blessed the proposed unity of the opposition parties and said that it would be good for democracy if Congress lost in some states, as it needed shock treatment.²⁸

Bhoodan-Gramdan Act was passed in Andhra Pradesh in 1965, came into operation in May 1966. Prabhakar and U. Keshav Rao were appointed Chairman and Vice-Chairman of the Board constituted under the Act.

Bihar Khadi Gramodyog Sangh resolved to spare one worker in every six workers for gramdan work. It made available 400 workers. But were all of them committed to gramdan? They would work for gramdan because they had been directed by their employers.

Prakhand-dan became reality for the first time in Pratappur (28 May)—221 villages out of 254 in the block embraced gramdan. Many blocks followed suit, not only in Bihar but also in other states.

The number of gramdans and prakhand-dans was rising. Prakhand-dans were being declared in other states like Maharashtra, Odisha and Tamil Nadu. Workers' ranks were swelling, but what of the quality of work? "We have failed to take the village with us because we are in a hurry. - - - Instead of bringing big villages in gramdan, we are turning to tiny hamlets (for inflating figures). Our haste has made us bargain for spurious goods", said Ramamoorti at Ranipatra conference (4-5 June) of gramdan workers. Introspection at the conference revealed chinks in the armor. It was pointed out that people from all the strata did not have a comprehensive view of the Movement, and also that necessary paperwork had not been completed before declarations of gramdan. Committed new leadership was not rising in gramdan villages. Shortcomings in *sankalp-patras* (pledge letters) were also coming to notice. People's power, which Sarvodaya talked about, was hardly evident anywhere.²⁹

Vinoba advised workers to work with renewed vigour without getting confused by the leaders' statements: "Spend one year in this work, and review thereafter the gains and identify

deficiencies.”³⁰ Clearly, even while figures were dramatically increasing, things were slipping out of control.

On 7 June, Vinoba made the declaration of ‘*sookshma-pravesh*’—retirement into the deeper recesses of Self. It was to be a limited withdrawal from external activities, although not from action in the true sense. It was rather to develop subtler, hidden forms of spiritual action.

“Whatever outward visible service could be done in the last 50 years has been laid at the feet of the Lord. Now I have received an inward call to reduce outward visible action as far as possible and enter the realm of what I call “*sookshma karmayoga*”—a deeper inward path of action. I believe that a lot of work can be done in this way. - - - We give less importance to reflection than speech, and give even higher importance to action. But I say that action is the least important, speech is more important than it and reflection is still more important. And that stage is the highest where even words do not remain necessary and the state of mind is sufficient in itself to bring about results.”³¹

That was Vinoba’s innate disposition. He was essentially a man of God; his one and only aspiration was to unite with the Supreme. Only he could take such a momentous decision at such a critical juncture in the Movement. It underlined his greatness and detachment. But was this decision appropriate in the interest of the Movement he had initiated and led all along? Was it an inevitable step in his spiritual journey or was he withdrawing because he had discerned the stagnation that lay ahead and hence was contemplating, at least for himself, a phase of ‘inactive, reflective penance’?³²

17. Campaign for Bihar-dan

Prakhand-dans had started in full swing. Prakhand-dan had the potential to impact politics and economy in a manageable area, neither too big nor too small. And the impact was likely to be greater, if such areas were in the neighbourhood of each other. Vinoba was, therefore, calling for *akhand-dan*—bringing blocks adjacent to each other in gramdan. He had told the workers on stepping into Bihar,

“If there are gramdans in hundreds, that will pose a problem. If they are in thousands, the problem will be lesser; and if they are in lakhs, the difficulties will altogether disappear. Then the blueprint of planning will get radically altered and there will also be transmutation of government. It is a revolutionary programme.”¹

Consequently, opposition from vested interests had to be anticipated, as the campaign picked up.

Prakhand-dan of Sahebpur Kamal block was a noteworthy event in July. On 6 July, Vinoba was at Bihpur and was to proceed to Poosa Road at a distance of 180 km. A halt was therefore proposed before the destination. Vinoba suggested that it be kept at Sahebpur Kamal, and asked for its prakhand-dan by the time he was to reach the place. He asked Brijmohan Sharma, a senior worker, whether it was possible. Sharma immediately said that it was. It was a task considered impossible to achieve within hardly nine days that were in hand, as the block was quite big in size and there was dearth of workers. Sharma and his colleagues, however, worked round the clock and achieved what was considered impossible. The prakhand-dan was presented to Vinoba on 16 July. Deeply moved, Vinoba lauded the exemplary efforts.²

As prakhand-dan gained momentum, Bihar-dan—gramdan of most of the villages in Bihar—became the target.

The work was progressing at breakneck speed. There was

no question of forgery, no question of fraud; signatures on the gramdan pledges were genuine—surely given not so much because of deep conviction, but more because of faith in the saint's words, insistence of workers or the pressure by respected elders in the village, or even by mundane considerations like the expectation of material benefits. Smaller villages or hamlets, feeling neglected in a hotchpotch unit named 'village' for administrative purpose, were seeing an opportunity of becoming independent villages through gramdan. Certainly it was a big positive feature of gramdan that it was giving independent status and identity to genuine communities. Whatsoever the immediate motives might be, the gramdan pledges could serve as the foundation for erecting the edifice of gram-swaraj.

But, as Ramamoorti put it, "Gramdan is still 'our' cause; it has not become their (the villages') cause."³ He pointed out that 25% people in the villages had not joined gramdan, and they were those having money, power and prestige, and so were capable of creating obstructions. That the leadership of the Movement was alive to this fact was commendable; but the fact, in itself, should not have been a cause of frustration. In a way, it was only to be expected. How could radical changes take place without a struggle against powerful vested interests? It required sustained efforts. The very fact that so many villagers were volunteering to sign on the pledge was an encouraging sight. It should have served as a springboard. That they had not understood the idea fully need not have been a cause of disheartenment. Perhaps there was as yet little disheartenment among ordinary workers. They were working vigorously.

On 13 September, addressing khadi workers, who had resolved to obtain 108 gramdans, Vinoba pointed out,

"Prakhand-dan is apparently a programme for social and economic revolution, but fundamentally, it is a programme for spiritual revolution. On what basis do you hope to obtain prakhand-dan? It is for the people to do; who are you to do it? There is a spiritual faith behind it that it is a programme to awaken the Lord residing in every heart. - - - To strengthen the faith, the programme of purification of heart must go on."⁴

Purification of heart—that was what Vinoba sought. He had once commented, “The number of gramdans obtained is the outward measure (of work); the real measure is the number of selfless workers that has been drawn towards this Movement.”⁵

On 20 September 1965, Indira Gandhi met Vinoba for the first time after becoming Prime Minister. Chief Minister Krishnavallabh Sahay apprised her of the progress of gramdan. Indira had been in touch with Vinoba and observing the course of the Movement. She had also attended Sarvodaya Conference at Ajmer (1959).

Bihar Congress President Rajendra Mishra advised Congressmen desirous of contesting elections that social work done by them would be a criterion for selecting candidates, and every aspirant should, therefore, try to obtain a couple of gramdans in his area, because “Congressmen have the greatest responsibility for the success of Gramdan Movement, as we have made it a programme of the party.”⁶

The country was witnessing unrest because of continued failure of successive governments in meeting aspirations of the people. Disenchantment with the ruling Congress party was growing. (And at the same time, Sarvodaya Movement was being associated with it in the public mind!) There were a few outbursts of student unrest in October. Vinoba told them that if they want to revolt in the true sense, they should leave colleges and devote themselves to the service of villages.

An agitation against cow-slaughter shook the country in November. Thousands of agitators led by mendicants, armed with swords and tridents, marched to the Parliament on 7 November. The march turned violent and army had to be called. Six persons died in the firing and around 500 persons were injured. Sarvodaya workers condemned the violence, but supported the cause of ban on cow-slaughter. That had been their consistent stand.

There was a terrible famine in Bihar in 1966, perhaps the worst in the last one hundred years. Thousands perished and millions were affected. Many villages were deserted. An all-party

Relief Committee was formed and Jayaprakash was prevailed upon to head the Committee. The Committee had full backing from the government. All relief work was to be done through it. It was a natural disaster, but government's commissions and omissions, particularly neglect of irrigation, were equally to blame for the prevailing situation. As Jayaprakash said,

"The land in Bihar is among the most fertile lands in the country. There are rivers like the Ganga, which bring water from the Himalayas. Groundwater is also in abundance. Therefore, such a situation should not have arisen due to lack of rain in just one year. - - - The fact is that despite repeated warnings from the nature, the issue of conservation of water resources was not seriously addressed. The planning process as a whole took a wrong turn at the outset itself. This has resulted not only in the present food crisis but also in increase in poverty and disparities."⁷

Vinoba issued an appeal for countering this crisis in every village with its united strength. He asked the workers to tell the people about gramdan while doing relief work. He was not ready to suspend gramdan work, as gramdan was the permanent remedy for such situations. Jayaprakash disagreed; he held that to talk of gramdan to hungry people was meaningless. This naturally created a chasm: some workers felt that relief should have the highest priority, while some thought that when Vinoba was fighting his last battle, dealing with temporary issues betrayed lack of foresight. An agitated Jayaprakash declared that he would not withdraw from the responsibility of relief work. Many workers concurred with Jayaprakash's view, but loyalty to Vinoba put them in a dilemma. Gaurishankar Singh, one of the seniormost workers, went to Vinoba and implored him not to put them to a severe test. Vinoba remained silent for a moment and then wrote on a paper: 'Baba (Vinoba) fully supports relief work.' The workers were relieved, and so was Jayaprakash, when this was reported to him.⁸ So, relief work continued in full swing. And as a result, gramdan work suffered.

Vinoba was little interested in the solution of transient problems: they would always be there. What was important was to empower people, so that they themselves could solve them;

their dependence on others had all along led them, and would inevitably lead them, to slavery. He would always ask workers, itching to fight against injustices at the local level, to desist from this temptation. For him, that entailed little except dissipation of energy which should be conserved for the basic work of transforming the system.

Vinoba was in favour of doing relief work through gramsabhas. That would have strengthened gramsabhas and facilitated gramdan work. But Jayaprakash preferred to route the work through the machinery of government and the khadi institutions.⁹

The famine forced Government of India to import food, and within weeks, its agricultural policies underwent a sea change. Daniel Thorner comments, "This was the moment chosen by the World Bank, the United States Department of Agriculture, the Ford Foundation and other agencies to renew their assault on India's strategy of development."¹⁰ They pushed for what came to be known as 'Green Revolution'—use of high-yielding seeds and heavy doses of chemical fertilizers and pesticides. Other economic policies also had to be changed. Devaluation of rupee was the most notable and controversial among them. Disastrous consequences of this 'Green Revolution' have now become evident. Sarvodaya thinkers showed foresight in cautioning the people in this regard.

One noteworthy incident in 1966 was the death of Pravirchandra Bhanjdev, former king of Bastar, in police firing. Bhanjdev was very popular among tribals, and his killing sent a wave of shock and indignation throughout the country, particularly Chhatisgarh. Sarvodaya worker Dadabhai Naik rushed to Jagdalpur, studied the situation and gave his report to Chief Minister D.P. Mishra. Vinoba apprised Pandit Nehru of Naik's findings. An enquiry commission was appointed.¹¹

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The *Toofan* in Bihar was motivating workers in other states as well. In Gujarat, Naswadi became the first tehsil to come under gramdan. Nanguneri tehsil in Tamil Nadu followed suit.

Prakhand-dan started in other states too. In Uttarakhand, villages at the height of 11,000 feet or more were contacted and pursued to adopt gramdan. Assam workers resolved to obtain the state-dan by Gandhi centenary year (1969).

The issue of cow-slaughter again came into focus when Niranjandev Tirtha, Shankaracharya of Puri and Prabhudatt Brahmachari began fast unto death. Vinoba supported the issue, but opined that 'fast is not a method appropriate for a Shankaracharya.'¹² He urged Shankaracharya to end his fast, but in vain. He also regretted the government's approach and appealed to it to issue an ordinance to ban cow-slaughter.¹³ Jayaprakash had requested Shankaracharya in December to give six months time to the government and promised that if no satisfactory solution was found by then, he would himself devote fully to this cause.¹⁴ In January 1967, Sarva Seva Sangh executive committee meeting at Madhubani (Bihar) passed, in Vinoba's presence, a resolution supporting ban on cow-slaughter.

The deteriorating situation in the country was fuelling discontent, particularly of the youth. They set fire to the Khadi Bhandar at Patna, burning it down and destroying khadi worth more than a million rupees. When their leaders met Vinoba on the next day, he castigated them: had they looted the khadi and distributed it to the thousands of women who could not come out of their homes for want of clothing, he would have commended them despite being in the wrong; but burning khadi was a crime!¹⁵

In most of the states, Vinoba had been authorised in Bhoodan Acts to nominate members of Bhoodan Boards/Committees. As he had done '*sookshama-pravesh*', he gave this authority to Sarva Seva Sangh.¹⁶

In February 1967, the first zilla(district)-dan was announced—that of Darbhanga (Bihar), a big district with a population of about 50 lakhs (5 millions).

Fulfilling stipulated conditions of gramdan (which had been termed '*pushti*') in villages, which had shown their readiness to

adopt gramdan, needed to be taken in hand now. After the zilla-dan of Darbhanga, Dharendra Majumdar asked Vinoba,

“If the work of *pushti* is not done with the speed with which gramdans have been obtained, we will lose a battle which we have almost won; the conditions created by our work will provide a base for the reactionary and antagonistic forces. I have seen during my tour that they are very much active. How should this work of *pushti* be organised?”

Vinoba suggested that ‘best talents’ in the Movement should come and work in Darbhanga. But that did not take place. Vinoba even said that he would start counting of gramdans after *pushti*, not after resolves.¹⁷

But *pushti* did not come on agenda. Whirlwind propaganda campaign continued almost exclusively. There were reasons. *Pushti* posed intricate problems. People had signed the pledge letters, but they had not taken them seriously. Otherwise, they themselves should have taken initiative for subsequent work. The Movement had acquainted them with an ideology capable of liberating them. They had responded to its call of declaring their resolve to adopt the path delineated by it. Now it was their responsibility, not the Movement's, to take further steps. But that was hardly anywhere in sight.

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Fourth general elections were held in February 1967. Congress received a severe beating, securing only a slender majority in the Parliament, winning 284 out of 520 seats, and losing majority in eight major states—Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Odisha, Rajasthan, West Bengal, Madras (Tamil Nadu), Punjab and Kerala. In Bihar, it got only 128 out of 328 seats. Gramdan did not have any impact on the elections. The idea of putting up candidates by clusters of villages could not materialise. An era of political instability, marked by sordid opportunism, began in India.

Vinoba did not give much importance to this upheaval. He reminded the workers,

“There is nothing revolutionary in the change in government

in a democracy. This has happened after twenty years, so it is exciting, but it is not surprising, and surely not extraordinary. But what you are doing is a work of an unprecedented revolution.”¹⁸

But, as the meeting of Sarva Seva Sangh at Shivarampalli (Andhra Pradesh) (25-27 April 1967) noted with concern, some workers actively participated in the elections. But no action against them was proposed.¹⁹ The Sangh welcomed the outcome of elections, calling the change as ‘a breath of fresh air’ and hoping that ‘the opportunity that all parties have got to prove themselves will have a healthy influence’.²⁰

In Bihar, government was formed by a motley combination of opposition parties, including parties as divergent from each other as the Communists and Jana Sangh, with some defectors from Congress. Mahamaya Prasad Sinha became the Chief Minister, who was followed after some time by Karpoori Thakur. Both had a deep respect for Vinoba and Jayaprakash. There was no change in the government’s policy about gramdan.

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On 27 November, Official Languages Amendment bill was passed in the Lok Sabha. It satisfied neither the protagonists of Hindi nor those of English. Rajaji and Kamraj opposed it. Anti-Hindi agitation again picked up. Jayaprakash supported the bill and invited the ire of people who marched on the streets of Patna, shouting that Jayaprakash was a traitor. Vinoba concurred with JP and said that there was no question of imposing Hindi on the Southern states; if it was imposed, Sarvodaya would stoutly oppose the move. He reminded the people that perhaps no one else had propagated Hindi as much as he had during his tour of India.²¹

The year 1967 also witnessed armed uprising by the extreme leftists in Naxalbari (Bengal). The terms ‘Naxalism’ and ‘Naxalites’ have since entered the lexicon. These Naxalites looked upon the Communist party (Marxist), which had come to power along with other parties in West Bengal, as traitor to the cause of revolution. Inspired by the Chinese revolution, they gave the slogan, ‘Chairman Mao is our Chairman’. Three Sarvodaya

workers toured Naxalbari in an atmosphere reeking with violence and intimidation. The state government, dominated by the Communists, asked the police to keep off the area! Jayaprakash condemned this strange order.

A high-level delegation of senior Sarvodaya workers, which included the President of Sarva Seva Sangh, toured the area and found that the land problem was at the root of the trouble.²² On the other hand, a delegation of Socialist leaders, who toured the area, opined that the agitation was not basically for land; it was a programme for political gains. They noted that leaders of the agitation were landowners, and that it was indulging in hooliganism.²³ Jayaprakash concurred with these views.²⁴ The C.P.M., which initially turned a blind eye to this ultra-left terrorism, was eventually forced to disown their perpetrators.

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The 12-year *Mahila Lok-yatra* began on 25 October. Four women workers—Hem Bharali, Lakshmi Fukan, Nirmal Ved and Devi Rizwani—began a walking tour of the whole country from Kasturbagram, Indore.

On 8-9 December, an educational conference was organised at Poosa Road in Vinoba's presence, through the efforts of the state Education Minister Karpoori Thakur. The education system was certainly one of the main reasons for the deterioration on all fronts and the consequent discontent, particularly among the students. The conference was for reconsideration of this system. Addressing the conference, Vinoba underlined the need of freeing education from the clutches of government. It had always been his considered opinion that the government should have no control over education, just as it does not have on judiciary, although it pays salaries to judges.²⁵

From Poosa Road, Vinoba came to Muzaffarpur, where the entry of police in the university campus had become a matter for concern. Vinoba said that while such entry was painful,

“The whole country is a university campus; and presence of police in it is a blot on the *acharyas*—the teaching community. *Acharyas* explain ideas to the people, transform

their ideas, change their hearts and show the way for transforming their lives. If need for the police persists in spite of the presence of such a community, it itself is a blot on the latter.”²⁶

Rains eased the famine situation, and workers could resume gramdan work with full concentration. Vinoba suggested that Bihar-dan—gramdan of majority of villages in Bihar—be achieved by 2 October 1968. Workers felt that it would not be possible and Jayprakash concurred with them. The rush for fulfilment of targets was affecting quality of work; even malpractices were creeping in. And this had become a matter for concern. In such a situation, it was feared that reduction in deadline would be inappropriate. But at Vinoba’s insistence, change in the deadline was approved.

In its meeting on 29 December, Bihar Rajya Panchayat Parishad adopted gramdan as its main programme, calling it ‘a programme to strengthen Panchayat Raj’. Bihar Rajya Sahakarita Sangh (federation of co-operatives) followed suit.

On 25 December, Tirunelveli in Tamil Nadu was declared zilla-dan. It was the second zilla-dan in the country.

John Papworth, editor of ‘Resurgence’ and a leading crusader against modernity in the West, invited Satish Kumar, at the instance of Donald Groom, to visit Europe to shed light on gramdan.²⁷ Satish Kumar went to Europe and eventually settled in England. He became the editor of ‘Resurgence’, a journal known for championing the cause of an alternative lifestyle and an alternative social order.

In December, earthquake at Koyna in Maharashtra devastated the area. Sarvodaya workers rushed for relief work.

The government removed restrictions imposed on Sheikh Abdullah on 2 January 1968. He visited Patna after a few days, and met Vinoba and Jayprakash.

On 23 January, Jayprakash announced the resolve to achieve Bihar-dan by 2 October at a mammoth rally in Patna. Chief Minister M.P. Sinha proclaimed, “Not as Chief Minister, but as an ordinary servant of the state, I declare that I will

continue to place my services at the feet of Vinoba for the sake of gramdan till I breathe my last.”²⁸ Vinoba declared that he would not leave Bihar till the achievement of goal. Activities were intensified.

On 4 February, there was an all-Party conference at Rajgir for deliberation over gramdan. Leaders of main parties except the Communists—Congress, Jana Sangh, Sanyukta Socialist Party and Bharatiya Kranti Dal—attended. Communists conveyed regret for not being able to attend. All those present expressed full support to gramdan and promised co-operation.

In Meerut on 15 to 17 February, workers resolved to work for the *rajya*(state)-*dan* of Uttar Pradesh, the biggest state in the country, by 2 October 1969, Gandhiji's birth centenary. Similar resolve was made in Tamil Nadu.

On 7 March, Vinoba announced establishment of 'Acharyakul', a fraternity of non-partisan and fearless thinkers, particularly teachers, which would deliberate over the problems of society and announce its unanimous opinions which could, and should, serve to guide the society. The organisation of Acharyakul was formally launched on the next day at Kahalgaon.

Ramamoorti told Vinoba that Gramdan Movement had now reached a point where study and research on its problems and potentialities had become imperative. Vinoba readily concurred:

“It is certainly essential. Those who are associated with villages and gramdan should undertake such study and research. A research institute on gramdan should understand the difficulties of villagers, help them in overcoming them and in propagating what is right. - - - I am not in favour of evaluation. Those who are engaged in the work of revolution have no time for evaluation and those who are not so engaged cannot do it properly.

“We forget that gramdan, in itself, is a value. People ask about increase in production, economic development, enhancement in the standard of living. All these will take

place according to the capacity of the village. But what is important is the extent of growth in the motivation behind gramdan. The institute of research on gramdan should work with this yardstick in view.”²⁹

Purnea became the third district to come under gramdan on 6 April. Gramdan campaign reached Naxalbari too, and a village named Ketugavur adoted gramdan on 27 March.

New governments in different states had started diluting the prohibition policy. Rajasthan government had earlier adopted prohibition policy, but was now taking no steps in this regard. Satyagraha was, therefore, started. It was suspended after receiving assurance from the government.

The 17th Sarvodaya Conference and Sarva Seva Sangh meeting were held at Abu road in June (from 6 to 10). The number of gramdans in the country stood at 59,772 including 22,450 from Bihar. Number of prakhand-dans in Bihar stood at 152, and that in India at 303. Zilla-dans numbered 3. Odisha too had resolved for rajya-dan. The statement issued at the end made a fervent appeal to the workers to reach every village in the country with the message of gram-swaraj by Gandhi centenary year (1969), and said that by that time, way should be paved for *‘Bharat-dan’*.³⁰

The movement, which had appeared to have stagnated three years ago, was now brimming with so much confidence that it was talking of Bharat-dan!

18. Achievement of Target

The Movement at its Zenith

The statement issued by the Abu Conference underlined the need for organised nonviolent power of the people in view of the bankruptcy of power politics and reaffirmed commitment to the three-fold programme (gramdan, Shanti-Sena and village-oriented khadi)..

Sarva Seva Sangh President noted that thousands including khadi workers, teachers, students and other citizens were working for gramdan, besides Sarvodaya workers, but they were beyond the pale of the Sarvodaya organisation. Involvement of so many people outside the periphery of the Movement was encouraging from one point of view, but was also a matter for concern. These people were certainly not thoroughly trained in the ideology as well as the working style of the Movement; and that was bound to affect the fortunes of the Movement. This was all the more disquieting for a movement which was basically founded on certain ideas, whose content and import were difficult to digest even for many of its workers and leaders.¹

Shortcomings were there; but using them for stigmatizing the Movement, instead of offering constructive criticism and contributing in remedying them, was hardly an appropriate response. But even the insiders were falling prey to such a negative attitude. The term 'bogus' was being irresponsibly used even in the Sarvodaya circle. Jayaprakash rightly retorted,

“Ask any worker of any political party about the programme of his party, ask him to explain Marxism and dialectical materialism. Will he be able to do so? Ask even big Congress leaders what is their brand of Socialism; they would not be able to explain it.”

He recounted incidents of burning of foreign clothes during the freedom struggle when such clothes were piled on papers. There were occasions when volunteers were recruited by offering

money. "Was it satyagraha?" he asked, and added that such incidents had occurred in all great movements. Goons and marauders had participated in Russian revolution. Such facts could by no means be used for judging great movements. He pointed out that 0.35 million acres bhoodan land had been distributed in Bihar, and 70-80% peasants were in possession of the allotted land. He also said,

"I asked Indradeep Sinha, the Revenue Minister in the (last) Sinha government and the tallest Communist leader in Bihar, how much land had been redistributed in Bihar since Independence through legislation, and he said that not even 5,000 acres might have been distributed. This is the outcome of 20 years of freedom, Socialism and Communism! I told ministers in the new government, who were my erstwhile co-workers, that implementation of pro-poor laws made by the Congress was sufficient to bring about a revolution and free the poor from oppression. But they could not do anything.² - - - Despite the dust, the dirt, the falsehood that it may have, there is a fundamental truth in this Gramdan Movement."³

But things were not being taken in proper perspective, neither by insiders nor by outsiders.

Vinoba made a novel suggestion now: Gramsabhas should be the primary unit of Sarvodaya organisation.

A conference of workers in Uttar Pradesh was held on 12 July. Acharya Kripalani declared his full support for the Movement. When asked why he himself was not participating in it, he replied, "It is not my *swadharma* (natural duty). I am in politics since 1916 and cannot quit it now. I will continue to be in Parliament and broadcast your voice there."⁴

Maharashtra Sarvodaya Conference passed a resolution in August to work for the rajya-dan. Zilla-dans started in Madhya Pradesh with Tikamgarh becoming the first one on 15 August. In Bihar, zilla-dans of Champaran, Muzaffarpur and Saharsa were achieved. Vinoba himself camped in Champaran from 27 July to 6 September. It was not easy to comb the district in rainy season, braving floods. Often the workers had to wade across rivers through waist-deep waters. Yet, zilla-dan was

achieved in one and a half month. "If Champaran district-dan can be achieved in one and a half month, why should more time be required in other districts? I will issue 'show-cause notice'"—Vinoba quipped⁵. His sense of urgency was getting transmitted to the workers. This entailed harder work; but, unfortunately, that increased probability of compromises also. Yet, the supreme commander was ready to take risks; for he believed that once the people's consent for this cause was secured through an intensive campaign, the rest would take care of itself.

In the second fortnight of September, Vinoba stayed in Saran district; zilla-dan followed. Now the whole of North Bihar had come under gramdan.

Vinoba was working, and motivating workers to work single-mindedly. But what the leadership of his main instrument—Sarva Seva Sangh—was doing?

JP wrote to Dharendra Majumdar, suggesting that voters' education should be taken in hand for a month, suspending gramdan work, as mid-term elections were due in Uttar Pradesh in February 1969! Sarva Seva Sangh passed a resolution on voters' education on 6 October at its Sokhodeora meeting.⁶

Growing instability had plagued the political life in the country after the 1967 polls. Governments were going down like ninepins because of unprincipled defections—more so in Bihar than anywhere else. Between March 1967 and May 1968, Bihar saw four governments. Assembly was dissolved at the end of 1968 and fresh elections were held in February 1969. No party got majority in that election also. The hotchpotch conglomeration that came to power lasted for only 17 days, and the government that followed survived for just a year. What sort of voters' education had any utility in such a situation, particularly when the Movement had a programme capable of lifting up people from this morass?

It was a recurrent criticism that gramdans were only on paper. Vinoba's rejoinder was:

"Much has to be done even for this 'paper-gramdan'. You have to go from village to village, from house to house. No

other movement had ever been so widespread. And what, after all, a vote is? It is just a piece of paper. You see votes being obtained through all sorts of dubious means. This is nothing but a facade of democracy. But still you see that it does generate some strength.”⁷

It is through these pieces of paper that governments are formed in democracy; it is through them that they collapse. The pieces of paper proclaiming resolve to work for self-rule had also great potentialities.

It was not sufficient to obtain pledge letters only. Some steps at least had to be expeditiously taken, as Vinoba outlined:

“The first thing to be done after gramdan is to constitute gramsabha (assembly of all the adult villagers) by consensus. Then, land is to be distributed to the landless, whereby they will get some reassurance. Gram-kosh (village fund) is to be formed and everyone should start contributing one-fortieth of their income to it. The papers should then be submitted to the government for confirmation of gramdan. The next step is to achieve the minimum—freedom from addictions, and the police and the law courts.”⁸

On 25 December, Vinoba came to Patna. Zilla-dan of Patna was achieved, followed by Gaya district.

In this concerted campaign, government officials were also taking part—the Bihar government had made the programme its own. It was interesting, and even intriguing, to find governments with different hues working for gramdan. Were not government servants part of society?—That was Vinoba’s argument. But this aspect had serious implications. Co-operation of the government machinery was certainly vital, but not in the propagation of the idea; they had a role—a critical role—in the subsequent phase. It was the government’s duty to simplify procedures for the transfer of land and registration of gramdans, expedite the same by cutting red tape, and also to prepare schemes for the bhoodan and gramdan kisans. Had there been political will, red-tapism could have been done away with and laws, better suited to the goal of making villages true units of self-governance, could have been made. That indeed was what the legacy of the

freedom movement demanded and the directive principle in the Constitution about making villages units of self-governance enjoined. But nothing of this sort happened; instead the government machinery's involvement in propaganda work identified the movement with the government in the public eye. The erroneous impression still persists.

Vinoba was visualising a speedier campaign after the current one, to fulfil stipulations for gramdan and lay the foundation of gram-swaraj. He had 1972 polls in view. He believed that the Movement had the last chance to make an effective political intervention in that election:

"I am absolutely clear in mind that if we fail in preparing the people for putting up people's candidates in the 1972 polls, at least in making them realize the need therefor, we—the believers in Sarvodaya—would be written off; and that would be perfectly justified. Your commitment and unremitting work deserves appreciation. But in the absence of any tangible result, people will not be convinced about your worth. - - -Yet, that is not our aim. That will be a by-product. Our main aim is to make people self-reliant."⁹

Eighteenth anniversary of Gramdan Movement was celebrated in London. Two hundred persons marched to Indian High Commission office and submitted a statement supporting bhodan. The public meeting held thereafter was addressed, inter alia, by Geoffrey Ashe, Ernst Bader and Donald Groom.

Sarva Seva Sangh met at Tirupati in April 1969. Ramamoorti warned that the time gap between rajya-dan and establishment of gram-swaraj would have dangerous consequences. "To avoid such gap should be the prime matter for concern, reflection and initiative."¹⁰

Jayaprakash said, "Even we do not understand fully this new technique; not to speak of others - - -."¹¹

That indeed was the crux of the matter. To understand the nonviolent technique needed grasping of the implications of nonviolence. Given their background of association with and fascination for statist socialism and liberal democracy, even

many of the leaders were finding it difficult. Who was then going to educate the workers? Perhaps Dharendra Majumdar was the only one doing something on this front.

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In Bihar, zilla-dans were taking place in quick succession, but bringing round the predominantly-tribal southern region was proving a tough nut to crack. In fact, gramdan was in tune with the tribal traditions and ethos; and that was why it had received enthusiastic response in the tribal belts in Odisha, Maharashtra, Gujarat and elsewhere. But vested interests of the powerful Church and self-centred politicians were misleading ignorant tribals and hampering gramdan work. There was dearth of workers as well. Vinoba was aware of the problem:

“Christians give money and render other help to the adivasis. They nurse the sick. In this way, they earn the love of the people. But they also consolidate their hold on them in the process. They ‘de-nationalise’ the tribals, tell them that the aid they were getting came from such and such foreign country, and thus create a feeling of disrespect for their own country in their minds.”¹²

Politicians were perceiving, and naturally so, a threat from gramdan: What would happen to their future, if people become empowered?

The Church people argued that the tribals were already following the principles of gramdan; what need did they have to adopt it? Workers of the Jharkhand Party distributed pamphlets alleging that the gramdan workers were agents of the Congress and they wanted to snatch land from the Santhal tribals.

Vinoba came to the area in July. Dialogue with the tribal leaders was intensified to dispel their misgivings. When he was camping at Khoonti, more than 2,000 tribals, armed with bows and arrows and axes marched to his camp, shouting ‘*Vinoba ki Jai*’ (Long live Vinoba) and ‘*Lekin gramdan nahin*’ (But we reject gramdan). Vinoba patiently explained to them the principles of gramdan. He met the leaders on the next day and reasoned with them. He assured them that land of tribals

(surrendered in gramdan) would not be distributed to non-tribals. It was argued that land revenue was being collected by the Mundas and it was their hereditary right; it would end after gramdan, which was not acceptable. Vinoba said that the Munda was an agent of the government; after gramdan, he could become agent of the village and the gramsabha could entrust revenue-collection to him. He also assured them that tribal rights under Chhota Nagpur Tenancy Act would remain untouched. The leaders also voiced opposition to the provision of election of the president of gramsabha, arguing that the headman's post had been traditionally hereditary. Vinoba explained. "If the hereditary headman is good, people will elect him. Anyway, the president has hardly any power. All decisions will be taken by all. What is the harm if a good man, whom people want, gets elected?"

When tribal leaders said that they wanted non-tribals to leave the region, Vinoba told them that they were wrong.

"The non-tribals will also be a part of gramsabha. What will you gain by distrusting them? Such an attitude will break India. If only tribals live here, their progress will be hampered. No one from your community will then become President or Prime Minister. And, have not Christians also come from outside? Do you want to expel them too? Moreover, if others are ready to live with you amicably, and still you want to expel them, you cannot legally do so. If you attempt to expel them by force, military will come; and your bows will be no match to it. You yourself will lose thereby."¹³

The leaders said that they were satisfied. But they returned on the next day and told, without giving any reason, that they had decided not to co-operate with gramdan!

Birsa Dal leaders also met Vinoba and asked similar questions. They also expressed satisfaction after discussion. Finally, Khoonti Anumandal Gramdan-prapti Samiti was constituted with Birsa Dal chief Khudia Pahan as the Chairman.

In view of the genuine apprehensions of tribal leaders, two changes in the gramdan scheme were proposed: (1) 5% of the land of a tribal landowner will not be given to a non-tribal

landless, and (2) tribal lands, which could not otherwise be alienated, will remain inalienable; there would be no question of their sale even with the gramsabha's permission.

Vinoba was pained with the attitude of these leaders:

"The tribal leaders have told the people that gramdan is harmful. This is absolutely wrong. I have toured the entire country. No one has as much heart-to-heart contact with the people as I have. Koraput district in Odisha has accepted gramdan. It is not far off from here. In other states too, gramdan is more welcome in tribal regions, as State-made laws have ruined their lives. Not selling land outside the village, sharing with and caring for each other—these are the age-old traditions of the adivasis. Therefore, they have nothing but gain from gramdan. As far as others are concerned, gramdan will make them happy; but to adivasis, it will mean empowerment and liberation."¹⁴

Vinoba disagreed with the demand for the separate state of Jharkhand, pointing out that a few would thereby have positions of power, but the masses would remain where they were.

When Dhebarbhai, ex-President of the Congress, met Vinoba, Vinoba told him that gramdan was generating self-confidence in the people and political parties should do nothing to harm the process; they should, therefore, desist from fielding their candidates in elections in gramdan areas; and the Congress, being the biggest party, should take lead in it. Dhebar said that he would convey this message to party high command.¹⁵ Needless to say, the Congress did not respond positively to this proposal.

Situation in Jharkhand began to change gradually. Misgivings of most of the tribal leaders were dispelled. Jaipal Singh, a prominent tribal leader and Member of Parliament, started campaigning for gramdan. He himself signed the gramdan pledge. Krishnaraj Mehta met Cardinal Gracious at Mumbai and obtained his stamp of approval. Still the Church's attitude remained ambivalent.

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Sarva Seva Sangh working committee met at Rajkot on 25 July 1969. Jayaprakash said in the meeting,

“If we engage ourselves in resisting minor injustices, our strength will be dissipated. It will be desirable to embark upon nonviolent resistance to counter injustices and other impediments faced while doing gramdan work. Satyagraha for minor problems will not help us in doing our basic task. - - - Unless rajya-dan takes place, entry of *lokniti* (people's politics) in the state Legislative Assemblies will not be possible.”¹⁶

That is what Vinoba had been consistently harking on.

The country was witnessing political turmoil. Power struggle within the Congress had exacerbated. Prime Minister Indira Gandhi openly supported V.V. Giri in the presidential election against the official party nominee N. Sanjeeva Reddy. To project herself as saviour of the poor, she announced populist measures like nationalisation of 14 major banks and abolition of privy purses being given to erstwhile native rulers after Independence. Giri won in the election in August. Congress high command expelled Indira from the party in November. Congress split vertically. Indira government lost majority in the Parliament, but it survived with the support of Communists and some other small parties.

When asked what would be his advice to the Congress in this context, Vinoba's reply was:

“You are putting three responsibilities on me. First, to think about the situation in Congress; second, to form an opinion about it; and the third, to give advice to Congressmen, even if they have not asked for it. I cannot shoulder any of these three responsibilities!”¹⁷

Vinoba thus steered clear of controversy. But Sarvodaya workers could not remain so detached from the goings-on in the Congress. Some of them smelt power-hunger in Indira, while some others were impressed by her pro-poor image.

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In September 1969, the figures for bhoodan were as follows¹⁸:

Bhoodan received — 41,76,815 acres (from 5,75,885 donors)

Land distributed — 11,75,838 acres (to 4,61,681 families)

Land set aside as undistributable — 18,54,882 acres

Land yet to be distributed — 11,46,095 acres

Figures for gramdan were as under:

<i>State</i>	<i>Gramdan</i>	<i>Prakhand-dan</i>	<i>Zilla-dan</i>
Bihar	60,065	550	15
U.P.	24,332	127	5
Tamil Nadu	14,604	143	4
Odisha	12,622	70	1
M.P.	6,629	33	4
A.P.	4,231	15	-
Maharashtra	4,000	17	-
Punjab, Haryana	3,986	17	
Rajasthan	1,736	1	
Assam	1,682	1	
Mysore	1,040	-	
Gujarat	1,040	3	
Kerala	418	-	
W. Bengal	748	-	
Delhi	74		
J. and K.	1	-	
Total	1,37,208	977	29
	X	X	X

In Bihar, Vinoba had staked his all. Yet, rather than concentrating all the energy in Bihar, workers in different states were aspiring for rajya-dans in their states. There were resolutions in Madhya Pradesh (26 October) and Rajasthan (31 December) to that effect. But was this a wise and practicable

strategy?

There was a communal riot at Ahmedabad on 18 September. Shanti-sainiks rushed to the city. Such incidents in the country were also diverting attention of the Movement from its task from time to time.

Vinoba came to Rajgir on 20 October. By this time, 575 out of 587 blocks in the state had come under gramdan, except 8 blocks in Santhal Pargana and 4 in Ranchi. Eighteenth Annual Sarvodaya Conference was held at Rajgir on this historic background from 26 to 28 October. Sarva Seva Sangh and its working committee also met there.

In the working committee meeting, Vinoba called for '*ati-toofan*' (campaign with greater intensity) for *pushti*, that is, fulfilment of stipulations for gramdan in the villages which had signed the gramdan pledge. He also said that satyagraha should be resorted to in the event of any impediments in the gramdan work. He listed freedom from the police and the courts and from the debts as priority areas of work to be undertaken. He again reminded the workers that gramsabha should be the main instrument of work; then only the movement would become a people's movement.¹⁹ In the Sangh meeting, he reiterated that actual developmental work should not directly be done by the Sarvodaya workers; they should rather get the work done by motivating the people.²⁰

The 18th Annual Sarvodaya Conference at Rajgir from 25 to 28 October was, in a sense, the pinnacle for the Movement. It was attended by thousands—estimates varied from 50, 000 to 3,00,000. People from outside the country were also present in good numbers; so were residents of gramdan villages. No conference in the past had seen attendance on such a scale. Delegates alone numbered 11,572. Besides Vinoba, V.V. Giri (President of the Republic), Dalai Lama (spiritual and temporal head of the Tibetan community), Fuji Guruji of Japan, Sheikh Abdullah and Geoffrey Ostergaard (an anarchist thinker from England) were seated on the dais. The Conference was inaugurated by Charuchandra Bhandari and presided over by Nirmala Deshpande.

Vinoba said, “A look at the congregation here should set at rest reservations of those who were apprehensive of being isolated from the mainstream while doing the gramdan work.”²¹ He also called for concentration on Bihar, disapproving resolves for rajya-dans in other states, stating explicitly that it was Jayaprakash who was ‘guilty for the resolves by other states’!²² He called for completion of *pushti* work in Bihar within one year:

“Not only India but also the whole world is watching what is going on in Bihar. Believers in nonviolence all over the world have their eyes on Bihar. If the experiment here succeeds, that will generate hope in them. Otherwise, frustration will set in. Therefore, forget differences of opinion for one year and work for *pushti*. A lot of differences of opinion will disappear while working together. If some still remain, discuss them thereafter, not now.”²³

Vinoba appealed to the workers again and again to work with single-mindedness and a sense of urgency. He pointed out that people were disillusioned with the political parties and they had expectations from the Movement. Those expectations needed to be fulfilled; and that too urgently; otherwise, the whole work would be wasted.

“Bhoodan was definite; but gramdan work is such that its result will either be infinite or zero. We have to see to it that the result is infinite.”²⁴

That was the crux of the matter.

Now that the goal had been achieved, Vinoba called for attention to different kinds of work with which the work needed to be supplemented, like working with industrial labour, ridding municipalities from party politics, convincing industrialists about joint control of industries etc.

“Till now, we have been working with concentration that could be termed foolishly obstinate. But now we have reached a goal. So, a few things may be added. And right time has come for that.”²⁵

He again reminded the workers that conscientization of

village communities and ending the State power thereby; and ending the vicious power politics and establishing people's politics—or what he had called '*lokniti*'—was what the Movement ultimately aimed at.

The statement issued at the end of the Conference ended with the appeal: "Gramdan of all the villages in the country and *ati-toofan* for *pushti* within one year—that is the message and the appeal of this Conference."²⁶

The draft statement, however, could not be discussed thoroughly in the atmosphere charged with enthusiasm and excitement of the vast crowd. Vinoba was to give the concluding speech, but other speeches went on and there was little time left for him! So, he just greeted all with folded hands.

Despite the fact that the Conference was attended by a great number of people, gramdan had not yet become the mainstream. Media continued to ignore it and the Movement still lacked its own press. There was hardly any tangible evidence of its impact on society.

So, work was needed on many fronts. Fulfilment of legal stipulations was, in fact, a minor step. Much needed to be done to constitute, activate and strengthen gramsabhas, to train them to take decisions by consensus—in other words, to make the gramsabhas an instrument of a continual revolution that could ensure continuous progress towards village self-rule.

But who was to do all this? Sarvodaya workers were tired. Nidhi-mukti had forced many to step aside to meet family obligations. They could gladly accept 'Vinoba's jail' for a year or so, not indefinitely. Teachers and government servants had participated in the campaign temporarily, and that too, mostly because of orders from their superiors. They had hardly any commitment to the Movement's vision. Khadi workers and other constructive workers had been deputed for a particular time by their institutions; their regular work was different. Paucity of workers was the biggest handicap of the Movement—such was the situation that the unemployed registered at the government-run employment exchanges were called to work in the Saharsa

zilla-dan campaign, and they were given coupons for collecting donations instead of salaries or honorariums!²⁷ What could be expected from those having little knowledge of the Movement's ideology? Those who had temporarily swelled the ranks of workers were, perhaps, more a liability than an asset.

Moreover, the work that had to be done now was of a different kind. So far, it was propaganda-centred. Now intensive work needed to be done and it required different temperament and different kind of expertise and skills. But there was hardly any arrangement for training for this purpose. Now mere revolutionary fervour was not enough; perseverance and patience, imagination and creativity were needed. All this called for a great organisational effort. The experienced workers had to bear more responsibility. But they were not only tired by the non-stop work, their minds were also assailed by doubts.

The work was against the current. The wave of modernity was sweeping the villages, and the welfare-State and the market were making deep inroads in them. Even while the Movement was engaged in a 'Do or die' campaign, 'green revolution' was engulfing the countryside. The very 'villageness' of the Indian village, which had remained intact for centuries despite upheavals, was never under more strain.

There was nothing wrong in the strategy of rapid and intensive campaign. But the hurry did give scope to practices that were not in tune with the Movement's spirit. Vinoba was never tired of saying that revolutions 'take place'; they cannot be brought about consciously and deliberately. But the 'Toofan' campaign does appear as an attempt to bring about revolution.

Once this phase was over, what was important was to leave that behind and concentrate on the next step. Otherwise, there was danger of losing what had been achieved with great sacrifices. Vinoba had given a timely call for '*ati-toofan*' for *pushti*. And had he stayed in Bihar, there was every possibility that he would have guided the Movement in that task.

But this was not to be. Khan Abdul Gaffar Khan—Frontier Gandhi—had come to India, for the first time after vivisection

of the country, to participate in Gandhi centenary celebrations. He was scheduled to visit Sevagram in November. Jayaprakash wanted Vinoba to meet him there. Vinoba acceded, and finally left Patna and reached Sevagram on 2 November. His speech at Sevagram on 5 November was his last public speech. The man who had already entered *sookshma* now practically made his exit from the scene.

Bihar continued to be on his radar; his concern and anxiousness for the slow pace of the work there were often revealed; he did at times talk of the impulse to go there. But Jayaprakash never favoured his return. The next phase of the Movement was bound to proceed under JP's leadership.

19. *Pushti*: Endeavour for Consolidation

On 21 and 22 November, Bihar Sarvodaya Sangh met and decided to dissolve the Gramdan-prapti Samiti (committee for obtaining gramdans, formed in 1965) and form Gram-swarajya Samiti for the work of *pushti*. But the new committee could not be constituted unanimously because of differences. Sarvodaya organisation in Bihar was beset not only with differences of opinions, but with personal differences as well. Finally, only four workers—Gajanan Das (President), Ramamoorti (Vice-President), Vidyasagar and Kailash Prasad Sharma (Secretaries)—were chosen and authorised to nominate other members.

Khadi institutions were requested to spare two workers per district for gramdan work and continue to give salaries to them. Seven institutions agreed and released 36 workers for gramdan work.

It was decided to take up distribution of one-twentieth part of the land of landowners who had signed gramdan pledge, as this would improve to some extent the position of landless labourers vis-a-vis landowners; it was thought that constituting gramsabhas prior to this step would be unwise. Vinoba was in favour of such a strategy.

Naxalism was raising its head in Bengal; it was attracting poor labourers, particularly tribals. Vinoba had repeatedly warned with prophetic insight that if the work of *pushti* was not completed within reasonable time, Naxalism could spread its tentacles in the neighbouring Bihar.

There had been sporadic attempts for *pushti*, but they had little success. The Movement had thought it wise to concentrate on obtaining gramdan pledges and postpone the intricate work. It was soon revealed that it was much more tiring, time-consuming and patience-trying than what had been imagined.

Workers began to visit the villages where gramdan pledges had been secured, often after a gap of quite a few years. The villagers had done nothing in the intervening time—they had either forgotten about the pledge or had waited for the workers! So stupendous was the task before an organisation that was far from being a united house. A disgusted Jayaprakash went as far as saying, in the Gram-swarajya Samiti's meeting on 29 April 1970, "If the mutual discord continues, I will absolve myself from the responsibility given to me by Baba (Vinoba)."¹ Hardly anything concrete had happened in the last five months. This was an ominous portent.

Lack of financial resources had always haunted the Movement. Sarva Seva Sangh working committee therefore decided, in its meeting at Pune on 17 March, to collect a fund, to be named Gram-swarajya Kosh, of rupees one crore (ten million) within six months. It was to be dedicated to Vinoba on his 75th birth anniversary (September 1970). It was decided not to keep it as a corpus, but spend it within three years. Vinoba gave green signal to this proposal. He also called for devoting two months to fund-collection.

It was true that the Movement needed money. But it was equally true that the number of workers had dwindled, and the remaining workers were tired. It was perhaps more necessary to give priority to contact villages as further delay in it was bound to make the work more difficult; and also to mobilising and training new workers for this new phase. Fund-raising at this critical juncture diverted the attention and energy of workers and wasted precious time.

Situation in the country was providing ample avenues for diversion of attention. Communal animosity was on the rise. There was a major riot at Bhiwandi in Maharashtra. In Kerala, formation of Muslim-majority Mallapuram district became a contentious issue. Sarvodaya workers took initiative for forming an organisation to work for national integration and communal amity. It was named 'Insani Biradari'. Its core committee included Jayaprakash, Sheikh Abdullah, Shahanawaz Khan and Pandit Sundarlal.

Vinoba was now contemplating a broader role for Sarvodaya movement: Sarva Seva Sangh could now work as the 'Lok-sevak Sangh' of Gandhi's conception, having gained sufficient strength to put pressure on the government and counter the wrong tendencies in society because of its wide reach—it had reached about three hundred thousand villages and secured gramdan pledges from half of them.²

Vinoba was not in favour of repeating the Bihar experiment of securing gramdan pledges elsewhere. Not that he had realized with hindsight that it was wrong. It was right, as 'securing people's consent has to be the first step of a people's revolution'.³ But attempting it at other places, where the Movement was not strong enough, was too ambitious. Still, other states were vying with each other in attempting zilla-dans and even rajya-dans.

In Bihar, the technique to achieve breakthrough was still eluding the Movement. Was satyagraha a way out? If so, what could and should its form be?

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Jayaprakash had retired to Himalayas for rest and recuperation. He was at Paudi when he learnt that Naxalites had threatened to kill Badrinarayan Singh and Gopalji Mishra, office-bearers of Muzaffarpur District Sarvodaya Mandal. Jayaprakash was shocked and, as he said, 'delighted' too, on learning about it:

"I have been feeling for quite some time that the fire in our Movement is going out, and that is making us workers lacklustre and lifeless. One of the reasons appears to be that the nature of our work is so mild and placid that there is neither any threat to our life nor is there any demand for any great sacrifice."⁴

Jayaprakash rushed to Muzaffarpur and decided to make Musahari, the block worst affected by Naxalite activities, his base. Media sensationalised this as 'acceptance of the challenge of Naxalites'. But what JP really desired was to work for breakthrough, which the Movement so direly needed. He was to

work intensively in the block for this purpose.

Musahari was one of the 40 blocks in Muzaffarpur district. It had an area of about 44,000 acres, 17 village panchayats and 121 revenue villages. Average land per person was 0.3 acre and the landless accounted for 39.2% of the population. Poverty and unemployment were rampant, and so was the resultant discontent. It was said that it would have been prudent to take up work in a block where conditions were comparatively favourable, rather than in Musahari where conditions were particularly adverse. But Jayaprakash had made his decision impulsively. With a man of his stature making Musahari his battleground, considerable hopes were naturally aroused.

"Let no one feel that the quiver of satyagraha has been exhausted", thundered Jayaprakash in his speech before a mammoth crowd at Muzaffarpur on 8 June.

"Sarvodaya Movement has completed the first stage of satyagraha, that of public education. Now the second stage is going to commence. From tomorrow, I will move from village to village along with Prabhavatiji (his wife). I will come to your door, explain things to you. If necessary, we will sit at your door without food and tell you that if you want to feed us, arrange to feed the hungry in your village; at least give them one-twentieth of your land.

"Let no one think that we will be afraid of threats or even death."⁵

Jayaprakash's resolve moved Vinoba. He told a co-worker,

"Jayaprakash had cut short his programme in the hills. I think I should not be a mute spectator. I, too, would have to go (to Bihar). We had looked upon the Bihar front as a reply to Bengal disturbances. But if trouble starts in Bihar itself, I will have to do something. I am watching the situation."⁶

But Jayaprakash thought otherwise:

"That Baba (Vinoba) is considering coming to Bihar is enthusing. But I think he should not come now. The mettle of all of us from Bihar is being thoroughly tested. If Baba

comes here, his lustre will hide our weaknesses. If we are weak, how long can we go on with borrowed lustre?"⁷

For him, expecting more from Vinoba was not proper. It may well be that he was thinking of an alternative strategy; and Vinoba's presence could have been a handicap.

In Musahari, Jayaprakash's priorities included constitution of gramsabhas, distribution of one-twentieth land, institution of gramkosh and submission of necessary papers for legal confirmation. He was also thinking about distribution of undistributed bhoodan land; take corrective steps about the land distribution done so far, if needed; giving homestead land to the homeless poor and tackling the problems of the landless, particularly the injustices.

The government offered security to JP, sensing danger to his life, but he refused.

He found that people were not denying that they had signed the gramdan pledge; but at the same time, they were reluctant to set aside one-twentieth land. What was the solution? JP talked of satyagraha. But what could be the form of such satyagraha? "I do not know. But nonviolence is not impotent. - - Either I will succeed or lay down my life."⁸

JP started work with 10 workers, mostly from Khadi institutions. The work involved going from village to village, home to home, and have dialogue with people from all strata. JP was certainly not unaware of the harsh realities of the rural life. But direct encounter with them shook him thoroughly:

"These villages have pathetically decayed, both materially and morally. Collective life there is in shambles. In village after village, you find Duryodhan's court where Draupadi is being disrobed and Bhishma, Dronacharya and Vidur, among others, are silent spectators."⁹

"JP has started the second stage of satyagraha based on gramdan. We had propagated our thought; now we are starting in a particular area the process of intensified persuasion."—wrote Ramamoorti in 'Bhoodan-Yajna'.¹⁰

Fulfilment of conditions of gramdan was to be attempted. But it was revealed that the gramdan pledges were also incomplete. Lack of authentic land records and land-grabbing by powerful people were also presenting difficulties.

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The Communist Party and two Socialist parties—Praja Socialist and Samyukta Socialist—started 'Land grab movement' in July. Vinoba rightly described it as nothing more than a 'political stunt'. These parties, when they were in government, had done little even for implementation of the land reform laws that were already in the statute book. The programme consisted of 'grabbing' government land or land held in fictitious names, and unfurl the flag of the party thereon. How the landless were going to get that land, who would distribute that land and how, and how legal sanction for it was going to be secured—nothing was clear. Obviously, it was just a ploy to mobilise the landless for political gains. JP, while lending support to the agitation, suggested that such land be distributed by consensus in open village meetings. He also expressed worry over the Communist party's instigation to the people to carry arms. Sarva Seva Sangh President Jagannathan called the movement as one not of grabbing the land, but of restoring it to the rightful owners. Ramamoorti, on the other hand, lamented that this agitation had caused a setback to the gramdan work, as it had aggravated tensions and bitterness. As it turned out, the agitation did nothing except harming the gramdan work. The Communists, in fact, had decreed in villages under their influence not to form gramsabhas! So afraid were the self-proclaimed 'revolutionaries' of the people's power!¹¹

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Ashadevi Aryanayakam died of cancer at Nagpur on 30 June. Her contribution to Gandhi's Basic Education was second to none. A votary of bhoodan, she had accompanied Vinoba in his Bengal tour and had translated his speeches in Bangla.

It was decided at a meeting in Sevagram on 11 September that intensive work of *pushti* be carried out in three blocks—

Musahari, Rupauli and Chakai—under the guidance of JP, Baidyanath Chaudhari and Ramamoorti respectively.

Sarva Seva Sangh met at Sevagram in the first week of October. On 2 October, Gram-swaraj Kosh (fund) was given to Vinoba. Target was Rs. 10 million, but it had been possible to collect only Rs. 6.25 millions. It was decided to extend the period of collection by three months. The Movement was ready to spend precious three months more on fund-collection, which meant diversion from gramdan work, which needed to be continued without a moment's gap!

Vinoba thanked the workers:

“Many factors were unfavourable. When Tilak Swaraj Fund was collected,¹² Lokmanya Tilak was at the height of glory, while Baba (Vinoba) is presently at the height of ignominy. His entire work is being believed to be bogus. For me, this is not unexpected. I had told that while bhoodan is definite, result of gramdan work will be either immeasurable or a big zero. Presently, it appears to be zero. Jayprakashji and all of you are trying for the other result. I trust that your efforts will bear fruit, as this is the demand of the era.”¹³

It was decided that 90% of the fund collected would remain with the concerned state and 10% would go to Sarva Seva Sangh.¹⁴

Vinoba was moved while referring to JP's decision to plunge himself in Musahari:

“Some say that it was a new step in the quest for revolution; some say that a new technique of gramdan work will emerge; some say that a new dimension of satyagraha will come to light. God willing, all this will happen. But all this is of little value. - - - It is love that is the most important.”¹⁵

It was suddenly decided in a meeting with Vinoba at Pavnar to make Saharsa district in Bihar a ‘national front’ for *pushti* work; all energies of the Movement were to be concertedly applied in the district.¹⁶ Sarva Seva Sangh concurred with this decision. It talked of creation of ‘*ati-toofan*’ in the district to complete the *pushti* work expeditiously. Saharsa was

going to be the ground of the Movement's last battle.

Jayaprakash made an appeal to focus all strength in Saharsa in pursuance of Vinoba's directive, but he was to stand firm in Musahari.

Choice of Saharsa was, most probably, Vinoba's own. According to him, "In North Bihar, Muzaffarpur (which included Musahari) is the most difficult, and Saharsa is the easiest. My tactics is, to go from success to success."¹⁷

Saharsa was a small district where 96% population was rural; even Saharsa, the headquarter of the district, had population less than 15,000. Here bhoodan had been received mostly from small landholders: 38,432 acres had been gifted by as many as 28,696 donors, and 16,387 acres had been distributed—a substantial portion as compared to other districts. According to the District Bhoodan-Yajna Committee, allottees had in their possession 16,097 acres; thus the problem of eviction, a grave problem elsewhere in Bihar, was practically non-existent. Sarvodaya organisation in the district was also fairly strong. For intensive efforts, the unit had to be a district, not just a block, as economic and political scenario could be expected to be affected only if work was done on the scale of a district. Vinoba pinned his last hope on Saharsa.

Now it was the last 'Do or die' battle. The battle was going to settle the fate of the Movement. Vinoba bared his mind before Vidyasagar, Secretary of Bihar Gram-swarajya Samiti, and his colleagues, asking them to lock the office and work in the field to complete the *pushti* work in the district positively by the end of January next:

"If you fail in this, you will have to engage in private business - - - First complete the Saharsa work and then talk of anything else. Work gets done when it is done with urgency. I had left Bihar with the word '*ati-toofan*' on my lips; but '*ati-toofan*' and even '*toofan*' remain a far cry from what is being done. Things are proceeding at a snail's pace. This is the last leap. - - - if nothing happens after working for twenty years, people may praise your tenacity and perseverance, but they will conclude that this work cannot go

to fruition. - - - Often there is an impulse in my mind to go to Saharsa, but I restrain myself, for then credit will be mine. But even sentiments in my mind will help you. - - Make a resolve to embrace death if the work is not completed. I will not ask for anything else if Saharsa work gets completed; there will then be no need at all to say anything else.”¹⁸

He also appealed to workers from other states to go to Saharsa and sounded an alarm bell at the end of Sangh meeting: “If the work is not completed in Bihar within a year, Naxalism will gain momentum.”¹⁹

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To bring fresh blood in the Movement, Kishor Shanti-Dal was formed in 1963. It later grew into Tarun Shanti-Sena (TSS) in 1967. Centres of TSS were opened at several places. Born in the background of Bihar famine, TSS regularly participated in relief work after natural and man-made disasters. An appeal was made to the youth to give one year after finishing formal education. At TSS’s Indore camp in October 1970, 9 young men and women responded to this appeal. TSS also started ‘Revolution in education’ campaign. TSS was closely linked to the Shanti-Sena and the Sarvodaya Movement in general and benefited from the guidance of senior workers, but its reins were in the hands of the youth, unlike youth organisations attached to political parties.

JP had fully immersed himself in the work at Musahari. Believing in the necessity of developmental work, he got prepared a plan for full employment in the block from the institute ‘AVARD’. His sustained efforts contributed to the lessening of tension in the area. To address discontent in the landless poor, he took up on priority the work of giving them homestead land. He did not consider the Naxals as rivals or enemies, and even helped their families.

Political instability in the country led to announcement of mid-term elections in 1971. For the leaders of Sarva Seva Sangh, voters’ education now became a priority! Sangh secretary asked the workers ‘to virtually stop work including that of obtaining gramdams and focus all energies on the work of voters’

education' adding that 'the work may be done in addition to the gramdan-*pushti* work, wherever it is continuing.'²⁰ In the working committee meeting from 21 to 23 January 1971, it was decided to organise voters' education throughout the country. JP said in the Sangh meeting that this election was different from the earlier ones, as it would decide the fate of democracy.²¹

Vinoba was straining every nerve to mobilise all his forces for the pitched battle; but where were his soldiers?

In his self-imposed confinement, he can do little more than appealing with all the earnestness and expressing his dissatisfaction with the way things were moving—or rather, drifting:

"Eight to nine months were spent in the fund-collection. Now the elections will take up more than three months. I think there will not be any excuse again to postpone the work (of gramdan). I will, therefore, again urge the workers to leave everything else and concentrate on gram-swaraj work, founded on gramdan."²²

It was revealed in the Nasik meeting (May 1971) of the Sangh and the Sarvodaya Conference that besides Bihar, *pushti* work was going on only in Bikaner district in Rajasthan, although the Sevagram conclave (October 1970) had decided to do this work in around 100 areas. Even in Bihar, work was going on only in a few blocks in six districts besides Saharsa; and in Saharsa district too, work had started in only 5 of the 23 blocks! The *pushti* work was turning out to be much more intricate, cumbersome, time-consuming and patience-trying. Perhaps it should have followed regeneration of community spirit; the awakened people's power would then have fought the vested interest and red-tapism effectively. But the latter was also a long process.

Another major difficulty was that the moral atmosphere created by Vinoba's walking tour was fast disappearing. The situation was getting worse and worse. The poor were getting impatient and exasperated, as little concrete was happening on the ground. Armed contingents of different castes were coming on the scene. As Ramamoorti observed,

“Tendency to oppress is growing in the youth of higher castes, and that of counter-violence in the Dalits, Muslims and Adivasi youth. The village is disappearing from everyone’s mind. Class and caste consciousness are rapidly growing.”²³

Forces working for the disintegration of villages were aplenty; Sarvodaya was fighting a battle all alone.

It was bound to be a protracted one. Neither despair nor impatience was, therefore, called for. What was needed was the right perspective and firm commitment. Dharendra Majumdar was urging for the same:

“Right from the beginning of history, the people have never carried out their functions. Either kings, masters, priests, service organisations, saints or great men have been solving their problems. The people have, at the most, followed them. Now we are saying that society should function on its own. We want to do away with outside leadership. Thus we want to bring about something that has never happened in history. - - - We want to create an altogether new culture. I, therefore, feel that we should not talk of completing the work in two, four or six months.”²⁴

Understanding of the nature and process of the desired transformation was of crucial importance. Talk of satyagraha and of championing the cause of the poor was not infrequent among workers. Dhirendrabhai was never tired of underlining the nature of nonviolent approach and strategy: it was not confrontation, but rapprochement. Confrontation is initiated by the have-nots, while rapprochement is inevitably initiated by those who are responsible for deprivation of some people.²⁵

But there were few who appreciated and shared this perception.

At the Nasik meeting, JP vented his misgivings:

“From what I heard in the discussion about gramdan work, it does not appear to me that the reports were based on first-hand experience on the ground. - - - Nothing has happened after Rajgir (1969). Is gram-swaraj our main programme? If

it is, whatever struggle, satyagraha or new initiative we want to take should be in connection with that work. But we are not doing this, and feel that nothing is happening, no impact of our work is visible, people are not following us, and that our movement is not becoming a people's movement. If we continue to be in such dilemma, we will be nowhere. Therefore, let Sarva Seva Sangh deliberate and decide whether it wants to discontinue this work and take up a programme which appears to be more effective.²⁶

"Baba has been duped. There was surfeit of declarations of prakhand-dans and zilla-dans. If we go to the roots, everything is found hollow. If the young people sitting here are not ready to become manure for this cause, I do not think that you will be able to accomplish this work. It is very, very difficult. All the circumstances are against us."²⁷

He bared his mind again in the Conference:

"The light within this Movement is getting extinguished. Where do we seek to find the impact of the Movement? If you look for it in politics, you will not find it there. Nor will you find it in the press. It should be found in villages. If it is not there too, then better give up the programme. We have a programme, but the Movement is waning. We have not given justice to the programme. We have duped Baba (Vinoba)"²⁸

But did the Movement really need a completely new strategy and programmes, writing off all that it had done in the last twenty years?

The race for setting higher and higher, practically unattainable targets, and clamour for declaring their fulfilment prematurely, had clearly resulted in deficiencies. The term 'bogus' was being repeatedly used, often irresponsibly. Vinoba himself had used the word; clearly in exasperation. But was that ground enough for its irresponsible use by others? How justifiable was the use of this term? Ramamoorti tried to find this out in two areas. He found that only 3 out of 866 landholders in Musahari and only one out of 1,335 landholders in Rupauli denied having signed the gramdan pledge.

Ramamoorti also noted that while 1,335 landholders had signed earlier in Rupauli, 1,935 new landholders had come forward to sign it during the *pushti* campaign.²⁹

People were not denying that they had signed the gramdan pledge; in fact, those who had not signed earlier were coming forward to sign. Was this not a cause for cheer? It was true that they were reluctant to part with the land. But was not that natural? And even if they were ready to give land, they were reluctant to sit with those belonging to the deprived sections and work with them on an equal footing. But this was also not surprising. How could long-established traditions going to give way in a matter of days? The work of integration of the village; in fact, that of building village communities afresh—for they had been totally ruptured—was no easy task.

The work in Musahari, although not at desired pace, was yielding positive results. After moving about in Musahari, Kanti Shah had this to say: “Our Movement has reached an important point. Now breakthrough is needed. And it appears a distinct possibility in Musahari.”³⁰

However JP, as he himself admitted, could not give the work undivided attention. He could not help going out of the area from time to time. In particular, the happenings in East Pakistan took a substantial portion of his time. He had to go out of India also, to mobilise opinion in favour of the freedom struggle there.

And at Pavnar, Vinoba was directing his mental energy on Saharsa work. “If work in Saharsa gets completed, you will have a technique in your hand, which we presently lack.”³¹

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Sarva Seva Sangh met at Bhopal in October 1971. Portent of things to come, that had already appeared, revealed itself more acutely at Bhopal. It was noted that although *pushti* work was proceeding at a slow pace, ‘it must be borne in mind that in the process we are observing the village society at close quarters and gaining valuable insights about its internal processes, and we are moving towards the sources of people’s

power, whereby the possibility of the Movement becoming a people's movement is getting closer at hand.'³²

However, this realisation did not put at rest the search for alternative strategy.

Dada Dharmadhikari's speech understandably created a storm. Dada was known as a leading interpreter of Gandhian ideology. In his speech, he advocated organisation of the landless and small farmers. More importantly, he said that vote is more powerful than satyagraha! From the platform which prided itself as the legitimate heir of Gandhi, who had called Parliament 'a prostitute' and 'a sterile woman', and from which Vinoba had time and again proclaimed his thesis of the Stateless society and rejected so-called democracy, Dada eulogised democracy. Vinoba considered his 'Talks on the Gita' as a foundation of Sarvodaya philosophy and had always advocated its propagation as an important tool for the progress of the Movement. Dada dubbed it 'a harmless spiritual tract' whose propagation would hardly serve any purpose!³²

This was shocking. But what was more ominous was that it thrilled many workers; and even JP said that every sentence of the speech was worth pondering over!

JP also said in the meeting that 'Sulabh' gramdan was perhaps a wrong step. Dhirendrabhai disagreed. Whatever one might find from hindsight, that would not have altered the nature of the work at hand.

One reason which JP noted as being responsible for the tardy progress of the movement called for serious attention:

"Defects in our character is one of the reasons. Although we are away from power, there is craving for petty posts in the organisation, which generates bitterness and groupism. We seek to bring about a great revolution, but are unequal to this task. - - - I know of the irregularities and corruption in the distribution of bhoodan land. Had the land distribution been done then and there by gramsabhas, or had we asked the donors to do it, this would not have happened."³⁴

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On 7 October, Kelappan, known as ‘Kerala Gandhi’, breathed his last. He had been President of the state Congress, had later left it to join Praja Socialist Party, and had eventually joined Sarvodaya Movement.

In Andhra, a gramdan campaign was organised in November, seeking gramdans and fulfilment of stipulated conditions simultaneously. In 33 villages, 789 acres land was received and 549 acres distributed then and there. Vinoba hailed this effort.

The year 1971 saw birth of a new nation—Bangladesh. Sarvodaya Movement had been concerned with the preceding developments and was actively engaged in doing what it could. JP had even toured several countries to mobilise opinion in its favour. Sarva Seva Sangh had advocated recognition to the new nation, which the Government of India eventually accorded. Indo-Pak war followed. The Movement contributed in the relief work necessitated by the influx of refugees.

Indira Gandhi, riding on the wave of popularity because of the deft handling of the crisis, won the election in March 1972 hands down. In Bihar, political instability since 1967 ended with Congress getting majority in spite of getting only 33% of the votes. Concerned by the growing authoritarian tendencies within it, JP, however, was getting more and more disenchanted with it. Vinoba, of course, was little concerned with these developments.

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Dhirendra Majumdar started ‘Lok-Ganga-Yatra’ of Saharsa district in a bullock-cart, despite his ill-health, on 3 December 1971. (It continued till April 1974.)

Flow of gramdans had not completely dried out. In several areas, workers were trying and getting gramdans. However, Saharsa was proving a tough nut to crack. On 29 April, Vinoba told workers in Saharsa that if they failed there, “Baba will have no faith in Bihar; he will entrust it to God. After all, Time Spirit is there.”³⁵ He had gauged from the letters he received from all over India that Gram-swaraj Movement was as good as finished.

Saharsa was perhaps the last hope.

This was disquieting. But what was far more serious was that the leadership, instead of searching ways to rejuvenate the Movement in tune with its foundation and spirit, was straying from its ideological moorings and from the two basic issues that it had firmly grasped—the land and the village. And the rank and file was tired, confused and disheartened.

20. Epilogue

A miracle had happened in Chambal ravines in 1960, when more than 20 dreaded dacoits had laid their guns at the feet of Vinoba. The miracle repeated itself in 1972: this time the number of surrendered dacoits was in hundreds. The first one had been brought about by Vinoba's charisma; this time, incessant efforts by JP and other workers bore fruit. The world witnessed the power of nonviolence again.

The peace committee formed in 1960 had continued its work of maintaining contact with the dacoits in jail, looking after their dependants and the families of their victims and education of their children. Besides rehabilitating the dacoits who had come out of jails, it was working for creating a normal atmosphere in the region. By 1971, 19 dacoits had come out of jail and were leading normal and peaceful lives. All this had wonderful effect on the psyche of local people. But the dacoity menace had persisted because of shortsightedness of the powers that be.

Madho Singh, a prominent gang leader, sent an emissary to Vinoba with a message that many dacoits were fed up with the life in ravines and wanted to begin a new chapter by surrendering, urging him to come again in the region. Vinoba directed him to JP. Madho Singh met JP, hiding his true identity, but JP declined, citing his bad health and preoccupation with the Bangladesh affair. Madho Singh met him again, revealing this time who he was. JP promised to take up the matter if the governments of concerned states—Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan—were sympathetic and ready to cooperate. He knew how the attitude of these governments had defeated a ground-breaking initiative earlier.

JP wrote to the Chief Ministers of concerned states. They responded favourably. On 13 December 1971, JP issued an appeal to the dacoits, asking them to surrender. The last

surrender was unconditional. But if surrender was to be on such a scale as to solve the long-standing problem, some concessions were necessary. In his meeting with JP, Madho Singh had outlined his expectations; major of them were: (i) No one should be hanged, (ii) Trial for offences in three states should be held jointly by them, (iii) Cases be registered within six months and disposed of within 2-3 years, and (iv) They should not be handcuffed and ill-treated in jails. JP found these expectations reasonable. The concerned governments were apprised of these expectations. They, in turn, desired that the dacoits should not be made heroes, garlanded or photographed, and the surrender should not take place in a public meeting. They were anxious about the morale of the police. After much deliberation, organisation of a public meeting at Jaura after surrender was agreed upon. An official statement was issued, expressing agreement with what Madho Singh wanted, subject to certain conditions.

The work of contacting dacoits in ravines began in full swing. Government machinery extended co-operation. Tehsildar Singh, who was serving a sentence of 242 years since 1958, was released in February 1972, probably at JP's instance. JP, freed from the Bangladesh affairs, devoted himself to this task. Police operations against the dacoits were suspended by the governments and jeeps were provided to the Peace Mission. JP had meeting with the Chief Ministers of concerned states on 2 April. He met the Prime Minister on 10 April and issued a press statement for the first time on the same day, thanking the governments, but pointing out at the same time that,

“the problem is not going to be solved by the surrender of a few hundred dacoits. It will only set in a process - - - so long as the psychological, social and economic aspects of this intricate problem are not tackled by the Central and the state governments and also by the Sarvodaya organisation and other social and voluntary workers and institutions, dacoit gangs will continue to rise and history will continue to repeat itself.”¹

The first surrender finally took place at Pagara, a remote village, on 14 April 1972. It started with Mohar Singh. Prabhavati (JP's wife) applied the auspicious mark on his

forehead. Mohar Singh bowed down before her, and also before JP, who embraced him. It was a rare spectacle. Mohar Singh was followed by Madho Singh, and 80 other dacoits followed. JP told them that they were now part of the Sarvodaya fraternity, and that he would see to it that none of them would be hanged, 'even at the cost of his life'.² Women workers tied *rakhis* around the wrists of the baghis, signifying that the baghis were now their brothers.

Public meeting later took place at Jaura, where the baghis laid their guns before Gandhiji's statue.

On 15 April, the Chambal Valley Peace Mission was reconstituted with JP as the President. Second surrender took place on 16 April; 81 dacoits surrendered on that day in the presence of the Chief Minister and a crowd of 40,000. Surrender continued even thereafter till October, taking the number of surrendered dacoits to 441. On 18 April, Madhya Pradesh legislative Assembly unanimously passed a resolution thanking JP and his associates for this historic work. Vinoba also sent a message.

The government constituted a rehabilitation board and provided funds to the Peace Mission as well. The Peace Mission undertook initiatives to maintain the atmosphere of peace and goodwill. The dacoits decided to plead guilty for the crimes committed. Peace Mission arranged legal aid to them. The dacoits confessed their crimes, which would otherwise have been difficult for the prosecution to prove. Some of them even confessed crimes for which they had not been charged by the prosecution! The court cases were expeditiously disposed of. By the end of 1973, cases on 336 dacoits had been disposed of. While 66 were sentenced to life imprisonment, 45 were acquitted. An open jail, named 'Navajivan Shivar' (camp for new life), was set up at Mungawali in November, where those with jail terms over 7 years were lodged.

The surrender continued, albeit in a trickle. Most of the remaining dacoits surrendered by 1976, thereby effectively putting an end to this centuries-old problem. Conduct of many dacoits during the trial and thereafter clearly showed the

efficacy of nonviolence.

Not that the whole episode was without some hiccups. Allegation that the Sarvodaya workers were glorifying the dacoits was hurled this time also. A fake surrender of 19 dacoits, some of whom were allegedly serving sentences in jails, was arranged before the Chief Minister! The dacoits were, at times, ill-treated in jails. But on the whole, the attitude of the government, bureaucracy and the judiciary remained fairly constructive, at least for some time.

Expressing happiness, Vinoba said that such incidents give boost to the power of nonviolence and strengthen the workers engaged in the cause of nonviolence; and that this incident would also give energy to the Gram-swaraj Movement. He also said that had the government and the police been favourable in 1960, the problem could have been solved to a large extent at that time itself.³

He asked the Peace Mission workers to give credit to the government and remain aloof from politics. About the process to be adopted for establishing peace, he said,

“What is the difference between the gramdan work and the work of the Peace Mission? The concept of gram-swaraj should be propagated. Let gramsabhas be established in every village. The landless should be given land. Work should be arranged for those who need it. Conflicts in the village should be solved in the village itself.”⁴

That was the core of gram-swaraj which was, for him, the panacea for all the ills afflicting the society. What he was concerned with was the furtherance of this cause. Other initiatives and interventions had value only if they could energise and complement the Gram-swaraj Movement.

Vinoba also suggested a programme of walking tour by female workers in the region, which was notorious for crimes just days ago. Nirmala Deshpande and others undertook *padayatra* of four districts from 2 May to 15 August 1973.

This incident did bring Sarvodaya into limelight for a while and demonstrated the power of nonviolence. However, it did not

revitalize the Movement. In fact, the events took JP away from Musahari, affecting the work there.

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The 20th Sarvodaya Conference was held at Nakodar in Punjab in May 1972. It was presided over by Ramamoorti and inaugurated by Sarala Bahan. German by birth, young Miss Catherine Mary Heilman had come to India, participated in her freedom struggle, devoted herself to the uplift of women in the Himalayan region, made India her home after Independence, and had taken the Indian name Sarala.

The progress of the Movement on several fronts was discussed. Saharsa was the 'national front'. But *pushti* work was going on in other states also. There were also attempts to add new dimensions. Fight against oppression of tribals in Shahada region in Maharashtra had thrown up local leadership. In Rajasthan, Gokulbhai Bhatt began indefinite fast for prohibition when consistent struggle failed to yield results; it ended when the Prime Minister gave promise in this respect on 27 May. Work for prohibition was also going on elsewhere, particularly in Uttarakhand and Tamil Nadu. A walking tour in Mahboobnagar district of Andhra, in which hundreds participated, resulted in land-gifts of 1,200 acres, distribution of 833 acres and declaration of 61 gramdams—certainly encouraging figures. Saharsa district, of course, was being combed; an intensive campaign was conducted in four blocks from 14 May to 30 June.

Work was going on here and there, but it was fast losing the fire and the fervour. Workers were going through the routine grind. According to Geoffrey Ostergaard, the summer of 1972 was the turning point for the Movement.⁵

JP again said at Nakodar that "if democracy comes to an end, it would be very difficult, if not impossible, to carry on our Movement and bring about the revolution of our conception."⁶ Not a few in the country were uneasy because of what they perceived as the growth of authoritarian tendencies. A natural corollary of this stand was that the Sarvodaya Movement should

concern itself with the survival of democracy in its own interest.

JP decided to take a sabbatical year. He was dissatisfied with the outcome of efforts in Musahari. On 25 October, he issued an open letter to Musahari, venting his concerns:

"I am writing this open letter to you with heavy heart and deep concern. Had my health allowed it, and had I not decided to take a sabbatical year, I would have personally gone from village to village and talked to you.

"In the Musahari block, Village Shanti-Sena has been formed in many villages. Many training camps of Shanti-sainiks have taken place. Electricity has reached many villages and well-to-do farmers have dug borewells. Bihar Relief Committee has installed hundreds of hand pumps in the farms of poor farmers. I have arranged bank loans of thousands of rupees for tobacco trade. AVARD has rejuvenated a number of ponds. Lift irrigation has been arranged on the banks of Gandak river. Homestead land has been allotted to hundreds. Many walking tours have been organised in the block and so also many training camps for the youth and village-level functionaries. Efforts have been made to improve primary and secondary education. There have been many talks by Sarvodaya leaders. The atmosphere of terror, which existed when I stepped in there, exists no more.

"Yet, I feel that all the efforts have failed. Gramsabhas exist on paper only; hardly a few of them are active. Stipulations for gramdan have not been fulfilled. One-twentieth of the land (surrendered in gramdan) has been distributed in a few villages only, and that too partially. Gramkosh has been formed only in a few villages, and that too by the contributions of poor farmers and labourers. - - - When we started developmental work, many of our Sarvodaya colleagues had cautioned that people would join gramdan without any commitment, coveting the gains of development, and will become inactive or may even oppose gramswaraj once they attain their end. But I did not accept this. I had thought that if developmental work accompanied social and psychological transformation of the villages, both kinds of work would strengthen each other and a picture of

gramswaraj will soon emerge. But my hope has been belied.”⁷

JP’s patience was running out. Kumar Prashant notes,

“The way in which work was being done in Musahari had reached dead end. People’s organisation was not taking shape. The organisation that had somehow been propped up needed a structure of development programmes; and even a man of JP’s stature was finding it difficult to keep that afloat.”⁸

What should have received priority was the infusion of gramdan spirit in the villages which had accepted gramdan during the *Toofan* campaign, but the workers and the leaders of the Movement were dissipating their strength on the tiring and time-consuming work of *pushti* and on programmes of economic development; and were then venting their frustration. Alternative strategy was certainly needed, but it had to be in consonance with the well-defined goal.

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Sarva Seva Sangh met at Ernakulam in the last week of December 1972. Sangh secretary told the meeting that work in Saharsa was now proceeding mainly on local strength; it was no more a ‘national front’ in the true sense. Work in Musahari was in dormant stage. In Tamil Nadu, Jagannathan was carrying out a militant struggle for land.

Vasant Gade, a senior worker from Nagpur, began a walking tour of Maharashtra on 2 October 1972 for propagation of the message of Gitai, Vinoba’s rendering of Bhagavad Gita in Marathi. The tour went on for 14 years.

There was an agitation in Uttarakhand for the protection of forests and for right to forest-based employment. Ecology of the region was under threat because of reckless cutting of forests by contractors. The agitation stood for forest rights to panchayats. Sangh supported the agitation.

When Rajasthan government broke its promise on prohibition, agitation was resumed. Ajmer distillery was raided

on 12 February 1973. Hundreds courted arrest at Jaipur on 16 February.

The year 1972 witnessed a devastating famine. The Movement took initiative to design a scheme 'Youth against famine' for tapping the energy of youth for relief work.

Tehri dam was being planned in Uttarakhand. Uttar Pradesh Sarvodaya Conference cautioned the government against hastening the scheme, demanded proper rehabilitation and said that benefits of the dam to the local populace should be ensured.

The government nationalised wheat trade on the background of famine and imposed levy on the farmers. JP urged the government to reconsider this policy, pointing out that inefficiency and corruption of the government machinery would lead to escalation of profiteering and black market.⁹ Vinoba concurred with JP's views.¹⁰ The policy, however, was persisted with.

Opposition parties were looking to JP for leadership. An effort for Opposition unity was made in the beginning of 1973 and JP was again requested to lead them. JP declined, but kept open the possibility:

"I have no intention to reverse my decision (to leave party and power politics) taken in 1954, either today or in the future. With acute differences and rivalry for power in the Opposition ranks, their coming together in the true sense appears impossible. But if it could be possible, I may take interest in it for the good of the country."¹¹

Such utterances, and the criticism of the ruling Congress in general, were bound to invite recrimination from its supporters. JP was dubbed 'a spokesman of Anti-Indira Gandhi rightist reaction'. In a statement on 15 May, JP clarified his position, saying that there was no reason for him to be an opponent of Indira; what he had been saying was motivated solely by his concern for the country and her future.¹²

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Sarvodaya Conference was held at Kurukshetra from 11 to 14 April 1973. Vinoba's message to it was: (1) All should recite Vishnusahasranam at 10.30 a.m. daily, (2) If Nagari script is accepted by the country, it will help unite the country for more than a thousand years, and (3) Workers should love each other.¹³

Was Vinoba looking for conservation of the seed, as the Movement was petering out? He was least bothered about the political turmoil and the future of so-called democracy. His five concerns now were: Brahmavidya (spiritual knowledge), gramswaraj, Shanti-Sena, Acharyakul and Devnagari script. For pure funding of Sarva Seva Sangh, he hit upon a novel idea of *upavas-dan* (gift of fasts): Those believing in Sarvodaya should forego one meal every month and donate the amount so saved to the Sangh. His calculation was that if 40,000 persons participated in the scheme, the Sangh would get Rs. 10 lakh, sufficient for its annual expenses. Besides, the donation so received would be pure. Vinoba himself made a beginning on his birthday, 11 September, although fasting was likely to be harmful to the ulcer in his stomach.¹⁴

Work in Saharsa was facing unforeseen difficulties. Most of the landholders were from outside. Kosi barrage had escalated land prices, and therefore the problem of evictions. This was also resulting in illegal sale of bhoodan lands. Opposition by big farmers was coming into the open. Workers in Saharsa met Vinoba in September (12 to 15). Vinoba asked them to complete the *pushti* work in three, or at the most four, months. Workers were diffident. The work had been going on since three years and still much had remained undone. What if the work was not completed in four months? Vinoba retorted, "Then step into the river Ganga collectively!" To the dejected and rattled workers, he later explained, "This also means that you should step into the masses of the country, with whatever degree of success you could achieve (in Saharsa) by working to the best of your capacity." Instead of completion of work in four months, Vinoba was now ready to give eight months for half of the work.¹⁵

But the work failed to take off. Dharendra Majumdar found,

on reaching Saharsa on 27 October during his Lok-Ganga Yatra that the local Vinoba Ashram, the centre for workers in the district, was deserted.

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Sarva Seva Sangh met at Sevagram from 21 to 23 September. Secretary Thakurdas Bang created a furore by announcing 'politicalisation' of the Sarvodaya Movement, claiming blessings from Vinoba for the move. Nirmala Deshpande asked agitatedly, "Do we want politicalisation or spiritualisation of the Movement? Please do not use Vinoba's name if you want politicalisation." Dharendra Majumdar thought it to be a misunderstanding of words.¹⁶

Vinoba was now asking the workers to work on the basis of consensus: whatever they did then had his approval in advance.

Almost all the prominent workers met at Pavnar Ashram in December 1973 for informal discussions on the present and the future of the Movement.

Situation in the country was deteriorating rapidly. The euphoria created by the successful Bangladesh war was waning. Corruption, price rise, unemployment and a host of other problems were assuming alarming proportion. Some workers felt that if the discontent among people could be peacefully channelised, a breakthrough could be achieved.

It was from Pavnar that JP issued an appeal to the youth to work for free and fair elections in Uttar Pradesh due to be held shortly. Youth power that had recently become manifest in the struggles all over the world had caught imagination of many inside the Movement.

1974 saw student agitations, first in Gujarat and then in Bihar, against the rampant corruption and other issues. The vibrant Gujarat agitation with its vigour and creativity struck a sympathetic chord all over the country. On 31 January, JP said in Saharsa, "I am seeing 1942-like situation in the country. Youth power has to step in to tackle it."¹⁷

Ramamoorti has narrated his conversation with JP on 16 March 1974 during which the former remarked, “It appears that now there is hardly anything worthwhile to do in Sarvodaya. Nothing appears interesting or motivating.” Hearing it, JP immediately sat up and said firmly, “No, no; much needs to be done.” “What?”—asked Ramamoorti. JP’s reply was: “Struggle—against the government, against the whole system.”¹⁸ When the most challenging task—that of establishing gram-swaraj brick by brick on the foundation of gramdan—was beckoning Sarvodaya workers, some of their prominent leaders were finding nothing worthwhile to be done, and their leader was visualizing an anti-government struggle, forsaking the task in hand!

In March 1974, Sarva Seva Sangh officially supported Gujarat agitation. And when JP took over the command of Bihar agitation, many Sarvodaya workers joined him enthusiastically.

In the first week of April, prominent pro-struggle leaders Ramamoorti, Jagannathan, Manmohan Chaudhari and Thakurdas Bang met Vinoba and explained their stand in detail. Their main argument was: ‘Experience of the last 25 years had demonstrated inefficacy of gramdan-gramswaraj programme. We have been compelled to withdraw our forces from Saharsa. A nonviolent, yet militant, struggle is necessary to save the country and further the cause of gram-swaraj as well.’¹⁹

But, was experience of 25 years sufficient to change rural India? If anything needed to be done to hasten this process, it had to be done. Vinoba was not denying need for a militant struggle. In fact, he was envisaging such struggle. But it had to be waged in villages, for removing obstacles in the gramdan work. How could a direct anti-government struggle—struggle against the government and not against the State—fought on the streets of cities lead to transformation in the countryside? Such a struggle could at best change the government—and it did succeed eventually in bringing about such a change. Pro-struggle workers were hoping that struggle would awaken and organise people which would cause a breakthrough—end stagnation and frustration in the country and ultimately help the cause of gram-swaraj also.

Vinoba said, "I am not against Jagannathan's struggle for land. But agitation against the government is another matter." His reading of the situation was different. He thought that in the delicate international situation, an anti-government agitation, even if peaceful, should be avoided. Pro-struggle workers were talking of 'people's candidates' in elections. Vinoba himself had been urging them to try for the same; but for him 'people's candidates' meant gramsabhas' candidates. But the Movement lacked strength to field such candidates even in one district.

Vinoba told the leaders—repeatedly, insistently and earnestly—not to abandon the issue of land and their non-partisan nature. They had been consistently working on the issue of land for 25 years. Nothing was going to be achieved by forsaking all that had been gained so far, and taking a path fraught with risks. The struggle had put question mark on the Movement's non-partisan nature, which it had assiduously nurtured. It had resulted in fissures in the Movement. While a majority of workers supported the struggle in collusion with opposition parties, a group was vociferously opposing it and had joined hands with the ruling party, although it was clearly manifesting authoritarian tendencies. Differences of opinion were leading to ill will and bitterness towards each other.

What was needed was a comprehensive and deep understanding of the forces, active not only in the country but also all over the world, and take stand and redesign strategy and tactics in tune with the fundamental principles and vision of the Movement. The Movement had been consistently anti-State, even while extracting concessions from the governments; its 'legitimate anarchism' had been a curious phenomenon for the Western eyes. It had worked for the withering away of the State and politics: supporting or opposing this or that government was clearly not in tune with its vision. Pro-struggle workers' submission was that the government of the time had neither interest nor strength in disturbing the status quo. Vinoba pointed out that no government could ever have such interest or strength. He reiterated that he had never supported any wrongdoing on the part of the government, and what he stood for was not aloofness from the State, but its destruction. To

work for the ending of the State and of the politics—that was really the distinctive work of Sarvodaya.

But pro-struggle workers were in no mood to listen to Vinoba's entreaties. They were convinced that Gramdan Movement had practically ended and the struggle they were engaged in was an effective alternative strategy. They believed that the strategy and the process they had followed all along had failed to involve the landless, and even the small farmers, and win the confidence of the poor. Were that true, remedial measures were certainly called for. But how could an anti-government struggle—which eventually became an agitation to dislodge the elected government—over certain vague issues like corruption and unemployment be the answer?

The differences persisted; the fissure in the ranks of the Movement continued to widen. Vinoba's last efforts to keep united his flock failed and the struggle continued, following its own dynamics. The wheel of history moved inexorably.

Sarvanarayandas comments ruefully,

“The wheels of History moved on the path, which they had to follow. But two heavy costs had to be paid: (1) Whatever merits the Sarva Seva Sangh had earned were utilised by the Opposition parties and moral strength of Sarvodaya workers got dissipated. An independent forum had taken shape; a community of non-partisan workers, enjoying goodwill of all, had emerged. Both of these started withering away. (2) Efforts so long were for the creation of people's power, independent of the State power; and the goal was freedom from the State. The idea was getting gradually etched in the people's consciousness. But everything became State-oriented with the involvement of Sarva Seva Sangh in the Bihar agitation, although it was anti-government.”²⁰

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In such a scenario, Saharsa, the so-called 'national front' of the Movement, naturally disappeared from the radar screen of both pro-and anti-struggle elements. In September 1973, Vinoba had extended the deadline for the last time: he had asked for

completion of half the work in eight months. In May 1974, a few workers, who were still active in Saharsa, came to Pavnar to meet Vinoba. He asked four leading workers—Vidyasagar, Brajmohan Sharma, Mahendrabhai and Sarvanarayandas—who had remained aloof from the Bihar agitation, to leave Saharsa and go to different southern states to serve the people there silently.²¹

The commander officially withdrew his forces from the last front. Saharsa campaign ended—it rather withered away. And with it a great Movement, which Vinoba had aptly termed ‘an ascension’, became a part of history. Bhoodan and gramdan still remained on the horizon as both, the ideas and the reality—their potentialities and relevance as valid as ever. But the Movement had ended for all practical purposes.

21. Postscript

The Bihar Movement continued, following its own dynamics, and the schism in the Sarvodaya Movement continued to widen. On 25 December 1974, Vinoba began silence for one year, to penetrate deeper into the inner recesses of his spirit.

Sarva Seva Sangh met at Wardha in March 1975. Vinoba urged JP to become '*Ranchhod*'—to leave the battleground to avoid internecine strife, just as Lord Krishna had done when he had left Mathura and went to Dwarka, 1200 km away. He even broke his vow of silence to implore JP to withdraw the agitation in view of the international situation. But JP was not convinced about the step. Acrimonious debate was naturally witnessed in the Sangh meeting. The Sangh finally split vertically. 54 anti-struggle workers walked out and resolved to devote themselves to land distribution to commemorate 25th anniversary of bhoodan. Pro-struggle workers decided to continue to participate in the struggle. The Sangh, as an organisation, decided 'to observe silence'—remain in hibernation—for one year. Vinoba discontinued his own *upavasdan* to the Sangh, signifying final break with the politicized Sangh.

Anti-struggle workers formed 'Bhoodan-Yajna Rajat Jayanti Samiti' (Bhoodan-Yajna Silver jubilee committee) and chalked out plans for land distribution in co-operation with the state governments, mostly led by the ruling Congress party. They also participated in government-sponsored programmes.

On 18 April 1975, Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed, President of India, lighted 'Bhoodan jyoti (torch)' at Pochampalli with which a group of workers walked to Pavnar; 5,000 acres were reportedly distributed during the one-year walking tour. JP appealed to all the workers to co-operate in the work of land distribution, rehabilitation of displaced farmers and fulfilment of stipulations for gramdan, irrespective of their stand about the Bihar Movement. Uttar Pradesh Government constituted a

committee for the distribution of bhoodan and government lands, and appointed R.K. Patil, a prominent anti-struggle Sarvodaya leader, as its head with the status of a cabinet minister. Reluctant Patil was persuaded by Vinoba to take up the responsibility.

The Bihar Movement finally resulted in the imposition of Emergency in June 1975 and arrests of hundreds of Sarvodaya workers. Civil liberties were curtailed and censorship was imposed on the Press. Democracy in India had never been under such a serious threat. Anti-struggle workers, however, rather than opposing all this, which was clearly against the ethos of the Movement, identified themselves with the ruling clique.

On 6 July, a few days after the proclamation of Emergency, Vasant Sathe, a Congress member of Parliament, came to Pavnar to meet Vinoba. As Vinoba was observing silence and he was also hard of hearing, communication with him used to be in writing. "I have come to meet you after the advent of this new era", wrote Sathe. Vinoba underlined the words 'this new era' and wrote, "*Anushasan-parva?*" Obviously he wanted to know whether Sathe meant 'an era of discipline' which was how the Emergency was being publicised. (*Anushasan* means discipline.) He had certainly not called the Emergency 'an era of discipline'. But the word was picked up by the government which launched widespread propaganda that Vinoba had supported the Emergency. Unfortunately, the mischievous propaganda was not countered, and Vinoba's image in the public mind nosedived.

It appears that Vinoba initially thought that the Emergency was for a brief period only. But when it continued to be prolonged, he did try in his own way for its revocation. In January 1976, after the end of his silence, a conference of selected *acharyas* (intellectuals and academicians) was held at Pavnar with his assent. The Conference called for steps to restore normalcy, but the government remained adamant.

In June 1976, Vinoba took up the issue of cow-slaughter, and announced fast for total ban on cow-slaughter. Cows and bullocks had been the backbone of the rural economy for centuries. Their indiscriminate slaughter was undermining rural

economy. Perhaps, Vinoba was contemplating preservation of seeds of gram-swaraj, as the Gramdan Movement had virtually ended.

Vinoba also withdrew the authority given by him to Sarva Seva Sangh to nominate members of the Bhoodan Boards. Many state governments happily initiated steps to delete the provision in Bhoodan acts authorising Vinoba or his nominee (that is, Sarva Seva Sangh whom Vinoba had nominated for the purpose) to nominate members of Bhoodan boards. Pro-struggle workers in Bhoodan/Gramdan Boards were either removed or they themselves stepped out, may be because they did not want conflict with their erstwhile co-workers, may be because they perceived no future for bhoodan.

The Emergency was lifted in early 1977 and the pro-struggle workers came out of jail. The next election was necessarily a sort of referendum against authoritarianism and excesses during the Emergency. The pro-struggle workers enthusiastically participated in the elections. Such participation could have been seen as an inevitable duty during a crisis (*apad-dharma*), but it was not so seen. The Sangh, in its search for an alternative strategy, continued to become more and more politicized. On the other hand, anti-struggles workers also turned to other programmes. Bhoodan and gramdan receded into background.

In June 1978, Vinoba again authorised Sarva Seva Sangh to nominate members of Bhoodan Boards, but the states which had amended their Bhoodan Acts to remove authorisation of the Sangh did not amend their acts again. Vinoba had made his exit from the scene, and there was no pressure of a movement. The situation in the country was rapidly changing. Land reforms were receding from the national agenda. In this situation, bhoodan and gramdan were bound to become irrelevant for the political class and the bureaucracy. Sarvodaya fraternity had also practically bade goodbye to the issue.

As a result, bhoodan and gramdan were bound to become victim of apathy, ignorance and even hostility. Today, ignorance about them in the political class and bureaucracy, and even in

the ranks of the Sarvodaya organisation—not to speak of the people at large—is appalling. The situation will be dealt with in detail while discussing the distribution of bhoodan lands. It is sufficient to note here that Bhoodan and Gramdan Acts, even where they still exist, are nowhere being followed either in spirit or in letter. The situation calls for timely action on the part of policy-makers, bureaucracy, the academic community, non-governmental organisations, the media, and above all, the Sarvodaya fraternity.

PART TWO
An Appraisal

1. Distribution of Bhoodan Lands

The first bhoodan was received at Pochampalli (18 April 1951) in response to the specific demand from the local Dalits. Therefore, to whom the land was to be distributed was not a question. The question was of the modality of distribution. The idea was to give the landless a permanent source of livelihood; conferring full title of land on them was not contemplated. A trust was, therefore, constituted including the donor and the representatives of the landless. The landless to whom land was given agreed to cultivate the land collectively.

However, as the stream of bhoodan gathered momentum, it was not possible to distribute gifted lands immediately after receipt. Formal legal arrangements were also not in place. So, the distribution did continue, but it inevitably lagged behind the receipt of land-gifts.

Vinoba appointed a committee in Telangana and gave it authority to distribute gifted land. He framed rules for its working on 12 June 1951. Government of Hyderabad subsequently framed detailed rules called 'Shri Acharya Vinoba Bhave Sarvodaya Bhoo-yagya Hyderabad Land Revenue Special Rules 1951' on 27 July 1951. The rules provided that any landholder could relinquish his rights in response to Vinoba's appeal by submitting *razinama* (letter relinquishing right over land) to the Tehsildar, attested by a member of the Bhoodan Committee constituted by Vinoba, and the Tehsildar, after due enquiry, accept it, whereupon the land would vest in the government. The Bhoodan committee would select persons to whom such lands would be assigned by the Tehsildar. It was also provided that the grantee would have to become a member of the co-operative society, if it was formed there, if so required by the Tehsildar. Stamp duty was waived and exemption from land revenue was granted for three years. The rules, made initially for one year, were subsequently extended from time to time.

The gifted land legally vested in the government, but it was clear that it was to be distributed by the Committee constituted by Vinoba, and not by the government.

Bhoodan started again when Vinoba proceeded from Pavnar to Delhi in September 1951. To solve the land problem through nonviolence, Vinoba called for gifts of 50 million acres. As he walked through different states, he constituted distribution committees in them. Rules framed by the Movement in this regard evolved with experience. In Sevapuri Sarvodaya Conference (April 1952), Sarva Seva Sangh resolved to collect 2.5 million acres in two years, and thus undertook responsibility of the Movement. The Movement thereafter began to spread throughout the country. As the idea was catching the imagination of the country, priority had to be given to seeking land-gifts, particularly when there was paucity of workers. (After the achievement of a target in 1954, Vinoba did call for expeditious distribution.) Moreover, it was not intended that the donor should immediately stop cultivating the gifted land; he was to continue it till its distribution. Formal legal arrangements were under process, and it was prudent to wait for them as far as possible. Of course, the risk was there that the spirit with which the gifts were given might wane, making distribution difficult; and the patience of the poor might be unduly stretched if little was done expeditiously. Keeping the delicate balance remained a tricky problem for the Movement.

Rules for distribution

Vinoba first framed elaborate rules in this regard in December 1952 in Uttar Pradesh¹:

1. The villagers in the village where distribution is to be done should be intimated of the date one week in advance through printed pamphlet and beating of the drum. It has to be ensured that every household is informed of it.
2. Intimation should be given again on the previous day. The programme of distribution should be intimated to the District Collector and concerned officers so that their representatives could attend it.

3. All information about the land to be distributed should be obtained beforehand from the head of the gramsabha and the *talathi* (revenue official responsible for keeping village land records). The land should be personally seen to ascertain its condition, quality etc.

4. The landless should be identified in a public meeting of the whole village.

5. Land distribution should also be done in a public meeting where the Tehsildar, or another official deputed by the Collector, should be present along with the *talathi* and the *kanoongo* (one having knowledge of the law).

6. Distribution should, as far as possible, be done by consensus. If this is not possible, the decision should be left to the landless themselves. If our representative has to take a decision, he should take it by drawing lots.

7. Co-operation of local respected persons should be secured, so that it could also be obtained in getting more land-gifts and providing facilities to the grantees.

8. As far as possible, at least one-third portion of the lands should be given to the Dalits.

9. Land should, as far as possible, be given to the landless in the same village. If big tracts of land have been received, and land is available after giving to all the local landless, the surplus may be given to the landless in neighbouring villages.

10. The (Bhoodan) Committee should frame special rules for settling a large number of the landless on big tracts. In such settlements, the scheme devised by Purushottamdas Tandon should be implemented. (The scheme mainly provided for giving some land to every family for backyard garden, manure pits etc.)

11. Land should normally be given to those landless who have no other source of income, desire land and are capable of cultivating it themselves. For new settlements, rules could be modified so as to make the new villages beautiful and self-sufficient.

12. A family of five members should normally be given one

acre of irrigated land or 2.5 to 5 acres of dry land. However, depending on the soil quality, more than 5 acres may be given in special cases.

13. Land received in fragments may be exchanged to form economic holdings. When this is not possible, or when there are no landless, such fragments may be given to marginal farmers; and if this too is not possible, they could be used for community purposes (like compost pits, latrines etc.).

14. The grantees will not be able to sell the land for 10 years.

15. If the land can be immediately cultivated, the grantee will have to pay land revenue as per rules from the same time.

16. If the land cannot be cultivated and remains uncultivated for two years, the government will have authority to grant the same to other landless persons.

17. After land distribution, efforts should be made to obtain land for the remaining landless in the village.

18. Three years should be given to bring under cultivation uncultivated, fallow or barren land.

19. The State Bhoodan Committee will take decisions from time to time in the interest of the work, in the context of circumstances.

No insistence on collective farming

The policy-makers of the time were enamoured of the idea of collective farming. Vinoba had also asked the Pochampalli Dalits to cultivate the land collectively. However, he soon changed his stand, as he observed that conditions in villages were not favourable for collective farming. Neither the mindset in the village nor the socio-economic condition of the landless was conducive to it. Poor and illiterate landless were bound to be exploited in collective farming. Actual experience of the collective farms was also far from encouraging. Only individual farming was likely to provide the landless incentive to do their best and ensure that the fruits of their labour accrued to them.

Beginning of legal arrangements

An Act was passed in U.P., first time in the country, in 1952, followed by Saurashtra, C.P. and Berar, Odisha (1953), Himachal Pradesh, Rajasthan, Bihar (1954), Delhi, Punjab, Madhya Bharat and Vindhya Pradesh (1955). As Vinoba entered any state and bhoodan picked up as a result, process of enacting the law also picked up, if the law did not already exist. Thus, Madras (Tamil Nadu) enacted bhoodan law in 1958, Jammu and Kashmir in 1960, and West Bengal in 1962. The transfer of land to the landless did need the seal of approval from the State, and it got it, although the contents of laws and their implementation left much to be desired.

Laws were indeed needed, but at the same time, it had to be ensured that the work of distribution was not vitiated by undue interference from the State. It was necessary to keep intact the revolutionary element in it and also ensure distribution in a transparent manner to the real needy, free from the involvement of revenue departments, notorious for corruption, and of political parties, bent on exploiting everything for petty political gains.

Who should distribute?

Bhoodan Committees constituted by Vinoba had political workers in them, as he wanted involvement of all in this work and also knew that the work was too demanding for the Sarvodaya workers alone. Perhaps it was one of the reasons why Vinoba wanted to avoid haste and proceed cautiously. He had no objection to the involvement of political workers, provided the distribution was done strictly according to the rules laid down in this regard.

But he did desire that the work should better be done by the people themselves through their own power. That is why his insistence was on distribution in gramsabha meetings. He repeatedly asked the villagers to do this work.

Dhirendra Majumdar suggested in 1954, when he became President of Sarva Seva Sangh, that the donor should have major role in distribution, and it was wrong to distrust him:

“We believed that our workers would be more honest than the donors. We forgot that those who actually gifted lands were likely to have better commitment to the (Movement's) ideology. We did not follow the process that was in tune with our philosophy. We wanted to build people's power, but resorted to the means that kept the people out. We wanted to revolutionise relations between the landowners and the labourers, but did not employ the means that could have brought them together.”

The lack of relation, even contact, between the giver and the receiver was, for him, a sure recipe for corruption:

“When the giver does not know the receiver and the receiver does not know the giver, the transaction is like that in a market, not like that in a family. And the worker has no relation with either of them. When the worker is not an independent individual, but is a part of a centralised institution, the situation becomes all the more impersonal and callous.”²

On the other hand, Baidyanath Prasad Chaudhari, a prominent leader from Bihar, held that it would not be proper when people were under the influence of feudal traditions—donors would then ‘gift’ land to their own labourers and continue to hold the land for all practical purposes. Vinoba concurred with him.

The ideological argument apart, there were practical advantages also in giving authority of distribution to the donor. Distribution could then take place then and there. Delay in it was causing numerous problems. Vinoba appears to have come around this view in the course of time. In September 1957, he asked the workers to let the donors distribute land.³ He also often sought ‘*prapti-patra*’ (written acknowledgement of the grantee on the land-gift letter).

At Arambagh meeting of Sarva Seva Sangh (29 April 1963), he articulated this view forcefully:

“We said that we would obtain land-gifts, but the donor would not have any say thereafter. He has parted with the land; why should he have right to distribute the gifted land?

It was thought that he should be free from vanity. We said that we would do this work—that is, the society would do it. But when distribution had to be done actually, no one came forward to help. - - - We were wrong in thinking that if the donor has this right, he would act selfishly and would give land to his own men. The gift would not then be a pure one. That would go against the revolution we envisaged. The obsession with revolution prevented us from right thinking. But we learn some things from experience. Had we given the right to the donor, it would have developed a relationship informed by love between the donor and the grantee. But we failed to realise this. The temptation to earn merit was also there.”⁴

But it was surely risky to give sole right to the donor. Apprehensions in this regard were not unfounded. They were borne out by experience during the ‘Bigha-kattha’ campaign (1961) in Bihar. Anyway, the idea of giving right of distribution to the donor was not tried on a large scale.

Consequences of worker-centric approach

The work of land-distribution remained worker-centric. And a bhoodan worker was also a human being, prone to slipping at times. Besides, he was working under trying circumstances. Nidhi-mukti (rejection of support from any fund) in 1956 added to his difficulties. There was paucity of workers and those who had come with revolutionary fervour were few. Many workers had come from institutions doing constructive work; for many of them it was like any other job. Therefore, corruption was bound to creep in to some extent. It did; and although it was far from being comparable to that in other areas of social life, it did tarnish the image of a Movement which prided itself on its moral stature.

When complaints about corruption were made (1962) in U.P. by a responsible and knowledgeable person like the Central Home Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri, Dharendra Majumdar investigated a few cases and reported the matter to the state bhoodan office. But Karanbhai, doyen of bhoodan work in the state, ignored it. Lack of timely action was bound to aggravate

the situation.

When once a complaint about wrong distribution was made to Vinoba (6 September 1965), he exclaimed,

“Whom else can I blame? I myself am at fault as I thought that if the land is distributed by revolutionary workers, it will result in the abolition of private property. Experience was contrary to expectation. This is Kaliyug (the age of evil). Mind is likely to get deviated and distorted. So, I myself bear the blame for the state of affairs.”⁵

Involvement of gramsabhas and panchayats

What was the way out? Society, that is, the village community should ideally have done land-distribution. It was its responsibility to remove landlessness in its midst. It knew the ground situation better than anyone else. It could do the work in a transparent and impartial manner. Moreover, discharge of this responsibility would have made the village community strong, stable and united; and added to its power and prestige. That was what the Movement was aiming at. Distribution by gramsabhas was most desirable from both theoretical and practical point of view.

Vinoba said in Gujarat in 1958,

“People say that the bhoodan lands have not been distributed. But whatever work we did so far was for the pursuit of knowledge. Our quest was fulfilled when we discovered the idea of gramdan. We distributed some land just to see whether people accept our ideas. But if workers distribute the lands, that would not bring about revolution. It will be brought about when people in the villages stand up one fine morning, resolve to distribute the lands in their village, and distribute them throughout the country by the evening. Whatever work we did in this regard developed our understanding and we realised that there should be people's consent behind this work.”⁶

Vinoba was in the search for some concrete manifestation of people's consent for the revolutionary transformation that Sarvodaya was seeking. For, nothing was intended to be thrust

on the people. What was sought was nonviolent revolution through people's power. It was in this context that he hit upon the idea of Sarvodaya-patra.

Vinoba once suggested in Odisha (11 December 1963) that the land be distributed in village meetings at the hands of the donor, but with the consent of the gramsabha.⁷

The village people—that is, the gramsabhas—should ideally have distributed the bhoodan lands. But where were the gramsabhas? They hardly existed. So the co-operation of panchayats was sought. But they were institutions, formed through elections and working on the basis of majority. Hence, Vinoba had hesitation in this regard. He believed that the so-called 'democratic decentralisation', under which the panchayat institutions had been formed, was nothing but 'a decentralised system of exploitation'. Still he did not oppose the efforts to involve them in the work of land-distribution in the hope that "if the panchayats take up a work of love, it could lead them to the principle of consensus."⁸ Jayaprakash, on the other hand, enthusiastically pursued this initiative. Strict adherence to the rules was, of course, to be insisted upon. Training for the panchayat members was also arranged. However, they hardly showed any initiative.

After the advent of gramdan, it appeared that the key to the arduous task had at last been found. Gramdan became the focus of the Movement. Because of the paucity of human and other resources, the work of land-distribution was bound to lag behind.

Vinoba's concern

Yet it continued to be a matter of concern for him. An incident may be noted in this connection. Vinoba was passing through Bihar (1961) on the way to Assam. In the public meeting at Berain it was mentioned that 45,000 acres had been received in the district, out of which 3,000 acres had been distributed and an additional 10,000 acres could be distributed. On hearing this, Vinoba snatched the mike from the speaker and thundered, "You have distributed only 3,000 acres; 10,000 acres

are waiting to be distributed. It means that you have robbed 10,000 persons of bread (that they otherwise would have earned)! Had I been in power, I would have hanged you!"⁹ He later had to console the stunned and crestfallen workers.

Legal framework

Enactment of laws to legalise gifts of lands and their distribution, as already noted, started in 1952. They provided for constitution of Bhoodan Boards or Committees to be nominated by Vinoba. It was unusual, and perhaps unprecedented, that a particular authority was given in a law to an individual, who was not even part of the government.

The laws were not enacted promptly, and when made, they did not reduce the difficulties. Enquiry and confirmation of gift letters, and mutation and revenue assessment of the grantees was the responsibility of revenue departments. The cumbersome and time-consuming procedure laid down for this purpose as well as the attitude of the revenue departments, which was mostly callous and non-cooperative, proved to be big hindrances.

After announcing '*sookshma-pravesh*' (retirement into the deeper recesses of the Self), Vinoba delegated his authority to Sarva Seva Sangh. This was duly noted in most of the Acts. The provision of nomination of Board/ Committee members by the Movement prevented politicization of the Boards/Committees to some extent for some time.

The Movement welcomed enactment of laws, which were necessary to have seal of approval from the State, so that the grantees and their successors could have uninterrupted access to the means of their livelihood. It even actively sought legislation and prepared drafts for the consideration of the governments. Yet many in the Movement had reservations and apprehensions: How can a Movement wedded to the ideal of a State-free society seek State-made laws and work within their framework? Would not the involvement of the State machinery undermine the revolutionary spirit in the Movement?

Ideological apprehensions apart, it was also revealed that the complicated procedures in the laws were creating hindrances

and delaying the work, rather than facilitating it. It remained the complaint of the workers that the laws had made land distribution difficult.¹⁰ In fact, when transfer of land to the poor, which was the government's avowed aim as well, was being done on a voluntary basis, it was the duty of the government to give legal effect to it through simple rules and procedures. That it did not do so betrayed its true character.

Many other difficulties

The question was not just of political will and administrative sincerity; difficulties were many. Lack of authentic land records, particularly in states like Bihar, which were under Permanent Settlement, was a great handicap. Zamindars there had faulty and incomplete records and the state governments had none. Moreover, the Zamindars in Bihar did not give records to the government even after losing a protracted battle in the courts. Efforts to create records and initiate fresh surveys and settlement had to be undertaken, and they expectedly faced active opposition and subversion from the feudal forces and their minions. This provided full scope to musclemen and unscrupulous elements of all varieties.

Many zamindars gifted large tracts of land, particularly in Bihar, but they themselves did not know full details of the land, at least when they submitted gift letters. To follow up the matter and get details was a strenuous task.

Gap between bhoodan and the land-distribution was bound to result in the waning of the spirit with which gifts were given. Some of the donors, or their heirs, were bound to procrastinate and even back out. Some of the gifted lands were uncultivable, under dispute or in the possession of tenants. Creation of a long chain of intermediaries had complicated matters as regards the rights of different stakeholders in the land.

The grantees belonged to the poorest of the poor. They lacked means and inputs like bullocks, seeds etc. The Movement did seek gift of these along with the land, but there were limitations. It was the duty of society and the State to provide inputs. Schemes to provide credit on easy and non-exploitative

terms should have been framed. Nothing of this sort happened; in fact, institutional credit was denied to them as they lacked full rights over lands, and therefore could not mortgage them.

Completion of procedures involved substantial expenses, which were difficult for the Movement to arrange. The state governments constituted the Boards, but prevaricated in providing sufficient resources to them, both technical and financial. Situation expectedly became worse after the demise of Vinoba and other towering leaders.

Still, the Movement did its best to distribute as much land in as best a manner as it could. After studying the distribution in Vidarbha region of Maharashtra, researchers K.R. Nanekar and S.V. Khandewale conclude, "While distributing the land, all the guidelines and laws have generally been adhered to."¹¹ Can it be said about the land-distribution by the revenue authorities?

The problem of evictions

Delay in confirmation of gifted lands and in the mutation of distributed lands was, to use a mild term, criminal. Even now, after so many years, much land in Bihar remains to be confirmed/mutated. Lack of mutation meant lack of revenue assessment. This made the position of the grantee vulnerable; lack of revenue receipt made it all the more so. This inevitably resulted in large-scale evictions of bhoodan holders. In fact, it was the duty of the State to give them actual and effective possession of the land. It was the duty of the State to protect the poor and vulnerable bhoodan holder from powerful feudal forces in the countryside, which had continued to have sway even after Independence. It was the duty of the State to take preventive measures and tackle the problem when it arose. It had the responsibility, and had also necessary resources and means. No voluntary organisation can ever be capable of discharging such responsibility.

In fact, it was the State who was responsible for the genesis of the problem and its aggravation, in part at least. The talk of land reform legislation without expeditious steps in that regard alarmed the landowners who resorted to evictions of even

established tenants. Provision of the right to keep self-cultivated land (*khudkasht*)—which included even the land cultivated by employing outside labour—in laws made a mockery of the reform. Vinoba did not mince matters, as he pointed out, “It is the result of this *khudkasht* provision that the owners are evicting farmers. Government is responsible for evictions.”¹²

Often big landlords would secure forged documents from the former employees of zamindars and evict bhoodan holders. Forest department, claiming monopoly over forests, would evict bhoodan holders, while revenue department would distribute land already distributed by bhoodan committees. Such cases were not quite rare.

The evictions could be seen as a reflection of the fear psychosis in the landowners, that the days of their ownership were numbered. In this sense, it was an indication of the impact of bhoodan which had undermined the very idea of land-ownership.

The malady was not restricted to bhoodan holders; it was widespread. For example, it was found in a survey in the Hyderabad state that out of the protected tenants in 1951, 2.6% were legally evicted, 22.1% were illegally evicted and 17.5% ‘voluntarily surrendered’ their tenancy rights in four years.¹³ This ‘voluntary surrender’ of tenancy rights was nothing but a euphemistic term for forcible eviction: why would tenancy right be surrendered voluntarily, and that too on such a scale?

What could the Movement have done in this regard? It was not possible for it to fight a large number of cases in law courts. It had neither resources nor time. Still, efforts were made in some cases. *Buddhidan* (gift of intellect) was sought from lawyers—that is, they were requested to fight the cases free of charge. Moreover, it was difficult, if not impossible, to get justice in courts, which too were under the influence of vested interests. Vinoba was not, therefore, much in favour of litigation.

Another remedy was satyagraha. But that was easier said than done. The evicted farmers, the poorest of the poor, were too emasculated to fight for their rights, and it was not possible

to mobilise other sections of society for their cause. Efforts to organise them and inform them with the spirit of satyagraha had necessarily to be a long-drawn process. Moreover, it was necessary to avoid anything that could have vitiated the climate of harmony and unity which the Movement was seeking to develop in the countryside. There was also the risk of exploitation of such agitations by political parties resulting in the escalation of class-struggle, which Sarvodaya wanted to avert, as it held that the solution lay not in class struggle, but in the elimination of classes through joint efforts of all the classes. In this view, Vinoba preferred to appeal to the divine element in the wrongdoers. It is the firm belief of satyagraha that a human being has innate goodness in him, which can be aroused:

“Many say that people give land on the one hand and mercilessly evict peasants on the other. They are thus duping Baba (Vinoba). Their gifts are mere sham. Evictions reflect their true nature. I think otherwise. I believe that the gifts reveal their true nature; for, tendency to give is a quality of the Self. The eviction is a result of circumstances. The government is not making law, but is talking of it since four years. - - - Greed is there in a human being, and fear is also there, and that is causing circumstantial failing.”¹⁴

It was not that moral persuasion was not yielding any tangible result. Senior worker from Himachal Pradesh, Dharamdev Shastri wrote in 1952 that evictions in the region had stopped with the advancement of bhoodan due to its moral influence.¹⁵

It may also be mentioned that Vinoba used to reject a land-gift, if he came to know that the donor had evicted peasants. He would, at times, seek the gift of concerned land from the owner—and such was his moral aura that he would frequently get it, and then grant the land to the evicted peasant.

Although Vinoba was not, in general, in favour of agitational satyagrahas, his consistent advice to the peasants was to stay on their land with determination, refusing to get evicted. This was also a form of satyagraha. At times, Vinoba did give permission to agitational satyagrahas also.

The realisation that something is unjust is the first step towards its elimination. Dharendra Majumdar once asked workers fighting against evictions whether their agitation had aroused in the peasants an awareness of the unjustness of eviction. When they said yes, Dhirendrabhai said, "Then you need not worry. If you are successful in arousing awareness of the unjustness of evictions, you have done your work. That awareness would eventually end the practice."¹⁶

Ultimately, unity and organisation of the villagers, that is, building up power of the village communities was the real remedy. That was what gramdan sought. What it offered was a lasting solution, but it could not have an immediate impact. The Movement could not give clear guidance to the workers nor could formulate an effective programme to tackle the problem in the immediate present. The homilies could not have much impact on the perpetrators; nor could they satisfy the victims or the workers, who continued to rue that their image as partisans of the poor was getting affected and felt guilty for not doing anything concrete for the poor.

Positive features

The problem of evictions was serious, but it needs to be noted that it was not as serious elsewhere as it was in the erstwhile zamindari areas. Most of the grantees in most of the states did get effective possession of the land granted and they and their successors continued to enjoy the fruits of their labour. An independent agency surveyed Wardha district in Maharashtra in 1964 and found that 73% land out of 13,487 acres received in the district had been distributed (4% remained to be distributed and 23% could not be distributed, being disputed, uncultivable or in too small fragments) and 89% of the bhoodan holders were cultivating the granted lands.¹⁷ Even in Bihar, where the problem was (and is) the most acute, the Bihar Bhoodan Committee found in a survey of three districts in 1967 that 70-80% of the grantees were in possession of the granted lands and were cultivating them.¹⁸

Just as at the time of gifts, distribution also witnessed morally elevating atmosphere at many places. However, the

media mostly ignored such incidents—it had news value only for the political and sensational news. Even the Sarvodaya journals failed in projecting them in an effective way. Vinoba had once told a worker:

“In Hazaribagh district (Bihar) 52,000 acres were distributed. No one knows how many fascinating incidents might have occurred there. In Solapur (Maharashtra), 5,000 acres were received and when the land was distributed after a gap of five years, all except 20-25 acres was distributed. Should not the Bihar people know this? What happens in a violent war? There are many fronts; and even when the soldiers are losing on other fronts and there is some advancement on one front, the news in this regard is quickly conveyed to other fronts to keep up their morale. We should also see to it that the laudable incidents during land-distribution become known all over India.”¹⁹

At many places, fresh gifts were received on the spot at the time of distribution when it was found that the land available was not enough for all the landless in the village. To give an example, 35 acres had been received in village Maniyar in U.P.; 60 acres were received at the time of distribution. At Khejadi (U.P.) only ten decimal land had been received; the land received at the time of distribution was as much as 40 acres.²⁰

Land to S.C. and S.T.s

It was the demand of Dalits that had led to the genesis of bhoodan. It had been laid out that at least one-third land should be given to them. In practice, most of the bhoodan land reached Dalits, Adivasis and other backward communities, as they were preponderant in the class of agricultural labourers. Viyogi Hari of Harijan Sevak Sangh had once observed on the basis of his experience that 80% land had gone to Dalits at many places.²¹

Concrete figures corroborate this surmise. In a field study in Vidarbha (Maharashtra) in 1969, 66% of the land was found to have been granted to the Dalits and Adivasis.²² In undivided Bihar, in the year 2000, the percentage of land given to the Dalits, Adivasis and other backwards stood at 31%, 31% and 28% respectively. The figures for Bihar in July 2012 were 42%,

8% and 36% respectively.²³ The respective figures for Andhra Pradesh as in March 2010 are 50% to Dalits and 29% to Adivasis.²⁴

Neglect and stagnation

In places where large tracts had been gifted and local landless were few in number, landless from outside were settled. Efforts were made to develop these localities as model villages. Many such settlements exist in Bihar, Rajasthan and other states.

A single tract of 88,750 acres (about 150,000 bighas) at Chhatargarh was gifted by a jagirdar in 1953. After the passing of Bhoodan Act, the land was duly vested in the Bhoodan Board in 1961. Most of this land was barren. However, the land became precious when Indira Gandhi Canal passed through it and the state government questioned the legality of the gift and stayed permanent allotment of the land. The matter dragged on for years, and in 1982, the government charged the Board for failure in distributing the land (which it itself had stayed) and asked it to surrender the land to the government! In 1986, it even sold 11,000 bighas to those displaced by a field firing range nearby. The Board filed suit in the court and stayed the sale. The government then got passed in the Assembly an amendment in the Bhoodan Act whereby it could order transfer of land from the Board if, in its view, it had failed in distributing it.²⁴ Vinoba himself termed the government stand as immoral.

In course of time, the Movement waned. Situation in the country also changed drastically. Bhoodan receded more and more from public view and from the agenda of even the Sarvodaya Movement. The stagnation was bound to lead to neglect. Hampered with the dearth of resources and funds and with little co-operation from the revenue bureaucracy, the Boards could do little to finish the work of land-distribution in reasonable time and the work dragged on.

Bhoodan holders deserved special attention; but even the facilities and concessions given to other cultivators were denied to them. They were starved of credit because land was not in

their names. In Haryana, farmers having less than 10 acres of land were exempted from land tax and certain charges, but bhoodan holders were denied these concessions as the land they were cultivating was vested in the Bhoodan Board, and they could not be treated as small farmers!²⁶

Lack of inputs therefore remained a problem for bhoodan holders. Sarva Seva Farms, formed in Tamil Nadu, worked in this direction in some parts of the country, mainly on the strength of funds received from abroad. Such efforts were destined to be limited and short-lived.

The present situation

Modification of Bhoodan laws were needed in the light of experience to make them more effective. They were indeed revised at times, but for different reasons. In Rajasthan, for example, the law was modified in 2008 to give *khatedari* rights to bhoodan holders. The bhoodan land is meant to be given to the real needy as a permanent means of livelihood, and therefore it has been specifically laid down that it cannot be alienated. This is a provision for the protection of the allottee. Its removal was surely against the spirit of bhoodan.

The Bhoodan Acts had been repealed in West Bengal and Madhya Pradesh. Wherever they exist in statute books, they are not being properly implemented. Boards have not been constituted despite legal provision in many states like U.P., Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Jharkhand, Punjab, Haryana, and Karnataka. In Odisha, a government official heads the Board; members have not been nominated. In Rajasthan, litigation is understood to have brought the work to nought. As the Boards did not have uninterrupted existence, their records are in shambles. The state of records is dismal at most of the places. The Movement should, in fact, have endeavoured to preserve the concrete evidence of its glorious achievements; its neglect in doing so is shocking.

Problems unforeseen at the time of bhoodan have arisen and the absence of clear guidelines for dealing with them is resulting in confusion and wrongdoings, sully the image of

the Movement. The problem of bhoodan lands that have now become part of urban or metropolitan areas is particularly posing intricate problems as the land mafia and the politically or financially powerful elements are eyeing them. As the Boards or committees, wherever they are working, are now staffed not by committed workers, but by paid employees having little understanding of the bhoodan philosophy and spirit, corruption has become unavoidable, particularly as the staff is paid meagrely. Bhoodan lands are being illegally alienated due to ignorance or even active connivance of officials in the revenue departments.

In spite of innumerable handicaps, the bhoodan boards and workers have distributed as much land as they could. As the figures tell, 64% of the land received in the country excluding Bihar and Jharkhand has been distributed (1.702 million out of 2.65 million acres) as against 72% (4.965 million out of 6.853 million acres) of the ceiling land.²⁷ The gap between bhoodan and its distribution is wide particularly in Bihar and Jharkhand due to various reasons like lack of authentic land records, faulty settlement, dominance of feudal elements and musclemen in the countryside, appalling corruption, withdrawal of forests from the land pool, and unending litigation.

Substantial area of land had been set aside as uncultivable and its present status is unknown. Only a comprehensive nationwide survey of all the distributed and undistributed bhoodan lands can reveal how much of that land can now be distributed, how much has been illegally alienated, from what records has the name of the bhoodan committee been removed and how much land is in possession of the rightful owners. But only the government can conduct such a survey; it is beyond the capacity of any non-governmental organisation. And this matter is far from its agenda. A magnificent legacy is thus in the danger of passing into oblivion. But, as the adage goes, those who forget the past have no future.

2. Bhoodan in the Context of Land Reforms

Inequality in landholding was a major problem, inviting urgent attention, on the eve of Independence. Redistribution of land was necessary not only for social and economic justice, but also for increasing production and moving speedily on the path of economic development. It was necessary for maintaining peace and preserving the newly-built democratic structure and newly-won political freedom. For the landless, land was not just a means of livelihood; landholding was also a measure of social status. Years of exploitation by the colonial regime and the dominant feudal elements in the countryside had made his condition pitiable and vulnerable. He wanted land, and enlightened public opinion in the country was in favour of land reforms to give him land; in fact, leaders of the freedom struggle had made a promise in this regard.

Abolition of zamindari

Zamindari had become an eyesore because of the blatant injustice in and excesses of the system. In British India, 57% of the land in individual hands was in the hands of zamindars.¹ Abolition of zamindari was naturally the first land reform attempted in Independent India. However, its progress was tardy because of resistance from zamindars, both overt and covert. The vested interests were influential in bureaucracy, judiciary and political class as well. Not surprisingly, bills in different state Assemblies remained pending for years, and the zamindars succeeded in delaying them and thereby defeating their purpose to a significant extent.

In Bihar Assembly, for example, a resolution for Zamindari abolition was passed in this regard in 1946, even before Independence, but the Act could come in force as late as in 1952. Even after that, the zamindars refused to hand over the land records to the government, which had to create them and

its own revenue administration in the zamindari areas. It absorbed in it the employees and agents of the zamindars on 'humanitarian grounds'. This had a detrimental effect as they were obliged to the zamindars and were under their pressure. The land records, on account of unending litigation and dominance of vested interests, could never be properly created; even today, Bihar lacks authentic land records. In U.P. too, zamindari abolition could take effect in 1952, six years after introduction of the bill in the assembly. Constitution had to be amended for the first time to remove zamindari abolition from the jurisdiction of law courts.

By 1953, zamindari abolition had been effected in most of the provinces—but not in all of them. In Kerala, it could take effect in 1969 and in Assam in 1970.

Zamindari was abolished, but the zamindars succeeded in retaining large areas of land by utilizing the provision of '*khud-kash*' (self-cultivated) lands—the law allowed employment of labourers on such 'self-cultivated' lands; it was sufficient if the labourers were paid wages in cash and not in the form of produce!

The zamindars also resorted to large-scale evictions of tenants. Report of the National Commission on Agriculture (1976) notes:

"So powerful was the eviction drive, that in the years immediately following the intermediary abolition legislation, the old tenancy arrangements between the landlords and tenants broke down and it took years for new arrangements to take shape. - - - The highly defective land records, the prevalence of oral leases, absence of rent receipts, non-recognition in law of share-croppers as tenants, and various punitive provisions of the tenancy laws were utilised by the landlords to secure the eviction of all types of tenants. Innumerable evictions were effected in the process of 'resumption' of land by landowners. Where law failed, evictions were effected through coercion, intimidation and even violence and the so-called 'voluntary surrenders' were secured even from protected tenants in very large numbers."²

Amendment to the Constitution also failed in curbing litigation. Besides, the government had neither resources to implement the measure immediately nor money to make lump sum payment of compensation, and therefore did it in stages. The zamindars received large sums as compensation, private property being a fundamental right in the Constitution. The total amount of compensation was estimated to be 6,700 million rupees.

This measure gave rights on land to a few protected tenants—those who held formal leases. But many of them had sub-leased the lands; so the actual cultivators got nothing. In fact, their position became more vulnerable. As far as land redistribution was concerned, the measure yielded nothing. As V.M. Dandekar and N. Rath note, “Abolition of intermediaries was basically a reform of revenue administration rather than a measure of land redistribution.”³

The State programmes and the landless

The Planning Commission accepted in the draft of the First 5-Year Plan:

“Schemes of land distribution are likely to confer somewhat restricted benefits on agricultural workers other than tenants. This is because in any scheme of distribution or resettlement the first claim will be that of tenants already working on lands, which may be taken over from the larger owners. In view of this difficulty, the contribution which the movement for making gifts of lands, which has been initiated by Acharya Vinoba Bhave, has special value, for it gives to the landless worker an opportunity not otherwise easily available to him.”⁴

It was an admission of its powerlessness to do something for the landless and also a tribute to nascent bhoodan. D.R. Gadgil, while delivering the presidential address to the 15th Annual Conference of the Indian Society of Agricultural Economics, quipped, “This can be only interpreted as meaning that the State itself considers it neither necessary nor possible to do anything for him (the landless worker).”⁵ This was the situation even though the planning body candidly acknowledged

that “to a large extent the pattern of economic and social organisation will depend upon the manner in which the land problem is resolved.”⁶

Dependence on food imports was a major concern at that time; and consequently, achievement of self-sufficiency in food was a prime goal. The Planning Commission believed that the landholdings should be ‘economic’—that is, of reasonably big size—in the interest of production. It had, therefore, apprehensions about land ceiling which was being advocated as an egalitarian measure. It instead supported co-operative farming. It also talked of co-operative village management, although nothing concrete was attempted in this direction.

Next to zamindari abolition, tenancy reform was on the agenda of the government. It included control on rent and protection to the tenants and sharecroppers. Laws were enacted in this regard in many states. But this measure also left unprotected a large number of actual tillers who did not have formal leases. They remained vulnerable to eviction.

Community Development Programme was initiated with much fanfare as a key to the revitalisation of rural India. A massive bureaucratic structure was established for the purpose. But there was nothing in it to address the inequality in landholding. The landless did not gain anything either from the abolition of intermediaries or from the Community Development Programme.

Land ceiling: the first phase

Land ceiling was being talked about since pre-Independence times. The Congress, which was spearheading the freedom struggle, talked about relief to the peasants, but took care not to antagonise the landlords as far as possible. Its National Planning Committee advocated land ceiling for the first time in 1945. Subsequently, the Congress Agrarian Reforms Committee (1947) chaired by J.C. Kumarappa recommended ceiling of three times the size of an economic holding.

However, the Planning Commission postponed the matter on the ground that authentic data was not available, although

it accepted it in principle. It asked the states in 1953 to collect the data, which proved to be a good excuse for them to postpone the matter. In fact, there was no reason for dilly-dallying in such a pressing matter. No step was taken to expedite data-collection and no financial help was given by the Centre to the states for this purpose. And the figures that were ultimately collected through sample surveys were hardly useful for policy-making. Report of the National Commission on Agriculture (1976) admits:

“(T)he question of ceiling on landholding was pushed into the background during the first six years of Independence by measures relating to zamindari abolition. The fact of the matter is that the Indian agrarian policy was very much influenced at that time by the belief that agricultural production could be increased only by larger farms, using modern techniques, and that small scale farming was the main cause of backwardness of Indian agriculture. The imposition of ceilings which would split up large farms was, therefore, considered a retrograde step.”⁷

Vinoba questioned the very idea of having ceiling at a higher level than the optimum holding:

“I do not understand this talk about ceiling. If a family needs 5 or 6 acres, why should it have the right to hold 4-5 times more land? To give such right means to deprive many people of the right to land. Land is for everyone; why can't all have right on it? The village land belongs to all of the villagers. People talk of ceiling. I do not stand in their way. But that is not enough to achieve what I want. My job would not be finished until every son of the soil has right over land.”⁸

An article in ‘Sarvodaya’, the Movement’s mouthpiece, expressed the apprehension that ceiling would break up the institution of joint family, which had been the backbone of our culture: “Partitioning (of land) on paper would eventually lead to actual partitioning.”⁹ That indeed was the result.

Planning Commission constituted a committee on land reforms for the first time in May 1955, to give suggestions for the Second Five-Year Plan. This committee constituted a sub-

committee to consider the question of ceiling. The sub-committee accepted ceiling in principle, again as an egalitarian measure only, and suggested ceiling of three times the economic holding. Most of the states paid no heed to its recommendation. In the Second Plan too, emphasis was on increasing production. The Commission recommended distribution of surplus land obtained through ceiling to tenants displaced by the landlords who had taken over their lands for 'self-cultivation', and to the peasants with uneconomic holdings and the landless. Thus, the claims of the landless were the last to be considered. Panjabrao Deshmukh, the Central Minister of Agriculture, was of the view that the surplus land should better be given to small farmers rather than to the landless in the interest of production.¹⁰

The enactment of ceiling laws was, therefore, sluggish. As the Report of the National Commission (1976) notes,

"In the whole pattern of development under the Plans, ceiling on agricultural property remained until about 1960 only a vague politico-economic concept lurking in the background."¹¹

By 1961, ceiling laws were in place in most of the states. However, the levels prescribed were quite high and a large numbers of exceptions were provided. Thus, in Andhra, a family of five persons could legally hold on to 1620 acres! The landlords effected transfers, many of them fictitious, anticipating legislation. Nothing was done to stop them; in fact, they were allowed even after the laws came in force. Some states even allowed 'grace periods' for effecting transfers after legislation!

Sarva Seva Sangh passed a resolution at the Jagannathpuri (1955) stating that the landless was not getting any land through ceiling; in fact, the law was putting its seal on the inequality in landholding.¹² In its Bangalore meeting (1960) it again expressed its considered opinion:

"It is a basic principle that everyone who wants to cultivate land with his own labours should have an opportunity to do so. This is what social justice demands. If the ceiling laws are to fulfil this purpose, the limit should be in consonance with

this aim. It means that there should be flooring instead of ceiling. The ceiling limits that are being prescribed in the laws have no relation to the average landholding in India. - - - The Planning Commission officials themselves estimate that not more than 0.7 to 0.8 million acres would be available for redistribution, even if all the states enact such laws.”¹³

The Third and the Fourth Five-Year Plan had hardly anything concrete to make the measure effective. Lack of political will, loopholes in laws and administrative laxity made a mockery of the measure. There were serious differences amongst the policy-makers. As the Central Minister of Agriculture himself continued to give vent to his opposition to ceiling (on the ground that it was not appropriate to impose ceiling on landholding when no such limit had been fixed on incomes and wealth of other kinds), the general secretary of the ruling Congress party was constrained to express regret about the questioning of accepted policies by those in the government!¹⁴

When Bihar government formed a land tribunal to discourage litigation in the context of ceiling laws, Patna High Court quashed the move. Madhya Pradesh government made a law that surplus land obtained through ceiling could be distributed even if under litigation and despite stay orders; in the event of an adverse court verdict, the allottee would be paid compensation as per market rate. Parts of the law were declared null and void by the court. Such was the judicial response when the governments tried to make the measure effective.

And as for the attitude of bureaucracy, it may be mentioned that the staff in the Bihar secretariat came out on the streets to protest against land reforms in 1954. Bihar's Revenue Secretary issued stern orders to stop registration of tenants, warning that disobedience of the instruction would be seriously dealt with!¹⁵ Planning Commission's Task Force on Agrarian Relations (1972) observed that

“(T)he attitude of bureaucracy towards the implementation of land reforms is generally lukewarm and even apathetic. This is, of course, inevitable because as in the case of men who

wield political power, those in the higher echelons of the administration are also substantial landowners themselves or they have close links with big landowners.”¹⁶

During 1967-1971, non-Congress coalition governments were formed in many states, but they too did little in this regard. According to Nirmal Chandra, the Land Reforms Commissioner of Bihar told Jayaprakash Narayan, who was trying to goad on the government to implement land reforms, “These people are wasting your time. They absolutely lack political will.”¹⁷ Nirmal Chandra also reports that Karpoori Thakur, the Socialist Chief Minister, told him, “The moment we touch the land reforms, the powerful landlords will behead us!”¹⁸

Jammu and Kashmir abolished jagirs and fixed ceiling at 22.75 acres of arable land. The state’s implementation of land reforms was being trumpeted as a success story. Daniel Thorner went to the state in April 1953. He found that,

“(L)and reform in Kashmir has clearly done away with the jagirs and has weakened the position of all the great landlords. It has distinctly benefitted those individuals who, at the village level, were already the more important and influential people. It has done the least for petty tenants and landless labourers - - - India’s most publicized land reforms cannot be said to have succeeded in improving the economic lot of the Kashmiri peasant.”¹⁹

By the end of the seventh decade, it had become clear that the ceiling had failed to make much dent in the inequality in landholding. There were many claimants on the ceiling-surplus lands. In some states there was practice of auctioning such lands. They were also being given in consideration of payments, and to political sufferers, ex-servicemen etc.

How much land the landless could be expected to get then? Sugata Dasgupta reports that V.T. Krishnamachari conceded while talking to a study team that their plans had nothing for the landless.²⁰ H. Venkatasubbiah writes,

“The Planning Commission failed to face the question of landless labourers squarely - - - It was Acharya Vinoba Bhave who comprehended the problem of the landlessness in

its logical light - - -²¹

By December 1970, ceiling acts in different states had made available only 2.564 million acres, substantial part of which was uncultivable. Out of this only 1.178 million acres had been distributed²², while the Bhoodan Movement had been able to distribute 1.216 million acres by July 1970 despite several constraints.²³ The details are given in the table below.

Land distribution through ceiling and bhoodan (1970)

<u>State</u>	<u>Land acquired (acres)</u>	<u>Land distributed (acres)</u>	<u>Land distributed through bhoodan</u>
<u>(acres)</u>			
1. Andhra	72,900	-	1,03,351
2. Assam	67,200	-	265
3. Gujarat	40,800	13,800	50,924
4. Mysore	-	-	2,123
5. J & K	4,44,800	4,44,800	5
6. M.P.	74,750	12,350	1,73,063
7. Kerala	-	-	5,774
8. Delhi	-	-	180
9. Rajasthan	-	-	84,781
10. H.P.	-	-	2,531
11. Bihar	-	-	3,91,400
12. Orissa	-	-	96,464
13. Maharashtra	3,75,600	1,15,150	70,950
14. Punjab,			
Haryana	3,69,500	1,14,100	3,601
15. Tamil Nadu	25,000	15,500	16,394
16. U.P.	2,37,800	1,19,200	2,10,091
17. W.Bengal	8,55,600	3,43,000	3,898
<i>Total</i>	<i>25,63,950</i>	<i>11,77,900</i>	<i>12,15,795</i>

The figures are revealing. Not a single acre had been obtained through ceiling in states like Bihar and Rajasthan, where the pattern of landholding was extremely skewed. Only two states—Jammu and Kashmir and West Bengal—accounted for more than two-third distribution of ceiling-surplus lands. And when it is also taken into account that these lands were not given to the landless only, unlike bhoodan lands, the performance of ceiling was decidedly pale as compared to bhoodan.

Enthusiasm for land reforms gradually waned, particularly because of food crisis in early 1960s. Clamour for increased productivity pushed land reforms in the background.

Ceiling: the second phase

Two developments, however, brought the matter into focus again. Unrest in rural India was giving rise to violence, and Naxalism was spreading as a consequence. Secondly, the power struggle within the ruling Congress party caused split in it in 1969 and Prime Minister Indira Gandhi gave the slogan '*Garibi hatao*' (Remove poverty). She thought it necessary to project herself as a messiah of the poor. It was imperative in this context that land reforms should come into focus again.

A conference of Chief Ministers was held in November 1969 to review land reforms. It was decided to raise the ceiling limits and plug the loopholes. Another such conference followed in July 1972, which laid down the 'National Guidelines' that were to govern the ceiling legislation in future. They included lowering ceiling limits, making family a unit, reducing exemptions and lowering compensation for acquired lands. Accordingly, laws were amended in the states. To circumvent litigation which was still continuing, Constitution was amended for the 34th time, providing that ceiling laws would not be challenged on the ground of being inconsistent with the Constitution.

Emergency was declared in June 1975 and expeditious implementation of ceiling laws and distribution of surplus lands was included as an important item in the 20-point Programme.

Land distribution programmes were held with much fanfare. But, as P.S. Appu comments, political will was not as evident in the matter of land reforms as it was in 'subverting the democratic process and snuffing out civil liberties.'²⁴

The latest available figures (2008) about the performance of ceiling laws are:

Land declared surplus	68,53,624 acres
Land acquired	59,89,867 acres
Land distributed	49,64,995 acres

Thus, all the state governments together have been able to distribute hardly double of the land distributed through bhoodan despite having all the resources, laws and law-enforcing machinery at their command. P.S. Appu sums up,

"- - -the enforcement of ceiling laws did not lead to any substantial redistribution of agricultural land - - - On the whole, the results achieved have not been commensurate with the amount of time, money and labour invested in the enactment and enforcement of the ceiling laws. Indeed, the game was not worth the candle!"²⁵

An article on the official website of the Planning Commission draws the same conclusion:

"It may be inferred that the steps taken by the Government have not made any significant impact on the agrarian structure to reduce, let alone eliminate, the inequality in the distribution of land or income or to afford to lend the poor the access to the land. It is also true that the land reforms did not seriously jeopardize the interest of the landholders. The structural impediments to production and equitable distribution of rural resources are very much in existence."²⁶

It may be mentioned that the agricultural census in 1970-71 had estimated the surplus land to be 30 million acres.²⁷ Actually, not even 7 million acres could be so declared. Land redistributed is not even 2% of the arable land. The record of the State-driven land reforms appears all the more dismal when compared to the performance of land reforms in other countries.

Latest figures for land distribution through ceiling and bhoodan are given in the following table.

Land distribution through ceiling and bhoodan (latest)

<u>State</u>	<u>Land distributed through ceiling (acres)</u>	<u>Land distributed through bhoodan (acres)</u>
1. Andhra Pradesh	5,97,461	1,08,804
2. Assam	5,45,875	877
3. Gujarat	1,61,805	50,984
4. Karnataka	1,26,122	3,663
5. J & K	-	5
6. M.P.	1,34,188	2,37,629
7. Chhattisgarh	60,680	
8. Kerala	76,676	5,774
9. Delhi	-	180
10. Rajasthan	4,65,517	1,42,699
11. H.P.	6,167	2,531
12. Bihar	3,05,512	2,56,659
13. Orissa	1,59,384	5,79,994
14. Maharashtra	5,42,788	1,10,261
15. Punjab	1,03,409	1,026
16. Haryana	1,01,169	2,043
17. Tamil Nadu	1,89,428	22,837
18. U.P.	2,62,755	4,18,958
19. W.Bengal	11,13,172	9,000
20. Jharkhand	876	4,88,735
21. Others	12,011	
<i>Total</i>	<i>49,64,995</i>	<i>24,42,625</i>

Limitations of laws

The gap between the land declared surplus under ceiling, the land actually acquired, and the land that had been distributed needs to be noted. The quality of the land acquired and distributed, and the worthiness of the beneficiaries are also areas that need to be studied to have a true picture. Critics, who have alleged, without any evidence, that bhoodan lands were mostly of poor quality, have cared little to carry out research in these areas. In fact, it can be safely surmised that landowners must have tried to give the worst lands under ceiling, as it involved coercion. The manner of distribution of surplus lands acquired under ceiling also calls for review to see whether the procedure allows scope for corruption and favouritism.

The procedure of enactment of laws is quite slow. The governments, compelled by public opinion to enact pro-people laws, are known for procrastination. Loopholes and ambiguities are left in the laws. Laws passed by the legislature are not promptly sent for Presidential assent, nor is the matter of obtaining that assent promptly followed up. Rules are not framed for years, making the laws inoperative in practice.

Vinoba was often asked during his *yatra* why was he not attempting land distribution through the State, and he had to repeatedly explain the limitations of laws.

Thus, in Mamandu (3 May 1956) he said,

“No doubt, there are three ways of solving the land problem. Other countries have resorted to violence, but we are not in favour of this way. Law is another way, and we do not obstruct it. Rather, our work facilitates it. But there are many impediments in this way. From the spiritual point of view, it does not solve our main problem, as it does not generate people's power. It does not arouse compassion; rather it creates bitterness. If the way of compassion succeeds in solving the problem to a great extent and then the law puts its seal on it, that law is acceptable to us; otherwise, there are several defects in the way of legislation.

“Moreover, we find that laws have hardly been able to

achieve much. The reason is that those in positions of power are themselves landowners. Therefore, the talk of gradually imposing ceiling goes on, and before enactment, the owners are able to effect land transfers. So, we are not enthusiastic about law. We prefer to follow the way of compassion, of building up people's power, of transforming people's hearts. This is the only way for the solution of land problem."²⁹

At times, he would be blunt enough to comment,

"Those who have amassed lands after Independence have governments in their hands now. These governments cannot cut the branch (of a tree) on which they are sitting."³⁰

Legal acquisition involves payment of compensation. Vinoba asked for and got donation of compensation amounts. He asked and got at times the donation of inputs to the land allottees. He got land from small farmers as well, while ceiling can take land from the bigger landlords only. Ceiling generated resentment and bitterness in the landlords; they tried to circumvent it. Bhoodan generated an atmosphere of goodwill.

Law cannot go against public opinion. If it does, it cannot succeed. It can succeed only if it follows public will. Then will not the direct exertion of public will be more effective? That was Vinoba's argument.

"I believe that if law, which represents indirect will of the people can have results, then the exertion of the direct will of the people must give results, and that too quickly, easily and in an elegant manner."³¹

Hastening and facilitating land reforms

Bhoodan created in its first phase such an atmosphere that prices of lands, and consequently their sale dropped significantly, particularly in Bihar, where intensive work was carried out. Legislation on land reforms was not only facilitated but also hastened. As Chester Bowles, ambassador of the United States to India, noted, it became increasingly difficult for the landlords to seek more compensation when many were gifting lands without compensation. He therefore expressed the hope:

“As Vinoba’s efforts spread, the power of the people will force the swift enactment of the long overdue land reform laws. Then all the creative energy, now of necessity going into Bhoodan, can go into the reconstruction of the country. Thus it may be that Vinoba will accomplish far more than he imagines.”³²

In fact, Vinoba had imagined all this.

That bhoodan facilitated land reforms was conceded by those in power, who were serious about land reforms. Thus, Pandit Nehru acknowledged that the Movement had engendered a new consciousness in the people and changed the atmosphere in the country:

“This had directly resulted in the solution of the problem to some extent; but indirectly, it has motivated the government and other people to solve the problem in a satisfactory manner.”³³

Voluntary character

All the land reforms in different parts of the world had been State-driven, and therefore involved coercion. It was the Bhoodan Movement alone which strove to achieve them outside the ambit of government and on a purely voluntary basis. It thus showed to the world a way which had hitherto been inconceivable. As economists Nanekar and Khandewale opine,

“The modest success of the Bhoodan Movement deserves to be lauded as this endeavour to solve an extremely important problem in a vast undeveloped country like India on a non-governmental level and on such a great scale was unprecedented.”³⁴

Lack of studies

It is an irony of fate that such a unique movement and its potentialities were not adequately studied. It was perhaps natural, because academic discourse of the time was inordinately influenced by Marxists who were annoyed with Vinoba for upsetting their applecart by dousing the fire in Telangana. Their heavily prejudiced approach coupled with the Movement’s

neglect of documentation and research left a serious gap in the academic discourse.

P.C. Joshi rightly notes that social scientists in India concentrated more on the land reform laws to the neglect of other efforts; only a few studied Bhoodan-Gramdan Movement, but that too as a social movement, not as an experiment about land reforms. Hardly any empirical studies were carried out by the economists.³⁵

Not only studies were (and are) needed, they needed to have a sensibility and sensitivity that such a movement deserved. D.R. Gadgil had said,

“The movement is so original in its conception, so novel in its methods, and so revolutionary as to its objectives that special effort has to be made to understand it and to place it in its proper perspective.”³⁶

The current situation

Planning Commission held a seminar on land reforms in June 1989. It concluded that the economic grounds of land reforms were still relevant and needed to be pursued in the interest of increase in productivity and distributive justice.³⁷ It was also pointed that 80% of legal disputes in district and lower courts pertained to land, mainly because of lack of authentic land records.³⁸ This was also one of the major reasons for the promise of bhoodan remaining unfulfilled.

Land reforms, however, continued to recede in the background. After the inauguration of new economic policy with thrust on privatisation, liberalisation and globalisation, the whole economic scene changed drastically. D. Bandyopadhyay comments,

“In 1991, when the neoliberal economic policy hit India with a thunderous gale force, land reform went off the radar screen of the Indian polity. It became a forgotten agenda of state policy.”³⁹

Land reforms may have passed out of sight of the powers that be, but has their centrality diminished as far as the people

are concerned? For the policy-makers, so-called growth in G.D.P. and so-called development may matter more than equitable redistribution of resources, but the latter still remains the key to true freedom, which is still eluding us. Therefore, the necessity to engage with the land problem, which has become more complex, still persists. Land-grabbing by the high and mighty continues unabated. In parts of rural India, if not everywhere, the nexus of money power and muscle power in collusion with politicians holds sway. The State and private corporations are grabbing land and displacing people on an alarming scale. Corporate farming has come to stay. With agriculture becoming totally dependent on inputs from outside and the agriculturist not getting sufficient return for his labours, agriculture has become a losing proposition leading to farmers' suicides on an unprecedented scale. The pernicious idea of 'eminent domain' is playing widespread havoc.

The problem persists. But the futility of the way of violence has become all the more manifest and it has become abundantly clear that the State cannot be relied on to solve the problem. The only alternative is the way of nonviolence, of compassion, of empowering the people and building strong, self-reliant communities.

That is the way of gramdan. Bhoodan, as Vinoba repeatedly said, was never seen as a remedy. It was only a temporary token measure to assure the last man. Increase in population is bound to lead to fragmentation of land and the small farmer is bound to lose land sooner or later. Land problem can never be solved as long as private property in land persists. Its solution lies in the abolition of land-ownership. Land should belong to all. That is what gramdan stands for.

3. Bhoodan-Yajna: an Evaluation

Mission brought in focus

Years of slavery and exploitation had broken India's backbone; to lift the country out of the mire was a challenge so enormous as to beggar all description. It needed pooling of all the energies in the nation. However, the spirit generated during the freedom struggle was fast waning in Independent India. Gandhi had called for conversion of the Indian National Congress, the biggest mass organisation in the country, into Lok Sevak Sangh, so that it could become a vehicle of the struggle for 'social, moral and economic independence in terms of seven hundred thousand villages'.¹ But the Congress had preferred to become a political party in the conventional sense. Moreover, it was enamoured by the modern 'development' which was to be thrust from above and carried out by the bureaucracy inherited from the British Raj. For Gandhi, constructive work was the means for attaining '*poorna swaraj*' (perfect self-rule), but the constructive workers were disheartened and confused about their role in the new order. There was every likelihood of the constructive work losing popular support and getting co-opted by the establishment.

It was bhoodan, which came as a breath of fresh air, that renewed hope. Jayaprakash Narayan had rightly said,

"There was a time when none was able to say how to proceed and where. The common people were then under the expectation that the close followers of Gandhiji would show the way to transform society, which Gandhiji would, of course, have done, had he been alive. But after his exit, the entire prospect was of utter darkness. Had not Vinobaji launched the Bhoodan-Yajna campaign, we would have forgotten Gandhiji and forgotten Sarvodaya; we would have lost faith in what Gandhiji said and done, and the path of Sarvodaya would have been blocked."²

Had bhoodan not appeared on the horizon, Gandhian rituals might have continued, but the revolutionary potential of the Gandhian vision would not have become manifest in the absence of a concrete programme. Bhoodan infused Gandhian workers with new enthusiasm, vigour and a sense of historical mission. To quote Jayaprakash again,

“Had Vinobaji not started such a revolutionary movement, we would have forgotten the idea of a nonviolent revolution and we would have lost the battle. - - - Had Vinobaji not come on the scene, and had we not had the benefit of his ideological purity, creative power and spiritual depth, Sarvodaya ideas would have been reduced to abstract and remote ideals.”³

Bhoodan made clear the Gandhian mission in the modern world.

Land to the landless

Bhoodan took up the land problem, which was the most complex and vexatious, yet the most urgent problem. The landless labourer was labouring on the land, which was not his, nor was he getting reasonable return for his labours. He was finding it difficult to meet two ends; had no guarantee about getting work even with meagre wages. Giving him land was the only way, not only for giving him an assured source of livelihood and for raising his social and economic status, but also for increasing agricultural production, which was sorely needed in the country that lacked self-sufficiency in food. This was needed not only as an egalitarian measure, but also as a step towards true freedom.

The government's steps for land reform were half-hearted because of pressure from the entrenched vested interests. Its endeavour was, moreover, restricted to abolition of intermediaries; the landless labourer had hardly anything to gain from those measures, and his patience was running out. His exasperation was likely to explode in violence. But violence was no remedy, as the experience of Telangana had demonstrated.

The government was embarking on so-called 'Community

Development' without touching the inequalities and injustices in the rural structure. Vinoba continued to warn time and again that things should be done in proper sequence: 'community development' and 'democratic decentralisation' without solving the land problem would inevitably end in the exploitation of the poor.⁴

Donating lands to places of worship was not uncommon; but gifting lands for the purpose of granting them to landless labourers, acknowledging their right to land, and that too on a significant scale is unheard of in the annals of history, and still remains beyond imagination.

Challenging the legitimacy of land-ownership

Land-ownership was deeply entrenched in society. The great Mahabharata War had taken place because Duryodhan had refused to give even as little land as the tip of a needle could hold. Dr. Rajendra Prasad had noted that people ready to go to jail and even to put their lives at stake during the freedom struggle would quail at the prospect of losing land.⁵ Naturally, the British would take recourse to attaching and auctioning lands to bring people to their knees.

Bhoodan attacked the moral legitimacy of land-ownership, which enjoyed legal sanction. No social injustice can be removed permanently and effectively unless and until its moral legitimacy becomes suspect in the public eye. Gandhi did the same thing while challenging untouchability, and thereby aroused a sense of guilt and remorse in the caste Hindus. Vinoba told the land-owners that holding on to land was morally wrong and they should gift land, accepting the right of the landless to the land. He told the landless that they had right to land, provided they were ready to labour on it. Had Gandhi not undermined the moral legitimacy of untouchability, mere legal measure would not have sufficed; and any agitation by the Dalits would have been doomed to failure. So would have been the fate of the State-sponsored land reforms in the absence of the atmosphere created by bhoodan.

Bhoodan contributed in highlighting not only economic but

also moral injustice in the pattern of landholding and showed a way to undo the same.

Vinoba thus provided an ethical basis to land reforms. D. Bandyopadhyay concludes at the end of a review of land reforms:

“Acharya Vinoba Bhave, a staunch Gandhian and a social activist who launched the Bhoodan Movement in India, used to end all his prayer meetings saying: ‘Land belongs to Gopal and all his children have equal right to its produce.’ This is the universal ethical basis of land reforms anywhere and everywhere.”⁶

Significantly, Vinoba did not allow the land-owners to hide behind Gandhi's concept of trusteeship by declaring unequivocally that we could not be the trustees of our lands, which did not rightfully belong to us: land belongs to the Lord.⁷

Heightening of moral sensibilities

A human being has in him a sense of fairness and justice, and a proclivity to share what he has with fellow human beings, howsoever dormant they may now appear because of circumstances and the social system, and they can be aroused by a moral appeal—that Vinoba not only argued, but demonstrated. He showed that people can come forward not only to give, not only to share, but also to sacrifice what they have even in this era of crass greed and pathological selfishness. There have been instances of individuals sacrificing their all, but making sharing a social movement had no antecedents. What Vinoba wanted was to arouse the good—what he called ‘*sattvaguna*’—which would control and subdue the wrong, distorted and evil tendencies. In a deep sense, therefore, the Movement was spiritual; and that was what Vinoba never tired of harping on. C. Rajgopalachari had aptly said,

“On deep analysis, I find that the objective of this Bhoodan movement is the revival of *dharma* in men, which they have now forgotten.”⁸

Critics have questioned, without any concrete evidence, the motive of the donors, alleging that they gifted lands to earn

plaudits and gain merit for the next birth. Some of the donors might have gifted lands with this motive; that is only natural. But to make unsubstantiated sweeping statements is, to say the least, irresponsible. Many donors donated income from the gifted lands till their distribution. Big landlords were alleged to have gifted lands to circumvent ceiling laws, but the critics forget that bhoodan had started years before ceiling laws became operative and that the landlords forwent compensation that they were entitled to when they gave bhoodan. Some landlords did give barren land or gave gift letters without sufficient details. But it would be wrong to assume that all of them did so intentionally. This would be unfair to many among them who honestly did not know the details of the lands; they gave details later and also gave good land when some of the gifted lands were found uncultivable.⁹

Babulal Gandhi probed the motives of the donors while distributing lands in Western Maharashtra. He found that 10-12% of the donors had given gifts with full understanding of the philosophy, and had therefore gifted one-sixth or even more of their landholdings. This is not a negligible percentage; in any revolution the number of those having full understanding of the ideology is small. While 38% had religious motive, 33% had donated because of social pressure—certainly moral pressure and not physical coercion. Those who donated just for show were 6-7% and those who had impure motive or gifted disputed lands were 7-8%. Thus the proportion of dishonest donors was no more than 15%.¹⁰ This is certainly not a high figure.

A study group in Odisha found that none of the donors had given gifts because of pressure. Only one of the donors complained of pressure, and what he meant was that the bhoodan worker had met him again and again!¹¹

Bhoodan aroused moral impulses not only in the landlords; there were instances of small and marginal farmers gifting their meagre lands, partially or even fully, and the landless forgoing their claims in favour of the more needy at the time of land-distribution.

The way the Movement morally elevated the workers is a

different story. Mention needs also to be made of its wider impact on the social psyche.

Building of people's power

Bhoodan made the people aware of their latent power, impressed upon them that they should, and could, solve their problems themselves; it was neither necessary to take recourse to violence nor seek and depend on the State intervention. And in the manifestation of this power and consequent action lay seeds of transformation in polity and politics. This is what Vinoba was visualising:

“Bhoodan-Yajna is a movement for augmenting people's power. Hence, it is not devoid of politics. Yet this movement is against conventional politics. That land will be redistributed through it will be its least gain; its most important result will be that people will realize their strength. They will be freed from the habit of expecting everything from the government and will have belief in their own capacities.”¹²

And therefore,

“(T)his work, which we are doing, is not merely for the solution of land problem, but also for elimination of the States from the whole world.”¹³

Therein lay the true significance of this Movement.

Satyagraha was, for Gandhi, the universal means for resisting injustice and bringing about individual and social transformation, as it arouses the latent power of the soul. For Vinoba, Bhoodan-Yajna was a sort of satyagraha, appropriate in the new context.

A movement with a difference

Radical total change in individual and society was the theme Vinoba harped on consistently and insistently. J.B. Kripalani saw in the Movement elements of a comprehensive revolution because, “when a revolution has once been started, ordinary individuals participating in it perform tasks which were never expected of them. Under the inspiration of a revolutionary

urge, they work wonders.” Citing examples from history, he pointed out that the same phenomenon was reappearing in the Bhoodan Movement.¹⁴ He, therefore, averred that the Movement should not be judged from what it actually achieved in terms of the solution of land problem:

“No revolution solves the problems which give rise to the revolution at once; what it does is to remove material and psychological barriers preventing the successful advent of new values. It is only subsequently that incorporation of these values in appropriate legal, political, economic and social institutions takes place.”¹⁵

It was a movement that was not just promising a golden age in future, it was giving tangible relief here and now—not a matter of little import in a country like India with its abject poverty. Secondly, the Movement was using and was committed to ethical means, resolutely rejecting instrumental morality, which is a hallmark of some so-called revolutionary theories.

Joining hearts

Bhoodan put before the Independent country a noble aim and a vision to build society. At a time when fissiparous tendencies were raising their heads in an already strife-torn country and when political rivalries were assuming ludicrous proportions, bhoodan strove to bring together people irrespective of caste, creed, gender, party, language etc. Bhoodan, as Vinoba said, proved to be a cementing factor, which was sorely missing in the country but which was direly needed.

For Vinoba, endeavour to solve the land problem was just a prop, a pretext, through which he wanted to unite people's hearts, to bring about a genuine heart-unity, which is an inescapable precondition for peace, progress and prosperity:

“The problem we have taken up is that of union. We want that there should be a unity of hearts. For this purpose, we have taken up as a pretext an issue like the land problem, which is a basic issue and whose solution is the demand of the age. Had we not taken up such an issue and simply

mouthed homilies telling people to live together amicably and love each other, it would have been futile. Many saints had told the same thing. People are used to hearing their sermons. But we do not just ask them to love each other, we ask them to provide a proof for it. When people give gifts, it proves that our message has penetrated their hearts. Uniting people's hearts is the main problem facing India."¹⁶

For this very purpose, Vinoba studied in depth the scriptures of all the major religions and presented the essence of their spiritual insights and the core of their teachings. He also presented the gist of the spiritual experiences of some saints, including the Maharashtra saints Jnanadev, Namadev, Eknath, Ramdas and Tukaram; and authored commentaries like that on Guru Nanak's 'Japuji' and Assamese 'Namaghosha'. Many such works appeared during the bhoodan tour. Suresh Ram has narrated one incident. When one such work was published, Vinoba commented that it was a by-product of their walking tour. Balvijay, his personal assistant, thereupon quipped whether such works were by-products of the *yatra* or the *yatra* was a by-product. Vinoba said, "Yes, it is a point worth pondering over!"¹⁷

That is why Vinoba considered his 'Talks on the Gita' as an effective vehicle of the message of bhoodan.

Wider implications

The Movement was not merely for the solution of land problem; it was not just socio-economic but spiritual as well, and therefore had much wider implications. As Vinoba said,

"Bhoodan-Yajna has created an atmosphere—the pre-eminence of moral values is being increasingly realised, a strong sentiment that social injustice should not be tolerated and should be ended is being generated, that the last man should be given attention first is being perceived by the people. I have called it '*Prajasooya yajna*'¹⁸ and '*Dharma-chakra-pravartan*'²⁰ and the voice of the dumb labourer. Compared to these, solution of the land problem is not of much importance. If this atmosphere and the vital spirit in it touches all, then not only the land problem but all the

problems would be solved, because all of them have at their base morbid tendencies and lack of understanding, and bhoodan strikes at both of them.”²⁰

In a deep sense, it was initiation of a new religion; rather, true religion was being established for the first time in human history—what had all along been considered religions were, in fact, denominations which, notwithstanding their positive role in the past, have now become anachronism in the age of science. Therein lay the true significance of bhoodan.

And it was not restricted to one country, as far as its ideological implications were concerned:

“I have often said that Japan has right over the land in Australia. Australia has less population and more land and Japan’s condition is just the opposite. The earth belongs to the Lord and to none else. The boundaries between nations are going to be obliterated; they are actually being obliterated. The world is going to be united. People in countries with less land have right to go to countries with more land. This is the message of bhoodan in the global context.”²¹

Bhoodan thus had seeds of the world revolution and world peace.

The technique of *padayatra*

Bhoodan Movement chose the technique of *padayatra* (walking tours) to approach the people. Sages, mendicants and *fakirs* had moved about on foot in the past. As far as socio-political agitations are concerned, Gandhi’s march in South Africa and the Dandi March and Mao Zedong’s Long March are well-known precedents. But it was in the Bhoodan Movement that the technique was first used extensively and consistently, and it subsequently became a popular technique in socio-political agitations all over the country.

When Vinoba started his first walking tour (1951), the idea of doing away with the money was certainly there, as he was engaged at that time in the experiment of *Kanchan-mukti*²². How can a revolutionary organisation mobilise necessary funds in a poor country? Moreover, if money is to be eschewed from

social intercourse, it is necessary that revolutionary work should not rely on money. In a walking tour, there is no question of travelling expenses and residents in the itinerary happily feed the trekkers. What's more, walking tour enables one to see the conditions on the ground at close quarters and gain love and confidence of the people. Vinoba, therefore, believed that in *padayatra* he had hit upon a new 'weapon'.²³

Walking university

The countryside was steeped not only in poverty but also in ignorance. The words 'Independence and 'democracy' meant little to the rural people. The world outside had cared little for them; at the most, they were objects of duping and exploitation. Vinoba and Sarvodaya workers reached out to the people even in the remote and almost inaccessible areas. There they did not just talk of bhoodan; they opened to them the treasures of knowledge. Tiny hamlets heard about profound ideas in philosophy and social sciences, and that too in the language that was easy for them to grasp. Vinoba would cite mythological stories and quote from the words of saints in their regions. He would teach them in the spirit of a true master. His tour was veritably a 'walking university':

"I do not only talk of whatever is necessary in connection with bhoodan; I put before the people the entire philosophy of Sarvodaya, which is a self-contained and constructive view of life, and discuss a good many matters within its purview. I also answer questions from the people on a wide variety of subjects. - - - Thus, what I do is what could be called free dissemination of knowledge."²⁴

If the mountain will not come to Mahomet, Mahomet must go to the mountain. Knowledge, if it remains confined to a few, can be dangerous. Bhoodan Movement caused knowledge to flow freely to the remotest corners of the country.

People would throng to listen, even to have a glimpse of the saint. They would brave scorching summer heat, incessant rains and chilling cold to have his *darshan* (sight). They would come in raging floods, sitting in boats.

Taya Zinkin describes a meeting:

“Never before in my experience of India had a meeting been silent. There is pindrop silence in the small courtyard where perhaps two hundred villagers squat. Babies do not whine, dogs have forgotten to bark. One can hear the sunset.”²⁵

Renowned writer Ramvriksha Benipuri describes a meeting:

“The saint talked for about an hour and a half. I was observing the faces of the listeners. They were as if trying to absorb every word. The sun was about to set, and the cold breeze was making the poor shiver. Yet they were not moving. Their eyes were fixed on the man sitting on the dais. - - - The discourse ended, meeting concluded, yet many continued to linger around (Vinoba’s) halting place as if they were tied by a rope.”²⁶

Such was the mood Vinoba’s talks would create. It would become difficult for landowners to turn a deaf ear to the appeal for land-gifts, and the clever among them would often prefer to leave the village before his arrival so as not to get influenced by the morally-surcharged atmosphere and gift land!

Reception in foreign countries

The Movement attracted attention of many sensitive souls in foreign countries also. Many came, joined Vinoba’s trek for a few days and then wrote or talked of their experiences and perception of the Movement. Hallam Tennyson, grandson of the celebrated poet Tennyson, wrote the book ‘Saint on the march’ (1955) which is a compelling piece of work. He also constituted a committee in England to mobilise funds for the Movement and roped in men like Bertrand Russell. ‘Manchester Guardian’ made an appeal to its readers to donate for the cause. Those who wrote on the Movement included Frank Horvat, Robert Trumbull, J.M. Prentice, Taya Zinkin, George Weller, Evelyn Reynolds and Arthur Koestler. Koestler also formed the committee named ‘Friends of Bhoodan’ in London. Many in the world thus perceived the potential of the Movement.²⁷

“Such events are without parallel in world history, and are the tonic which this spiritually weakening, bewildered age sorely

needs", wrote Wilfred Wellock.²⁸ Daniel Hoffman wrote,

"Bhoodan Movement is the first practical living example on a large scale in centuries that illustrate that man is a spiritually co-operative being. The deeper appeal of the movement is spiritual in nature, but its practical aspects present a fascinating story of human engineering and adventure."²⁹

France's Lanza del Vasto, after spending several days with Vinoba, wrote a book, which he termed 'not a tale but a call'.³⁰

Many in Japan, finding the bhoodan philosophy akin to Buddhist teachings, embraced the cause. A Sarvodaya ashram was established at Yoshiwara. A journal titled 'Sarvodaya' was started. Kodama Kametaro, a peasant leader, distributed all of his 500 acres land to his labourers.

There were instances of students in foreign countries fasting or working during holidays and sending the money so saved or earned to the Movement. Victor Thompson gifted his factory to the labourers, applying the principle of bhoodan to his industry. Shah of Iran told Satish Kumar that Vinoba's work had greatly inspired them.³¹

Bhoodan, as they all perceived, had a global significance; it was not just a movement for the solution of a particular problem in a particular country.

Women's liberation

Bhoodan contributed appreciably to the cause of women's liberation and empowerment, silently and unobtrusively, without inciting language and loud programmes. Gandhi brought the women in freedom movement and constructive work. Many women took part in satyagrahas and proved their mettle. During the Bhoodan Movement, many women freely took part in walking tours. Vinoba had once said,

"I find wonderful the part played by women in the progress of Bhoodan-Yajna. Many are engaged in the movement, leaving their studies, jobs and homes. They are few, but have worked a lot.³² - - - If you look at the history of bhoodan,

you will know how they moved about in the forests of Koraput (Odisha). That saga should have become known all over the country, but the country is hardly aware of this. The participation of women in this Movement is a remarkable page in history.”³³

Groups consisting of women only moved about fearlessly. It can be imagined how stirring and subversive this sight would have been in a society dominated by feudal and patriarchal values.

Women bhoodan workers gained access to women to whom none else could reach. They impressed on them the value of equality, motivated them to discard blind beliefs and binding systems like the *purdah*.

Arousing latent soul-power of the women was, for Vinoba, the effective way to liberate them in a true sense, unlike ‘Women’s liberation’ of the Western variety. He would, therefore, prefer the expression ‘*stri-shakti*’ (women’s power). Establishment of Brahmavidya Mandir at Pavnar for collective spiritual quest of women was Vinoba’s distinctive contribution to the cause.

In the quest of social equality

Bhoodan strove to further the cause of social equality in a society that had traditionally been marked by unequal and hierarchical relationships. It gave to the Dalits, the Adivasis and the backward communities a dignified and permanent source of livelihood, thereby raising their economic, and consequently social status. Bhoodan gave land to members of those castes which had hitherto been deprived of it. Kaka Kalelkar, chairman of the first Backward Classes Commission, had pointed out that out of about 3,000 castes in the country, only 15 to 20 traditionally owned land. Bhoodan gave land to others:

“Had not Saint Vinoba started this Bhoodan-Yajna, India’s frustrated downtrodden communities would have, in exasperation, revolted some day in a different manner and would have brought about their own destruction along with that of others.”³⁴

The downtrodden were given land not condescendingly, but with due regard. A landlord of the so-called higher caste applying the auspicious mark on the forehead of a Dalit labourer and giving him land in a public function must have been a liberating experience to both. As has already been stated, it had been expressly stipulated that at least one-third land would be given to the Dalits. (Figures of proportion of the Dalits in the allottees of bhoodan lands are given in the first chapter of Part 2.) Homestead land was also given to Dalits and other poor through bhoodan.

Problems of Dalits were often addressed during the walking tours for bhoodan, as and when they invited attention. Thus, when Vinoba was informed at Haldi (Madhya Pradesh) that Dalits were not allowed to draw water from public wells, he announced that he and other members of the tour party would not take food as long as the Dalits were prevented from drawing water. Needless to say, the disability was instantly removed.³⁵

Outsiders had traditionally been seen as looters and exploiters by the tribals. Those who extended humanitarian service to them had no qualms in utilizing the credibility earned thereby to convert and denationalise them. Selfless service of Sarvodaya workers had a special value in this context.

Contribution of bhoodan to the conscientization of backward communities in North India, particularly Bihar, the citadel of feudal lords belonging mostly to so-called higher castes, can be an interesting subject for research. A Naxalite had told a Sarvodaya worker, "You are doing sowing; we would do harvesting!"³⁶

Ennobling incidents

Vinoba worked with faith in the innate goodness in human heart, howsoever corrupted it may appear due to corroding circumstances, and it can be called out and activated. Many incidents during the Movement vindicated his faith. The ennobling incidents that occurred not only in the course of Vinoba's walking tour, but also in the course of work by other workers, constitute a saga worth treasuring. Some of them have

been described during the course of the chronological overview in earlier pages. Recounting some other incidents here will be apposite.

A farmer having 60 acres land gifted 5 acres. When his mother came to know of this, she expressed her displeasure for such a niggardly gift: Why had he given so small a gift when Vinoba was seeking one-sixth of the land? The farmer walked 13 km on the next day to Vinoba's next halt and gifted 10 acres.³⁷

Chimanrao Patil of Kasode (Maharashtra) gifted more than 14 acres, keeping only one acre for the family. His reasoning was: Why should one keep more land when the national average landholding was less than an acre? He was persuaded to change his mind, but remained firm on his resolve.³⁸

At Kodro (Bihar), a woman in tatters offered 0.4 acres in Vimala Thakar's meeting. She used to work as a housemaid, had two daughters and had only that much land. Vimala persuaded her to take back the gift, but she was adamant: "You are accepting gifts from others; why not my gift? Is it because I am poor? But did not Lord Krishna accept a fistful of parched rice from poor Sudama?" The next day, a farmer came to the halting place and said, "I had gifted 13 acres out of 50 acres I own. But I saw that destitute woman giving 0.40 acres. I could not sleep throughout the night. Please accept gift of 17 acres more." Many others gave additional gifts.³⁹

A Dalit man having only 5 bighas and twelve members in the family was accompanying the bullock-cart carrying the luggage of the tour party and was listening to people talking about bhoodan. He hesitatingly offered to gift from his meagre holding. Vinoba had to accept a few decimal (fraction of an acre) land to satisfy him.⁴⁰

Young Vimala Thakar went alone to the mansion of a zamindar notorious for being a drunkard and a vicious man. He asked in amazement, "Have you not heard about my unsavoury reputation?" Vimala said, "I have come to my brother." The zamindar, whom nobody expected to give anything, gifted 125

acres out of 500 acres he had, and even accompanied Vimala to seek bhoodan from others.⁴¹

School-children from Chhindwara (Madhya Pradesh) moved about on their own even in hostile villages and collected 250 acres.⁴² College students of Wardha (Maharashtra) undertook walking tour, expecting gifts of about hundred acres. They got 1,350 acres in two months.⁴³

No wonder, bhoodan appealed to the creativity of renowned poets like Maithilisharan Gupta and Ramdhari Singh Dinkar.

Response by economists

It was difficult for the economists conversant with modern terminology to understand bhoodan. Yet many of them responded positively to it. D.R. Gadgil said in his presidential address to the 15th Annual Conference of the Indian Society of Agricultural Economics (1954),

“In Vinobaji we have not only the greatest but also, perhaps, the only force that has acted in independent India for dealing with the problem of concentration of economic and political power, which is at the root of all evil in society. Such an effort made in such a bold, all-embracing manner and involving such vital reinterpretation of our traditional values must needs receive the instinctive sympathy of all Indians.”⁴⁴

Citing the figures of the Rural Credit Survey to substantiate existence of land hunger among the landless, he said,

“Given the existing situation in India and given the present apparent powerlessness of the Government either to initiate rapid economic development in general or to devise any logical solution to the land problem in particular, the bhoodan approach cannot be dismissed as either irrelevant or ill-directed.”⁴⁵

Presiding over the 17th Annual Conference of the Indian Society of Agricultural Economics (1956), D.G. Karve said,

“The great merit of the movement consists in this that the social evaluation of ownership of agricultural land beyond what one actually cultivates with the assistance of one's own

family is drastically reduced; this would - - - facilitate land legislation.”⁴⁶

C.D. Deshmukh, ex-Finance Minister of India, told at a seminar (January 1957) that

“- - - the idea of bhoodan commended itself to me, as legislation for the redistribution of land could never be so comprehensive or, indeed, equitable except where the free consent of the landholder who is giving up land has been secured, which Bhoodan naturally secures.”⁴⁷

A few other economists were impressed by bhoodan's attention to the landless. However, most from the fraternity remained not only critical, but unfortunately prejudiced also.

Objections were raised not only by the economists, but also by some Gandhians like Miraben and J.C. Kumarappa.

Quality of the gifted land

It had been a persistent contention that most of the land received as bhoodan was poor in quality. It was alleged that the landless would be saddled with poor land, got rid of by the landlords who would earn plaudits in return. The fact is that it was difficult for the critics to believe that a precious asset like land, which had been the major source of disputes and even bloodshed, could be gifted through moral persuasion. Never had such thing happened in history. And when the fact could not be denied, they not only surmised but concluded that the land must be of poor quality! They did not even find it necessary to check facts—the matter was so self-evident to them!

The fact is that lands of all types were gifted, which was natural. No one has ever claimed that all the bhoodan lands were of good quality. But it is a fact that over 2.5 million acres have so far been distributed, and it is also a fact that uncultivable lands were not distributed. And what about the lands acquired under Ceiling Acts? In fact, it is a safe conjecture to assume that landlords would have parted with the worst lands they had. Any serious study on the quality of lands acquired under Ceiling Acts does not appear to have been undertaken so far.

Secondly, the owners were hitherto holding poor lands also. Was not the society benefited when they gave up such lands? In fact, land is a priceless asset. It is not used only for agricultural production, it can be put to various uses. It can be used as grazing land, can be given to the poor for housing, can be used for afforestation, can be used for compost pits, or for any public purpose such as school, hospital, community centre etc. Some land was actually so used. The purposes for which land can be used are indeed innumerable. Income can be had even from earth and rocks. Akshay Kumar Karan, a senior worker, had exclaimed while giving rejoinder to this objection, "Coins can be counterfeit; land can never be bad!"⁴⁸

When a complaint about worthlessness of a land was made to Vinoba, he quipped, "No land is ever worthless. If it appears worthless to you, it means that you lack intelligence to use it!"⁴⁹

Proportion of uncultivable land in the gifted lands was more in Bihar because gifts of big zamindars contained large tracts including forests and hilly areas. Elsewhere the proportion of such land was hardly appreciable. Thus, 11.7% (4,835 out of 41,163 acres) in Western Maharashtra was found uncultivable during its distribution.⁵⁰ Proportion of such land in Vidarbha was similar—11.4% (7,786 out of 68,360 acres).⁵¹

And it cannot be assumed that the land that is uncultivable at a particular point of time would remain so for ever. It can be brought under cultivation through irrigation. It can be made fertile by investing labour and money. It was, in fact, a challenge before the State and the society to make poor bhoodan lands fertile and make them available for production, which was so sorely needed. Kanti Shah laments:

"But the fact, that so much land was being obtained through such a novel and unprecedented process, stirred no one to put in collective efforts to make every inch of it fertile. People in Israel have put in commendable effort in turning deserts into oases. If our governments, our garrulous intellectuals and leaders in various fields had at least a little imagination, a nation-wide campaign harnessing the nation's energies for this purpose could have proceeded along with

bhoodan. But these noise-makers were least bothered about the country's uplift; what they were concerned with was how to proclaim Vinoba's failure as early as possible!"⁵²

It must not be overlooked that to have land in one's name meant much to a poor labourer, irrespective of its quality. That was why he would not mind doing backbreaking labour and even took loans to buy land.

It is also worth mentioning that Vinoba would refuse to accept gifts if he came to know that the land was poor in quality. If such land happened to be there in gifted lands, he would ask the donor to exchange it with better land. He would also ask the donor of a fallow land to make it ploughable.

Were disputed lands gifted?

Another common criticism was that disputed lands were gifted. This contention is also not borne out by facts. For example, a study in Vidarbha region of Maharashtra found such land to be 2.4% of the gifted land⁵³, while a study in Western Maharashtra found the percentage to be 5.2%.⁵⁴ These cannot be considered high figures. It too cannot be alleged that such land was gifted with full knowledge that it was disputed. Disputes could have cropped up later in many cases. Moreover, it is not that disputes can never be resolved. As Vinoba argued, if one of the parties in a dispute gifted land, that meant it had forgone its claim:

"Does it not mean that the dispute has ended as far as one party is concerned? We would talk to the other party. If he needs the land, we would give it to him. Otherwise, we would seek gift from him too. Is reduction in disputes not a distinct gain?"⁵⁵

The question of uneconomic holdings

Some economists were worried that bhoodan would fragment the economic holdings, making them unviable. The assumption that agricultural plots have necessarily to be bigger to have more production has been contested by many economists, often citing actual experience. Even studies in 1950's

had proved that production per acre increases with reduction in the size of holdings.⁵⁶

After all, it was the labourer who was actually working on the land. It is a safe conjecture that he would work more if the land belonged to him. So, logically there was every likelihood of increase in production. The cost society would have to pay if discontent brewed in the landless is also a factor worth considering. Vinoba's contention was that bhoodan would join hearts and once there was joining of hearts, there would be no difficulty in joining pieces of land later.

It was also a fact that fragmentation of land due to bhoodan was not on the scale the critics imagined, as Dharendra Majumdar pointed out:

"I do not know any case where the donor has gifted fragment of a piece of his land. Generally we have been gifted entire pieces. At some places, we have received such pieces which could constitute a single holding. Thus bhoodan is not fragmenting land; rather it is consolidating it. People assume that if someone owning 12 acres gives 2 acres, he is giving a fraction of his single holding of 12 acres. This is not the case. The piece of two acres that is being gifted is already an isolated piece."⁵⁷

Viable holdings were being granted to the landless, not unviable small fragments. They were also free to pool their lands and undertake co-operative farming. B.R. Mishra had opined that bhoodan, by bringing to an end the sense of ownership, was paving way for co-operative or collective farming.⁵⁸ Gramdan augmented such hopes. Pandit Nehru also entertained such hope, and it was one of the reasons for his support to gramdan.

Some more objections

Miraben had apprehension that bhoodan would reduce land for pastures and for growing trees. In fact, pastures were fast dwindling because of other pressures on land. Uncultivable bhoodan land was often reserved for pastures.

Kumarappa's contention was that it was not enough to give small pieces of land to individual farmers; there should be no

private ownership. Vinoba was well aware of this, and gramdan did come up in the course of time. Kumarappa also emphasised the need for suitable training. The Movement was surely aware of this and did what it could, although that fell far short of the need. Lack of technical training was particularly glaring.

It was alleged that Vinoba was frightening the landowners by raising the spectre of bloody Communist revolution. Vinoba's rejoinder was that he was only explaining the scientific relation between cause and effect! Anyway, this was only one of the several arguments that Vinoba marshalled.

Another objection was that bhoodan would strengthen land-ownership. Bhoodan was also faulted for ignoring the problem of the rational layout and utilisation of land surface. Such objections became redundant with the advent of gramdan. In fact, Vinoba held, and preached, right from the outset that land belonged to all:

“What do you think we mean when we ask for one-sixth of land? We would take one-sixth portion and distribute it. But that will not be sufficient for the landless. So, we will again ask for one-sixth portion of the rest of the land. This is a process, which will be repeated until all get land. There is not much difference in asking for one-sixth land and dissolution of ownership. - - -

“Right from the outset, I have been saying that land is a gift from God like air and water and should, therefore, be used as such. But there has to be a strategy. One-sixth share is like a wedge, which we drive in and then strike with a hammer. We will not be satisfied till the dissolution of land-ownership.”⁵⁹

Vinoba would not hesitate to call land-ownership a sin and an evil idea. He also declared (1954) that “those who are gifting land have no right to give it, as land does not belong to them. In a way, therefore, Bhoodan-Yajna is a fiction.”⁶⁰

Role of the landless

The Movement was exhorting the land-owners, even the smallest ones, to give land. But what was the role of the landless

in it? Was there any space for their active participation and organisation in it?

The landless were spiritless and unorganised. Giving land to them was the first step towards their organisation and empowerment by generating confidence and a sense of self-respect in them. Bhoodan was taking that step. Without such a step, all else would have been sterile talk.

Acharya Narendra Dev had acknowledged that 'this Movement has generated confidence and mutual affability', although his complaint was that the Movement had no plan to utilise the power of the landless.⁶¹

In what way could the Movement have utilised the awakening in the landless? Vinoba expected that the landless should themselves go to the landowners and ask for land. Such incidents did happen, but they were few. Perhaps it was not right to expect too much from the Movement in its nascent stage. After the advent of gramdan, which had a role for everyone, such questions became redundant.

Distribution of poverty?

Seeking and taking gifts from the poor was also faulted. It was said that this would only distribute poverty; it would not make a dent in inequality. Vinoba often explained that land was being sought in proportion to the landholding; the poor were expected to give only symbolically, but that was essential to involve them in the Movement and to generate readiness in them to share whatever they had.

Vinoba, in fact, took this not as an objection but as a compliment, and said that poverty would end only if distributed:

"That we are distributing poverty is what distinguishes us. If food sufficient for four persons is served to four of us, we are beginning to dine and a fifth one comes, should we say, 'Food is sufficient for four persons only. Wait till production increases.' No, we cannot say this. The joy in sharing is a matter of experience. Poverty ends when it is distributed. Happiness increases when it is shared"⁶²

Gifts from the poor

For Vinoba, bhoodan was a '*yajna*'—a mission wherein everyone had to make an offering. A small farmer may be poor, but he is in a somewhat better condition than the landless; so he also should give what he can. If gifting is good, why should only the better-off give? "Everyone should have opportunity to participate in meritorious deeds. That will please the deity of the *yajna*."⁶³ If eradication of poverty is to be sought, the effort therefor must involve the poor; they cannot be expected to be mere recipients of the largesse.

The root of the problem lay in private property. Big or small, every property-holder was clinging to it. Attachment of small owners strengthens the hold of the bigger ones on their property. If the poor is ready to relinquish his nominal property, the very legitimacy of private property becomes questionable. When small farmers share what they have with the landless, that action will unite them. And then private ownership of land will not last long. That was Vinoba's strategy:

"The poor have to renounce ownership; ownership of the rich will then automatically disappear. Renunciation of ownership by the poor is the most effective way to conquer the citadel of the property of the rich."⁶⁴

Giving would raise the self-esteem, and thereby strength, of the poor—that was what Vinoba believed:

"People think that the strength of the poor will increase if we organise and motivate them to ask for land. But pleading will make them more spiritless and pitiable; their strength will increase if we motivate them to give what they have."⁶⁵

Gifts of the poor would bring moral pressure on the rich, and such moral pressure is a part of *satyagraha*.

"Either they will have to bow before that moral pressure or face boycott from the peasants and labourers or expropriation by the government or death. There is no fifth alternative."⁶⁶

Vinoba believed that the empowerment of the poor through giving would be so efficacious that they would not have to fight;

the very sight of that power would be sufficient to bring about results.

A kind of satyagraha

Vinoba would repeatedly explain to those advocating satyagraha that Bhoodan-Yajna too was a kind of satyagraha and it would serve as a preparation for militant satyagraha, in case the same is necessitated—to move from village to village, explain the ideas and undergo hardships in its course was a kind of satyagraha, albeit of a constructive variety. He would remind those who nursed a grudge against him for allegedly abandoning Gandhi's militant satyagraha that he was the first satyagrahi chosen by Gandhi himself (in 1940) but held that the form of satyagraha needed to change in the changed context. What the land problem called for in the first place was education of the public opinion to mould it favourably:

“Sarvodaya says that satyagraha can be resorted to when a universally-accepted principle is being disregarded. But if a principle is not universally accepted, public education needs to be done in that regard. Everyone does not agree with the principle that private ownership should not exist. So, this calls for propaganda and not satyagraha.”⁶⁷

Only when the justice of an issue is universally acknowledged, militant nonviolence can be used against the recalcitrant few. Vinoba readily gave green signal to satyagraha against eviction of peasants, or for prohibition and for ban on cow-slaughter. He even initiated satyagraha against indecent film posters (1960). But he consistently warned that even in justifiable cases, satyagraha should be resorted to only if the workers had control on the situation and could prevent outbreak of violence or exploitation of the issue for political gains.

Was setting targets wrong?

There was no question of setting any target in Telangana. When Vinoba set out for Delhi (1951) he called for collection of 50 million acres. That started the trend. In fact, setting targets is not uncommon for a movement. But critics wondered whether this was in keeping with nonviolence: In the endeavour for

achieving target, the means are likely to be compromised. Vinoba tried to remove this apprehension:

“In fact, it is not that we can make any resolve to collect 50 million acres. We can at the most resolve to go to the people and explain our ideas to them with love. It is for the people to give. So, setting the target only means that we are telling the people that this much is necessary for their deliverance. The time frame that we have thought of is based on our reading of history and on certain faith. It absolutely does not mean that we should work in an unbecoming manner. We have started this work with commitment to truth and nonviolence.”⁶⁸

The point is that unless targets are set, one is not enthused to work with a sense of urgency. Secondly, extent of achievement of targets can give us an idea about the efficacy of our strategy, which can be revised in the light of experience. Moreover, a campaign cannot go on forever; it would be fruitless if it cannot achieve certain results within a particular time frame.

Working for a target makes man work with unadulterated devotion and energies of all can be pooled together in a concerted endeavour. And it was highly necessary to make such an endeavour for the last man whose patience was fast running out. Vacillation on the part of nonviolence in this regard meant keeping the door wide open to violence. That was what Vinoba was worried about.

And, after all, what is a target? It is just an estimate of what could reasonably be achieved with the available resources within a particular period. That is why the governments and other organisations routinely set targets. According to Vinoba, there was no spiritual harm in this.⁶⁹

Hallam Tennyson laments:

“In one form or another, Vinoba repeated his arguments. But the protesters took little notice. They went on protesting—querulous, nagging, captious and continual. It was hard for those who prided themselves on their sophistication to accept the fact that something as simple as Bhoodan could possibly work!”⁷⁰

Vinoba's approach

Bhoodan, as Vinoba would insist, gave a permanent and dignified source of livelihood to the poorest and the most helpless, thereby raising their economic standing and social status. It was not a gift that would make the giver conceited and recipient indolent. No kind of social service can match this.

For Vinoba, land was not only means of livelihood; it was a means of worship. Therefore, depriving anyone from land was worse than preventing him from entering a place of worship.

Just collecting and distributing land was not enough; in fact, it was incidental. What was important was transformation in relationships. Therefore, motive of the donor was important. Vinoba would, therefore, outright reject gifts if he suspected any wrong motive. He wanted people to give with full understanding and acceptance of the underlying philosophy: "We do not want to collect land by hook or by crook. We want to enkindle an attitude of Samyayoga and Sarvodaya."⁷¹

So, when a landowner offered land on the condition that it should not be given to a Muslim, Vinoba censured him and refused to accept the gift. When a gift was offered on the condition that it should not be given to a Dalit, he rejected the gift.⁷²

Vinoba was ready to concede that the concentration of land in a few hands was not a result of injustice alone: Some might have got land as a reward for the valour shown in wars; some might have lost land because of their own doings. But that was no reason for putting up with that concentration now. Whatever might have happened in the past, and whatever might be the current situation, the fact remained that private property in land was wrong. It was the responsibility of all to undo that wrong and all should therefore be involved in the process of ending that concentration. Therefore, Vinoba was not in favour of class struggle; what was necessary was elimination of classes through a creative process. What was being sought was an integrated society based on mutual love and co-operation.

Bhoodan-Yajna was the foundation of an endeavour in this

direction. Much needed to be built on that foundation. Vinoba was fully clear about this. He told from the outset that land of the village belongs to the village. Bhoodan was for uniting the hearts.

“Land will be given today. But population will double in no time. So we cannot rely on land redistribution alone. Village should become like *gokul*⁷³ and work in unison. That is what we should work for.”⁷⁴

Villagisation of land was the key. The idea of gramdan organically sprouted from bhoodan and the gramdan became the main focus of the Movement.

Relevance of bhoodan

Bhoodan was only the first step and it fulfilled itself by blossoming into gramdan. Relevance of gramdan needs, therefore, be judged; not that of bhoodan in isolation.

Land problem still exists, although its form has changed. Bhoodan showed a nonviolent way. A novel process was tried and it had results. This process appeared impossible at that time; it appears so today also. It may not be possible now to follow that process, but there is no alternative to a nonviolent process. Experiments need to be done with courage and creativity in this regard. One such experiment is that of LAFTI in Tamil Nadu which persuades the landlords to part with excess land, accepting moderate consideration. But in the last analysis, it is gramdan which is the key to solve not only the land problem, but also the whole gamut of problems that are obstructing individual and social regeneration.

4. Gramdan: Getting off the Ground

Negative response

Adoption of gramdan should have aroused admiration and sympathy for the gramdan villages in the State and society, as it presented a wonderful opportunity for resuscitation of rural India. This would have happened in a lively nation. To foster the spirit in which the villagers had accepted gramdan, changes should have taken place expeditiously in laws and administration with backing of political will. Not that nothing was done, but whatever was done was not only appallingly inadequate but was also not timely.

Declaration of gramdan was a declaration of war on the vested interests, and to counter those powerful interests gramdan villages needed backing of the enlightened sections in society. But that did not happen.

It is gratifying that despite this, many gramdan villages fought their battle against powerful forces ranged against them almost singlehandedly and strove to move ahead towards self-rule. That is an inspiring story that the Movement can legitimately be proud of.

Different villages travelled to different distances in this unending journey. That most of their successes were short-lived was not surprising. What is important is that they opened the realm of possibilities and left for the posterity much that could inspire and much that could teach.

The process of legislation to legalise gramdan proceeded at snail's pace, necessitating some alternative arrangement. Gram-swaraj or Sarvodaya Co-operative Societies were, therefore, formed and efforts were made to register the village lands in their names. This too faced difficulties; Harivallabh Parikh of Gujarat had to undertake satyagraha for this purpose!¹

Difficulties

Abolition of landownership in gramdan villages is such a novel thing in the present set-up that the law and administration could not digest it. The main problem was of credit. Lenders pressed for repayment of debt and refused credit as land was no longer private property, and could not be offered as security. Vinoba exhorted time and again to the moneylenders to participate in gramdan and find a way out. His answer to the problem was:

“There are astronomical figures of debt on different nations. What do they mean? They are only figures on paper. - - - Money was given and it was fruitfully utilized. That is all that matters. Of course, those who lent it should not be put to hardships. They are entitled to a reasonably good living. That would be ensured, and the rest would remain on paper only. That is my answer to the problem of debt.”²

But this was easier said than done. Such exhortations had value, but evolution of structural mechanisms was also a crying need. Economist D.R. Gadgil had even said that “we should not persuade people to give gramdan unless we have made some arrangement of giving some temporary accommodation to the people.”³ Agriculture was the mainstay of village life and credit was of crucial importance to it.

Lack of property presents many other practical difficulties. Gramdan kisans cannot become guarantors. Agricultural colleges give priority in admissions to the wards of agriculturists having some land in their names, and the wards of gramdan kisans are not considered eligible for this. Many examples of such step-motherly treatment can be cited. Denying development programmes is a blatant example of this kind. In practice, many problems arise because of ignorance or apathy of the bureaucracy. The number of gramdan villages is too small to expect the administrators to be conversant with gramdan. After the Constitutional amendment about Panchayat Raj, propriety of gramdan laws is being questioned.

In fact, it is a wonder that so much could be achieved by so many villages despite so many odds.

Steps in gramdan

Three stages were contemplated for gramdan: declaration of intent, fulfilment of stipulated conditions, and reconstruction. The stipulated conditions included constitution of gramsabha, surrender of land to it, distribution of 5% of the surrendered land to the landless and beginning of gramkosh (village fund to which everyone was to contribute regularly a fixed portion of their produce or income). Campaigns were carried out for fulfilment of stipulated conditions in selected areas. Still the number of villages which could fulfil the same remained small.

The third step, which was called '*nirman*' pertained to the reconstruction of the village. Generally, but erroneously, it was equated with economic development. Economic development was surely needed, as the villages were mired in poverty, and villagers were impatient about such development. In fact, that was one of the major motives for accepting gramdan. But that had to be a long-drawn process whose success depended on the ability of the people having stake in it.

What was most important was to integrate the village community fissured by attacks for centuries, to foster the community spirit in villages and enhance their capability of looking after their own affairs. This was the first and the foremost—rather the sole—work for the Movement which valued its revolutionary credentials above everything else.

The so-called development was not the Movement's responsibility, nor was it within its capacity. To bring funds from outside and build a model in a few selected areas might have served as an example, but such attempts could not be replicated everywhere. As Vinoba said, "The village you intend to be a model will not really be a model, as workers, resources and funds from outside are poured in it. Such a model village in effect means a village spoilt by pampering."⁴ He held that "our job is to solemnise the marriage, not to carry out domestic duties of householders."⁵

This was what Dharendra Majumdar also stressed:

“The *nirman*, that is, building up the village means elimination of exploitation, injustices and conflicts that have been going on in the village. You take *nirman* to mean construction of wells, tanks and embankments and some enterprising activities. But the real *nirman* does not mean starting external activities; it means creation of appropriate attitude and psyche in the villagers.”⁶

Refraining from developmental work completely was certainly not intended; what was to be avoided was distortion in priorities.

Mangaroth’s progress

Mangaroth was the first village wherein all the landowners gifted their lands (23 May 1952). Vinoba sent Baba Raghavdas and Ramgopal Gupta to Mangaroth to explore about an alternative land system. In the public meeting in their presence (3 June 1952), everyone agreed that land should belong to all, but no concrete arrangement could be evolved. Vinoba then constituted a committee comprising of Diwan Shatrughna Singh, Karanbhai and Sadashiv Gadre for the purpose. Incidentally, hostile propaganda by the vested interests started in no time after cent per cent bhoodan, leading to some vacillation by the villagers. This was exacerbated when Gadre prematurely started talking about ultra-radical steps. However, apprehensions of the villagers were allayed and it was agreed that land should belong to all, collective farming would be optional, land would be redistributed in such a way that landholding after redistribution would not be less than 80% of the earlier holding, and no holding should be below 15 bighas; smaller holdings would be progressively increased until everyone came to have at least 15 bighas. It was also agreed that the village panchayat would overhaul the system every five years.

As the gramsabha had no legal recognition, a ‘Sarvodaya Mandal’ comprising of all the adult villagers was constituted and Vinoba authorised this Mandal to make arrangements as regards land, spelling out the principles that should govern them. Registration of the Mandal, however, took four years! The village’s decision to pay land revenue for the whole village was

also contested by the bureaucracy, which issued notices of attachment of lands and sent the police to execute them! The matter ultimately reached Gobind Ballabh Pant, Chief Minister of the state, and the government issued orders on 20 January 1955 to register the village land in the name of the Mandal and recover land revenue from the Mandal.

The village made efforts to increase production through irrigation and soil conservation and by bringing fallow land under cultivation. Production of grains, pulses and oilseeds increased from 858 maunds to 3,173 maunds in three years (1954-57). Production of khadi also began. A co-operative store was established. Prohibition was successfully implemented and attention was paid to education as well.⁷

The story of Manfar

Manfar was the first gramdan village in Bihar. The hamlet of 33 poor tribals declared gramdan in 1953. The village land was redistributed equally, taking into account the quality of lands, at the hands of the state's Revenue Minister in June 1954. Yet the revenue administration continued to demand revenue on the basis of earlier holdings for years!

Food production in the village was sufficient for only four months. Naturally, irrigation was given priority, whereby self-sufficiency in food was achieved. Addiction to liquor was greatly reduced. A school was opened in the village where none was literate. Disputes started getting resolved at the village level. The villagers decided to regard family functions as community affairs for which everyone would contribute.

That the villagers became fearless was the greatest achievement. A contractor took the contract for collecting mahua from a nearby forest from the government and started collecting mahua from Manfar's village forest as well. Gramsabha decided to resist the encroachment. The people were browbeaten, and were actually beaten by the contractor, but ultimately he had to yield. Corruption and tyranny of the forest department were also ended.⁸

Berain's striving

Berain in Bihar declared gramdan in February 1958. The village was notorious for being an abode of thieves and dacoits. Most of the village lands were owned by outsiders and the villagers worked on them as sharecroppers. After gramdan, the gramsabha decided that outsiders should seek labour from it and not directly from individuals. As a result, the owners stopped employing their labour, letting the land remain fallow. So, in the interest of production, the villagers worked on the fields voluntarily, but refused to take payment individually. This had desired effect.

Collective farming was started. Self-sufficiency in clothing was achieved in just two years. Private shops were closed and a co-operative store was opened. Moneylender's debt on individuals was considered debt on the village and repaid accordingly. Expense for education of village children was borne by the village. Freedom from liquor was achieved. Image of the village naturally improved.

Perhaps the most noteworthy initiative was to equalise the level of incomes through salaries at Rs. 30 per month. It was decided that everyone with salary over this amount would deposit the excess amount in the gramkosh and money would be given from it to those having less salary to bring their monthly income to Rs. 30 per month. That people accepted this arrangement was nothing less than revolutionary.⁹

Mohazari: success of local leadership

Mohazari in Madhya Pradesh was a big village with a population of 3,000. Mahipal Singh Naktode, a resident of the village, had main role in directing the village's efforts. Some gramdan villages attained much because of selfless local leadership with deep ideological understanding and contact with the outside world. Mohazari was one of such fortunate villages.

The village already had some good traditions like decision-making through consensus. Vasant Vyas found in 1966 that regular prayers were being held in the village, wells were open to all, disputes were being settled in the village itself and village

co-operative store was in operation. Liquor shop in the village had been closed. A noteworthy feature was that all marriages used to be solemnised on only a single auspicious day.¹⁰

Rangpur's *lok-adalat*

In the tribal area of Rangpur in Gujarat, Harivallabh Parikh solved hundreds of disputes in around 750 villages through *lok-adalat* (people's court) and aroused consciousness in the downtrodden populace in the process. Exploitation and excesses of forest department were successfully resisted.

At Tadmachhala, employees of forest department made tribal girls kneel, walked over their backs and then lashed them. Gajlaghat, a neighbouring gramdan village took up the issue. The agitation resulted in the dismissal of the concerned employees and higher officials apologised for the excess. At Ambalia, the people foiled attempts by a powerful landlord in a neighbouring village to usurp village land. During the agitation, every adult villager went to jail, but ultimately they succeeded. When three policemen raped a minor tribal girl at Renadhi, people rose against it. The concerned policemen were dismissed, but the people continued agitation for the removal of top officials who knew everything but had tried to cover up the matter. They too were finally removed despite backing by powerful people including politicians.

Corruption was fought, so was blind faith and attendant practices and exploitation by moneylenders. Debt claims were resolved in the *lok-adalat*. Irrigation facilities were created resulting in significant increase in production. Social problems were also tackled and attempt was made to put an end to improper customs. Local leadership arose in many villages. The work attracted wide attention.¹¹

Some more glimpses

Belsara of Bihar followed Berain in levelling incomes through salaries to the level of Rs. 30 per month. Collective farming was successfully attempted. Gramsabha became the vehicle for administering village affairs.

Stealing and robbery were the main occupations in Madhua (Bihar). After gramdan it was decided to stop them. The police began to harass the villagers, as regular bribes to them had stopped. It was difficult for the villagers to get work because of the bad image. Still they did not budge.

West Bengal's Krishnapur, which too had similar reputation, successfully effaced the blot on its image. Production of illicit liquor was rampant. Not only was it stopped, the villagers even gave up consumption of liquor.

Akili (Odisha) was the first gramdan village where title deeds of the land were distributed by Vinoba himself (19 May 1955). The land had already been redistributed giving equal share to every family. After gramdan, the villagers decided to abstain from liquor and said no to forced labour. Substantial fallow land was brought under cultivation.

Many villages in the Kadappa district of Andhra Pradesh carried out collective farming, solely on the basis of mutual faith. People voluntarily provided labour, bullocks and implements as and when needed.¹²

Dawn of a new life

In many villages, collective farming was attempted. Agricultural production increased through land reclamation, irrigation and other appropriate measures. Land was given to all. Co-operative stores were started, ending exploitation by shopkeepers. Untouchability was removed and the edge of casteism was blunted. Women and depressed sections became vocal and active in village affairs. People started putting in labour for public purposes. Education and literacy was given attention. The curse of drinking was combated. Spinning wheels began to hum. Domination and exploitation by outsiders, particularly the State machinery, traders, moneylenders and contractors was resisted.

What was important was that a new consciousness was generated. The people in villages, particularly in remote and tribal areas, had become desolate. Independence had hardly touched their lives. Gramdan generated hope in them and

inspired them to better their condition. Breaking the shackles of poverty, exploitation, inequality and slavery that bound them for centuries, they set out to regain the very humanhood. The transformation was on all levels. At the same time, the moral sense of the haves was aroused. Thus a silent revolution was set in motion. But there was nothing sensational in it, and so it went largely unnoticed in the media!

Problem of capital formation

Capital was a main problem in villages. The villagers lacked resources and could hardly have any savings. Agriculture was a losing proposition and industries were scarce. Collective labour was, therefore, widely employed. Sarvodaya Movement also tried to mobilise funds from outside. Funds for khadi work were received from Khadi and Village Industries Commission. Gandhi Smarak Nidhi extended help. Foreign funding organisations like 'War on Want' and Oxfam contributed for some activities. But all these avenues were not enough, looking to the need of so many villages.

Neither were they enough nor were they likely to be enough, nor was it proper to rely on them. Reconstruction of villages could and should have been done with their own resources and on their own strength. Gramkosh (village fund) was an integral part of gramdan. Every villager was to give a certain portion of his produce or income in it. Had this become possible, much could have been achieved. But in practice many villagers, although they had agreed to it, would drag their feet. It was easy to give a portion of produce or income once in a while, but difficult to give the same regularly. The State can recover taxes through coercion; there was no question of coercion in a gramdan village. Consequently, the question of capital formation remained a Gordian knot and no way could be found to cut it.

Two institutions studied gramkosh in some villages (1972) in areas where intensive work was being done by the Movement. It was found that it was difficult for the gramsabha to assess the correct income or produce and recover the same; so, in practice, the contribution to the gramkosh depended on the will of the

villagers. Some gramsabhas, therefore, fixed particular quantity of produce as contribution irrespective of production. Storage of grains was also a problem. It was more difficult to get contribution from the labourers. The study, however, testified that the accounts of the gramkosh were being properly kept in a transparent manner. But it was, in general, difficult for the villagers to find time for paperwork and accounting, and appointing a worker for the purpose was not practicable even if such workers were available.¹³

Findings of some studies

A few researchers tried to probe what was happening in gramdan villages.

Dr. Biswabandhu Chatterjee studied gramdan villages in Rajasthan. He found perceptible increase in the level of consciousness and self-confidence. He was particularly impressed by individuals voluntarily working for the community.¹⁴

Avadh Prasad chose gramdan for doctoral research. He went to Darbhanga (Bihar) and asked the people why had they voluntarily parted with a precious asset like land? People told him that Gramdan would empower them, that village would have common fund for agricultural development, that gramdan had eliminated conflicts about land and ensured their continued possession of land. Avadh Prasad pointed out that although they had declared gramdan, necessary paperwork was yet to be done, whereupon the villagers replied that they did not have an office working throughout the day, doing paperwork; ‘things will happen gradually.’ He also sensed opposition from those whose interests had been hurt.¹⁵

Avadh Prasad also studied the working of gramsabha at Hathal in 1968 on behalf of Kumarappa Gram-swarajya Sansthan. He found that resolution of disputes in the village itself had put an end to corruption of the police and fleeing by lawyers. As many as 87% people noted freedom from harassment by government servants as the biggest gain from gramdan.¹⁶ He was impressed by social intercourse in the village: people from all castes were freely participating in

discussions in gramsabha meetings¹⁷

A survey of six Rajasthan villages in 1973 by the same institution also noted loosening of caste fetters. Gramsabhas had noticeably become active and foundation of village ownership had become strong.¹⁸ The institution made a comprehensive survey of gramdans in the state in 1981. By this time, ignorance and apathy of the administration had become more pronounced. Still gramdan villages were striving to the best of their capacities.¹⁹

Nousher Bilpodiwala travelled in gramdan villages in south India for 33 days in 1961 with a Thai monk. At Kottaipatti, the whole of the village land had been brought under irrigation and three crops were being grown annually; he found that 'miraculous'. He concluded that the people were inspired and progressing in the right direction where they had understood the spirit and essence of the Sarvodaya philosophy. He felt the need for workers who could build upon the motivation.²⁰

Workers were sorely needed, and so was their training. But this could not be adequately organised and the Movement had to pay the price for it.

Sarva Seva Sangh and Gandhian Institute of Studies (Varanasi) sent a team to a few blocks in Bihar, Odisha and Tamil Nadu to study gramdan and prakhand(block)-dan in 1966. It was intended to find out the perceptions, expectations and anticipations of the residents in gramdan villages and the assessment of workers about people's participation and expectations and the changes brought about by gramdan. It was found that the villagers had clear ideas about the rationale and outcome of gramdan and their experience matched their expectations. Not only people knew sufficiently about gramdan, they believed in its success—believed that it would lead to a new society free from social inequality and economic exploitation.²¹

Erica Linton visited India as a representative of the funding agency 'War on Want' in 1967. Her book 'Fragments of a vision', published in 1972, gives an account of what she saw and perceived. She found that people looked to gramdan mainly as

a means for bettering their lot economically and expected aid from outside. The knowledge about the possibility of such aid, she thought, was “hindering rather than furthering development by its psychological effect on the people.”²² But she also perceived the fearlessness and confidence promoted by gramdan. An illiterate villager told her at Haria (Bihar), pointing at the men near the well who belonged to different castes, “Since we accepted gramdan, we have learned to care for one another as a community.”²³ Linton observed that gramdan was a workers’ movement and therefore calibre of its workers was of paramount importance; she, therefore, underlined importance of training in this context. Her broad conclusions were:

“- - - formation of the village council has helped in unifying the villagers in communal efforts. - - - The villagers have become conscious that they can succeed today by united efforts where they failed previously as individuals or by belonging to factions. - - - Pride in achievement is felt by all the villagers. - - - Exploitation through moneylenders and other corruptive influences has lessened. Drunkenness in many villages has practically stopped.”²⁴

Vasant Vyas travelled in many states, stayed in many gramdan villages and talked with their residents and wrote five books on state-wise surveys of gramdan. He was particularly curious to know what the villages had understood by gramdan. A villager in Andhra told him succinctly, ‘Gramdan, for us, means love!’²⁵

Sachidanand studied gramdan in Kerala in 1958. Gramdan was only two years old in the state and situation in the state was peculiar, marked with the presence of clusters of houses; there were no villages as such in the state. There was dearth of workers. The state was ruled by Communists who had grass-root organisation and were cold or even hostile to Sarvodaya. His observation that “practical achievements of Gramdan phase in delivering land to the landless are much below that of Bhoodan phase”²⁶ is therefore not surprising. His conclusion that “Voluntary method of sharing land through gramdan has failed to come to grips with the central elements in Kerala’s agrarian problems”²⁷ might have been premature, but unfortunately it

was not proved wrong.

T.K. Oommen studied only four gramdans in Rajasthan in early sixties and gave the spacious subtitle 'An analysis of Bhoodan-Gramdan movement in India' to his book, 'Charisma, stability and change'. He drew sweeping conclusions that clearly betray his ignorance and prejudice. For example, he writes that "to a large extent, the Bhoodan-Gramdan movement emerged due to the failure of land reform legislation"²⁸ although the Movement started much before the enactment of ceiling laws. His statement that "the presumed collective ownership of land on the one hand and the actual concentration of land in a few hands on the other, defeat the purpose of progressive legislative measures such as land ceiling, agricultural income tax, estate duty etc. thereby rendering gramdan villages pockets of vested interest forces"²⁹ also reveals his bias and lack of understanding. Observing just four villages, which by no means could be considered representative, Oommen could imagine things which even the Prime Minister of the country had failed to realize!

Ambitious project in Koraput

Many villages embraced gramdan in the Koraput district of Odisha during Vinoba's tour, and their number continued to swell. The area was thought to be eminently suitable to implement a Sarvodaya plan for integrated development, and it was decided to create an alternative model. Work began in November 1955 under the leadership of Annasaheb Sahasrabuddhe, an expert in khadi and agriculture.

The district, with an area of 16,000 square km, was mainly constituted by forests and had only 1.4 million acres under cultivation. Out of 1.2 million inhabitants, 1 million were tribals. The district was poor and backward, but rich in natural resources. Education, artisanship and enterprise were negligible. The problem of debt was grave, and so bonded labour was common. After gramdan, credit had become scarcer. The tribals had sunk deep in misery. They were neither interested in agriculture, nor accustomed to, or even capable of, sustained labour.

Annasaheb procured the services of K.R. Datey, an engineer interested in working with the people in a challenging task. Training programmes were started. Forest co-operative societies were established and forest-based industries were planned. Annasaheb's idea of protection and development of forest resources with active involvement of the local people was visionary. The realisation that forests can be protected and nurtured only by the local people dawned much later on environmentalists and policy-makers.

Koraput was rich in mineral resources. So, mineral-based industries were conceived. The local people used to make steel, but the indigenous way was able to convert only 10-15% of the iron to steel. By making improvements in the technique, the percentage was raised to 80-90%.

Land distribution and improvements in agriculture were given priority. By June 1957, 1,12,058 acres had been redistributed, out of which 93,610 acres were given for individual farming and 2,762 acres for collective farming. Provision of inputs, minor irrigation and soil conservation were also attended to. A forest resources laboratory was set up. Capital was provided for co-operative stores. Illiterate persons successfully ran these stores. A particular skin disease named 'yaj' was widely prevalent; measures to eradicate it were initiated.

Such a wide-ranging developmental endeavour necessitated mobilisation of funds and experts from outside and financial transactions on a wide scale. Practically, a parallel administration was created with different departments for public works, health, education and legal aid. This was conceded by Annasaheb himself. This ultimately proved to be the undoing of the project.

The project was being run on a large scale, but there was lack of clarity about alternative development. Emphasis on khadi and village industries was, of course, there; but there was also attraction of 'modern' methods, even in the initiators. So, outside experts' opinions were valued more and they were also paid higher salaries, naturally causing resentment in others.

At a seminar in March 1957, some participants contended that what was taking place in Koraput was not much different from the State-sponsored Community Development Programme.

The erection of parallel administrative structure was inevitably going to offend the government machinery. Land records were not corrected by it promptly, leading to many problems. It had to be decided in May 1957 that land distribution be suspended till the revision in records as regards the land already distributed was completed.

Nabakrishna Chaudhari, Chief Minister of the state, resigned in October 1956 to devote himself to Sarvodaya work. His renunciation of power at the dictates of an inner call was, to say the least, extraordinary. It set a glorious example. But the altered political equations had serious repercussions on the fate of the Koraput project.

Nabakrishna relinquished office, but continued to wield considerable influence in the state's politics. His successor, Harekrushna Mahatab, set out to wipe out that influence systematically and unscrupulously. He began to denounce openly the Bhoodan Movement and expressed regret that he did not oppose it earlier than he did. He said that the Movement had done great harm to Odisha.³⁰ This was a signal to the administration whose vested interests were being undermined by the Movement which was conscientizing the tribals. It joined hands with the moneylenders, contractors, traders—all those who were interested in oppressing and exploiting the tribals and putting them down. Mahatab's political manoeuvres set off a no-holds-barred campaign to wreck the project, crush the Sarvodaya Movement in the state, and consequently the tribals. Mahatab, writes Sachidanand, "unleashed the worst lot to hunt out the ghosts of Gramdan from Koraput and finally from Orissa".³¹

Officers sympathetic to the project were transferred. Criminal cases were lodged against gramdan workers. Donors were incited to take back the gifts. People were forced to make submission that they did not want gramdan. Moneylenders were encouraged to file cases. In connection with the change in the record of rights, people would be harassed by calling them from

distant places again and again. In spite of all this, the redistribution of land remained operative. It was a glowing testimony to the honesty and commitment of the tribals. Agricultural co-operatives were also not registered. To cap it all, the government revoked prohibition.

Sarva Seva Sangh ultimately decided to withdraw its forces from Koraput in June 1958. Some programmes continued, but the work decelerated. There was some change in the government's attitude in September 1958, which gave green signal to a pilot research project at Boipariguda. In 1963, the Sangh decided to withdraw completely. Some work continued, but co-ordinated intensive work could not be undertaken thenceforth.³²

In 1969, the government made an allegation that the Sarvodaya workers were inciting violence and helping militant Communists. It was also said that the figures of land-gifts and land distribution were all humbug. But the government's own Finance department had confirmed that 9,66,898 acres had been gifted and 5,47,981 acres distributed.³³ Grant to Bhoodan Board was stopped alleging irregularities, although two ministers were members of the Board and had never mentioned any irregularity! According to Manmohan Chaudhari, this was because the Sarvodaya workers had criticised excesses on tribals by the police.³⁴

Kotraput project was short-lived, but not only did it make significant contribution to the betterment of the tribals' lives, it gave important lessons to the Movement.

Vinoba, who was never favourably inclined to such initiatives, said in 1967,

"Koraput is an excellent example of how *nirman* (developmental) work could be carried out. People possessing a thousand intellects³⁵ devoted themselves to the task. People came from outside and so did money. Workers coming from outside were paid higher salaries, which caused jealousy. We must learn from all this that one must not be hasty about development. Developmental work gives good results only when it is done by the local people; otherwise it goes wrong."³⁶

The problem is not really easy. When the local community is deeply mired in poverty and listlessness due to centuries of exploitation and suppression, local resources can never suffice. It can, of course, be debated whether an organisation like Sarva Seva Sangh should have involved itself in such work.

The experiment certainly taught a lot to the Movement, and to the social scientists. Its success lay in the gratifying response of the local tribals, as Annasaheb notes,

“It should be remembered that the Gramdan experiment has been something like the attempt to create ‘a moral man in an immoral society’. In an economic order based on private property and profit we were trying to create an oasis of co-operative living and co-sharing. The machinery of the Government, traditions, social conventions, the moneylender, the shop-keeper, the whole apparatus of economic and social living was opposed to our ideas. They were trying systematically to sabotage our experiment. The fact that a vast majority loyally stood by Gramdan as they understood it, and continued to support our efforts, speaks volumes for their goodness and right intentions.”³⁷

A study group, headed by T.P. Singh and constituted mainly of social scientists having no connection with the Sarvodaya Movement, was formed in 1970 to study gramdans in Odisha. It found that the donors had given land-gifts voluntarily. The people had good opinion about Sarvodaya workers. But the government officials neither knew nor wanted to know about gramdan. The researchers emphasised the need for workers' training and recommended enactment of a law to remove hurdles in the gramdan work.³⁸

It is worth mentioning that gramdan law was enacted in the state much afterwards. Proper legislative measures were not in place when the Koraput project was in operation.

Living gramdans: Keliweli and Kularbhatti

Without timely legislative measures, redistribution of land in gramdan villages could not be sustained. Gramdan co-operatives had been formed as gramsabhas had no legal status.

These got liquidated in the course of time. Even after the enactment of laws, not many villages could be registered under them. As the Movement ebbed and the matter receded into the background, it became increasingly difficult for the gramdan villages even to hold their ground, not to speak of progress. Lack of political will, ignorance and apathy of the administration and ignorance and weakness in the villages contributed to making laws inoperative in practice. Despite all this, a few villages in Maharashtra and Rajasthan managed to keep alive gramdan to some extent.

Keliveli (Maharashtra) is a big village, having adult population of 1,150 at the time of gramdan in 1971. 87% villagers had given consent for gramdan. The village got a selfless and committed local leader in Ramkrishna Aadhe. Several initiatives were taken under his leadership, such as providing employment to all, providing grains to all during famine, solving the problem of water etc. The installation of a statue of Dr. Ambedkar in the village square was noteworthy on the background of growing caste tensions in the countryside. The village has been ensuring representation of women and all sections of the community in the working committee although no specific provision in this regard is there in the Gramdan Act. The land records are with the gramsabha and transfers are effected at the level of gramsabha. The gramsabha meets regularly, all sections take part in it and all decisions are taken in the gramsabha. There have been vacillations occasionally, which is not surprising, but as the legal structure has remained in place, everyone's participation in the village affairs is ensured; no caucus can take the people for granted and lord over them. Disputes do occur, but the villages understand very well the advantages of gramdan and are steadfast on it.

Kularbhatti (Maharashtra) is a hamlet populated by Adivasis. As in Keliveli, the village land records are with the gramsabha and decisions are taken in the gramsabha. Production of liquor was the main occupation in the village. After gramdan, it was curbed effectively. But when monsoon failed for two consecutive years, the gramsabha resolved to start the same again, and discontinued it when the condition bettered.

This shows the maturity, wisdom and capability of the village to take its own decisions.³⁹

Seed: An example of successful gramdan

Seed in Rajasthan consistently fought against the government machinery to get rights given in the Gramdan Act, and even had to go to the court. The village had no landless; so there was no question of setting aside 5% land; the farmers instead contribute income from 5% land to the gramsabha. The village has enforced prohibition and disputes are solved at the village level. The most spectacular work of the village is the protection of its forest of 800 acres. No wonder, the village caught attention of the media and the environmentalists. Noted environmentalist Anil Agarwal writes in 1989,

“Being a Gramdan village, the gramsabha of Seed has full control over all the land within the village boundary, including erstwhile government lands, and exercises full control over their use. It has devised clear rules for the protection of the village common lands. It is the only village in the country that we have seen which has a clear land use plan and rules to enforce that plan. - - -

“Seed’s gramsabha does not allow even trees on private lands to be cut. The gramsabha also has a system of penalties to enforce disciplined use of the village trees and grasslands. Seed became a Gramdan village only in the early 1980s, yet in the first few years, the gramsabha had levied and collected fines worth nearly 5,000 rupees—which is an enormous sum for a poor tribal village—for cutting trees, grazing in prohibited areas and for even breaking leaves.

“The experience of Seed shows clearly how Gandhiji’s concept of village republics can work for ecological regeneration—each village with an active community forum and an ecosystem of its own to control, manage and share, in which common resources are developed and improved and all get their due benefits. We are absolutely convinced—after watching the environmental scene in India for over 15 years—that there is no alternative to this concept. Increasingly we get convinced that the most sophisticated decision-making

will begin only when village people start sitting under banyan trees as a group to discuss their problems and find common solutions. Only this form of decentralised decision-making can match the enormous cultural and biological diversity of Indian villages. People sitting in closed rooms in distant Central and State capitals or even district headquarters can only produce monolithic nonsense which will have little relevance on the ground.”⁴⁰

Criteria for evaluation

A glimpse of what gramdan brought about and what it can bring about has been provided in the preceding few pages. But it will not be right to judge gramdan on that basis alone. It should be judged on the basis of the soundness and relevance of its philosophical foundation and its potentialities. Vinoba had warned:

“Some people say that they will form an opinion on the basis of actual observation of gramdan villages. This is the mentality of status-quoists. This betrays lack of revolutionary thinking. A revolutionary perceives the revolutionary potential in a thought and then endeavours to propagate and implement it. - - - You will find that the idea has taken shape in villages in proportion to the strength and intellect in the villagers to understand and implement it. - - - Limiting the potentialities of a revolutionary thought on the basis of its actual implementation betrays status-quoist mentality.”⁴¹

Declaration of gramdan is not like a magic wand which would bring about instantaneous transformation. It is the beginning of a long journey whose success depends on innumerable factors. One has to judge that journey in the context of circumstances and adversities. Looking to them, and the meagre help they received from the State and the society, and even from the Sarvodaya Movement, what the gramdan villages could achieve, albeit for short periods, is remarkable by any yardstick.

5. The State, Politics and the Movement

Bhoodan-Gramdan Movement strove to secure co-operation from all segments of society and the political class. Most of the political parties did extend co-operation to it from time to time. However, it is a fact that it was perceived to be close to the Congress party and government. Because of the Congress party's support, government machinery too appeared supportive. This support, particularly in Bihar, and particularly in the gramdan-toofan phase, served to deepen the impression. During the Emergency (1975-77), it was maliciously propagated that Vinoba supported Emergency. Although that was absolutely wrong, the charge stuck, and the misconception persists even now. People went to the extent of branding Vinoba as a '*sarkari sant*' (saint of the government)! Such impression in the public mind is surprising, as the Movement was avowedly anarchist. The Movement's attitude towards and its relations with the State and the political parties needs to be probed in this background.

Relations with the Congress

Sarvodaya was born out of the womb of the constructive work, which was under the Congress umbrella before Independence. The Congress workers and constructive workers fought side by side in the freedom movement. Many were active in both, political and constructive work. Congress, in fact, was not a political party in the conventional sense before Independence. Gandhiji was worried that it would become so, and had recommended its conversion into a '*Lok-sevak Sangh*' (Organisation of the servants of the people) after Independence. Congress did not accept the advice and Gandhi's fears were vindicated. It also became obligatory for it to wield the instruments of violence. Enamoured with the modern political and economic ideas, it speedily drifted away from the Gandhian vision. On this background, constructive workers organised

themselves under the banner of Sarvodaya and declared the policy of equidistance from all the political parties at Vinoba's instance. The policy was not based on expediency; it had a firm philosophical foundation. Sarvodaya, which stood for the rise of all irrespective of class, creed, caste and other differences, could not choose between the parties. In fact, it had to take up cudgels against party-and-power politics which stood in the way of empowerment of the people.

However, relations between Congress workers and Sarvodaya workers were naturally cordial. Bhoodan began in Telangana, where no party except the Congress and the Communist party had notable existence. The Congress actively participated in bhoodan; and it was not surprising that, as a political party, it tried to derive political mileage. Vinoba had been advised by some workers to keep Congressmen away, but he expectedly did not pay any heed to this advice. It may be mentioned that Ramchandra Reddy, the first donor, was sympathetic to the Congress. Later, he even contested election as a Congress candidate.

Vinoba had appointed a three-member committee to look after bhoodan in Hyderabad state. All three were Congressmen. In the first general elections (1952), Kodanda Ram did not stand for elections. Laxmibai and Keshav Rao contested; Laxmibai won and Keshav Rao lost. It was alleged that Keshav Rao used the name of Vinoba and even the jeep of Bhoodan Committee for political purpose.¹

Vinoba's consistent endeavour was to establish independent identity of bhoodan and Sarvodaya. However, many Congressmen expected Sarvodaya workers to help the party, and were unhappy when their hopes were dashed. At times, Congress workers at lower levels would give cold-shoulder to bhoodan. But Vinoba's stature was such that co-operation continued to be extended by the Congress. It even passed resolutions setting targets for bhoodan in many states.

Gandhi wanted Congress, the biggest people's organisation in the country, to become an organisation solely devoted to service, rather than becoming a conventional political party, so

that service could become the mainstream activity. Congress' refusal to do this had serious repercussions on the society and polity of the nascent State. Vinoba had even said once,

“Coming to think of it, I wonder whether the Congress would not be the greatest impediment in the way of creation of a nonviolent order in this country - - - When the biggest organisation in the country is election-oriented, it appears that a massive structure blocking the progress of nonviolence has been erected.”²

Vinoba was so outspoken. Jayaprakash and some others like Nabakrishna Chaudhari used to criticize the Congress frequently. Many opposition politicians shared space on Sarvodaya platforms.

Co-operation from other parties

Acharya Kripalani, a avowed Gandhian, left Congress and formed Kisan Mazdoor Praja Party. He looked upon his party as the political wing of the Gandhian movement, and wanted to be recognised as such. A section believed that Sarvodaya Movement was closer to this party compared to others. But Vinoba repudiated this assumption. Socialist leader Jayaprakash Narayan was attracted to bhoodan, and even declared *jivan-dan* (commitment to devote one's life to the cause till the end) at Bodhgaya Conference in 1954. Many Socialists looked at bhoodan sympathetically and took part in it. Many even left the party and joined bhoodan. The Socialist party also passed resolutions in favour of bhoodan and enthusiastically participated in it.

Vinoba received co-operation even from Jana Sangh, a rightist party professedly championing the cause of Hindus, and from Janata Party, a party of big landlords in Bihar.

Golwalkar, Chief of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (R.S.S.), the militant Hindu outfit, expressed sympathy for bhoodan. This position of the organisation, which had been opposed to Gandhi's mission, was all the more striking. Mridula Sarabhai later (1974) alleged that “the country had rejected R.S.S. and Jana Sangh, and they were afraid to stir out of their

houses. All of them became your followers and bhoodan workers. After rehabilitating themselves under your tutelage, they have left you.”³ To say the least, facts do not corroborate this indictment.

Striving to be a ‘cementing factor’

Vinoba looked upon bhoodan as a programme which could bring together all the political elements irrespective of ideologies, as this was a programme for the uplift of the poor, to which all were avowedly committed. He believed that when the values in political life were fast getting eroded, a programme which would call for selfless service was very much needed. In a newly-Independent country, unhealthy competition between political factions was harmful to the unity of society, and it was necessary to bring together good individuals in all the parties. Bhoodan was a suitable programme in this respect, and by uniting all the forces in a righteous cause by providing to them a common platform, it could prove to be a cementing factor in the already fissured land; through working together in it, petty considerations and bickering would get reduced. Vinoba held that every party had good individuals in it, but political considerations compel them to support bad individuals in their parties and justify or gloss over their wrongdoings, which was inimical to the country’s interests.

Bhoodan, for him, was in consonance with all political ideologies and programmes:

“Socialists say that Vinoba is working to solve the land problem, and is thus doing our work. I accept it and invite them to join me. Jana Sangh people say that Vinoba is working in accordance with our culture. I accept it and invite them to join me. Congressmen also say that I am doing their work. I accept that too, and invite them to join this work.”⁴

Voices of opposition

However, disagreement or even opposition was also voiced from some quarters. Prominent kisan leader Charan Singh opposed land distribution to the landless. Another kisan leader N.G. Ranga opposed bhoodan and also denounced gramdan on

the ground that it would necessarily mean collectivisation of land and would be detrimental to individual liberty. Despite Vinoba's clarification, he persisted in opposition. Eventually, both left the Congress party. Ranga, along with Rajaji and Masani, founded Swatantra party to defend individual liberties. Interestingly, Rajaji always supported both bhoodan and gramdan.

Firebrand Socialist leader Dr. Ram Manohar Lohia, a protagonist of militant satyagraha, was also not happy with bhoodan. Perhaps he shared the resentment of some Socialists toward Sarvodaya for 'hijacking' Jayaprakash. But there was no ground for opposition. Yet the Socialist party, which Lohia floated after leaving the Praja Socialist party, asked its members not to take part in bhoodan activities as 'the problem cannot be solved through love. Poor people will not get any land, but the rich will make a show of giving land. It will end the class struggle. So, it is dangerous.'⁵ However, members of Sanyukta Socialist Party (SSP), its successor, did extend co-operation to bhoodan-gramdan later. When the *toofan* campaign was on, SSP was a prominent partner in the Bihar government and it heartily participated in the campaign.

Communists were naturally antagonistic. The Marxist ideology believed in class struggle and therefore was suspicious of Sarvodaya, which sought to eliminate classes through joint endeavour of all the classes. As was their wont, they would not mind heaping abuse and question intentions. Thus, Aruna Asaf Ali called Vinoba 'a shrewd agent of the capitalists'.⁶ Peasants and Workers Party, a Marxist outfit, also opposed bhoodan. (Its stand and Vinoba's rejoinder had been dealt with in earlier pages and need not be repeated here.) However, in the course of time, the Marxists changed their line and their opposition mellowed. Many workers helped at the local level and even gave bhoodan. Communist government in Kerala gave land for the Ashram established by Rajamma, a disciple of Vinoba.

While touring South India, Vinoba met Ramaswami Naicker and found that the grounds of agreement with him were more than the differences. However, the Dravidian parties continued

to have suspicions as they associated Sarvodaya with the Congress and North India.

Followers of Dalit icon Dr. Ambedkar also harboured suspicions about bhoodan, although bhoodan was giving land to the Dalits, and was thus doing for them what no one else was doing. Dalit leader P. N. Rajbhoj joined Vinoba's tour for some time. But prejudices persisted. Some leaders even said that gramdan was against the tenets of Buddhism!⁷ Their biased attitude was rooted in the discord between Gandhi and Ambedkar in pre-Independence times.

On the whole, it appears that political streams which were hostile to Congress and had taken little part in the freedom movement were not particularly enthusiastic about bhoodan because of ideological differences, ignorance and prejudices rooted in history. Yet the Movement always strove to secure co-operation from all.

Distancing from the parties

While seeking co-operation from the political parties, Vinoba was fully aware about their nature. He was therefore ever vigilant. Workers of many parties were active in the Bhoodan-Gramdan Movement, but the reins of the Movement were firmly in Vinoba's hands. Active political workers were not preferred as conveners of Bhoodan Committees.

To make the Movement a people's movement, it was necessary to keep it aloof from political influences. This was clearly one of the reasons why Vinoba disbanded Bhoodan Committees in 1956. The Sarvodaya Mandals which were subsequently formed were organisations of *lok-sevaks*—non-political Sarvodaya workers. On being asked why members of political parties had been barred from joining Sarvodaya Mandals, Vinoba's reply (in 1965) was:

“There is no doubt that, without the co-operation of political parties, at least 75% gramdans would not have been declared. I want them to become more active. - - - But Sarvodaya Mandal is a non-political organisation, whose aim is not limited to securing gramdans; it wants to build up a

community, which would be devoted to service and would not take power in its hands, but would keep the power in check. If people from political parties join Sarvodaya Mandals, they would fight each other in elections. We want a community which would remain non-political and exert influence. People from political parties were there in Bhoodan Committees. But we dismantled that structure in 1956, specifically because we did not want different forces to fight each other. It is not in the interest of the country if Sarva Seva Sangh becomes a battleground for such fight. But ad-hoc committees including all can be formed.”⁸

As the political workers had little role in land distribution after 1956, their involvement naturally declined. One could hope to gain political mileage from bhoodan, but there was little scope for it in gramdan. Secondly, gramdan sought to build up people's power and thereby challenged the party politics. Yet, contacting villages could be beneficial from the political point of view, and perhaps for that reason parties participated in the gramdan work to some extent. But their participation in the subsequent phases could certainly not be hoped for. Gramdan was a sort of ‘State within a State’, and it was difficult for the politicians to digest this.

The most important way in which the political parties could help the Movement was the assertion of political will for administrative and legal measures facilitating gramdan, whenever and wherever they were in power. Unfortunately, this did not happen to the desired extent, despite show of sympathy and support at Yelwal (1957).

Freedom from parties

It is interesting that even while seeking and obtaining co-operation from the political parties, Vinoba continued to criticize the party system. He denounced the parties for dampening people's self-confidence and initiative by telling them that they (the parties) would do everything for them; what people had to do was only to vote for them. Tussle for power inevitably results in unscrupulous compromises and consequent moral decline.

“Party, as the very term suggests, pertains to a part, not to the whole. But human being is an integral whole. Parties divide the nation and dissipate its strength. Party discipline prevents partymen from speaking truth. Therefore, freedom from parties is as necessary as freedom from the castes.”⁹

Political parties, elections, the nature of vote and the process of voting, the principle of representation—Vinoba vehemently and comprehensively attacked all these elements in democratic politics consistently. He stood for freedom from the State, which he held to be an evil institution, and wanted to build up a polity wherein everyone would participate equally—what he had termed ‘*sarvayatan*’.

Words of concurrence with this stand reverberated time and again on the Movement’s platforms. But how far was the rank and file and even the leaders were convinced in this regard remains a moot question.

Stand about the elections

After the framing of the Constitution, elections were around the corner and the matter of taking a stand about them came up for consideration.

It was clear from the outset that a believer in nonviolence could not be a candidate in the elections to become a part of the coercive machinery of the State. However, there was no proposal to dissuade the people from voting in the elections. For them, the advice was to vote for selfless and virtuous individuals irrespective of any other consideration like that of friendship, caste, personal obligations or erudition.¹⁰

In its resolution in July 1951, Sarva Seva Sangh said that it did not find the manifestos of political parties conducive to the creation of a Sarvodaya society, and therefore was not in a position to back any party. It expressed the belief that by remaining away from power and serving the voters selflessly and honestly, a political force could be created and the voters could be guided to vote for right candidates. Envisaging a situation when the constructive workers themselves would be asked to wield power by the people, it accepted that it was a far cry. But

it called on the workers to educate the voters and asked the voters to vote for candidates with impeccable character, qualifying the advice with an appeal not to vote for those who believe in violence and communalism (thus indirectly excluding communal parties and the Communists).¹¹

For Vinoba, election was a deviation which the workers should scrupulously avoid.

In 1956, on the eve of the second general elections, the Sangh reiterated this policy.

Jayaprakash was of the opinion that it should be seen how the existing system could work properly and how elections and politics could be reformed; and in this context, a strong opposition party was necessary. It may be mentioned that JP had continued to be a member of the Socialist party even after declaring *jivan-dan* in 1954; he left the party only in 1957.

Commenting on the Sangh resolution, Vinoba pointed out that democracy was based on the pernicious doctrine, 'greatest good of the greatest number' to which Sarvodaya was opposed; it stood for the rise of all, the power of all. "We do not object to a particular kind of election; we object to its fundamental ideological premises." He also explained the difference between power politics and what he called 'strength politics' and asserted, "Bhoodan-Yajna is a movement for augmenting people's power. Therefore, it is not devoid of politics. But this movement is against the current politics."¹²

Building up alternative politics—a politics that would lead to a true people's polity—was the mission before Sarvodaya. Its indifference to politics did not betray defeatist mentality. Vinoba was never tired of pointing out how it was essential to remain out of the existing politics: As he aptly put it, one can cut a tree only by standing outside it, not by sitting on its branch.¹³

But many within the Movement were not as convinced about it as Vinoba. Those coming from political parties had not completely shed their belief in politics, and they were many. The mainstream discourse was greatly influenced by the ideas of democracy and Socialism. JP had joined Sarvodaya after getting

disillusioned from politics; he had even rejected Pandit Nehru's offer to become deputy prime minister. Yet he would often be inclined to intervene in electoral politics. Especially when elections were around the corner, Sarva Seva Sangh would deliberate over it to take a stand.

In March 1961, the Sangh advocated selection of candidates through voters' councils and even resolved that work be done in this regard wherever Sarvodaya work had made some headway.¹⁴ The idea that people should put up their own candidates was not new. It was important to work in this regard while working to build up lokniti—people's politics. But to be genuine people's candidates, they should have been candidates put up by the gramsabhas, which were people's instruments in the true sense. No political party could then dare to put up candidates against them. That was what Vinoba had been consistently saying. So-called voters' councils had necessarily to be amorphous entities which could hardly be hoped to represent the opinion of all. Even if some such 'people's candidates' could win the election, how could they be hoped to be effective, and even to work for Sarvodaya? Political intervention was certainly necessary, but when and how it should be made was the question. Organisation and strengthening of gramsabhas was the only logical way in consonance with the Movement's ideology. But that was a long way and the Sangh was, perhaps, impatient and was searching for shortcuts.

Presiding over Unguturu Sarvodaya Conference (1961), JP made an appeal not to remain indifferent to politics and advocated intervention by Sarvodaya to save the country. Sarva Seva Sangh resolved to work for educating the people for putting up its own candidates through voters' councils. Shankarrao Deo, while supporting the resolution, did concede that the step was such as could lead to 'slipping or getting entangled (in difficulties)'.¹⁵

Fascination for politics

Those in the Movement who favoured its active involvement in electoral politics were few. But the number of those who believed that some positive results could be had

through conventional politics was not insignificant.

There was never a question of supporting a particular party. But many were inclined towards the Congress or the Socialist party. Disillusionment with Congress took many, including JP away from it. Many came to believe that the end of the Congress monopoly over power would be better for Indian democracy. JP canvassed against Krishna Menon, the leftist intellectual and ex-Defence Minister, who was widely believed to be responsible for India's debacle in 1962. In 1963, Sarva Seva Sangh's mouthpiece conducted a debate on the need for a political organisation committed to Sarvodaya. Narayan Desai was not off the mark when he expressed worry that Sarvodaya workers' fascination for politics, even while opposing it, might lead to identification with it.¹⁶

Even leading lights of the Movement were not free from such fascination. Sachidanand had commented about Kelappan, the most prominent Sarvodaya leader in Kerala, "With his feet in Sarvodaya, his head is as yet in politics."¹⁷ Nabakrishna Chaudhari of Odisha was a forceful critic of the Congress. And many opposition politicians looked upon JP to help them unite against the Congress.

Geoffrey Ostergaard and M. Currell carried out a survey in 1965 on the background and opinions of Sarvodaya workers. They found that in the first general elections in 1952, 33% had voted, in 1957 62% and in 1962 66%.¹⁸ Majority of them had voted for the Congress. Ostergaard and Currell asked many probing questions to extract political views of the workers. To the question whether 'good' candidates should be helped in the elections, 49% gave affirmative answer.¹⁹

The researchers invited response to the view that the Movement should do more effort to take up current problems such as price rise and evictions. 74% respondents agreed with this. As the authors noted, this showed that the Movement 'might be tempted to move into conventional politics'.²⁰ It was a clear indication of dissatisfaction with the existing programmes, which did not appear to give immediate relief to the people. In the words of the authors, "to ask that it should

do more to take up current problems comes near to asking that it should act more like a political party.”²¹

Unfortunately, many did not appear to realise ideological implications of their impatience for quick results and discernible impact. The enthusiasm with which the majority of workers joined the Bihar Movement later was the logical end result of such line of thinking.

Losing an opportunity

The *Toofan* (whirlwind) campaign during 1965-69 was Vinoba's last-ditch attempt to bring a large enough area under gramdan so as to make a political impact. When asked in 1968 whether the people should be forcefully asked to vote for the representatives of the gramsabhas and not to the party candidates in 1972 elections, Vinoba said,

“Don't just tell this to the people; work for this. If you miss this opportunity nobody will pay heed to you for 25 years. You will be looked upon as good people, doing good work; but you will not be able to talk of revolution.”²²

This was a prophetic insight which future events vindicated. Had the *Toofan* campaign for obtaining gramdan pledges been followed by intensive work on a wide scale to empower the gramsabhas, the 1972 general elections in Bihar would have been different. That was why Vinoba was working with a sense of urgency. But nothing concrete could come out of prakhand (block)-dans and even zilla-dans. An opportunity was thus lost, and this had far-reaching effect not only on the fate of the Movement but also on the future of Independent India.

Freedom from the State

Vinoba vehemently attacked not only politics, but also the institution of State. A 'good' State, for him, was contradiction in terms:

“Some people ask me why I do not protest strongly when the government does something wrong. It is true that I do so only occasionally. But I raise my voice when the government does something good. There is no need for me to protest

against the government's wrongdoings; it is against its good deeds that my protests are needed. I have to warn people not to be like the sheep driven by shepherds. - - - People know very well that bad government should not be tolerated, and everywhere they protest against it. But to me, allowing ourselves to be governed, even by a good government, is itself lamentable."²³

Therefore, replacing one government with another had little significance; what was necessary was to work for the elimination of the State from society. Vinoba was, therefore, not in favour of a struggle against any government; such struggle could only bring about transfer of power, not dissolution of power which was the consummation to be devoutly wished for. Nonviolence seeks co-operation from the property-owners for elimination of institution of property; it likewise seeks co-operation from the governments for elimination of the institution of State. In securing such co-operation lies the strength of nonviolence. Vinoba had, therefore, no hesitation in seeking co-operation even from the governments. That the Movement succeeded in getting it to some extent was as much due to the distinctive functioning of nonviolence as to Vinoba's spiritual stature. For Western anarchists, this 'legitimate anarchism' remained a riddle.

When asked by a Dutch youth whether his talk of decentralisation and village self-rule would not lead to a conflict with the government, Vinoba said,

"It may lead to it or it may not. If bhoodan develops into gramdan speedily, we will be able to transform the government before long and conflict will be averted through love alone. But if conflict becomes inevitable, we are not afraid of it, as love is our *modus operandi*. - - - We accept that, in principle, we are opposed to every government even if the government is not opposed to us, and therefore we are opposed to our government also."²⁴

Still presidents, prime ministers, governors and ministers would share the Sarvodaya platform, and so bureaucracy too would be supportive, although Vinoba did not mince his words while speaking about bureaucracy:

“If the class of (public) servants goes on increasing in number and the reins of the country pass into its hands instead of being in the hands of peasants and workers, God knows what will happen to this country! - - - A middle class has emerged, which does not have to produce anything, does not have to do bodily labour, and yet enjoys a high standard of living. It could oppress others if it so wishes. - - - There could be no greater danger to the country than this.”²⁵

Co-operation from the government

Yet bhoodan and gramdan continued to get co-operation from the parties and the governments. Laws were enacted by the state governments to facilitate transfers of bhoodan lands and gramsabhas in gramdan villages were given wide powers, though not as much as the Movement desired.

In Yelwal conference (1957), it was decided to have closest co-operation between Sarvodaya and Community Development Programme. The latter changed its objective to bring it in tune with the Sarvodaya vision. But it was also interpreted as acceptance of the government’s vision of development by the Sarvodaya Movement! Government officials started running around for the arrangements of the tour party. Vinoba called B.D.O.s (Block Development Officers) and S.D.O.s (Sub-Divisional Officers) ‘Bhoodan Development Officers’ and ‘Sarvodaya Development Officers’. That was perfectly in keeping with his outlook:

“These people (the government officials) too are ours. We are surely not non-cooperating with the government. If they do not come to work at the time of Kumbh mela²⁶ or similar such occasion, you will say that they have not done their duty. So, I do not think that they are doing anything wrong in coming to our help.”²⁷

But it did send a wrong message.

The question was, how to secure co-operation from the governments, even while avoiding its undue interference and also identification with it in the public eye. Dharendra Majumdar expressed his concern in 1962:

“There is nothing wrong in taking benefit of government’s help. But we should do what Lord Krishna did: while sucking Pootana’s milk, he sucked her blood as well.”²⁸ Even when we are securing co-operation from the government, the process of its dissolution should go on unabated. We should not get co-opted in the name of closest co-operation. That will forestall revolution. Vinoba is adept in the art, which Lord Krishna had. But Sarva Seva Sangh is not so adept, and that is why the activities of the Sangh are getting swallowed in the womb of the government.”²⁹

Vasant Bombatkar has recounted an incident during Vinoba’s tour in Wardha district (Maharashtra) in 1964. People from the next proposed halt tersely wrote to Vinoba not to come to their village. When Bombatkar went to the village to know the reason, the villagers showed him a list of 40 directions given by government officials regarding tour arrangements! Bombatkar tore the paper and asked the villagers whether they had any objection if the tour party came and stayed under a tree. Vinoba went to that village and was heartily welcomed. According to Bombatkar, government officials used to have a good time under the pretext of making tour arrangements.³⁰

The so-called co-operation did not change the nature of bureaucracy and its style of functioning. It did little for the bhoodan kisans. Pending mutation of thousands of acres after so many years is a stark evidence of its attitude. In fact, doing these things was not a matter of extending co-operation to the Movement; it was obligatory on a welfare-State.

In Bihar, the government sanctioned a few thousand rupees for thousands of acres of bhoodan lands (1959). When Rs. 10 million were sanctioned for gramdan villages in the third Five-Year Plan having an outlay of 200,000 million rupees, Vinoba retorted,

“What do 10 million count in relation to 2,00,000 millions? I will not like to accept this much. The space given to gramdan in planning is comparable to the space a mosquito occupies in a big mansion! This is an affront to a moral movement, to a moral power. Nowhere else could this have taken place.”³¹

And to cap it all, even such an outrageously paltry amount was not disbursed as no agency was identified for this purpose!

Bhoodan kisans and gramdan villagers received little help from the government. On the contrary, they had (and have) to face hardships, as if they had committed a crime! On the whole, the Movement gained little and lost much on account of the facade of co-operation from the governments.

6. Leadership and Organisation

There was no elaborate planning behind the beginning of the Bhoodan Movement. For Vinoba, it was a signal from God. Social scientists do not understand such language. But it was natural for Vinoba, a man of God. His language was not artificially contrived: it had arisen from deep conviction born out of direct experience.

Vinoba had not consulted anyone before embarking on this mission. Consultation would hardly have mattered. That anyone could give land in response to a moral appeal was beyond anyone's imagination. Vinoba set on foot and others joined in. Sarva Seva Sangh undertook the responsibility of conducting the Movement on its own accord.

Vinoba—the undisputed leader

Vinoba was not only the initiator; he remained the topmost and undisputed leader of the Movement. He would decide the strategy and devise the tactics. He would formulate the programmes and delineate the style of functioning. He would clarify as well as develop the ideology. He would guide the workers and monitor performance. He nominated Bhoodan Committees in the initial phase, and made appointments on Bhoodan Boards when they were formed. Sarva Seva Sangh would deliberate on policy matters and would often disagree with Vinoba's views, but would invariably fall in line eventually, even though the Sangh worked on the principle of consensus, and disagreement of a single person would have blocked any decision. Vinoba had no formal place in the organisation and was in no position to take any disciplinary action against anyone. But nothing could happen in the Sangh without his concurrence. People impatient for an alternative strategy would get irritated, but could do nothing.

If Vinoba's name and quotes appear profusely in the preceding pages, this was because Bhoodan-Gramdan Movement

was Vinoba's movement out and out.

The unwilling leader

Yet, the leadership was thrust on Vinoba by the circumstances.

Few in the country knew him before 1940, when Gandhi announced his name as the first satyagrahi in Individual Civil Disobedience campaign. Constructive workers knew him and looked upon him for leadership after Gandhi's demise, and he naturally became the leader of the Bhoodan Movement. But, by nature, he was a spiritual seeker, not a mass leader. Of course, his quest was not only for spiritual liberation for himself only, but for all. What he sought was collective liberation through collective quest; and the Movement was an instrument for him for this purpose. No other leader could have done '*sookshma-pravesh*' (entering the inner recesses of the Self) at the height of the Movement, when 'the last and the best' fight was on.

So, success could never charm him, nor could failure depress him. Neither would he be flattered by praise nor disheartened by neglect, criticism or opposition. Equanimity of mind was what counted most to him. He had said as long back as in April 1952:

"Sometimes I am happy when I get land. If I feel happy or dejected, I discern that the day has been wasted. Pleasure and dejection, both are flaws. I take as fruitful the day when there is equanimity and contentment in mind."¹

So, that was the criterion; not the figures of land-gifts or number of gramdams.

By his own admission, there was an element of mysticism in him and had not destiny taken him to Gandhi, he would have followed the way of the mystics or the saints:

"Had I not received inspiration from Gandhiji, I would not have been what I am today. It is not in my nature to get involved in all this. The current situation and relations with Gandhiji have propelled me to get involved in it. But I perceive that my mind is made in a different mould."²

Both instinctively and philosophically, Vinoba concurred with the position of Shankaracharya: One should show the way, just as scriptures do; one should not hold anyone's hand and take him to the destination. But when leadership was thrust on this unwilling leader, he rose to the occasion.

Vinoba's leadership style

Vinoba's leadership was basically charismatic. And he was well aware of it. Ostergaard and Currell comment,

“Vinoba's conduct of leadership suggests that he has an intuitive grasp of what charismatic leadership demands and of its dangers (from the movement's point of view) inherent in its routinization. His campaign has been marked by successive dynamic changes, adoption of new programmes, new targets, new objectives, often in the short run bewildering to his disciples, all of which can be interpreted as efforts at the continuous creation of charisma or, at least, as efforts to demonstrate his possession of it.”³

It was the result of his charisma that hundreds of workers held their ground although they were required to put up with hardships without any hope for material gain. To enhance their strength, purity and commitment was Vinoba's main concern: that would inevitably influence the people and motivate them. Every movement goes through ebb and flow; morale of the workers, their faith and hopes should never waver. It is the responsibility of the leadership to ensure this. That Vinoba could do it fairly successfully for a couple of decades bears testimony to the efficacy of his leadership.

Vinoba's image was particularly that of a saint. He would profusely use religious terms and concepts and refer to mythological stories, but with a fresh interpretation in tune with the modern times. The regular prayers he conducted were from Hindu texts. This has been alleged to have affected participation of non-Hindus, but to attribute their lesser participation to this factor alone would be wrong; there were many other reasons. On the whole, Vinoba's references to the ancient values and stories did strike a chord in the hearts of the simple rural folk.

His spiritually towering personality was the Movement's biggest asset.

But this had its disadvantages as well. It had been the complaint of many that it was difficult to have a dialogue with him. His great erudition, his thorough knowledge of people and situations, his unassailable arguments and his style of silencing any dissent were said to prohibit frank discussions. Donald Groom complains while referring to a discussion:

“(Vinoba) seemed to enjoy squashing his adversary in argument and, of course, he is very clever at it. I do not think that under these conditions a good argument takes place. - - - I have a feeling that this method leads to the stultification of the thinking of Bhodan workers, they hesitate to initiate thought and there is a sense in the end that Vinoba has his workers on a string.”⁴

If such complaints were valid, it was certainly a disquieting feature. And this was not the complaint only by ordinary workers, even leaders of the stature of JP had this complaint. According to Kumar Prashant, JP had told him,

“I had a feeling that intellectual debate with Vinoba was not possible. It was possible to have it with Gandhiji. You may not concur with him, but you would have a feeling that you have got points to ponder over. Vinoba talked in the manner of showing right path to those who have strayed from it. His erudition was compelling, but not convincing. But he was the leader, had the whole picture in sight, and most importantly, he himself was active in the field. So, I considered it enough to apprise him of disagreements. And such occasions were many.”⁵

A man like JP could put forth his misgivings or disagreements, but what about ordinary workers? Their silence meant lack of feedback from them about the actual conditions on the ground, and the hopes and expectations of the people. This was certain to affect adversely the formulation of strategy and tactics of the Movement, and consequently their efficacy. Lack of collective decision-making was particularly odd, and also alarming, for a movement that stood for the participation of all

in all areas of life.

Was Vinoba's stature intimidating? Had his spiritual quest and solitude-loving nature distanced him from the ordinary workers so that he had become unable to understand their minds and their limitations? Could he not understand the people's psyche adequately, and therefore was unable to judge men well? Sachidanand opines,

"Confined all his life to scholastic pursuits and consequent upon the high spiritual basis of his personality, Vinoba has proved a poor judge of persons and indirectly harmed his own cause."⁶

It can very well be argued that no leader can conduct a nation-wide movement for years without firm grasp of the people's psyche; and the fact that Vinoba could do this refutes such opinions. Whether he was a poor judge of men or not can also be contested on the same ground. Surely, he put faith in the human nature, and this faith brought out the best in the workers and motivated people for sacrifices.

Not leadership, but collective service

Vinoba was not only an unwilling leader, he was also a leader who was against the very idea of leadership and who not only wanted to eradicate it from society, but took concrete steps in this regard. Conventional leadership can have no place in a society where everyone is looking after everyone else, where the societal affairs are taken care of by all jointly through consensus. Leadership, at a point, can and does appear to fetter a revolutionary movement. Modern Western anarchists go to the extent of giving the slogan, 'Kill the leaders'.

Ever vigilant to discourage leadership, Vinoba also devised a style of working which was consonant with this position:

"It is a great beauty of bhoodan that it does not give rise to all-India leadership, as its means are walking tours. Therefore, leadership has necessarily to be local. In fact, not local leadership but local servanthship gets evolved, as we will get land only if we go to the people with the spirit of service, not as leaders."⁷

In this context, Vinoba put forth the concept of '*ganasevakatva*' (collective servanthip). It was his distinctive contribution to the science of organisation and to political science. He declared that there would be no leaders in future and explained the concept of *ganasevakatva*:

"Some people look upon it as mass leadership. Some think that it pertains to an initiative to serve the people with a sense of duty. Some equate it with selfless service. So, it needs to be clarified. There is absolutely no leadership in it. We deliberate together. Our views may not match. We express our opinions, but accord our consent to the general consensus that has emerged, and then extend full cooperation to the work. This is what *ganasevakatva* means. It signifies awareness of one's strengths, lack of ego, humility, and a clear perception of one's place and utility (in the community). Love being at the base of it, it will be much more powerful than the leadership."⁸

Second line of leadership

It was certainly not possible for Vinoba to spread the Movement throughout the country without the involvement of seasoned workers from different regions. The Movement was fortunate to have such second line of leadership. Prominent among them were Jayaprakash Narayan, Shankarrao Deo, Dharendra Majumdar and Dada Dharmadhikari. Many prominent figures from the Gandhi era enthusiastically participated in the Movement, but some remained a bit aloof despite having sympathies, while some had reservations. Kishorlal Mashruwala and Shrikrishnadas Jajoo supported the Movement, but could not contribute for long. Miraben and J.C. Kumarappa, however, had some reservations. Persons like Kaka Kalelkar and Appa Patwardhan supported the Movement, but had different priorities. Leading politicians like Nabakrishna Chaudhari, Kelappan and Charuchandra Bhandari sacrificed flourishing political career. Spiritual aspirants like Swami Ramanand Tirtha, Baba Raghavdas and Tukdoji Maharaj, and a virtual saint like Ravishankar Maharaj found fulfilment of their quest in the Movement. Individuals like Annasaheb Sahasrabuddhe, Thakurdas Bang, S. Jagannathan, Manmohan

Chaudhari, Narayan Desai, Ramamoorti, Siddharaj Dhaddha, Radhakrishna Bajaj, R.K. Patil and Nirmala Deshpande earned a pan-Indian identity. Doyens of constructive work like Laxmibabu, A.K. Karan, Vichitrannarayan Sharma and Ashadevi Aryanayakam contributed in their own way. Saraladevi, Keithan and Marjorie Sykes became part of the Movement despite being foreigners. Individuals like Shriman Narayan remained an insider even while discharging other responsibilities.

Sachidanand has commented,

“[T]he emotional upsurge generated by Vinoba in the Indian masses needs practical realistic men for its effective channelization. Vinoba is a Marx who needs a Lenin in the Indian context.”⁹

It can be said that Vinoba was both Marx and Lenin combined together. The question is not of the aptness of simile; it is whether Vinoba could get a worthy successor or not.

Jayaprakash was undoubtedly the tallest in the second line of leadership. He had the aura and qualities of a leader. He could communicate the thought of the Movement in modern terms. He was known all over the world. The Movement was greatly benefited by his leadership. But JP could not become Vinoba's Lenin. He was basically a charismatic leader; organisation-building was not his forte. He had not been able to build the Socialist party. Nor could he later forge, while the Bihar Movement was on, an organisation which could consolidate the gains of the movement. More importantly, it appears that he was not fully convinced about the ideal of State-free society. Perhaps he was not able to get rid of the fascination for democracy and socialism (which, incidentally, he shared with not a few leaders and workers). His vision for the 'reconstruction of Indian polity' was little more than an alternative scheme for democratic decentralisation. His perplexity is evident throughout the course of the Movement. One can unquestionably place Gandhi and Vinoba among the greatest anarchist thinkers, not JP. Bhoodan-Gramdan Movement remained an anarchist movement despite seeking and receiving co-operation from governments; Bihar movement

cannot be so categorised although it engaged in direct confrontation with the government.

Many other leaders like Shankarrao Deo, Kelappan, Nabakrishna Chaudhari and Dada Dharmadhikari were also not free from the idea that democratic politics, as it existed, could achieve something positive. Dhirendra Majumdar was perhaps the only one in the top echelon who had total commitment to Vinoba's vision and ideal. But his inclination was towards experimentation, not organisational work on a wide scale.

Worker of the Movement

The concept of *ganasevakatva* demanded that the workers should have high calibre. But there was no arrangement for selection of the workers. Everyone who wanted to join was welcome. Many came from politics, not necessarily because of disillusionment, but also because they had been discarded. The proportion of the latter was surely not substantial, but an impression was created that the Movement was a refuge of such elements. Workers from political parties stayed only till their parties and political interests were being served. Many came from institutions of constructive work because they were deputed and many were only job-seekers; with so much poverty and unemployment around, what nominal the Movement offered was also welcome. When hundreds declared *jivan-dan* (gift of life) at the Bodhgaya Conference (1954) Dhirendra Majumdar suggested their screening, but Vinoba declined: "Who are we to test them?"¹⁰ He believed in trying to raise the calibre of the stuff in hand. In fact, any revolutionary movement has to have this approach. Besides, as the work of bhoodan involved hardships, selfless service and no material gains, it could be expected that those with impure motives would eventually step aside of their own accord.

It was necessary, but not sufficient, that the workers should have honesty and integrity. The Movement was basically an ideological movement; not political programmes and agitations for the solution of current problems, but education was its means. So, the workers needed to have thorough understanding of its philosophy and capability to propagate it effectively. Study

was indispensable in this regard, and Vinoba was never tired of stressing its importance. But lack of adequate study remained a drawback of the Movement. The workers were few in number and were overburdened with work; finding time for study was easier said than done.

Training was also of crucial importance in this connection. Vinoba was well aware of this. Establishment of ashrams was a step in this direction. But adequate facilities for this purpose could not be created. In the heat of the movement, training received back seat. Pyarelal had charged, "Bhoodan began by dismantling ashrams instead of reorganising them."¹¹ Listening to the speeches by the leaders remained the main source of training. New workers would sometimes be attached to senior workers. But that was not enough. And then the workers would parrot the leaders' words, which was hardly enough to make an impression, neither on the rural folk who compared their words with their lives, nor on the educated and the elite.

In fact, after the phase of obtaining bhoodan and gramdan, what was needed was not preaching, but working with the people. Technical expertise regarding many matters was also needed. Matters like distribution of lands needed technical expertise, besides patience and tact to work with the revenue bureaucracy. And post-gramdan work involved understanding the problems, earning credibility in the people's eyes, and motivating them to think and work for themselves. But in the race for targets, all this was virtually forgotten.

Dhirendra Majumdar was serious about training and established Samagra Gramseva Vidyalaya (School for integral service of the villages), but it did not last long. Also, his emphasis was on labour-intensive self-sufficient life, not on imparting skills in social engineering or even in revenue matters.

For Vinoba, the Movement being basically spiritual, those with a spiritual bent of mind were more likely to stay put. But it was too much to expect that many workers with such bent of mind as well as revolutionary fervour could be found. Most of the workers could possess either of the two; and at times friction between these two kinds of workers could not be avoided.

Paucity of workers was appalling. Political and constructive workers were there temporarily. The Movement's own cadre could not become significant in number. *Nidhimukti* (freedom from funds) and *tantramukti* (freedom from organisational structures) in 1956 forced many workers to leave. When JP told Ben Gurien, Prime Minister of Israel that four to five thousand workers were working in this movement, he wondered how such a small number would suffice for 400 million people.¹²

Strength of the handful of workers would also be diverted to many other programmes and initiatives from time to time despite Vinoba's consistent appeals to devote wholeheartedly to bhoodan and gramdan. At times, even Vinoba appeared to put emphasis on other programmes.

Ordeal by fire

That a handful of workers remained active on the front for years through thick and thin despite so many odds is an accomplishment that the Movement should be proud of. In a survey by T.K. Oommen, 59% respondents told him that the workers were not self-serving, only 12% said that they were.¹³ These workers were, after all, human beings and were not entirely free from human failings. They came from and lived in a society which was in the vortex of self-interest and greed. If some of them, in certain situations, fell prey to temptations, it was hardly exceptionable, though surely not justifiable. Broadly speaking, these workers did honestly try to rise above self-interest, and also differences on account of caste, religion, gender, language etc.

Their penance is an inspiring chapter in the history of Independent India. Vinoba's example was before them. The old man was walking on throughout the length and breadth of the country: scorching heat, chilly winds, incessant rains and flooded rivers—nothing could deter that frail man with ulcer in stomach and a host of other ailments. Rural India, known for her hospitality, did try to look after the sage as best as she could. But ordinary workers had to face a lot of hardships. There was no question of carrying provisions and cooking; so at times they had to go without food. Timely medical help was not available

in many regions. Financial difficulties were always there. Different kinds of food at different times, different arrangements for sleeping—all such factors were patience-testing as well as physique-testing. Lack of proper toilet facilities, particularly for women, was also a problem.

At times, the workers had to face opposition from dominant landlords; it was not all smooth sailing. Opposition could take the form of denial of food or shelter or even threats and beating. Goons would be let loose on workers working against evictions. Strongholds of Communists would expectedly be non-cooperative. Price had to be paid for not believing in and not practising untouchability. Vinoba knew that “as the true nature of work will be revealed, it will prick without fail. - - - If our work affects society, strong opposition will be forthcoming.”¹⁴

Names of some of the prominent workers have appeared in preceding pages. By no means others were less noteworthy. It is worthwhile here to mention a few names: Yadunath Singh (Kashmir), Baidyanath Prasad Chaudhari, Gourishankar Sharan Singh, Motilal Kejariwal, Ramdev Thakur, Dhawaja Prasad Sahoo, Gajanan Lal, Vidyasagar, Sarvanarayandas, Brijmohan Sharma, Ahad Fatmi, Razi Ahmed, Mahendra Narayan, Ramjee Singh, Tripurari Sharan, Dwarko Sundarani, Nirmal Chandra, Krishnaraj Mehta (Bihar), Gokulbhai Bhatt, Poornachandra Jain, Chhitarmal Goyal, Badriprasad Swami, Deendayal Dashottar (Rajasthan), Dadabhai Naik, Kashinath Trivedi, Hemdev Sharma, Rajmohini Devi, Devendra Gupta, Narendra Dube, V.S. Khode, Mahendra Kumar, Manav Muni, G.U. Patankar, Swami Krishnanand, Banwarilal Chaudhari, Manindra Kumar, Chaturbhuj Pathak (Madhya Pradesh), Lala Achint Ram, Omprakash Tripathi, Yashpal Mittal, Satyam Bhai, Ujagar Singh Bilga, Som Dutt (Punjab), Sunderlal Bahuguna, Karan Bhai, Prem Bhai, Suresh Ram, Diwan Shatrughna Singh, Shrikrishnadutt Bhatt, Tejsinghbhai, Amarnathbhai, Vinay Awasthi, Prakashbhai, Ravindra Singh Chouhan, Vidyabahan and Narendrabhai (U.P.), Govindrao Shinde, Govindrao Deshpande, Vasant Nargolkar. Prabhakar Bapat, P.G. Shendurnikar, Vasant Gade, Vasant Bombatkar, S.M. Pente, Gangaprasad Agrawal,

Ram Deshpande, Anna Jadhav, Eknath Bhagat, Bhau Dharmadhikari, Babulal Gandhi, Vimala Thakar, Chandusingh Naik, Baburao Chandawar, Mama Kshirsagar, Baba Redikar, Ramkrishna Aadhe, Shriram and Malati Chinchalikar, Ramakant Patil, Eli Gadkar, Daniel and Hansa Majgaonkar, Suman Bang (Maharashtra), Jugatram Dave, Babalbhai Mehta, Prabodh Choksi, Harivallabh Parikh, Kanti Shah, Jagdish Shah, Chunibhai Vaidya, Amrut Modi, Meera and Arun Bhatt, Kanta-Harvilas, Dukhayal, Dwarkadas Joshi (Gujarat), Keshav Rao, Prabhakar, C.V. Chari, Birdhichand Chaudhari, Gora, Lavanam, Dr. Sooryanarayan (Andhra Pradesh), Krishnamma Jagannathan, K. M. Natarajan, T. Damodaran, V. Ramachandran, Arunachalam, Dr. Aram (Tamil Nadu), Sadashivrao Bhosle, S.N. Subbarao, E.P. Menon, Satyavrat (Karnataka), Rajamma, Radhakrishna Menon, Gopinathan Nair, Govindan (Kerala), Kshitish Raychaudhari, Vidhubhushan Dasgupta, Krishnakant Chakravarti, Shailesh Bandyopadhyay (West Bengal). Amalprabha Das, Ravindra Upadhyay, Hem Bharali, Lakshmi Phukan (Assam), Malatidevi Chaudhari, Harihar Das, Ratan Das, Dayanidhi Patnayak, Harmohan Patnayak, Babulal Mital, Annapoorna Maharana, Sharatchandra Maharana, Mohammed Baji, Biswanath Patnayak (Odisha) and Dharamdev Shastri (Himachal Pradesh).

This list is far from exhaustive. Many more deserve mention here. The Movement is not only a saga of the deeds of a few outstanding leaders; it is a saga of the contribution of many such workers who served as foundation stones. (It is to them that this book is dedicated.)

Names of Damodardas Moondada, Mahadevi, Balvijay, Jayadev, Kusum Deshpande and Kalindi, who diligently attended on Vinoba and preserved his words for posterity, also need to be mentioned.

Organisation of the movement

Leadership is of crucial importance to any movement, but its actual conduct depends on the organisation: its form, skilfulness, creativity and ability to take timely and effective decisions. Can a nonviolent organisation be created and can it be effective?

Gandhi had said, "Organisation is the test of nonviolence." Elaborating the idea, Vinoba said,

"Protagonists of violence build a strong organisation with obligatory directives and rules, and thus create the strength which violence intrinsically lacks. In nonviolence, orders cannot be given, there cannot be punishments, inducements or rewards. It is the test of nonviolence to show that a stronger organisation can still be created."¹⁵

How could this be possible? This needs faith in consensus-building. Hence, Vinoba insisted on consensus decision-making and Sarva Seva Sangh adopted the same process.

A nonviolent organisation cannot have hierarchy. It cannot enforce discipline through coercive sanctions. Its programmes can be implemented only if the cadre has full faith in them. They should therefore be formulated by the rank and file, not by a small group. That is implied in the idea of *ganasevakatva*. Vinoba was ever conscious to discourage leadership and encourage *ganasevajatva*. Sarvodaya conferences used to be held at his halting places; he insisted on changing this practice in 1960. Still, it has to be admitted that it was Vinoba who continued to devise strategy and formulate programmes; collective decision-making in this regard could not become a reality.

In the 1948 conference of constructive workers, Vinoba had talked of '*sahaj sangathan*' (natural organisation)—an organisation without a structure. Sarvodaya Samaj was supposed to be such an organisation. But it did not evolve on the expected lines.

After 1957, when the idea of Shanti-Sena was put forward, Vinoba again deliberated the question of a nonviolent organisation.¹⁶ How can it have the capacity to mobilise forces without discipline? How can self-imposed self-discipline and commitment to consensus be more effective than the enforced discipline? How can the element of power be done away with in an organisation?—These were his concerns. But Shanti-Sena too was short-lived and could not become a model of nonviolent organisation.

For Vinoba, it was the spirit that mattered, not the external size. Conventional organisations rest on the sanction of violence, and therefore he had aversion for them. This was often taken to mean that he was against organisation as such, and it was thought that it proved to be a bane for the Movement. Dhirendra Majumdar tried to dispel this misconception:

“All the revolutions to date have been organised through the power of a particular coterie. Vinoba wants to revolutionise the means for revolution. He holds that a revolution can truly take place not through the strength of a coterie but through the strength of thought. Hence he always says that a revolution cannot be ‘brought about’; it takes place of its own accord. When a revolution is brought about through the strength of a leader and his coterie, the latter’s vested interest is created in the consummation of revolution and society remains where it was. Hence, Vinoba does not build an organisational structure; he rather advocates *tantra-mukti* (freedom from the structures). So it is not his weak point; it is his conscious effort.”¹⁷

Vinoba gave the *mantra* of *tantra-mukti*, but alternative arrangements had to be devised.

Commitment to ideology

After *tantra-mukti* (1956), a *nivedak* (reporter) was named in every district to keep contact with Vinoba directly. But the idea did not prove satisfactory. Sarva Seva Sangh took the centre-stage particularly after the change in its constitution in 1959. Dominance of a handful of the leaders in the Sangh remained a persistent complaint of the cadre. Perhaps this was inevitable as the Movement continued to be campaign-based, and therefore necessarily centrally commanded. Lack of heart-unity among the workers also proved to be a weakness. To work for consensus and follow it needs putting oneself behind others. This could not take place in the degree needed. There was nothing unusual in it, but a movement that was qualitatively different in essence and ethos should have presented a different picture. Its failure in this respect had inevitable repercussions.

In every movement, only a few fully understand its ideology. The case should certainly have been different for a movement which had faith in the power of thought, and which sought transformation in society through transformation in thoughts. But unfortunately, that was not so. Vinoba had realisation of this weakness; his comment in 1958 is pertinent in this respect:

“The ideas on which our community stands are extremely solid, extremely deep and wide-ranging. But our vision of them is neither deep nor broad nor firm. Hence, we are struggling to find the way even after 7 years.”¹⁸

Sarvanarayandas had written to Kanti Shah, in retrospect, in 2001,

“The character of this community of workers was broadly political. Most of the workers had come because of political consciousness and impulse. Vinoba continued to devise measures for purging them of that influence and reform their style of working. This was achieved to some extent. This purging essentially meant purification of minds and lives. - - - Most of the workers in Bihar could not sustain themselves in the Movement not because they were not cared for, although they did leave citing this reason. They were not ready to pay the price this task of purification demanded.”¹⁹

Is this a harsh comment? Vidyasagar had even harsher comment to make in a letter to the author:

“The followers of Gandhi and Vinoba did not properly understand their ideas and programmes. Why? Because their minds, in the language of the Gita, had become intent on pleasure and power.”²⁰

Kameshwar Prasad Bahuguna laments,

“Vinoba was buried under the weight of history, as he was all alone. He got a big band of devotees, but they were just bards. Vinoba remained extremely lonely amidst the din and the crowd.”²¹

One may not agree with these comments. But it has to be

admitted that the workers' ideological commitment to nonviolence, and consequently to the ideal of State-free society remained doubtful.

Compromises in practice

Compromises in practice could not be averted. Sarva Seva Sangh, which was spearheading the Movement, owned real estate and had the responsibility to safeguard it; at times it had to fight legal cases. This was not a happy situation for a movement which stood for abolition of property and the State and freedom from the law courts.

When Vinoba was at the helm, consensus was a smooth affair. But when he withdrew, the principle of consensus came under strain. Rather than having patience, courage, ingenuity and creativity to devise ways to build consensus, the principle itself was thought inconvenient. The Sangh, as an organisation, could not take pro-Bihar Movement stand because of this principle. Perhaps irked by this, protagonists of Bihar Movement removed this principle from its constitution in June 1978, although anti-Bihar Movement elements had left the Sangh and there was no urgency to overturn in haste an established practice that distinguished the Sangh from its contemporaries.

Removal of this provision had far-reaching implications; it meant transformation of an anarchist organisation into a conventional democratic organisation.

Social base of the Movement

The social base of the Movement could not become as wide as it should have been. That was perhaps inevitable in a country like India characterised by diversities—a country with plethora of castes, communities, religions, languages, customs, traditions, and even histories.

The first major land-gift (11,000 acres) was given by a Muslim. Many Muslims gave land-gifts and received bhoodan lands. Yet inadequate participation by Muslims remained a matter of concern for the Movement. The number of Christians was also not noteworthy. In the survey by Ostergaard and

Currell in 1965, proportion of Muslims and Christians among senior workers in the movement was found to be only 1% each (Jains were 3%, Sikhs 1% and Hindus 94%).²² Vinoba's idiom and prayers are often considered a major reason for this state. But that would be too simplistic. Discussing why Muslims were so few in the Movement, Ostergaard and Currell also cite the 'ethos of Hinduism' as a likely factor, but also note,

"Part of the answer undoubtedly lies with the Muslims themselves. Muslim suspicions, even of liberal Hindus, are indeed hard to remove! Moreover, while there are many elements in the Islamic faith which are perfectly compatible with Sarvodaya doctrine, there are elements in the latter which may have little appeal to the orthodox Muslim. Among these elements are the equality of the sexes, the 'equal truth' of all religions, and, perhaps, the principle of Non-violence itself."²³

As far as the caste configuration is concerned, the survey found that 38% were Brahmins, 26% Kshatriyas and 26% Vaishyas—the twice-born castes thus accounted for 90% senior workers.²⁴ In the context of the time of this survey, this is perhaps not surprising, although a higher percentage of those from backward communities would have been desirable. The rise of middle castes and the women and the depressed classes occurred in subsequent years. Sarvodaya did contribute to this phenomenon in its own way: how far did it contribute is an interesting matter for research.

Sources of monetary support

Money is needed in every movement: to support workers, and to implement programmes. How a movement raises the requisite money influences its nature and fate. A revolutionary movement needs to raise money through means commensurate with its vision.

Padayatra (walking tours) was the main medium for the Movement. So, the question of travelling expenses was taken care of to a large extent. Villagers of the halting places would arrange for food and public meetings. But money was needed for land distribution and certain other purposes.

Gandhi Memorial Fund had been raised in the memory of Gandhiji after his demise. It volunteered to aid the Movement. For leaders responsible for fund-raising, it was godsend. Vinoba, a protagonist of *Kanchan-mukti*, was, in principle, opposed to reliance on any such fund, but practical considerations prevailed. The aid was accepted and it was hoped that alternative sources would gradually take its place.

Raising alternative sources was Vinoba's persistent concern. He was not interested to collect the money somehow; he wanted onset of transformation in the donors. He came up with many ideas in this regard. In 1952, when the Movement was in its infancy, he put forth the scheme of *sampattidan* (gift of wealth). The idea of *sootanjali* (gift of self-spun yarn) in Gandhiji's memory had already been suggested. But neither of the two ideas could work. Reliance on funds like Gandhi Memorial Fund had its adverse effect on the revolutionary character of the Movement. To restore its revolutionary character and to make it people's movement in the true sense, Vinoba took the ambitious and risky step of *nidhi-mukti* (refusal to seek or accept money from accumulated funds) in 1956 and expressed the hope that other sources of funds would spring up. He gave the programme of *Sarvodaya-patra* in this connection. It had many potentialities: raising funds was only one aspect. But this programme also failed to gain desired momentum.

Many workers embarked on a courageous experiment to live on *janadhar* (people's support) and suffered hardships. Some like Vasant Gade of Nagpur continued to live on *janadhar* till the end. Some workers received support from their families. But prodding oneself on this path for long expectedly proved difficult for the majority of workers. Some found such effort so time-consuming as to leave little time for work!

So, financial problems continued to haunt the Movement and it had to depend on funds collected by a few leaders having requisite skills. It was decided to present a purse of Rs. 10 million to Vinoba on his 75th birth anniversary, but collections fell short of the target despite extending the deadline from time to time. And the formula of distributing the amount to different

states was so skewed that it was not much of a help to the Movement.

Vinoba made many suggestions. The idea of *upavasdan* (donation of money saved by fasting once in a month) was the last and perhaps the brightest. It was the idea of funding the Movement through the purest means. But it met the same fate as the earlier proposals.

Thus, the Movement failed to raise financial resources commensurate to its vision, and to the extent needed. It is indeed surprising that so much could be achieved despite so acute dearth of resources. The ideas put forth at that time can still be tried. Much can be learnt from the churning of ideas and experiments conducted by the Movement at that time in this regard. That a revolutionary movement will have to mobilise financial resources in a revolutionary manner is an indisputable postulate.

7. Gramdan: Retrospect and Prospect

During the British Raj, land became private property; and that was a major reason for the devastation of the peasants and the villages. Constitution of Independent India put a seal of approval on this. To abolish private property in land was neither possible through legal measures in the democratic structure nor through violence. Bhoodan-Gramdan tried to do this through nonviolence and paved the way for protection and nurturing of natural resources and their sustainable use by giving everyone equal rights on and equal obligations towards natural resources, and consequently empower the communities to look after their own affairs and move ahead towards self-governance. Making an honest effort in this direction is itself invaluable; whatever such an effort actually achieves adds to its value. Bhoodan-Gramdan made a sincere effort, and that too against the tide. Even today, 3,972 villages are registered under Gramdan Acts in various states; private ownership of land stands abolished there. It is not a significant figure, compared to about 5,00,000 villages in the country; but is certainly not inconsiderable.

Moreover, this effort was not just for abolition of private property in land, it was for total transformation in man and society. Higher the aim, more are the chances of failure. Bhoodan-Gramdan Movement preferred to risk failure instead of having a lower aim.

It was not just an effort to solve a particular problem; it was to empower and motivate people to solve their own problems. History tells that whenever any problem is solved by a group, it inevitably leads to the domination of that group. Revolutionaries of today become tyrants of tomorrow. The Movement did not seek to become vanguard of a revolution; it strove to create conditions under which a revolution would take place. Herein lies the uniqueness of the Movement and its unparalleled contribution. It put forth an alternative to

Capitalism and Socialism with a strong theoretical foundation and effective programmes. And while doing this, it drew upon the spiritual legacy of mankind and evolved it.

Saints had sowed the seeds of moral values in people, not only to make them better human beings, but also to bring about transformation in them leading to their true liberation. Social revolutionaries had sought to transform society and dismantle structures inimical to freedom. Both approaches have their utility and their limitations. Both have proved inadequate. Gandhi fused both of these together so that human race could take the next step in evolution. Vinoba carried this idea further and made Gandhian discourse more comprehensive, more cogent and more effective.

How can such an unprecedented endeavour be evaluated? Have we any appropriate criteria for this purpose? Sugata Dasgupta was right in commenting,

“A dynamic movement like this, which seeks to bring in a fundamental revolution, is not easy to evaluate. Even if it can be done, there are questions: Can such a movement, for example, be evaluated by its contemporary critics? Or should it be left to history to do that? And again: has any such movement, anywhere in the world, ever been evaluated? And do we, accordingly, know the method by which one can conduct such evaluation? The questions are difficult to answer.”¹

Language also poses a problem. To those versed in the terminology and jargon of the modern social sciences, it is difficult to understand the terms, the phrases, the idioms and the metaphors of the Movement. How can one evaluate the Movement getting neither unnerved nor fascinated by them?

But evaluation is inescapable. Why did the Movement peter out so rapidly? Was anything wrong with the leadership, the strategy, the tactics, the style of working, the programmes or their implementation? These and similar questions must be grappled with. Then only the relevance and usefulness of the Movement will become clear, and we will learn lessons to develop our understanding of the present situation and find a

way out of the present impasse. Revisiting history is rewarding because we can learn something from it in the interest of a better future. That holds true for the history of Bhoodan-Gramdan Movement as well.

From bhoodan to gramdan

Evolution of gramdan from bhoodan was the natural culmination of a process. Bhoodan was to kindle the spirit of sharing. Gramdan developed this spirit further and paved the way to a society free from exploitation, domination and coercion of any kind. In elaborating the potentialities of gramdan, Vinoba's genius scaled new heights.

Many objections on bhoodan became redundant with the advent of gramdan. Economist D.R. Gadgil wrote in 1957,

“(A)s considered against a static background, Bhoodan had justification. If there was no prospect of a change either in the structure of economic society or the level of its productivity, social justice supported the plea of the Bhoodan movement. If the population was to remain prominently agricultural and poor, there was every reason for sharing our poverty more equitably. - - - While I still hold that in a dynamic situation Bhoodan would prove inappropriate, I can visualise Gramdan being a powerful instrument of initiating the rapid socio-economic changes, in bringing about which there appears general agreement in the country. - - - the contention that in Bhoodan ‘dan’ is to be interpreted not as charity but as equal distribution (दानं संविभागः) was never proved in practice to be true and was difficult to accept even conceptually. With Gramdan there is no difficulty in accepting this definition of the term ‘dan’.”²

Gadgil called Gramdan ‘an unprecedented movement with many and complex implications and very great potentialities’.³

Pyarelal, who knew Gandhi's mind during his last years more than anyone else, wrote,

“Gandhiji's idea (of trusteeship) is today reborn and is being pursued with spectacular success by Vinoba Bhave. It promises to usher in the ‘thorough social awakening’ of

which Gandhiji had prophetically talked - - - and to become spearhead of a nonviolent revolution whose implications reach far and wide. - - - It is not merely the transfer of land from one hand to another that constitutes the core of the Bhoodan revolution, but development of the full function of land which it makes possible. - - - Gramdan provides an opportunity, especially where donated villages form solid blocks, to try out all the techniques devised by Gandhiji from time to time to enable the toiling masses in the villages to retain and enjoy their full share of nature's bounty and the fruits of their toil against any combination of vested interests, however well-entrenched and powerful, and to realise on a regional scale the full picture of a nonviolent, non-exploiting egalitarian society.”⁴

It was, therefore, understandable that the focus of the Movement shifted from bhoodan to gramdan. It has been argued that it was wrong, as bhoodan gave immediate relief to the poor. It created a pro-poor image of the Movement among the poor as well as in the society at large, and also gave satisfaction to the workers. Gramdan might be a grand idea, but had its time come? If not, was the effort to take it up premature and therefore unavoidably futile? Should the Movement have concentrated first on achieving the target for bhoodan and solve the land problem first before taking up gramdan? Or should bhoodan and gramdan have been taken up concurrently? Many such questions arise in this context.

One thing was crystal clear. Bhoodan, in itself, could not solve the land problem, as Vinoba repeatedly said. Permanent solution of the problem lay in villagisation of land—community control and management over land. So, when a concrete programme was found for the purpose, it was proper to put emphasis on it. The workers were limited in number, and their energies should have been harnessed to the most important task. Secondly, land-gifts had come to a trickle after the initial euphoria. Land distribution was time-consuming and not many workers were interested and well-versed in this dreary task. Boards constituted by the governments were working in this regard. An inspiring programme that could rekindle the

revolutionary fervour was the need of the time. Gramdan was such a programme.

But bhoodan was not completely forgotten. Vinoba and other leaders continued to underline the need to pay attention to bhoodan also. While travelling to North East, Vinoba appealed to the people of Bihar to achieve the bhoodan target through 'Bigha kattha' campaign. The difficulties in land distribution brought home the realisation that it was beyond the capacity of the Movement's workers. Gramsabha alone could accomplish this task properly. And gramdan was essential to empower gramsabhas to discharge this function.

It was not that gramdan was not providing immediate relief to the poor. They were getting 5% of the village land under gramdan. Gramsabha, where they were equal partners, could be trusted to look after their interests more than any other agency. It was expected to encourage setting up of industries in the village and provide for full employment. In Bodhgaya, Vinoba had announced *jivan-dan* for 'nonviolent revolution with Bhoodan-Yajna as foundation and village industries as its mainstay'. Idea of gramkosh had been put forward to provide for capital formation for the gramsabha's developmental functions and welfare measures.

Bhoodan was an impractical programme by conventional standards. But it was tried and did give some results. Gramdan was even more impractical, but it too showed some results. It showed that what appeared improbable could take place, and that too on a significant scale. If some villages can come forward voluntarily to abolish private ownership on land and resolve to look after their affairs, there is no reason to assume that other villages cannot or will not do it. They may not be able to do this because of several impediments. But that is no case for rejecting gramdan out of hand; what is then needed is to remove those impediments through effective strategies.

Inadequate legal framework

D.R. Gadgil had rightly said,

"Wherever the Gramdan experiment is conducted in a

substantial measure, very special legal and administrative provisions would be required to give it a fair trial; these could not be made perfect within a short time, and a large amount of sympathetic experimentation could alone prove what is required.”⁵

The State signally failed in its obligations. Many states did not enact gramdan legislation. Some states incorporated some provisions in the Bhoodan or Panchayat Acts, which mattered little as far as self-governance was concerned. Lack of discernible people's power was one reason for the lukewarm response by the State. One also wonders whether adequate efforts were made at the level of the Movement to make Gramdan Acts more in tune with the gramdan spirit.

Gramdan laws, wherever they were made, were far from satisfactory. The stipulated procedures were not only complex, patience-trying and time-consuming, many were unnecessary. Rather than encouraging villagers who had taken such a bold step, they served to dampen the spirit. Many provisions gave the State an upper hand and ultimate control. For example, there is a provision in some Acts that the government can supercede the gramsabha. There may be a case for supercession of the working committee of the gramsabha, but how can gramsabha, which is a body of all the adult villagers, be superseded? Such a provision is not only preposterous, it is also outrageous.

Sugata Dasgupta notes,

“The legal squabbles, the official red tape, the time that takes for commutation to take place—all these built-in deficiencies of the political system conspire to tone down the original enthusiasm and achievement of gramdan. From ‘*sankalp*’ (resolve) or ‘*prapti*’ (declaration) to actual transfer is a long step and the delays that take place all along the route often defeat the original mission and kill much of the fighting spirit of the movement. Had the State been more co-operative and thrown all its weight to ‘legalise’ the transfers that have already taken place by mutual consent and then zealously guarded the rights of the small peasantry, as it does the interests of the industrial workers,

the whole panorama of rural society would have undergone a vital change. A voluntary organisation is bound to fail in certain respects.”⁶

Distortion of the village structure

British Raj had distorted the village structure—whether it was out of ignorance or for administrative convenience or was a deliberate malicious attempt to kill community spirit in the villages is anybody’s guess. Creation of revenue villages, dividing natural villages in different administrative villages or clubbing together many natural villages in a single revenue village—all these did contribute to the weakening of village communities, even if it might not have been intended. Sarvanarayandas writes,

“A great hurdle in the way of establishment of gram-swaraj, which is like an iceberg, is the dichotomy between the actual village and administrative village. In an actual village, parts of many revenue villages have been joined. You will find parts of a single house in two revenue villages. Parts of a *locality often fall under different panchayats* (development blocks) and even under different districts. I had seen in my childhood that my village with a population of 1,000 was divided in four revenue villages, and three of them included localities at a distance of one to two miles. I had thought it to be a strange peculiarity of my village. But when I found such distortions everywhere during land distribution work, I was compelled to conclude that it was a deliberate plan by the British to divide the village in such a way that it would not be able to unite. - -

“This was not an insurmountable barrier during land distribution, but it sounded death knell for the gramdan *pushti* work and the working of gramsabhas. Dichotomy between the actual village and the revenue village prevented village unity, and the provisions of the Gramdan Act or facilities extended by the government could be of no avail. To unite real villages, the unnatural and fictitious villages would have to be effaced altogether. It needs reordering of stupendous magnitude; and the will necessary for this purpose exists neither in the government nor in the people.”⁷

Such situation might not be there in the whole of the country; but it existed in Bihar, where the Movement fought its longest and the toughest and the last battle. Only in a genuine village can gramsabha work effectively.

The State's failure

The State did take some measures, but defaulted where its backing was most crucial and was vitally needed. Gramdan was raising hopes and aspirations of the poor, and timely measures by the State were essential to avert their getting dashed. Its failure in this respect was bound to have serious repercussions.

This apprehension was expressed by many observers. 'Times of India' wrote (1957), "It will be a tragedy if this hope (for a better life) is defeated for the lack of action on the part of Government."⁸ Sugata Dasgupta warned that this would lead to 'cumulative frustration, frustration to aggression and the latter ultimately to disintegration' of the individuals.⁹ Erica Linton called the Movement 'at least an honest attempt to put life into rural India, to lift it up from apathy and stagnation, and to give new hope to millions of poverty-stricken Indians' and said, "It would be tragic if it were allowed to fail."¹⁰

But the State did allow it to fail. Gramdan villages had displayed an exemplary spirit in surrendering voluntarily their private property in land. No measure was initiated and carried out to foster that spirit.

Contribution to integration and equality

In the course of the Movement, workers went to even the smallest and the remotest villages; to the homes and fields of the people to propagate the philosophy of the Movement and to obtain signatures or thumb impressions of the people on gramdan pledges (*sankalp-patras*). People do not put their signatures on any paper casually; they are even more hesitant when they cannot read what they are called upon to affirm concurrence to. They do so only when no doubt is lurking in their minds. Obtaining signatures or thumb impressions in such a situation on such a massive scale on papers, not for making

any demand but to express readiness to voluntarily surrender ownership of land, is an achievement that is wonderful by any standard.

In the course of doing this, there was unprecedented churning of rural India. Never in the history had such churning happened. Saints and sages had moved in parts of the country, giving religious sermons, but never had social activists and revolutionaries stirred up the whole country propounding a political programme that required people to do something themselves.

No amount of democratic decentralisation and no provision of reservation to the weaker sections can give equal share to all in political power; only gramdan can accomplish this: a gramsabha constituting of all the adults in the village community and working on the principle of consensus can not only be the best, but rather the only instrument which can ensure this. And equal share in political power will automatically lead to equality in social status and economic self-sufficiency.

Sarvodaya workers served all sections of the society, rising above all sorts of narrow considerations. Building up of such a group in a society riven with innumerable differences is itself a noteworthy achievement of the Movement. These workers remained aloof from all sectarian agitations and tried to douse communal and other conflagrations with the message of peace and goodwill and with readiness for self-sacrifice. Reorganisation of states was fuelling violence, communalism was raising its head, sense of neglect in peripheral regions was stoking secessionist tendencies and short-sighted political parties were intent on exploiting the situation for petty political gains. In such a volatile situation, Sarvodaya workers stood for integration, unity, mutual affection and peace. They worked as lubricant whenever friction occurred in the society.

The predominance of English had continued in Independent India and the question of a national language had become delicate because of the obstinacy of some elements in Hindi-speaking regions and misguided opposition to Hindi in

South India. In spite of hostility to Hindi, particularly in Tamil Nadu, Vinoba spoke everywhere in Hindi. He also appealed to southerners to learn Hindi so that they could influence the North. Wherever opposition to Hindi was strong, he spoke on the importance of Hindi. He told the southerners that the North and the South had been alternately dominating the ideological discourse in India: first, the Vaidiks, the Buddhists and the Jains went to South from the North; in the middle age Shankara, Madhva, Ramanuja, Vallabh went to North from the South; in the modern times the ideas of Ramakrishna Paramhans, Sri Aurobindo and Gandhi from the North influenced the South. Vinoba appealed to the southerners: "Now your inning is going to start. The more you delay in learning Hindi, the more will it be postponed."¹¹ When anti-Hindi agitation in Tamil Nadu (1965) threatened the unity and integrity of the country, Vinoba's fast and his three-language formula warded off a disaster.

Wherever Vinoba went, he studied the works of the great spiritual masters in those regions and made them known to the other parts of the country. He acquainted the North with Tirukkural, acquainted the South with Tulsidas and acquainted both with Assam's Shankardev and Madhavdev. Vinoba's contribution in this respect is undoubtedly unequalled.

Presentation of an alternative

In the course of the Movement, various facets of the Sarvodaya philosophy were developed and courageous experiments were conducted. When the country was caught in the vortex of modern development, the Movement stood firm and showed an alternative in almost all aspects of the societal life. Many instances can be cited.

Even in the early days of the euphoria over the so-called green revolution, dissent was voiced from the ranks of the Movement.¹² In March 1974, in a meeting of functionaries of various ashrams in Vinoba's presence, use of 'improved' seeds was proposed to increase production and make the ashrams self-sufficient. Vinoba countered:

“Read the book, ‘Farmers of forty centuries’. Utilize human excreta fully. Fertilizer will give result today, but will harm future generations. Study ecology.”¹³

We find the issue of the prices of the farm produce, which has made agriculture a losing enterprise and which took rural India by storm in the eighties, raised in an article in ‘Sarvodaya’, the mouthpiece of the Gandhian fraternity, way back in 1949.¹⁴

When it was almost universally believed that the forest bureaucracy was best equipped to manage the forests, Sarvodaya workers held that only the tribals and other traditional forest-dwellers could protect, manage and nurture the forest resources.¹⁵

The Movement expressed concern about the displacement of people and damage to environment caused by big dams and other mega-projects. Efforts were made to develop alternative energy sources. Path-breaking experiments in the field of education were conducted. Courageous experiments were made in the direction of equality. For example, thousands of workers of Bihar Khadi Gramodyog Sangh accepted equal salaries for some time. Satyanarayan Sharma, a worker at Seoni (Madhya Pradesh) built up an organisation of *tonga* (horse-driven carriage)-pullers and kept it going for nine years.

The Movement propounded a new path for and a new process of revolution. It revolutionised the concept of revolution itself. Vinoba’s genius was in full bloom as the Movement continued its ascension. The idea of Shanti-Sena was proposed to maintain peace—and to restore it when disturbed—through people’s initiative. Sarvodaya-patra was a novel programme not only for taking care of the livelihood of the workers, but also for providing value education to the future generations. An alternative to politics was put forth in the form of lokniti. The concept of satyagraha was refined and elaborated in the context of the changed situation. The idea of confluence of science and spirituality was put before the world shocked by the monstrous consequences of the developments in science. New dimensions to spirituality were developed in the form of collective spiritual quest and collective spiritual liberation and the concept of entry

of labour into the realm of spirituality.

Dissemination of ideas

It has been charged that the Movement put almost exclusive emphasis on propaganda and neglected developmental work in the gramdan villages. This has been discussed in the preceding pages. The most important point in this connection is that it was a conscious strategy, not an inadvertent omission. Vinoba's assertion was:

“A revolution will take place neither through love nor through struggle. Love or struggle can never bring about a revolution. Friction that takes place in a struggle dissipates energies of both the parties, and love cannot create anything new; it only creates enthusiasm. A revolution in society takes place only through thoughts.”¹⁶

To Vinoba, action was useful and necessary only to the extent it contributed to the understanding, acceptance and implementation of thoughts.

To make people think and to bring about change in their thoughts has to be the first step, if the revolution is not to prove abortive. The country had accepted Gandhi's leadership, but not his vision, enunciated in 'Hind-swaraj'. The policy-makers were enamoured of the modern development. People had to be pulled out of the deceptive spell of modernity. If change is to be brought about by the people themselves, there is no alternative to the conscientization of the people. That was what was needed and what the Movement tried. People should wrest control over their own lives from the forces inimical to their freedom and dignity. Once they do it, the rest will follow. It is for the people to do this. A movement's work is only to kindle the flame of transformation.

That the Movement stuck to this basic task underlines its revolutionary character.

Secondly, it is not that the movement totally neglected the developmental work. It did work in this direction as far as its resources and priorities permitted.

It was surely the Movement's duty to guide the villagers who were making efforts for their own development. Theoretical formulation of alternative development was not enough. Experiments in the development of appropriate technology and energy resources and taking the results to the villages was also necessary. What the Movement did in this connection was surely not adequate, but nor was it negligible.

Taking up current problems

The Movement is often faulted for not taking up current problems facing the people. Vinoba's stand was that problems would never end; new and new problems would keep on arising. No individual or organisation can solve the problems once and for all. What is important is that the capacity of the people to solve their problems should be built up. Then they would do the rest. Secondly, taking up current problems would have diverted attention from the focal point of the Movement and led it astray.

Once the focal point was firmly grasped, there was no harm in paying attention to such problems. This the Movement did not overlook. Current problems were frequently deliberated in Sarvodaya conferences, meetings and other forums and considered opinions were put before the people. Communal riots, disturbances in Nagaland, the imbroglio of Kashmir, the dacoit menace in Chambal valley and such other instances can be cited in this connection. JP, in particular, was always seized of prevalent problems and tried to educate public opinion in their context. His initiative to establish peace in Nagaland was perhaps the last significant effort from the civil society to solve a festering national problem.

After the achievement of 'Bihar-dan' (October 1969) Vinoba suggested many programmes that could and should have been taken up. Were they suggested too late? Should they not have been taken up earlier in conjunction with the dissemination of ideas? Can climate conducive to revolutionary changes be created through propaganda alone, overlooking contemporary affairs? These are bound to be moot questions.

Conquest or consolidation?

That the Movement did not pay serious attention to follow-up has also been a persistent objection. In fact, whether to concentrate on conquest or consolidation always remained a dilemma for the Movement. Ideally, both should have proceeded hand in hand. They are not successive stages. The Movement concentrated on creating favourable climate; but it is not that the favourable climate once created would persist for ever. Opposing forces are also active in the field; the climate can get deteriorated in no time. But the paucity of workers and resources prevented the Movement from pursuing the both, the conquest and the consolidation, in a balanced manner.

Gandhi used to keep a time gap between satyagraha campaigns and he would engage the workers in the meantime in constructive work—conquest and consolidation alternated in his strategy. The time in between satyagrahas was the time for training, as well as for rest and recuperation of the workers. Vinoba continued his campaigns without break; he put forward new programmes in quick succession and goaded the workers to achieve fresh targets. It has been alleged that incessant work with breakneck speed exhausted the workers. That may have been the case, but that alone does not explain dissipation of the movement.

Aversion to struggle?

It is a widely held opinion that Vinoba had aversion to and tried to avert struggles, especially against the government. Jainendra Kumar, a celebrated writer, said in Balia Conference (1966),

“Sarvodaya has perhaps everything, except protest to necessary extent. I had told Vinoba at Indore (1960) that your thinking and work are restricted to a particular framework: we have got Independence and our brothers are running the Independent country under the leadership of Jawaharlalji and difficulties should not be created for them. Vinoba demurred; he said that he had not vowed not to create difficulties for the government.”¹⁷

Vinoba, it has to be realised, was working in a country which had recently become Independent, where the reins of power were in the hands of tested patriots and which had adopted a democratic structure wherein there was freedom to all to propagate their views. The question was to take benefit of that freedom for community-building, which was the first and the most necessary condition for lasting social change. It should also not be overlooked that Vinoba did protest against government policies harmful to public interest from time to time, such as discouragement to handlooms as against powerlooms, ban on production of jaggery, dragging of feet in enforcing prohibition etc.

Yet, this was not the complaint of outsiders only. For example, Annasaheb Sahasrabuddhe, in an interview in 1980, identified three reasons for the failure of the Movement: desisting from creating difficulties for the government, eschewing the path of confrontation and organisation, and refusal to take responsibility of implementation (in other words, of the developmental work).¹⁸

Jayaprakash shared this view:

“Perhaps Vinobaji held, and still holds, that systemic change in the political order could be brought about without a struggle, even a peaceful struggle. But my experience of years of gram-swarajya (village self-government) work has convinced me that gram-swarajya is a valuable political organisation in itself, provided it works and is not only on paper. But the gram-swarajya movement was not capable of bringing about a systemic political revolution. Theoretically, there is no reason why it should not. - - - But nowhere has success been achieved.”¹⁹

If it is conceded that theoretically there was no reason for the failure of the Movement, then the question is of strategy, tactics and programmes. Was struggle an appropriate strategy? Jayaprakash thought so:

“It seems to me that in (an) atmosphere (of struggle) psychological forces are created that attract men and drive them to accept challenges and to change themselves and

change others. In a placid atmosphere in which gram-swarajya was working, such psychological forces remained dormant.”²⁰

This raises many pertinent questions. In fact, the propagation of ideas can be carried out and be effective in a calm atmosphere, not in a turbulent atmosphere which is not conducive to rational and balanced thinking. Should the calm atmosphere be branded as ‘placid’? The struggle would surely have become necessary in the stage after the acquisition of people’s consent for revolutionary transformation through widespread propagation of ideas. The irony of fate is that the Movement threw in the towel when that phase had come!

In Musahari, JP was outraged by the ‘courts of Duryodhan’—the domination of evil forces—in the villages. Of course, they had to be confronted and defeated. But how and where? And how could an anti-government struggle in the cities and the state capitals be expected to defeat the ‘Duryodhans’ in the villages?

Vinoba was fully aware that struggle would become inevitable in the process of building gram-swaraj on the foundation of gramdan. In fact, he was asking the villagers to gird up their loins for such a struggle:

“When you say that you will look after the affairs of your village, there are others who are saying that they will look after the affairs of your village. There are people who think that it is their responsibility to look after the affairs of the world and you should follow their dictates in all the spheres of life. In such a situation, struggle becomes imminent.”²¹

In the Sarva Seva Sangh meeting held after the Rajgir Conference (1969), Vinoba said categorically,

“If there are obstacles in the working of gramsabha and they cannot be removed even after trying in the right direction, satyagraha can be resorted to when necessary. You have my consent for this.”²²

Struggle was thus never ruled out; the misconception needs to be laid to rest once and for all. But the struggle needs

to be resorted to only when the next stage of revolution demands the same. Moreover, this struggle had to be carried out in villages, not in cities. Struggles in cities do generate certain psychological forces; that cannot be denied. But are all the consequences of that phenomenon desirable? Secondly, cities are not familiar grounds for the villagers. How can they succeed on unfamiliar grounds?

So, struggle will inevitably be there; and it will necessarily have to be a protracted struggle, a 'political' struggle in the true sense of the term. But it will not be against a particular government; it will be against the State. Fight with a particular government may bring about change in that government, but it does not change the character of the political system—this is the lesson of history.

Class struggle was, of course, ruled out. It militated against the Movement's ideology. Its way was not that of confrontation, but that of rapprochement. When Dharendra Majumdar was asked by workers whether any programme which would make them known as champions of the poor could be thought of, his reply was:

"We need not look around for such a programme. We have to end injustice and poverty, but not by becoming champion of a particular class. We have to champion the interests of the whole society. We have to understand that both the perpetrators and sufferers of injustice are victims of the customs and systems which give rise to injustice and poverty. In fact, there is no dividing line between the rich and the poor and between the perpetrators and sufferers of injustice. Everyone is in either of the roles at different points. That is why Gandhi used to say that a fight between the gods and the demons goes on in every heart. - - -

"In our revolution, there is no struggle between two classes; but the whole society fights against the conditions which had given rise to injustice, poverty and other maladies. - - -

"If you want to eliminate class differences and prepare the entire society to fight against these differences, not confrontation but rapprochement will be your method. In

confrontation, the deprived sections are organised for resistance; in rapprochement, those who have deprived others are organised and motivated.”²³

That was what Vinoba wanted the Movement to do.

Thus, the question is not of avoiding struggle; question is of devising new and creative forms of nonviolence. It has to be ensured that the unity of village is in no way harmed; it should rather be strengthened in the process. This was a challenge before the Movement.

Abolition of urban wealth

It was also a point of criticism that the Movement concentrated on land and the village to the exclusion of other forms of wealth and the urban areas. Annasaheb Sahasrabuddhe had contended,

“Gramdan was obviously the movement of the villages. Towns remained completely outside the orbit. A revolution has to have a universal appeal. Gramdan was always a sectional movement. I would make bold to say that land revolution would not be effected even if every village was to declare its gramdan.”²⁴

For the abolition of private property in land, the Movement had the remedy of villagisation of land, and the programme of gramdan for the purpose. But what about abolition of other forms of wealth? It was contended that in modern times those were predominant, but the Movement had no effective programme to deal with them.

D.R. Gadgil had warned,

“If no way is found in this respect, Bhoodan movement will receive a setback. A strong accusation will then be made that the Bhoodan workers are the scourge of the poor and say nothing about the real power-holders and the urbanites which are their own kin. If it is to be demonstrated that the process of *dana* (sharing) would lead to transformation, it would have to be shown how this is possible in an urban economy.”²⁵

The idea of sampattidan was put forward in the initial stages of the Movement. It gave opportunity to urbanites having no land to participate in this mission, but it was hardly capable of abolition of urban property.

It has to be realised that all the necessary programmes cannot be presented simultaneously; they necessarily evolve gradually. It is true that no effective programme about urban wealth came up, but it is also true that the Movement was attacking the foundation. Vinoba did use the term ‘factory-dan’, but neither did he elaborate the idea further nor put it up as a programme. He did not want dissipation of the limited strength in various programmes. To the objection in this regard, his reply was:

“We are demolishing the ground floor. Will higher floors remain as they were? They will collapse automatically. If villages accept gramdan in tens of thousands, the ownership of Tatas and Birlas will not last. When people on the lower rungs of society hold on fast to their ownership, the ownership of those on the higher rungs is not in the least dented. If the former let go their ownership, ownership of the latter cannot continue, for the government will then be yours as you constitute 80% of the population. Once the ownership of land ends, end of the ownership of factories will follow as a matter of course. If I go to the factory-owners today, they will extend warm hospitality and send me off. To go to such people, one should have strength. What strength do I have? I will have strength when villages in tens of thousands accept gramdan.”²⁶

Vinoba had also used the word ‘landslide’: “When ownership of land is demolished, ownership of factories will not last. There will be a sudden landslide.”²⁷ Revolutions are always characterised by landslides.

Cities and the intelligentsia

The Movement was never oblivious of the need to work in the cities also. It did what it could. But that remained marginal. In 1960, Vinoba gave a call for making Indore a Sarvodaya city. Various programmes were undertaken in this

connection, but they did not last long. In 1969, Vinoba enunciated many programmes for the cities, but they were not earnestly taken up. The message of the Movement did not, therefore, reach the cities effectively. As a result, urban intelligentsia could not understand the Movement properly, and the Movement had little appeal for the urban youth. The terminology of the Movement and the 'modern' education the educated sections had received hindered their understanding of the Movement. Their vested interests in the status quo were also not less important in this context.

It also needs to be noted that it was a firm conviction of the Movement that nonviolence could have full scope only in small face-to-face communities where people share each other's joys and sorrows and lead a shared communal life. Only in such communities self-rule is possible. Present cities are centres of exploitation and domination. They can have no place in a structure based on village communities, and have to be destroyed. Vinoba would often recall the Vedic word 'Purandar' for god Indra (destroyer of the cities) in this context.²⁸

The Movement and the media

The Movement's failure to influence the urban intelligentsia inevitably resulted in its neglect or ridicule or in ignorant criticism by the media. The media, in its hankering after sensationalism, signally failed in taking note of this unprecedented and revolutionary endeavour in rural India, barring a few exceptions. Vinoba was naturally unhappy about it. As he once said (in 1958):

"These newspapermen have no realisation where the real India lives, and so they fill the newspapers with trash which only serves to mislead. The language too is vulgarised in the process, harmful tendencies are encouraged, dissensions arise in the country and it is weakened. - - - They do not realise the importance of events having far-reaching consequences. 3,500 villages have declared gramdan. Had the land in 5-10 villages been grabbed with violence, that would have made headlines in bold letters. But these gramdan villages have followed the way of love. Because of

this fault their value goes unnoticed.”²⁹

For the media, political activities were of paramount importance, and the Movement was working outside their realm. Was the dismissive attitude of the media a result of distorted priorities and superficial perception, or were there other reasons too? Erica Linton notes that at the time of the Koyna earthquake the press mentioned every relief organisation, but not the Sarvodaya workers, and asks, “Publicity for Sarvodaya would challenge existing society into a painstaking process of evaluation and the painful exercise of self-analysis. Who is prepared for this?”³⁰

It is not that there was absolutely no goodwill for the Movement in the media. But the Movement could not take sufficient advantage of that goodwill.

Unable to become the mainstream, the Movement remained confined to a particular circle. To quote Linton again,

“If one moves within the movement, Sarvodaya workers and Gramdan villages seem to be everywhere. If one looks at it from without, from the viewpoint of people either not interested, or engrossed in the pursuit of other ideologies, or in self-centred occupations, one could easily dismiss Gramdan as a fringe activity of less than marginal importance.”³¹

Not only for this reason, but otherwise too, the Movement’s own press should have been strong. Journals were published in almost all the regional languages, but none could become its effective vehicle. Circulation of only a few could cross five figures, and that too for short periods. Naturally, they could not break even. As workers were neither keen nor good at reporting, the activities would not be properly reported—not to speak of highlighting important events. Special reporters should have been appointed to remove this lacuna. Much should have been, and something could have been done to improve the outer form too, but paucity of resources, and perhaps also of suitable persons ready to do this job came in the way. Vinoba lamented in 1971, “This is our weakest front!”³²

Contribution overlooked

The attitude of the media and lack of strong press resulted in inadequate understanding of the Movement in the articulate sections and the intelligentsia, who dominated the academic discourse. In the treatises on the history of Independent India, and even in treatises on land reforms, there is no guarantee of even a passing mention of the Movement. Bhoodan, which gave 2.5 million acres to the landless, gets at most a passage or two and it is often dismissed with a few baseless sweeping statements.

Gramdan hardly finds place in contemporary history. The level of ignorance is appalling. The NCERT's text book for social science for class X (Contemporary India Part II : text book for geography), has this—and only this much—to say about gramdan:

“Some zamindars, owners of many villages offered to distribute some villages among the landless. It was known as Gramdan.”³³

Is this ignorance only? Such ‘information’ betrays lack of at least the academic, if not moral, honesty and calibre of the authors.

Other contributions by Vinoba and the Movement are also overlooked. Let us take one example. In 1965, the country was shaken by anti-Hindi agitation in South India which threatened the unity and integrity of the country. Vinoba announced indefinite fast, whereupon the Central Home Minister rushed to Pavnar, stayed in the ashram and parleyed with the concerned parties from there, and the three-language formula suggested by Vinoba was ultimately agreed upon. But one will find no mention of this in the works by Ramchandra Guha and Bipan Chandra, writers of two celebrated and acclaimed histories of post-Independence India: ‘India after Gandhi’ and ‘India after Independence’ respectively.

Pandit Nehru had said that if a genuine historian wrote an authentic history, Vinoba would have a prime place in it.³⁴ Differences of opinion are natural. But opinions should be based

on hard facts. Denial of rightful place to the Movement on the basis of inadequate understanding and concrete studies serves only to harm the authenticity of history and makes the academic discourse distorted and incomplete.

Bhoodan and gramdan were not only inadequately studied, prejudices are predominant in at least some of the studies. T.K. Oommen's work has already been referred to. Oommen has expressed the concern that in gramdan villages, gramsabhas would be able to distribute land in the way they liked, and progressive laws to remove inequality in landholding would thereby be defeated!³⁵ This apprehension is nothing but absurd. Gramdan stands for ending inequality in landholding.

'Toofan' as a response to the situation

In the seventh decade of the 20th Century, spread of gramdan became a distinct possibility with the advent of Sulabh Gramdan. However, situation in the country at the time was deteriorating rapidly. Land prices were on the rise, and so was attachment to land. Welfare State was spreading its tentacles to even small and remote villages, whereby the dominant sections in rural society were becoming stronger through control over panchayats and co-operatives secured through collusion with politicians and the bureaucracy. The so-called 'Green revolution' was devastating the land and the farmer.

The moral atmosphere created by the message of bhoodan and gramdan was rapidly waning; and so was enthusiasm of the workers. Political class was suspicious of gramdan, 'a State within a State'.

To the objection that gramdan was 'a State within a State', Vinoba's reply was:

"Just as every seed in a pomegranate is independent, there can be different States within a State. In that fruit, a number of seeds are contained in different cells. But all of them together make a single fruit of pomegranate. In a similar way, we want every village to be an independent State; there will be clusters of such States and all such clusters will constitute the world State—such is the structure we envisage."³⁶

This was an ingenious argument, but vested interests were shrewd enough to perceive potentialities in gramdan, which were detrimental to them.

Society was passing through a transition stage. The social dynamics of the pre-Independence period was withering away and the forces bent on destroying whatever vestiges of community spirit were alive in the villages were on the rise. Something needed to be done urgently to check those forces.

'Toofan' campaign (1965-69) was, in Vinoba's own words, the last battle fought in this background. The figure for gramdans swelled, but the credibility of the Movement suffered a jolt. In the race to reach ambitious targets, compromises were made and warning voices and signals were overlooked. Material benefits of gramdan were emphasised: money would come from outside, preference would be given in development schemes, small villages could gain independent status. Labourers were persuaded to sign gramdan pledges, telling them that they had nothing to lose.

It must also be admitted that one of the reasons was Vinoba's own impatience manifested at times during this period. Commending achievement of targets was natural, but he would often rebuke the workers for failing to achieve the targets. This inevitably led to the entry of falsehood, leading to concoction of figures and other impurities.

It is not that the leadership was unaware of this. But Vinoba was ready to take risks:

"Had I wanted to construct a well, I would have constructed a well having extremely pure water. But I wanted to create an ocean. In an ocean, rivers with pure water merge as also streams with dirty water. Some impurity might have entered this campaign. You need not bother about it."³⁷

Work at a fast pace to achieve targets, and work through transformation in thinking—balancing these two requirements was indeed like tightrope walking. Every moment, there was risk of losing balance. But a revolutionary has to take such risks.

Kanti Shah writes,

“Vinoba’s *Toofan* was like the testing of a rocket. We certainly could not mobilise people’s energies sufficient enough for the rocket to attain expected momentum and cross the gravitational field. Sometimes, rockets fell down. But scientific research must go on. The same is true about research in social sciences.”³⁸

Rocket could not cross the gravitational field. The last effort to make the Movement a people’s movement failed. But did any other endeavour for bringing positive change succeed?

Technique remained elusive

No serious challenge was posed to the power elite in rural India. But there were seeds of such challenge in the Movement, which were disquieting for the establishment. Krishan Kant had contended that Nehru was afraid of the Bhoodan movement, because he felt Vinoba might give a call to the landless to occupy lands.³⁹ Gramdan implied transfer of power to the village communities, which could not be expected to be palatable to those who wielded the reins of power, and also to those who wanted and hoped to wield these reins in future. Pandit Nehru thought that gramdan would facilitate collective farming, his pet project. When Vinoba did not insist on it, or even encourage it, he must have lost at least some interest in gramdan.

Giving some land to the landless had certain advantages for the landowners also. But to deal with the poor labourers on equal footing was not acceptable to the power elite. To help the poor was one thing, to give him equal status was an altogether different thing. Hierarchies and differentiation have always characterised human societies. What the Movement was asking for was a tall order. Moreover, feudal values were more entrenched in Bihar, which the Movement chose for intensive work. Ramamoorti said at Nakodar Conference (1972),

“These people who firmly hold reins of development, legislation, politics and all the aspects of social life—law could not defeat them, gun could not intimidate them, compassion could not melt them. They have given land-gifts, but a change in the status of the labourers is not acceptable to them.”⁴⁰

'Village leaders' got alarmed as the potentialities started getting manifest. Taya Zinkin has narrated how Ghanapujari, the hereditary headman of a village in Odisha, who persuaded other villagers to accept gramdan, soon realised, as things began to change, that his ancestral privileges, and with them his income, were getting hacked.⁴¹ When a campaign for the zilla-dan of Darbhanga (Bihar) was being carried out, a group of landlords denounced bhoodan and appealed to the government to expel the Sarvodaya workers from the district.⁴²

To persuade the villagers to accept gramdan was no easy task; but to devise nonviolent and efficacious ways to neutralise both covert and overt opposition of the antagonistic forces was much more difficult. The Movement could fairly succeed in the former, thanks to Vinoba's charisma; but it could not devise a technique that could work irrespective of this charisma. And in doing the later task, it lost patience prematurely. The Movement remained so Vinoba-centric that when he withdrew, it could not sustain itself. That it failed in designing a nonviolent process to build gram-swaraj on the foundation of gramdan is not as tragic as the fact that it did not make sufficient efforts.

Right perspective about evaluation

That outsiders lacked the right perspective about the evaluation of the movement is understandable, but it is more surprising to find insiders lacking such perspective.

Jayaprakash had rightly cautioned,

"Social transformation and reconstruction through nonviolent method has never taken place in the world. This is an extremely tough task. It will need strenuous exertion. Therefore, one should be ready to devote oneself to this task till the end without caring for the impact."⁴³

The task demanded patience of the highest order. Unfortunately the workers lost patience when it was most needed. Kanti Shah notes ruefully,

"Everything was there, but because of lack of comprehensive perception and skilful planning and co-ordination everything went haywire. An impression gained ground in the minds of

the workers that whatever had been done had proved futile, and that their labours had been wasted in the experiment of securing gramdan pledges on paper only. This impression hurt them deeply, eroding their faith and strength. This was one of the consequences of the lack of revolutionary perspective about evaluating the work.”⁴⁴

What could be the fate of a Movement when its workers lose their faith and strength?

There was nothing wrong in securing gramdan pledges on paper. It was a well-thought out strategy for the first stage. The Movement’s aim was not attainable in a few years; not even in a few generations. The question was of taking the right path and move on it to the best of one’s capacity without hoping for or expecting immediate discernible impact.

One should not overlook the difference between failure and non-attainment of specific aims. A truly revolutionary movement may not attain particular objectives in the short run. What is important is the ideas it throws up. If these ideas have intrinsic strength, they can sprout anywhere, any time when circumstances become favourable and opportune.

Ascension of ideas

Even if any invention in science is not put to immediate use, its value is not lessened thereby; for the possibility of its use is always open. Same is true in the realm of social sciences. Gramdan is a precious invention in the realm of social science, and therefore has an intrinsic value independent of its immediate outcome. How far and where and how the idea is fruitfully applied depends on several factors, most of them unforeseen at the moment.

Ascension of ideas witnessed during the Movement is one of its magnificent achievements. During his tours for eighteen years (1951-1969), Vinoba gave thousands of talks, talked with thousands of people for thousands of hours. In them, numerous topics were dealt with in amazing depth. The Movement did go through ebb and flow, but the ascension of ideas continued uninterrupted. Gandhi had presented a rough outline of the

concept of gram-swaraj; Vinoba developed and refined it and built a whole philosophy on its foundation. A novel process of revolution was unfolded—both the theory and practice of revolution were revolutionised. In the words of Dada Dharmadhikari, Vinoba made the process of revolution as charming as a fine art.⁴⁵ Aspects and facets of a nonviolent process of working were elucidated: *Vichar-shasan* (supremacy of reason) and *kartrutva-vibhajan* (decentralisation of power and capabilities); initiatory instead of responsive love, progressive lessening of the intensity of action and expansion of rational thinking, increasingly gentler satyagraha and so on. Nature of a nonviolent organisation was spelt out. Original and innovative ideas and concepts such as lokniti, *ganasevakatva* (collective servanthship), '*Jai Jagat*' (victory to the world), confluence of science and spirituality were enunciated and elaborated. Even the science of the spirit was enriched with the ideas of collective spiritual quest and collective spiritual liberation and the entry of labour in the realm of spirituality. Programmes such as bhoodan, gramdan, sampattidan, Shanti-Sena, Sarvodaya-patra, village-oriented khadi, Acharyakul (fraternity of independent intellectuals) and development of women's power through spiritual empowerment were given successively.

Vinoba's words constitute a treasure-house of wisdom for the whole world for all times to come.

Gramdan and the present times

The Movement generated a desire for change through ideological propaganda mostly directed from above. Now this desire is springing up from below due to the compulsions of situation.

The process of disintegration of the villages is in full swing. Yet the realisation that this process would destroy the country and society, both materially and spiritually, is also growing. The Dalits and the backward communities are realising that taking refuge in urban slums is no solution to their problems. Social workers working in the rural areas are coming to the conclusion that the unity of village is a better guarantee for justice to the

downtrodden. Non-governmental organisations (NGOs) have proliferated in the countryside, and although much valid criticism of their nature and working is possible, they have surely made some contribution to the conscientization of villagers. Domination of a few may still be a reality, but resentment against that domination has become vocal and even active. Weaker sections of community are becoming more aware and insistent about their rights. The apprehension that gramsabhas would invariably be dominated by a few is no more valid at least in many parts of the country.

At the same time, disillusionment about modern development is growing, and with it a desire for a more equitable and inclusive growth is also growing. Corporate capitalism might be stoking the delusion that there is no alternative, but its foundations are getting eroded. The development built on the mindless consumption of non-renewable natural resources can never be sustainable; its collapse sooner or later is inescapable. Greed and self-interest can never build a happy and humane civilisation. Stockpiling of nuclear weapons, which can destroy the mankind several times over, has jeopardized the very existence of human race.

Today, man stands alone and unarmed in the face of powerful forces of the State and the market. He needs the support, the security and the warmth of the community. He may be appearing helpless today, but he surely cannot go on taking things lying down. Human consciousness will rise and revolt. And in this revolt, gramdan can teach it valuable lessons. Herein lies the relevance of gramdan.

Years have passed since the virtual end of the Bhoodan-Gramdan Movement. Bhoodan-Gramdan have almost disappeared from even the agenda of the Gandhian organisations. But there are distinct signs of its resurrection. Years after the last gramdan in the seventies, Mendha (Lekha), a village in Gadchiroli district of Maharashtra, has embraced gramdan unanimously (2013), not as a response to any propaganda but through careful and thorough study. The village, which has been progressing towards gram-swaraj since years

defying the State and the Naxalites, has found that gramdan can be their bulwark. Sparks have appeared; whether they get extinguished or lead to conflagration, only time will tell.

When land is being rapidly grabbed by the State and the corporates and the land sharks, gramdan can ensure that the land remains with the tiller of the soil. Agriculture is in dire straits and hundreds of farmers are committing suicide every year. If and when the realisation that gramdan is the way out of impasse grows, the tide may turn.

In the background of changed circumstances, the traditional form of gramdan may have to be revised. But the idea and several features of the scheme can guide us even today. And therein lies the value of revisiting the precepts and the practice of bhoodan and gramdan.

Annexure 1

Ramchandra Reddy's Gift-declaration

H.H.H.

187
187/4/15

I hereby declare on behalf of my brothers (the sons of Shri Vedra Narasimha Reddy of Pochampalli Bhongir Taluk, Naganda Dist.) and also on my own behalf that according to the wish of my dear deceased father out of the landed property belonging to our family (Vedra family) at Pochampalli and Gulur, fifty acres of land (including wet and dry crops) at Pochampalli and fifty acres of land (arabore) at Gulur are hereby declared to be dedicated for the uplift of the local Haryans of Pochampalli and Gulur and now very solemnly I hereby request Shri Vinoba Bhave (who is now forwarding on his peace tour in our Andhra Dist.) to denote to the notice of these Haryans and explain the purpose and use of these dedicated lands so that the soul of my dear deceased Pithaji (called "Bapji" in my family) may be in peace and the souls of these deserving brethren may be with him at such a unique and appropriate occasion.

Details of the Dedication -

- I 50 (fifty) acres of land at Gulur village
- II 50 (fifty) acres of land at Pochampalli.

Total 100 (One hundred acres only).

The possession of these lands shall be given to these brethren in the beginning of the coming Raining season in the respective villages. I request Shri Vinoba Bhave to form the trust (of course according to

his established "Savdaya" principles
and direct the local inhabitants
concerned to take appropriate interest
in this matter. But according to the wishes
of my dear deceased father one member
of our wide family should be taken
in the said trust and naturally some
of the local Honjani members also
should be included in the trust and
the management and utilization of
these lands should be left to the local
Honjani by gradual development every
year. With these hints and request I
conclude this document and entrust
the matter to Shri Vinopaji to decide
and take necessary action in this regard.

Y
Ram (Ramona Reddy)
(eldest-brother);
18/4/51.

આમા નીચેનાજો રામજી જાણ સહેજોજો:

૧. ૩૩, માટે ૫, ૫૧ ૧૦૯ અપેક્ષા પેન્શનનાર
૨. જોના, ૫૨, ૨૫૫૫, ૫૫૫૨ ૧૧૯ માટે ૫, ૫૧ પેન્શનનાર
૩. ૨૫૫૨, ૨૫૫૨, ૨૫૫૨ ૧૧૯, ૨૫૫૨, ૨૫૫૨ પેન્શનનાર
૪. ૫૧, ૨૫૫૨, ૨૫૫૨ ૧૦૯ ૧૨૫/૨૫૨, ૨૫૨, ૨૫૨ પેન્શનનાર
૫. ૨૫, ૨૫૨, ૨૫૨ ૨૫૨, ૨૫૨, ૨૫૨ ૨૫૨, ૨૫૨, ૨૫૨

સહી કરનાર
શ્રી રામજી

શ્રી રામજી
શ્રી રામજી



મુદ્રા



મુદ્રા

Y
Ram (Ramona Reddy) ૨૨૨૨.

Annexure 2

Bhoodan and Gramdan: Latest Figures

<u>State</u>	<u>Land gifted</u> (Acres)	<u>Distributed</u> (Acres)	<u>Gramdans</u>
Andhra Pradesh	2,52,119	1,08,770	1
Assam	877	877	312
Bihar	6,48,593	2,56,659	1,583
Delhi	300	180	-
Gujarat	1,03,530	50,984	-
Haryana	2,070	2,043	-
Himachal Pradesh	5,240	2,531	-
J & K	211	5	-
Jharkhand	14,69,280	4,88,735	-
Karnataka	17,844	3,663	-
Kerala	26,293	5,774	-
Madhya Pradesh	4,10,151	2,37,629	-
Maharashtra	1,58,163	1,10,261	20
Odisha	6,38,706	5,79,994	1,309
Punjab	5,168	1,026	-
Rajasthan	5,46,965	1,42,699	205
Tamilnadu	27,677	22,837	537
U. P.	4,36,362	4,18,958	5
W. Bengal	16,000	9,000	-
India	47,65,549	24,42,625	3,972
Bangladesh	58	58	
Total	47,65,607	24,42,683	3,972

Sources

1. Andhra Pradesh (including Telangana): Figure for bhoodan from Bhoodan-Yagna Board letter no. BYB/Qly/Pdl/E/59/04 dated 5-8-2009 to the Special secretary of A.P. Government. Number of donors 12,981. Figure for distribution from Bhoodan-Yagna Board letter dated 3-5-2010 to the author. Number of donees 49,054; figure as in January 2010. Figure for gramdams from A.P. Bhoodan Board's letter no. 135/81, dated 4-8-1981 to Balvijay, Secretary to Vinoba.

2. Assam: Figures for bhoodan and distribution from Assam State Bhoodan Gramdan Board's letter ABGB/26/81/42, dated 18-8-1981 to Balvijay. Number of donors and donees 181 and 851 respectively. Figure for gramdams from *Database on Gramdan villages in Assam*.

3. Bihar: Figures for bhoodan and distribution are as in July 2017; provided by the Bihar Bhoodan-Yajna Committee. Figure for gramdams given by the said Committee in June 2008; this figure is for undivided Bihar.

4. Delhi: Figures as in September 1969, from *Sarva Seva Sangh Karya-vivaran, May 1969-September 1969*, Annexure 6.

5. Gujarat: Figures from Bhoodan Committee of Gujarat Sarvodaya Mandal. Number of donors and donees 18,327 and 10,279 respectively.

6. Haryana: Figures for bhoodan and distribution from Haryana Bhoodan-Yagna Board letter no. HBYB/84-85/2/3, dated 4-4-1984 to Balvijay. Figure for gramdan from the Board's letter no. HBYB/81-82/35/501, dated 29-1-1982 to Balvijay.

7. Himachal Pradesh: Figures as in September 1969, from *Sarva Seva Sangh Karya-vivaran, May 1969-September 1969*, Annexure 6.

8. Jammu and Kashmir: Figures as in September 1969, from *Sarva Seva Sangh Karya-vivaran, May 1969-September 1969*, Annexure 6.

9. Jharkhand: Figures for bhoodan and distribution as in

March 2000, received from Bihar Bhoodan-Yajna Committee. Number of gramdans included in the figure given for Bihar.

10. Karnataka: Figures for bhoodan and distribution from Government of Karnataka's letter no. 132.LGP.78, dated 30-1-1979 to Sarva Seva Sangh. Number of donors and donees 5,305 and 1,286 respectively.

11. Kerala: Figures as in September 1969, from *Sarva Seva Sangh Karya-vivaran, May 1969-September 1969*, Annexure 6.

12. Madhya Pradesh (including Chhattisgarh): Figure of bhoodan from M.P. Bhoodan-Yagna Board's letter no. 753/78-79, dated 26-10-1978 to Sarva Seva Sangh. Number of donors 58,630. Figure for distribution from the Board's letter dated 23-3-1984. Number of donees for 229,160 acres is 59,805.

13. Maharashtra: Region-wise break-up is as follows—

<i>Region</i>	<i>Bhoodan</i>	<i>Distribution</i>
Western Maharashtra	41,163	26,207
Marathwada	7,000	3,204
Vidarbha	1,10,000	80,850
Total	1,58,163	1,10,261

Figures for Western Maharashtra from Babulal Gandhi: *Bharatateel Bhoomiheen ani Bhoodan*, p. 110, 216. Number of donors and donees 8,001 and 6,001 respectively. Figures for Marathwada from the Report of Maharashtra Sarvodaya Mandal 1970. Figure for distribution in Vidarbha arrived at after adding the figure as in March 1981, given by Bhoodan-Yajna Mandal, Vidarbha to the figure for the period February 2014 to September 2017 (860 acres, 269 donees) given by the said Mandal; number of donors and donees 20,351 and 15,815 respectively.

14. Odisha: Figures for bhoodan and distribution from UNDP report '*Status report: Land rights and ownership in Orissa*' (p. 22) published in 2008, available on website www.undp.org accessed on 5-10-2017. Number of donees 1,52,852. Figure for gramdan from Orissa Bhoodan Yagna Samiti

letter no. D-I/83, dated 27-12-1983 to Under Secretary, Board of Revenue, Orissa.

15. Punjab: From Punjab Bhoodan Yagna Board's letter no. 72/PBYB/81-82, dated 3-8-1981 to Balvijay.

16. Rajasthan: Figures about bhoodan from Rajasthan Bhoodan Yagna Board letter no. 665 (Rajya 3/gathan/656, dated 30-1-1982 to Balvijay. Figure for gramdan from Rajasthan Gramdan Board records quoted in Sudarshan Iyengar and others' paper '*Gramdan to Gram-swaraj: Insights from Rajasthan experiments*'.

17. Tamilnadu: Figure for bhoodan from online edition of 'The Hindu' dated 13-11-2000. Figure for distribution and gramdan from Tamilnadu Bhoodan Yagna Board letter no. 1608/84, dated 23-3-1984 to Balvijay.

18. Uttar Pradesh: Figure for bhoodan from '*Uttar Pradesh Bhoodan Yagna Samiti Karya-vivaran from June 1978 to June 1982*'; for distribution from Uttar Pradesh Bhoodan Yagna Samiti letter no. 19/84-85 dated 12-4-1984 to Balvijay. Figure for gramdan from Uttar Pradesh Bhoodan Yagna Samiti letter no. 186/81-82, dated 18-7-1981 to Balvijay.

19. West Bengal: From Sarvodaya Mandal's letter dated 1-2-1982 to Balvijay.

20. Bangladesh: From Charu Chaudhari's '*Vinoba ki Pakistan Prem-yatra*', pp. 181-88. Number of donors 37, number of donees 69. The figure in bighas has been converted into acres.

As the source details show, most of the figures are quite old. Some land must have been distributed since the dates of the figures, but we do not have exact data.

Thus, while the figure for bhoodan can be considered static, the actual figure for distribution must be somewhat more than the figure given here.

Numbers of donors and donees are not given in the Table as figures for all the states are not available.

Annexure 3

Forms of Declaration of Gramdan

(Forms for declaration of Gramdan as prescribed vide Maharashtra Gramdan Rules 1966, made under Maharashtra Gramdan Act 1964, are given here as a sample. Different state governments have prescribed such forms with some variations.)

Form I

Declaration of Gramdan

I, - - - - the owner of land in - - - Village - - - Tehsil - - - Taluka - - - District, carrying on the business - - -, having fully understood the idea of the *Gramdan* Movement initiated by Acharya Vinobaji Bhave, declare that I do hereby donate, that is to say, voluntarily and without consideration, agree to transfer to the *Gram Mandal*¹ all my land in the said village by way of *Gramdan*, subject to the provisions of the Maharashtra Gramdan Act 1964 and the rules made thereunder.

I would like to hold the land specified in column 1 of the Table hereto as *Gramdan Kisan* and the land specified in column 2 of the Table may be distributed to landless persons under the Act.

Table

Lands to be held as <i>Gramdan Kisan</i>		Lands which may be distributed to landless persons	
Survey No.	Area A.g.	Survey No.	Area A.g.

Out of the lands to be held by me as *Gramdan Kisan*, the following lands are subject to encumbrances, as indicated below:

(Here specify lands and the nature of encumbrances,
lease, mortgage etc. against them)

1. In the Maharashtra Act, gramsabha has been referred to as Gram Mandal.

2. It is hereby declared that I also undertake —

(a) to join the *Gramdan* community of the aforesaid village, and

(b) to make a periodical contribution to the *Gram Mandal* in accordance with the provisions of clause (d) of sub-section (1) of Section 27 of the aforesaid Act, for community purposes.

Date

Signature

Form II

Form of Declaration to be filed by persons residing in a village (not being minors) who do not own land in Gramdan village for joining the Gramdan community

I/We the undersigned, the adult residents of the - - - village in the - - - Taluka of the - - - District, who do not own any land in the said village, having fully understood the idea of the *Gramdan* Movement initiated by Acharya Vinobaji Bhave, do declare that I/we undertake, subject to the provision of the Maharashtra Gramdan Act 1964 and the rules made thereunder, to join *Gramdan* community of the said village and agree to pay a periodic contribution equal to one-fortieth of my/our net annual income to the *Mandal*, for community purposes.

Date

Signature(s)

Annexure 4

A Brief Chronology of the Movement

1951	18 April	First land-gift received at Pochampalli.
	27 June	End of Telangana tour. 12,200 acres bhoodan received.
	12 Dec.	Vinoba leaves Pavnar for Delhi for discussions with the Planning Commission.
	2 Oct.	At Sagar, Vinoba calls for bhoodan of 50 million acres to solve the land problem.
	13 Nov.	Vinoba reaches Delhi. 19,436 acres bhoodan received during the tour.
	13-23 Nov.	Vinoba's discussions with the Planning Commission.
1952	13-16 April	4th Sarvodaya Conference at Sevapuri. Sarva Seva Sangh adopts bhoodan as its programme and sets target of 2.5 million acres bhoodan within 2 years.
	23 May	Gramdan of Mangaroth.
	11 Sept.	Vinoba's announcement not to return to his ashram before solution of the land problem.
	14 Sept.	Vinoba enters Bihar after getting 2,95,504 acres bhoodan in U.P.
	23 Oct.	Vinoba announces the scheme of sampattidan.
1953	7-9 March	5th Sarvodaya Conference at Chandil. Vinoba's appeal to build 'people's power, opposed to the power of violence and different from the coercive power of the State'.
	27 March	Parliament members' conference on bhoodan at Delhi.
	3 May	Bihar Congress resolves to collect 3.2 million acres bhoodan.
1954	18-20 April	6th Sarvodaya Conference at Bodhgaya.

		Hundreds of workers including Vinoba and JP declare <i>jivandan</i> (gift of life) for 'Nonviolent revolution founded on Bhoodan-Yajna and with village industries as its mainstay'.
	31 Dec.	End of Bihar tour. 2.23 million acres bhoodan received in the state.
1955	1-25 Jan.	Tour of W. Bengal. 1,851 acres bhoodan received.
	25-27 Mar.	7th Sarvodaya Conference at Jagannathpuri.
	30 Sept.	End of Vinoba's Odisha tour. Bhoodan of 0.26 million acres and 812 gramdans received in the state.
1956	13 May	End of Vinoba's Andhra tour. Bhoodan of 62,634 acres and 20 gramdans received in the state.
	27-29 May	8th Sarvodaya Conference at Kanchipuram.
	16 Nov.	Decision taken at Palni for <i>nidhimukti</i> and <i>tantramukti</i> .
1957	15 April	At Kanyakumari, Vinoba reiterates his resolve not to rest till establishment of gram-swaraj.
	18 April	Vinoba enters Kerala after receiving 254 gramdans in Tamil Nadu.
	9-16 May	9th Sarvodaya Conference at Kaldi. Resolve to work for gramdan.
	23 Aug.	Constitution of Shanti-Sena
	24 Aug.	Vinoba enters Karnataka. 1,571 acres bhoodan and 301 gramdans in Kerala.
	21-22 Sept.	All-Party Conference on Gramdan at Yelwal supports gramdan and recommends closest co-operation between Gramdan Movement and Community Development Programme of the Government.
	1 Nov.	Vinoba gives the <i>mantra</i> 'Jai Jagat' (Victory to the world).
1958	1 February	Sarvodaya-patra scheme announced.

	23 March	Vinoba enters Maharashtra. 1,000 acres bhoodan and 36 gramdans in Karnataka.
	30-31 May	10th Sarvodaya Conference at Pandharpur.
	22 Sept.	Vinoba enters Gujarat. 432 gramdans in Maharashtra.
1959	15 Jan.	Vinoba enters Rajasthan.
	27 Feb.-1 Mar.	11th Sarvodaya Conference at Ajmer.
	13 Mar.	Establishment of Brahmaavidya Mandir.
	1 April.	Vinoba enters Punjab. 171 gramdans in Rajasthan.
	22 May.	Vinoba enters Jammu and Kashmir to give 'message of love'.
	11 July	Vinoba reaches Pir Panjal at the height of 13,500 ft.
1960	20-27 Mar.	12th Sarvodaya Conference at Sevagram.
	19 May	19 dacoits in Chambal valley surrender to Vinoba.
	24 Jul.-	Work at Indore to make it a 'Sarvodaya
	25 Aug.	city'. Establishment of Visarjan Ashram. Opposition to indecent posters.
	25 Dec.	Bigha-Kattha campaign in Bihar.
1961	5 Mar.	Vinoba enters Assam.
	14-20 April	13th Sarvodaya Conference at Unguturu.
1962	12 January	Assam becomes the first state to pass Gramdan Act.
	5-21 Sept.	Vinoba in East Pakistan (Bangladesh). 176 bighas received and distributed.
	23-24 Nov.	14th Sarvodaya Conference at Vedchhi.
1963	5 Feb.	Khadi workers accept free weaving scheme.
	1 Mar.	<i>Maitri Yatra</i> starts from Delhi.
	2-3 Nov.	Planning Commission's conference on Gramdan.
	27-29 Dec.	15th Sarvodaya Conference at Raipur. Triple programme of village-oriented khadi, Shanti-Sena and Gramdan accepted.
1964	13 Nov.	Vinoba ends walking tour.

1965	12-17 Feb.	Vinoba fasts to end violence in anti-Hindi agitation. Suggests three-point formula.
	8 May	Call for <i>toofan</i> in Bihar.
	11 Sept.	Vinoba arrives in Patna.
1966	15-17 April	16th Sarvodaya Conference at Balia. Resolve to obtain 50,000 gramdams by the year-end.
	7 June	Vinoba announces ' <i>Sookshma-pravesh</i> '.
1967	19 Feb.	Zilla-dan of Darbhanga.
	25 Oct.	<i>Mahila Lok-yatra</i> begins.
1968	24 Jan.	Resolve for 'Bihar-dan' by 2 October.
	8 Mar.	Foundation of 'Acharyakul' at Kahalgaon.
	8-10 Jun.	17th Sarvodaya Conference at Abu Road. Desire expressed for 'Bharat-dan' by the Gandhi centenary year.
1969	26-28 Oct.	18th Sarvodaya Conference at Rajgir. 'Bihar-dan' almost achieved. Announcement of future programmes.
	30 Oct.	Vinoba leaves Bihar.
1970	8 Jun.	JP arrives at Muzaffarpur for intensive work in Musahari block.
	11 Sept.	Saharsa district in Bihar declared 'national front'.
	2 Oct.	Gram-swarajya Kosh of Rs. 6.25 millions presented to Vinoba.
1971	8-10 May	19th Sarvodaya Conference at Nasik.
1972	14 April	Dacoits in Chambal valley surrender to JP.
	19-21 May	20th Sarvodaya Conference at Nakodar.
1973	11-14 April	21st Sarvodaya Conference at Kurukshetra.
	11 Sept.	Vinoba announces idea of ' <i>Upavasdan</i> '.
1974	1-3 April	Vinoba's discussion with pro-Bihar agitation workers. Parting of ways becomes imminent.
	May	Forces withdrawn from Saharsa. End of the last campaign.

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35. Francisco Benet, quoted in T.K. Oommen, *Charisma, stability and change* (New Delhi: Thomson Press, 1972), p. 100.

36. R.C. Dutt, *The Economic History of India, Vol.1*, op. cit., p. 98.

37. Swami Sahajanand Saraswati, *Khet mazdoor aur Jharkhand ke kisan* (Hindi) (Delhi: Granthshilpi, 2001), p. 45.

38. Ibid., p. 70.

39. RNCA, 1976, p. 238.

40. Swami Sahajanand Saraswati, *Khet mazdoor aur Jharkhand ke kisan*, p. 45.

41. *Report of the Congress Agrarian Reforms Committee (1949)* (New Delhi: All India Congress Committee, 1951).

42. Swami Sahajanand Saraswati, *Khet mazdoor aur Jharkhand ke kisan*, p. 43.

43. Aatre, T.N., *Gaongada* (Pune: Varada Books, 1989), pp. 174-76.

44. Jawaharlal Nehru, *An Autobiography* (New Delhi: Jawaharlal Nehru Memorial Fund, 1988), p. 52.

45. Mahashweta Devi and Nirmal Ghosh, *Bharat men Bandhua Mazdoor* (New Delhi: Radhakrishna Prakashan, 1981), p. 34.

46. RNCA, 1976, p. 6.

47. A.R. Desai, *Rural India in transition* (Bombay: Popular Prakashan, 1979), p. 166.

48. RNCA, 1976, pp. 8-9.

49. *Progress of Land Reform* (Delhi: Planning Commission, Govt. of India, 1963), pp. 168-69.

50. Dantwala M.L. et al: *Indian agricultural development since Independence* (New Delhi: Oxford and IBH Publishing co., 1986) pp. 2-3.

51. R.K. Patil, member of the first Planning Commission, had used this idiom while talking to the author.

52. Pyarelal, *Mahatma Gandhi—the early phase*, p. 39.

53. Interested readers may profitably refer to Dharampal's book '*The Beautiful Tree*' (*Collected Writings, Vol. III*, Other India Press, Mapusa, Goa, 2000).

54. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya, Vol. 16*, p. 185.

55. Vinoba, *Sarvodaya Yatra*, p. 81.

3. The Land Problem: Search for Solution

1. Bipan Chandra, *Bharat men arthik rashtravad ka udbhav aur vikas* (Hindi) (New Delhi: Anamika Publishers and Distributors Pvt Ltd., 2004), p. 190.

2. Ibid, p. 194.

3. Ibid., pp. 199-201.

4. Ibid, p. 227.

5. H.D. Malaviya, *Land Reforms in India* (New Delhi: Indian National Congress, 1955), pp. 4-5.

6. D. Rothermund, *Mahatma Gandhi—An essay in political biography* (New Delhi: Manohar, 1999), pp. 54-55.

7. RNCA, 1976, pp. 18-19.

8. Ibid, p. 19.

9. Ibid, pp. 20-21.

10. *Report of the Congress Agrarian Reforms Committee (1949)*, p. 36.

11. RNCA, 1976, pp. 22-23.

12. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya, Vol. 18*, pp. 29-30.

13. Ibid., p. 39.

14. Narendra Chapalgaonkar, *Karmayogi sannyasi*, p. 5.

15. Ibid., pp. 286-87.

16. C. Rajeswar Rao, *The historic Telangana struggle* (New Delhi: Communist Party Publication, 1972), p. 21.

17. Ravinarayan Reddy, *Heroic Telangana—Reminiscences and experiences* (New Delhi: Communist Party Publication, 1973), p. 60.

18. Ibid, p. 64.

19. Narendra Chapalgaonkar, *Karmayogi sannyasi*, p. 332. Many accounts of the brutalities of the Communists were told to Vinoba during his Telangana tour.

20. Damodardas Moondada, *Bhoodan Gangotri* (Wardha: A. B. Sarva Seva Sangh, 1957), p. 8.

21. P. Sundarayya, quoted in Barry Pavier, *The Telangana Movement, 1944-1951* (Vikas Publishing House, New Delhi, 1981), p. 117.

22. C. Rajeswar Rao, *The historic Telangana struggle*, p. 31.

23. Ibid, p. 14.

24. Laxminarayan Bharatiya (Ed.), *Damodardas Moondada Smriti-granth* (Hyderabad, Harishchandra Heda, 1986), Marathi section, p. 12.

25. *Sarvodaya*, September 1953, p. 93.

26. Narendra Chapalgaonkar, *Karmayogi sannyasi*, p. 327.

27. Barry Pavier, *The Telangana Movement, 1944-1951*, pp. 173-74.

28. M.K. Gandhi, *The Story of My Experiments with Truth* (Ahmedabad: Navajivan, 1969), p. 224.

29. D.G. Tendulkar, *Mahatma, Vol. 3* (New Delhi: Publications Division, Government of India, 1969), p. 104.

30. M.K. Gandhi, *The mind of Mahatma Gandhi* (Ed. R.K. Prabhu and U.R. Rao), (Ahmedabad: Navajivan, 1969), pp. 218-19.

31. M.K. Gandhi, *Constructive Programme*, p. 22.

32. Louis Fischer, *A week with Gandhi* (Bombay: International Book House Ltd., 1944), p. 43.

33. Sushila Nayyar in *Bhoodan*, 1-8-1956.

34. Ibid.

35. M.K. Gandhi, *The mind of Mahatma Gandhi* (Ed. R.K. Prabhu and U.R. Rao), p. 220.

36. N.K. Bose, *Studies in Gandhism* (Ahmedabad: Navajivan, 1972), p. 31.

37. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya, Vol. 15* (Hindi) (Pavnar: Paramdham Prakashan, 1996), p. 41.

38. Vinoba, *Krant-darshan* (Marathi) (Wardha: Paramdham Vidyapith Prakashan, 1956), p. 65.

39. Ibid, p. 66.
40. Ibid, p. 67.
41. Vinoba, *Sarvodaya-yatra*, pp. 4-5.

4. Bhoodan: the Beginning

1. This is the title of the collection of Vinoba's speeches during the first 21 days. '*Sarvodaya Padayatra*' by Damodardas Moondhada (Wardha: A.B. Sarva Seva Sangh, 1956) describes the entire tour in detail.

2. Vinoba, *Sarvodaya Yatra*, pp. 66-67.
3. Damodardas Moondada, *Sarvodaya Padayatra*, p. 80.
4. Ibid, p. 135.
5. Ibid, p. 159.
6. Ibid, pp. 202-03.
7. Ibid, pp. 208-10.
8. *Sarvodaya*, March 1951, cover p. 3.

9. *Teesara Sarvodaya Sammelan* (Shivarampalli, 1951) *Vivaran* (Report of the 3rd Sarvodaya Conference), p. 1.

10. Ibid, p. 92 kh,g.

11. *Progress of Land Reform (1963)*, p. 14, 18, 35.

12. The account of the Pochampalli incident here is mostly based on Damodardas Moondada's authoritative account *Bhoodan Gangotri*. Moondada had accompanied Vinoba on the tour.

13. Shrikrishnadas Jajoo in *Sarvodaya*, July 1953, pp. 774-75.

14. Literally, the people of God. It was the name given to the untouchables by Gandhi. Untouchability has since been legally banned and practically eradicated. Those belonging to the formerly untouchable castes, however, now prefer the term 'Dalit', and are, therefore, referred to here accordingly.

15. Damodardas Moondada, *Bhoodan Gangotri*, p. 34.

16. Ibid, p. 38. '*Bhoodan in Andhra Pradesh*', a report by A.P. Bhoodan-Yajna Board (Year of publication not given), however, says that the land was immediately distributed to 62 families. (p. 2)

17. Ravinarayan Reddy, *Heroic Telangana—Reminiscences and experiences*, p. 78.

18. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 24-6-1955.

19. Roderic Church in '*Vinoba: the Spiritual Revolutionary*', ed. R.R. Diwakar, Mahendra Agrawal (New Delhi: Gandhi Peace Foundation, 1984), p. 45.

20. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 15, pp. 39-40.

21. Strangely, the incident does not find mention in Moondada's authentic '*Bhoodan Gangotri*' although it has been told by Vinoba himself several times, albeit with minor variations, e.g. in 1955 (*Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 15, p. 40), 1958 (Talk at Vedchhi, 2-11-1958), 1964 (*Trividh Karyakram*, Pavnar: Paramdham Prakashan, 1965, p. 94) and 1970 (*Maitri*, November 1993, pp. 14-15). It is regrettable that we do not know the name of the man who was virtually the first donor in the Bhoodan-Yajna.

22. *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 15, p. 40.

23. Damodardas Moondada, *Bhoodan Gangotri*, pp. 58-59.

24. Ibid., p. 81.

25. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 1 (Sarva Seva Sangh, Varanasi, 1956), p. 8.

26. Damodardas Moondada, *Bhoodan Gangotri*, pp. 151-52. Vinoba met Communist prisoners at Nalgonda on 10 May and at Warangal on 29 May and apprised the Home Minister of the difficulties being faced by them.

27. Damodardas Moondada, *Bhoodan Gangotri*, p. 172.

28. Ibid, p. 201.

29. Ibid, p. 234.

30. *Sevak*, November 1951, p. 483.

31. Damodardas Moondada, *Bhoodan Gangotri*, p. 167.

32. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 1, p. 10.

33. Ibid. pp. 100-101.

34. Damodardas Moondada, *Bhoodan Gangotri*, p. 202.

35. Ibid., p. 253.

36. Ibid., p. 169.

37. *Sarvodaya*, June 1951, pp. 714-15.

38. Ibid., p. 717.

39. Damodardas Moondada, *Bhoodan Gangotri*, p. 319.

40. Suresh Ram, *Vinoba and his mission* (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1962), p. 60.
41. *Harijan*, 23-6-1951.
42. The original letter is with the author.
43. Damodardas Moondada, *Bhoodan Gangotri*, Preface, pp. 3-4.

5. Bhoodan Gathers Momentum

1. *Sarvodaya*, August 1951, p. 855.
2. The author has original letter with him.
3. *Sarvodaya*, August 1951, Cover p. 4.
4. Damodardas Moondada, *Bhoodan Gangotri*, p. 382.
5. *Harijan*, 21-7-1951 and *Harijan*, 18-8-1951.
6. *Sevak*, November 1951.
7. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 1, pp. 31-32.
8. Damodardas Moondada, *Sant Vinoba ki Uttar Bharat Yatra* (Hindi) (Kashi: Sarvodaya Sahitya Sangh, 1953), p. 12.
9. *Sarvodaya*, February 1952, p. 1255.
10. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 1, op. cit., p. 35.
11. Ibid., p. 37. Total land under cultivation in the country at that time was 296.875 million acres. (Source: Data-Book-2011, Indian agricultural statistics research Institute, New Delhi. From Website unstats.un.org accessed on 8-11-2014.)
12. Damodardas Moondada, *Sant Vinoba ki Uttar Bharat Yatra*, p. 39.
13. *Sarvodaya*, December 1951, p. 1117.
14. Suresh Ram, *Vinoba and his mission*, p. 70.
15. Vinoba, *Rajghat ki sannidhi men* (Hindi) (New Delhi: Sasta Sahitya Mandal, 1952), p. 9.
16. Ibid, pp. 10-11.
17. Ibid, p. 45.
18. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 1, op. cit., p. 89.
19. Vinoba, *Rajghat ki sannidhi men*, pp. 23-25.
20. Ibid, p. 27.
21. *Harijan*, 29-12-1951.

22. *Sarvodaya*, February 1952, p. 1308.
23. Damodardas Moondada, *Sant Vinoba ki Uttar Bharat Yatra*, p. 151.
24. *Sarvodaya*, April 1952, p. 1377.
25. A measure of the land area, which varies from region to region.
26. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 1, pp. 78-82.
27. *Ibid*, p. 88.
28. *Harijan*, 19-4-1952.
29. The author has Lohia's original letter with him.
30. The author has a copy of Vinoba's letter with him.
31. Sarva Seva Sangh Minutes Register.
32. Sarva Seva Sangh Minutes Register.
33. *Sevapuri Sarvodaya Sammelan* (1952) *Vivaran*, p. 74, 79.
34. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 1, p. 98-99.
35. Damodardas Moondada, *Sant Vinoba ki Uttar Bharat Yatra*, p.194 and Nirmala Deshpande, *Vinobanchya Sahawasat* (Marathi) (Pavnar: Paramdham Prakashan), p. 7.
36. Nirmala Deshpande, *Vinobanchya Sahawasat*, pp. 8-9.
37. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 1, p. 116.
38. Vinoba was adept in coining new terms from the concepts and incidents from ancient history and mythology to drive home his points. In ancient India, emperors used to perform Rajasooya Yajna at the time of coronation as a mark of their undisputed sovereignty. What Vinoba meant was that bhoodan would lead to the establishment of sovereignty of the masses (*praja*) as opposed to a monarch (*raja*).
39. *Sevapuri Sarvodaya Sammelan* (1952) *Vivaran*, Appendix 3, pp. 5-7.
40. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 1, p. 127.
41. *Ibid.*, p. 142.
42. *Ibid*, pp. 157-58.
43. Nirmala Deshpande, *Vinobanchya Sahawasat*, pp. 82-85; *Sant Vinoba aur Bhoodan-Yajna* (Patna: Bihar Bhoodan Prapti Samiti, 1953), pp. 48-51 and *Harijan-Sevak*, 7-6-1952.
44. Shyamsundar Shastri (Ed.), *Diwan Shatrughna Singh Abhinandan granth* (Rath, Hamirpur: Bundelkhand-Kesari Jayanti

Mahotsav samiti, 1960), p. 29. See this book as well as Shrikrishnadatta Bhatt, *Chalo chalen Mangroth* (Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1958) for details of the incident and the preceding and following processes.

45. *Raipur Sarvodaya Sammelan* (1963) *Vivaran* (Report of the Sarvodaya Conference, Raipur), p. 87.

46. *Sarvodaya*, August 1952, pp. 21-22.

47. Damodardas Moondada, *Sant Vinoba ki Uttar Bharat Yatra*, p.281.

48. *Sarvodaya*, May 1952, p. 1557.

49. *Sarvodaya*, September 1952, pp. 1-3.

50. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 1, op. cit., p. 179.

51. *Bhoodan-Yajna* (Marathi), 25-9-1952.

52. *Sarvodaya*, October 1952, pp. 185-86.

53. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 26-12-1958.

54. *Uttar Pradesh men Bhoodan-Yajna ka arambh aur pragati* (1951-1959) (Hindi) (Varanasi: Uttar Pradesh Bhoodan-Yajna Samiti), p. 4.

55. *Harijan-Sevak*, 22-11-1952.

56. *Harijan-Sevak*, 18-10-1952.

57. *Sarvodaya*, September 1952, pp. 115-17.

58. *Harijan-Sevak*, 25-10-1952 and *Sarvodaya*, October 1952, pp. 213-17.

59. *Sarvodaya*, August 1952, p. 54.

60. A.R. Desai, *Rural India in transition*, p. 138.

61. *Ibid*, p. 148.

6. Bihar as a Laboratory

1. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva* (Hindi) (Pavnar: Paramdham Prakashan, 1998), pp. 5-6.

2. *Sarvodaya*, January 1953, p. 459.

3. *Chandil Sarvodaya Sammelan* (1953) *Vivaran* (Report of the Sarvodaya Conference, Chandil), pp. 59-60.

4. *Bhoodan as seen by the West* (Tanjore: Sarvodaya Prachuralaya, 1957), p. 15.

5. Nirmala Deshpande, *Vinobanchya Sahawasat*, p. 123.

6. Ibid.
7. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, pp. 8-9.
8. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 1, pp. 188-89.
9. Nirmala Deshpande, *Vinobanchya Sahawasat*, p. 135.
10. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 1, op. cit., p. 188.
11. Nirmala Deshpande, *Vinobanchya Sahawasat*, p. 144.
12. Ibid., p.163 and *Sarvodaya*, December 1954, p. 338.
13. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 1, op. cit., p. 212.
14. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 18, p. 106.
15. Ibid., p. 114.
16. Nirmala Deshpande, *Vinobanchya Sahawasat*, pp. 165-66.
17. Bipan Chandra et al, *India after Independence* (Viking - Penguin Books, India, 1999), p. 134.
18. Ajit Bhattacharjee, *Jayaprakash Narayan - a political biography* (Delhi: Vikas Publishing House, 1978), pp. 148-49.
19. *Sarvodaya*, January 1953, pp. 446-47.
20. Ibid., p. 430.
21. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 1, p. 239.
22. Ibid., pp. 246-47.
23. Ibid., pp. 248-49.
24. *Chandil Sarvodaya Sammelan* (1953) *Vivaran*, p. 38.
25. Ibid., p. 10.
26. Ibid., p. 12.
27. Ibid., pp. 14-18.
28. Ibid., p. 24.
29. Ibid., p. 35.
30. Ibid., p. 54.
31. Ibid., Annexure, pp. 21-22.
32. Ibid., p. 15.
33. Ibid., p. 50.
34. Ibid., p. 12.
35. *Sevak*, March 1953, p. 143.
36. *Sarvodaya*, March-April 1953.

37. *Harijan*, 18-4-1953.
38. *Sarvodaya*, March-April 1953, p. 638.
39. *Bhoodan as seen by the West*, p. 44.
40. *Ibid.*, p. 45.
41. *Sarvodaya*, July 1953, p. 804.
42. An image of the cover is available on the internet.
43. *Sarvodaya*, May 1953, pp. 657-59.
44. *Sarvodaya*, July 1953, p. 793.
45. *Ibid.*, p. 801.
46. *Sarvodaya*, June 1953, pp. 707-08.
47. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga, Vol. 2* (Hindi) (Varanasi: Sarva Seva sangh, 1956), pp. 28-31.
48. *Ibid.*, p. 68.
49. *Sarvodaya*, June 1953, p. 739.
50. *Sarvodaya*, July 1953, p. 807.
51. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, p. 34.
52. *Ibid.*, pp. 42-43.
53. *Sarvodaya*, October 1953, pp. 192-94.

7. Bihar: Second Phase of the 'Tour of Joy'

1. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, pp. 47-48.
2. Vinoba, *Vinoba Pravachan (Purnea)* (Hindi) (Patna: Bihar Bhoodan-prapti Samiti, 1954), pp. 128-29.
3. *Ibid.*, p. 62.
4. *Ibid.*, p. 103.
5. *Sarvodaya Samaj ka Chhatha Varshik Sammelan* (Report of the sixth Sarvodaya Conference, Bodhgaya, 1954) (Gaya: Secretary, Sarvodaya Sammelan, 1954), pp. 15-17.
6. *Ibid.*, pp. 26-29.
7. *Ibid.*, p. 32.
8. *Ibid.*, pp. 42-46.
9. *Ibid.*, p. 49.
10. *Ibid.*, Annexure, p. 8.

11. Ibid., Annexure, p. 17.
12. Ibid., p. 95.
13. Ibid., p. 87.
14. Ibid., Annexure, p. 32.
15. Ibid., pp. 72-73.
16. Sarvanarayandas, op. cit., pp. 59-60.
17. *Sarvodaya Samaj ka Chhatha Varshik Sammelan*, Annexure, p. Ba-Ka.
18. Ibid., Annexure, p. 47.
19. Ibid., p. 77.
20. *Japa*: Uttering the Lord's Name; *Tapa*: Penance; *Jnana*: (Self-Knowledge. All these are different ways of spiritual pursuit.
21. *Sarvodaya Samaj ka Chhatha Varshik Sammelan*, pp. 21-22.
22. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, pp. 61-62.
23. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 2, pp. 263-64.
24. Suresh Ram, *Sant Vinoba ki anandyatra* (Hindi) (Kashi: Sarva Seva sangh, 1955), pp. 70-71.
25. *Sarvodaya*, October 1953, pp. 163-64.
26. Suresh Ram, *Sant Vinoba ki anandyatra*, p. 112.
27. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 2, p. 274.
28. Suresh Ram, *Sant Vinoba ki anandyatra*, p. 179, 193.
29. Ibid., p. 210.
30. Ibid.. pp. 215-16. Abhimanyu, the son of Arjuna, learnt how to enter the *chakravyuha*, a complex formation of army, which was difficult to penetrate, while he was in the womb of his mother. But he did not know how to come out of it. During the great Mahabharata war, he penetrated the *chakravyuha*, but as he could not come out of it, was surrounded by the Kaurava army which he valiantly fought, but was finally killed.
31. Suresh Ram, *Vinoba and his mission*, p. 116.
32. Suresh Ram, *Sant Vinoba ki anandyatra*, p. 262.
33. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, pp. 77-78.
34. Ibid., p. 75 except for the figure of kilometres which is taken from *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 20 (Hindi) (Pavnar: Paramdham Prakashan, 2001), p. 532.

35. *Sarvodaya*, August 1954, p. 50.

36. Suresh Ram, *Sant Vinoba ki anandyatra*, pp. 303-04.

37. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, p. 84.

38. *Sarvodaya*, January 1955, p. 419.

39. It may be mentioned that the government launched Million Wells Scheme much later, in 1988. However, its progress has been tardy and emphasis continues to be on big projects.

40. *Sevak*, February 1955, p. 96.

8. In Bengal and Odisha

1. *Sarvodaya*, January 1955, pp. 359-60.

2. Suresh Ram, *Vinoba and his mission*, pp. 122-24.

3. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 3 (Hindi) (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1957), p. 21.

4. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 27-2-1959.

5. Shriman Narayan, *Rishi Vinoba*, pp. 233.

6. Vinoba's talk at Tyagaraj Nagar, Madras, 19-5-1956.

7. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 3, pp. 37-38.

8. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 16-2-1955.

9. *Sarvodaya*, February 1955, Cover p. 4.

10. Kusum Deshpande, *Krantichya Dishene* (Marathi) (Pavnar: Paramdham Prakashan, 1956), Foreword, p. 3.

11. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 3, p. 59, 65. The concept of *Samyayog* is one of the unique contributions by Vinoba. *Samyayog* believes in the unity of all life. It seeks to establish perfect equality in all spheres of life..

12. Kusum Deshpande, *Krantichya Dishene*, p. 75.

13. *Ibid.*, pp. 107-13.

14. *Sarvodaya*, April-June 1955, Annexures, p. 95.

15. *Ibid.*, p. 645.

16. *Ibid.*, pp. 602-03.

17. *Ibid.*, pp. 609-10.

18. *Ibid.*, Annexures, p. 50.

19. *Ibid.*, Annexures, p. 72.

20. Ibid, Annexures, p. 73.
21. Ibid., pp. 594-98.
22. Ibid., Annexures, pp. 56-57.
23. Kusum Deshpande, *Krantichya Dishene*, p. 175.
24. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 3, p. 199.
25. Ibid., pp. 203-05.
26. Ibid., pp. 211-13.
27. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 3, pp. 214-17.
28. Nirmala Deshpande, *Krantichya watewar* (Pavnar: Paramdham Prakashan, 1956), pp. 45-46.
29. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 3, pp. 227-30.
30. Nirmala Deshpande, *Krantichya watewar*, p. 70.
31. Ibid., p. 86. For a detailed elaboration of the concept, see Vinoba's '*Swaraj and Lokniti*' (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 2014).
32. Ibid., p. 114.
33. Nirmala Deshpande, *Krantichya watewar*, p. 154.
34. Shrikrishnadatt Bhatt, *Nakshatron ki chhaya men* (Hindi) (Wardha: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1957), pp. 95-96.
35. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 3, p. 279.
36. Ibid., pp. 289-91.
37. Ibid., p. 305.
38. Suresh Ram, *Vinoba and his mission*, p. 154.
39. *The Revolutionary Bhoodan* (Sarvodaya Prachuralaya, Tanjore, 1955), pp. 36-37.
40. Sarva Seva Sangh Minutes Register.

9. In Andhra and Tamil Nadu

1. Narendra Chapalgaonkar, *Karmayogi Sannyasi*, p. 359.
2. Talk at Sarunagar, 4-2-1956.
3. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 4 (Hindi) (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1957), p. 95, 98.
4. Ibid., p. 101.
5. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 27-1-1956.
6. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 6-4-1956.

7. Sarva Seva Sangh Minutes Register
8. Shrikrishnadatt Bhatt, *Nakshatron ki chhaya men*, pp. 210-11.
9. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 4, p. 214.
10. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 18-5-1956.
11. *Bhoodan*, 9-5-1956.
12. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 4, p. 239.
13. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 1-6-1956.
14. Suresh Ram, *Vinoba and his mission*, p. 166.
15. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 4, p. 298.
16. *Ibid.*, p. 302.

17. The word 'niti' has many meanings: policy, conduct and management and the science of morality. 'Raj-niti' means politics, that is, the way power is exerted. While making this comment, Vinoba has the last meaning of 'niti' in mind. Such play with words is Vinoba's characteristic.

18. *Ibid.*, p. 318.

19. *Kanchipuram Sarvodaya Sammelan Vivaran* (1956) (Report of the Sarvodaya Conference, Kanchipuram, 1956), p. 167.

20. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 5 (Hindi) (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1957), p. 60.

21. *Ibid.*, pp. 126-27.

22. Indrasen, in Banarasidas Chaturvedi et al. (Ed.), *Vinoba—vyaktitwa aur vichar* (Hindi) (New Delhi: Sasta Sahitya Mandal, 1971), pp. 164-66 and *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 20-7-1956.

23. Vimala Thakar, in *Bhoodan*, 29-8-1956 and Nirmala Deshpande, in *Bhoodan-Yajna Varta*, 10-7-1956.

24. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 7-9-1956.

25. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 31-8-1956.

26. *Bhoodan*, 26-9-1956.

27. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 7-9-1956.

28. Vinoba: *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 5, op.cit., p. 187.

29. Talk at Tandampaleyam, 27-10-1956.

30. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 7-12-1956.

31. *Ibid.*

32. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 14-12-1956.
33. Ibid.
34. *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 19, p. 286.
35. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 6 (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1957), pp. 93-96.
36. Geoffery Ostergaard and M. Currell, *The Gentle Anarchists* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1971), p. 207.
37. Vinoba: *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 6, pp. 134-35.
38. Ibid., pp. 157-61.
39. Ibid., pp. 162-66.
40. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 18-1-1957.
41. *Bhoodan-Yajna Varta* 11, 11-1-1957.
42. Vinoba, *Maharashtrat Vinoba*, Vol. 1 (Marathi) (Pavnar: Paramdham Prakashan, 1958), pp. 34-35.
43. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 6, p. 19.
44. Ibid., p. 37.
45. Ibid., p. 40.
46. Ibid., p. 125.
47. *Bhoodan*, 27-2-1957.
48. Allan and Wendy Scarfe, *Jayaprakash—ek jivani* (Hindi) (New Delhi: Radhakrishna Prakashan, 1978), p. 260.
49. Talk at Kaladi, 11-5-1957.
50. Talk at Pulinipatti, 9-1-1957.
51. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 3-5-1957.

10. In Kerala and Karnataka

1. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 15-2-1957.
2. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 16-8-1957.
3. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 26-4-1957.
4. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 3-5-1957.
5. Charuchandra Bhandari, *Gramdan kyon?* (Wardha: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1958), p. 49.
6. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 10-5-1957.
7. Talk at Alwaye, 7-5-1957.

8. Suresh Ram, *Vinoba and his mission*, p. 196.
9. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 10-5-1957.
10. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 6, p. 315.
11. *Ibid.*, p. 307.
12. Talk at Alwaye, 7-5-1957.
13. *Kaladi Sarvodaya Sammelan* (1957) *Vivaran* (Hindi), pp. 11-13.
14. *Ibid.*, p. 64.
15. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 7-6-1957.
16. *Kaladi Sarvodaya Sammelan* (1957) *Vivaran*, pp. 65-66.
17. *Ibid.*, p. 40.
18. *Ibid.*, pp. 33-35.
19. *Ibid.*, p. 202.
20. *Ibid.*, pp. 94-96.
21. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 7 (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1962), pp. 43-44.
22. Talk at Karivellur, 15-8-1957.
23. Sachidanand, *Sarvodaya in a Communist state* (Bombay: Popular Book Depot, 1961), p. 48. As already stated, a group of 20 villages was considered a village for the purpose of gramdan in Kerala. Interestingly, workers took it literally—thus, a locality of 180 families was taken as 9 villages—obviously to inflate the figure of gramdans!
24. *Bhoodan*, 2-10-1957.
25. Talk at Mysore, 25-9-1957
26. From a folder published by Sarva Seva Sangh. Author has a copy of this folder.
27. *Ibid.*
28. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 3-5-1957.
29. *Community Development and Panchayati Raj in India 1952-1972* (New Delhi: Government of India, Ministry of Agriculture, 1972), pp. 39-40.
30. Talk at Arsikere, 8-11-1957.
31. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 7, pp. 147-48.
32. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 1-11-1957.

33. Army raised by Subhas Chandra Bose during World War II from prisoners of war captured by Japan, to fight for India's freedom.

34. Akshaykumar Karan et al (Ed.), *Baba Raghavdas smriti-granth* (Varanasi: Uttar Pradesh Gandhi smarak Nidhi, 1963), p. 104.

35. Talk on 22-1-1958.

36. *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 16, p. 376.

37. Ibid.

38. What Vinoba meant was that they had only propagated ideas so far; concrete action had yet to start, and was beginning with this programme.

39. *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 16, p. 373.

40. Suresh Ram, *Vinoba and his mission*, p. 218.

11. In Maharashtra and Gujarat

1. Appa Patwardha, *Mazee jeevanyatra* (abridged), pp. 193-94; Narendra Chapalgaonkar, *Karmayogi sanniyasi*, pp. 377-78.

2. Narendra Chapalgaonkar, *Karmayogi sanniyasi*, pp. 377-78. Incidentally, Vinoba had suggested this long back, in 1949. (*Sarvodaya*, September 1949, pp. 117-18)

3. Talk at Belgaon, 15-3-1958.

4. Vinoba, *Maharashtrat Vinoba*, Vol. 1, pp. 72-76.

5. Ibid., pp. 1-10.

6. Ibid., pp. 20-21.

7. Ibid., p. 180.

8. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 13-2-1959.

9. Vinoba, *Maharashtrat Vinoba*, Vol. 2 (Pavnar: Paramdham Prakashan, 1958), p. 145.

10. This is a peculiar custom prevalent at the Pandharpur shrine.

11. Vinoba, *Maharashtrat Vinoba*, Vol. 2, p. 154.

12. Ibid., p. 158.

13. *Pandharpur Sarvodaya Sammelan (1958) Vivaran*, pp. 8-9.

14. Pyarelal, *Mahatma Gandhi—the Last phase* Vol. 10, p. 774. (www.mkgandhi.org)

15. *Pandharpur Sarvodaya Sammelan (1958) Vivaran*, pp. 116-22.

16. Ibid., pp. 126-27.
17. Ibid., pp. 186-87.
18. Meera Bhatt, in *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 9-2-1962.
19. Talk at Aurangabad, 18-7-1958.
20. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 3-10-1958.
21. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 10-10-1958.
22. Sadly, even their faith and commitment could not stand the test of time, as the author found, to his dismay, in a workshop on gramdan at Gujarat Vidyapith, Ahmedabad in June 2008.
23. Talk at Mangrol, 10-10-1958.
24. Harivallabh's work of conflict-resolution in Rangpur area received wide appreciation. For details, see Harivallabh Parikh, *Kranti ka arunodaya* (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1973).
24. Talk at Borsad, 2-11-1958.
25. Talk at Rajkot, 21-11-1958.
26. Suresh Ram, *Vinoba and his mission*, p. 241
27. Ibid.
28. Sarva Seva Sangh Executive Committee Minutes Register..
29. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 17-10-1958.
30. www.rmaf.org accessed on 12-4-2015.
31. *Gramraj*, 16-1-1959.

12. Message of Love

1. *Gramraj*, 16-1-1959.
2. *Bhoodan-yajna*, 13-3-1959.
3. *Ajmer Sarvodaya Sammelan (1959) Vivaran*, p. 108.
4. Ibid., pp. 26-36.
5. Ibid., p. 126.
6. Ibid., pp. 171-75.
7. Ibid., pp. 67-68.
8. Ibid., 200-201.
9. Suresh Ram, *Vinoba and his mission*, p. 255.
10. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 22-5-1959.

11. *Gramraj*, 5-5-1959.
12. Vinoba, *Mohabbat ka paigam* (abridged) (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1996), p. 58.
13. Talk at Ropar, 5-5-1959.
14. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 12-6-1959.
15. The talks have been published in the form of a book (*Japuji*) which has been translated in English and in some Indian languages.
16. However, it turned out that the figure included some lands gifted in the past, and 30,000 acres of government land also, so as to reach the target set by the workers.
17. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 8-5-1959.
18. Vinoba, *Mohabbat ka paigam* (Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1962), p. 14.
19. *Ibid.*, p. 315.
20. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 19-6-1959.
21. Vinoba, *Mohabbat ka paigam*, p. 195.
22. *Ibid.*, pp. 198-99.
23. *Ibid.*, pp. 326-27.
24. Shriman Narayan, *Rishi Vinoba*, p. 293.
25. *Gramraj*, 25-9-1959.
26. *Gramraj*, 15-7-1959.
27. See *Tenali men Sarvodaya-patra* (Tenali: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1959) for details.
28. From the press note issued by R.T.P. Subramaniam. A copy of the same is with the author.
29. *Gramraj*, 25-5-1959.
30. *Gramraj*, 25-7-1959.
31. *Ibid.*
32. Vinoba, *Mohabbat ka paigam*, p. 236.
33. *Ibid.*, p. 248.
34. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 15-4-1960.
35. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 11-3-1960.
36. *A.B. Sarva Seva Sangh Adhiveshan, Sevagram (1960) vivaran*, pp. 215-16.

37. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 22-4-1960.

38. Shrikrishnadatt Bhatt, *Chambal ke behadon men* (Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1960), pp. 74-75.

39. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 29-4-1960.

13. The Madhya Pradesh Tour

1. Gurusharan, *Chambal ke daku—samasya aur samadhan* (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1987), p. 59.

2. The author has the original letter of 30-3-1960 with him.

3. Shrikrishnadatta Bhatt, *Chambal ke behadon men*, pp. 58-59.

4. *Ibid.*, p. 106.

5. *Ibid.*, p. 154.

6. *Ibid.*, pp. 130-31.

7. *Ibid.*, p. 140.

8. Gurusharan, *Chambal ke daku—samasya aur samadhan*, p. 64.

9. Shrikrishnadatta Bhatt, *Chambal ke behadon men*, pp. 154-55.

10. *Ibid.*, p. 174.

11. *Ibid.*, p. 179.

12. *Ibid.*, pp. 199-200.

13. *Ibid.*, p. 215.

14. *Ibid.*, p. 217.

15. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 17-6-1960.

16. *Hitavada*, 15-3-1980.

17. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 19, p. 402.

18. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 24-2-1961.

19. Geeta Sane, *Chambalchi dasyubhoomi* (Marathi) (Mumbai: Mauji Prakashan Gruh, 1965), pp. 12-13.

20. *Gramraj*, 23-3-1959.

21. Vinoba, *Nagar Abhiyan* (Hindi) (Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1961), pp. 146-47.

22. They have been published in the form of a booklet titled '*Shuchita se atmadarshan*' (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh). Their gist has been included in the book '*Where silence speaks*' (Pavnar: Paramdham Prakashan, 2013), pp. 161-176.

23. Vinoba, *Nagar Abhiyan*, p. 276.
24. Ibid., pp. 250-51.
25. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 11-11-1960.
26. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 9-12-1960.
27. *Bhoomi-kranti*, 22-7-1963.
28. *Bhoomi-kranti*, 19-6-1961.

14. In the North-East

1. The author has with him the original letter written by Nehru in his own hand.
2. Babulal Gandhi, *Bharatatil Bhoomiheen ani Bhoodan* (Marathi) (Pavnar: Paramdham Prakashan, 1962).
3. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 22-7-1960.
4. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 20-1-1961.
5. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 24-2-1961.
6. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 13-1-1961.
7. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 3-3-1961.
8. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 31-3-1961.
9. *Unguturu Sarvodaya Sammelan (1961) Vivaran*, p. 130.
10. Ibid., pp. 130-31.
11. *Sarva Seva Sangh Adhiveshan, Unguturu (1961) Karyavahi*, p. 52.
12. *Unguturu Sarvodaya Sammelan (1961) Vivaran*, pp. 33-34.
13. *Sarva Seva Sangh Adhiveshan, Unguturu (1961) Karyavahi*, p. 64.
14. Ibid., pp. 185-86.
15. *Unguturu Sarvodaya Sammelan (1961) Vivaran*, p. 111.
16. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 4-8-1961.
17. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 25-8-1961 and 6-10-1961.
18. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 5-1-1962.
19. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 16-2-1962.
20. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 20-4-1962.
21. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 16-2-1962.

22. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 1-11-1963.
23. *Sarva Seva Sangh Patna Adhiveshan (1962) karyavahi*, p. 52.
24. Satish Kumar and E.P. Menon have narrated their experiences in the book '*Bina paise duniya ka paidal safar*' (Walking tour of the world without money) (Hindi) (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1965). Satish Kumar later settled in U.K.. He edits the journal '*Resurgence*'.
25. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 14-9-1962.
26. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 21-9-1962.
27. The author has the original letter with him.
28. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 27-4-1962.
29. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 27-10-1961.
30. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 24-11-1961.
31. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 18-5-1962.
32. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 1-6-1962.
33. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 22-6-1962.
34. Charu Choudhuri, *Vinoba ki Pakistan yatra* (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1963), p. 1. An abridged translation in English had also been published, titled '*Vinoba in Pakistan*' (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1964). However, the Hindi version has been referred here.
35. *Ibid.*, p. 5.
36. *Ibid.*, p. 27.
37. *Ibid.*, p. 44.
38. *Ibid.*, pp. 69-70.
39. *Ibid.*, p. 70.
40. *Ibid.*, p. 104.
41. *Bhoomi-kranti*, 17-9-1962.
42. Charu Choudhuri, *Vinoba ki Pakistan yatra*, p. 176.
43. *Ibid.*, pp. 181-88.

15. Towards Paramdham

1. *Bhoomi-kranti*, 5-11-1962.
2. *Vinoba, Cheen-Bharat seema sangharsh* (Hindi) (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1963), p. 8.
3. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 2-11-1962.

4. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 30-11-1962.
5. The author has copies of these letters dated 28-11-1962 and 2-12-1962.
6. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 18-1-1963.
7. *Sarva Seva Sangh Karya-vivaran (November 1962-November 1963)*, pp. 78-80.
8. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 7-2-1964.
9. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 17-1-1964.
10. *Sarva Seva Sangh Karya-vivaran (April 1961-November 1962)*, pp. 4-5.
11. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 28-12-1962.
12. Shriman Narayan, *Rishi Vinoba* (Hindi), pp. 326-27.
13. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 26-4-1963.
14. *Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh chhamahi Adhiveshan, Arambagh (29-30 April and 1-2 May 1963) Vivaran*, pp. 25-26.
15. *Ibid.*, p. 81.
16. *Ibid.*, pp. 27-29.
17. Talk at Calcutta, 20-6-1963.
18. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 8-11-1963.
19. *Bhoomi-kranti*, 2-9-1963, *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 23-8-1963.
20. Dharendra Majumdar, *Gramdan—shanka aur samadhan* (Hindi) (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1968), p. 30.
21. Vinoba, *Sulabh Gramdan* (Hindi) (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1968), p. 19.
22. Vinoba, *Toofan ka sanket* (Hindi) (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1965), p. 64.
23. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 16, pp. 199-200.
24. Vinoba, *Sulabh Gramdan*, p. 48.
25. *Gramdan movement: a handbook* (New Delhi: Planning Commission, Government of India, 1964), pp. 15-17.
26. *Ibid.*, p. 11.
27. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 10-1-1964.
28. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 28-2-1964.
29. *Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh Varshik Adhiveshan, Raipur*

(23-27 December 1963) *Vivaran* (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1964), p. 231.

30. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 12-6-1964.

31. *Sarvodaya Samayiki (2): Sampradayik Hinsa* (Hindi) (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1964), p. 32.

32. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 1-5-1964.

33. *Sarva Seva Sangh Traivarshik Ahawal 1963-1966* (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1966), p. 99, 102, 103.

34. A copy of the letter is with the author.

35. Recounted by Narendra Dube, *Govibha*, February 2005.

36. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 4-12-1964.

37. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 19-2-1965.

16. *Toofan*: Declaration of the Last Battle

1. *Sarva Seva Sangh traivarshiki Ahawal 1963-66*, p. 6.

2. Vinoba, *Toofan ka sanket*, p. 58.

3. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 6-8-1965.

4. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 10-9-1965.

5. *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 15, Editor's Note, p. 15.

6. *Ibid.*, p. 345.

7. Suresh Ram, *Toofan-yatra* (Varanasi: sarva Seva Sangh, 1966), p. 60.

8. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, p. 97.

9. Suresh Ram, *Toofan-yatra*, p. 64.

10. *Ibid.*, p. 141.

11. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, vol. 15, p. 362.

12. Suresh Ram, *Toofan-yatra*, p. 118-19.

13. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, vol. 15, p. 357.

14. Suresh Ram, *Toofan-yatra*, pp. 129-30.

15. *Ibid.*, p. 159.

16. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, p. 108.

17. Suresh Ram, *Toofan-yatra*, p. 176.

18. *Ibid.*, pp. 178-79.

19. Ibid, p. 181.
20. Ibid., p. 188.
21. Ibid., pp. 236-37.
22. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, p. 117.
23. Suresh Ram, *Toofan-yatra*, p. 281.
24. Sarva Seva Sangh Minutes Register.
25. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 13-5-1966.
26. *Vinoba Chintan* (1), February 1966, p. 17.
27. Sarva Seva Sangh Minutes Register.
28. Ghanashyam Shah in *Economic and Political Weekly*, 9-4-1977.
29. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 1-7-1966.
30. *Vinoba Chintan* (6), July 1966, pp. 14-15.
31. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, pp. 124-25.
32. This phrase had been used by him at the Constructive workers' conference in 1948.

17. Campaign for Bihar-dan

1. Suresh Ram, *Toofan-yatra*, p. 102.
2. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, pp. 126-27 and Suresh Ram, *Toofan ki pukar* (Patna: Sarvodaya Prakashan Samiti, 1968), pp. 93-95.
3. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 24-6-1966.
4. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 7-10-1966.
5. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, p. 129.
6. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 7-10-1966.
7. Suresh Ram, *Toofan ki pukar*, pp. 128-29.
8. Nirmal Chandra, *Jeevan ke zarokhe se Jayprakash ka prakash* (Hindi) (Sevagram: Jayprakash Amrut Kosh, 2002), pp. 76-78.
9. Saraladevi has written that Nirmal Ved's experiment to do relief work through gramsabhas at Sarguja in Madhya Pradesh was fairly successful, while Jayprakash's method of working led to suspicions, and therefore criticism. (Saraladevi, *Vyavaharik Vedant—ek atmakatha*, Gandhi Peace Foundation, New Delhi, 1976, pp. 225-26).
10. Daniel Thorner, *The shaping of modern India* (New Delhi:

Allied Publishers, 1980), p. 141.

11. Mahendra kumar and Balkrishna Joshi (Ed.), *Dadabhai—Ek Adaranjali* (Hindi) (Indore: Dadabhai Naik Abhinandan Samiti, 1991), pp. 40-41. Naik has, however, wrongly given the year of the incident as 1958.

12. Ahad Fatmi in *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 24-3-1967.

13. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 6-1-1967.

14. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 13-1-1967.

15. Ibid and Saraladevi, *Vyavaharik Vedant—ek atmakatha*, p. 211.

16. Sarva Seva Sangh Minutes Register.

17. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, p. 141.

18. Ibid., p. 140; *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 31-3-1967.

19. *Sarva Seva Sangh Shivarampalli Adhiveshan (1967) Karyavahi*, p. 11.

20. Ibid., p. 20.

21. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 15-12-1967.

22. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 11-8-1967.

23. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 28-7-1967.

24. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 25-8-1967.

25. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, p. 143.

26. Ibid.

27. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 29-3-1968.

28. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 30-1-1968. Sarvanarayandas has, however, given a different date.

29. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 5-4-1968.

30. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 21-6-1968.

18. Achievement of Target

1. *Sarva Seva Sangh Adhivashan, Abu Road (June 1968) Karyavahi*, p. 29.

2. Ibid., pp. 60-61.

3. Ibid., p. 69.

4. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 19-7-1968.

5. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, p. 154.

6. Sarva Seva Sangh Minutes Register.
7. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 15, p. 374.
8. Ibid., pp. 372-73.
9. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, pp. 158-59.
10. *Sarva Seva Sangh Tirupati Adhiveshan (1969) Karyavahi*, pp. 97-98.
11. Ibid., p. 78.
12. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 29-12-1969.
13. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 6-10-1969.
14. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, pp. 162-63.
15. Ibid., p. 164.
16. Sarva Seva Sangh Minutes Register.
17. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 20-10-1969.
18. *Sarva Seva Sangh Karya-Vivaran (May 1969-September 1969)*. Annexure 5.
19. Sarva Seva Sangh Minutes Register.
20. *Sarva Seva Sangh Rajgir Adhiveshan (1969) Karyavahi*, p. 36.
21. *Rajgir Sarvodaya Sammelan (1969) Vivaran*, p. 15.
22. Ibid., p. 25.
23. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 10-11-1969.
24. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 15, p. 381.
25. Ibid., p. 383.
26. *Sarvodaya Samaj* (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1971), p. 129.
27. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 12-7-1968.

19. *Pushti*: Endeavour for Consolidation

1. From the unpublished report of the meeting, a copy of which is with the author.
2. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 15-12-1969.
3. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 11-5-1970.
4. Jayprakash Narayan: *Aamne saamne* (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1997), p. 19.
5. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 15-6-1970.
6. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 6-7-1970.

7. Ibid.

8. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 6-7-1970.

9. Ramamoorti, *JP ki Virasat* (Hindi) (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1999), p. 28. Reference is to the incident in the epic 'Mahabharat' wherein the Pandavas, after losing their kingdom and even their persons to Kauravas in a game of dice, staked their wife Draupadi and lost her too. Dushshasan, younger brother of Kaurava prince Duryodhan, then forcibly brought her in the court and tried to disrobe her in the presence of elders, who remained silent. What Jayprakash meant was that rural India was in the vicious grip of local strongmen against whom nobody uttered a word.

10. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 6-7-1970.

11. Thakurdas Bang in *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 23-11-1970.

12. The fund of Rs. 10 million was collected by the Congress at Gandhi's initiative in 1920 after the death of Lokmanya Tilak.

13. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 19-10-1970.

14. Rationale behind this decision is difficult to understand; for major chunk had naturally been collected in big cities where the Movement neither had much presence, nor much work to do. The decision resulted in the Sarvodaya Mandals in the concerned states getting major portion. Bihar needed the money most, but got only Rs. 0.36 million and some Mandals got huge amounts and did not know how to utilise them! The work that had to be urgently taken up was delayed to collect money, which eventually was of little use to it.

15. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 19-10-1970.

16. Accounts in this regard vary. Sarvanarayandas writes that Mahendrabhai, a leading worker from the district, volunteered to accept responsibility and Vinoba blessed this resolve (Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, p. 171). This is also noted in *Maitri*, November 1993 which is an authentic source. Nirmal Chandra, however, writes that it was Vinoba's initiative, Mahendrabhai responded to his appeal and Bihar workers silently consented (Nirmal Chandra, *Jeevan ke jharokhe se...*), p. 82.

17. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 28-12-1970.

18. Ibid.

19. *Maitri*, November 1993, p. 17.

20. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 18-1-1971.

21. Sarva Seva Sangh Minutes Register.
22. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 1-3-1971.
23. Banarasidas Chaturvedi and others (Ed.), *Lok-kranti-patheya* (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1981), p. 107.
24. *Bhoodan-yajna*, 3-5-1971.
25. For a detailed discussion of the concept, see Banarasidas Chaturvedi and others (Ed.), *Lok-Kranti-Patheya*, pp. 41-46.
26. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 24-5-1971.
27. *Sarva Seva Sangh Nasik Adhiveshan (1971) Karyavahi*, pp. 47-48.
28. *Nasik Sarvodaya Sammelan (1971) Vivaran*, p.50.
29. *Ibid.*, pp 48-49.
30. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 5-7-1971.
31. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 8-11-1971.
32. *Sarva Seva Sangh Bhopal Adhiveshan (1971) Karyavahi*, p. 95.
33. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 8-11-1971.
34. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 15-11-1971.
35. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 29-5-1972.

20. Epilogue

1. Prabhash Joshi, Anupam Mishra and Sharavankumar Garg, *Chambal ki bandooken Gandhi ke charanon men* (New Delhi: Gandhi Peace Foundation, 1973), p. 29.
2. *Ibid.*, pp. 98-99.
3. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 19-6-1972.
4. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 4-6-1973.
5. Geoffrey Ostergaard, *Non-violent revolution in India* (New Delhi: Gandhi Peace Foundation, 1985), p. 41.
6. *Sarva Seva Sangh Adhiveshan (Nakodar, 16-18 May 1972) Karyavahi*, p. 57.
7. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 4-12-1972.
8. Kumar Prashant, *Shodh ki manzilen* (Sevagram: Jayaprakash Amrutkosh, 1992), p. 161.
9. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 19-3-1973.

10. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 2-4-1973.
11. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 19-2-1973.
12. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 21-5-1973.
13. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 26-3-1973.
14. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 1-10-1973.
15. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 15-10-1973.
16. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 1-10-1973.
17. Rammoorti, *JP ki virasat*, p. 34.
18. Ibid., p. 36.
19. Ibid, p. 180. For detailed account of this discussion, see pp. 179-215, and also Kusum Deshpande, *Vinoba: Antim Parva* (Pavnar: Paramdham Prakashan, 2010), pp. 52-81. The latter book is an authoritative source for understanding Vinoba's mind during his last years.
20. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, pp. 185-86.
21. Kusum Deshpande, *Vinoba: Antim Parva*, p. 94.

AN APPRAISAL

1. Distribution of Bhoodan Lands

1. *Sarvodaya*, December 1952, pp. 375-76.
2. Banarasidas Chaturvedi et al. (Ed.), *Lok-kranti Patheya*, pp. 92-93.
3. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 1-11-1957.
4. *Sarva Seva Sangh Arambagh Adhiveshan (1963) Karyavahi*, pp. 27-29.
5. Cited in Suresh Ram, *Toofan-yatra*, pp. 40-41.
6. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 21-11-1958.
7. Talk at Bargarh (Odisha), 11-11-1963.
8. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 8-11-1963.
9. Sarvanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, pp. 83-84.
10. See for example, Siddharaj Dhadha in *Kaladi Sarvodaya Sammelan (1957) vivaran*, p. 24 and Badriprasad Swamy in *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 22-4-1960.

11. K.R. Nanekar and S.V. Khandewale, *Vidarbhatil Bhoodan* (Nagpur: Nagpur Vidyapith, 1970), p. 94.
12. Talk at Tiruvadadar, 5-1-1957.
13. A.M. Khusro in V.B. Singh (Ed.), *Economic History of India, 1857-1956* (Allied Publishing House, 1965), p. 193.
14. *Kanchipuram sarvodaya Sammelan* (1956) *Vivaran*, p. 27.
15. *Sarvodaya*, August 1952, p. 33.
16. Banarasidas Chaturvedi et al. (Ed.), *Lok-kranti Patheya*, p. 35.
17. R.K. Patil in *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 17-7-1964.
18. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 22-9-1967.
19. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 22-4-1960.
20. D. Moondada, *Sant Vinoba ki Uttar Bharat Yatra*, pp. 274-75.
21. *Pandharpur Sarvodaya Sammelan* (1958) *Vivaran*, pp. 11-12.
22. K.R. Nanekar and S.V. Khandewale, *Vidarbhatil Bhoodan*, p. 85.
23. Information received from the Bihar Bhoodan Yajna Committee.
24. Information received from the Andhra Pradesh Bhoodan Yajna Board.
25. *Ek dukhant vivaran* (A tragic account) (Jaipur: Rajasthan Bhoodan-yajna Board) (A booklet published by the Rajasthan Bhoodan Yajna Board) gives detailed account of the whole affair which throws light on the state government's attitude towards bhoodan.
26. From a letter of Haryana Bhoodan-Yajna Board to Balvijay dated 30-9-1982.
27. Annual report of the Ministry of Rural Development. www.ruralgov.nic

2. Bhoodan in the Context of Land Reforms

1. *RNCA* 1976, p. 49.
2. *Ibid.*, p. 56.
3. V.M. Dandekar and N. Rath, *Poverty in India* (Bombay: Economic and Political Weekly, 1971), p. 60.
4. <http://planningcommission.nic.in/plans/1planch12>, accessed on 9-1-2001.
5. *Presidential address to the 15th annual conference of the Indian Society of Agricultural Economics* (1954), p. 222.

6. <http://planningcommission.nic.in/plans/1planch12>, accessed on 9-1-2001.
7. *RNCA 1976*, p. 27.
8. *Sarvodaya*, December 1952, p. 339.
9. Baidyanath Prasad Chaudhari in *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 22-12-1954.
10. *Samyayog*, 8-1-1960.
11. *RNCA 1976*, p. 72.
12. Sarva Seva Sangh Minutes Register.
13. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 25-11-1960.
14. Daniel Thorner, *The Agrarian Prospect in India* (New Delhi: Allied Publishing House, 1976), pp. 54-55, 66. The minister was Panjabrao Deshmukh and the party secretary was Shriman Narayan.
15. Ghanashyam Shah in *Economic and Political Weekly*, 9-4-1977, p. 607.
16. *RNCA*, 1976, p. 88.
17. Nirmal Chandra, *Jeevan ke zarokhe se Jayaprakash ka prakash*, p. 49.
18. *Ibid.*, p. 48.
17. Daniel Thorner, *The Shaping of Modern India*, p. 158.
20. Sugata Dasgupta, *A great society of small communities* (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1968), p. 38.
21. H. Venkatasubbiah, *Indian economy since Independence* (Bombay: Asia Publishing House, 1958), pp. 75-76.
22. P.S. Appu, *Land Reforms in India*, p. 155.
23. T.P. Singh, *Bhoodan and Gramdan in Orissa* (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1973), p. 127.
24. P.S. Appu, *Land Reforms in India*, p. 174.
25. *Ibid.*, p. 190.
26. K. Venkatasubramaniam, *Land reforms: an unfinished agenda*, <http://www.planningcommission.nic.in> accessed on 26-6-2016.
27. P.S. Appu, *Land Reforms in India*, p. 178.
28. www.ruralgov.nic for figures of ceiling-surplus lands. For sources of figures on bhoodan lands, see Annexure 1.
29. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 4, pp. 243-44.
30. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 6, pp. 132-33.

31. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol.16, p. 175.
32. Chester Bowles, *Ambassador's Report* (New York: Harper and Bros., 1954), p. 192.
33. *Sarvodaya*, March 1954, cover page 4.
34. K.R. Nanekar and S.V. Khandewale, *Vidarbhatil Bhoodan*, p. 104.
35. P.C. Joshi, *Land Reforms in India—Trends and Perspectives*, pp. 88-89.
36. *Presidential address to the 5th annual conference of the Indian Society of Agricultural Economics (1954)*, p. 230.
37. *Proceedings and papers of the seminar on land reform: A retrospect and prospect* (New Delhi: Planning Commission, Government of India, 1989), p.1.
38. Ibid., p. 3.
39. D. Bandyopadhyay, *Does land still matter?*, Economic and political weekly, Vol. 43, issue 10, 8-3-2008, p. 38.

3. Bhoodan-Yajna: an Evaluation

1. D.G. Tendulkar, *Mahatma*, Vol. 8 (New Delhi: Publications Division, Government of India, 1969), p. 284.
2. Jayaprakash Narayan in '*The Revolutionary Bhoodan*', pp. 12-13.
3. Jayaprakash Narayan, *Meri Vichar-yatra* (Ed. Kanti Shah) (Hindi) (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1974), p. 151.
4. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 19-6-1969.
5. Cited in R.P. Masani, *The Five Gifts* (London: Collins Paperbacks Ltd., 1957), p. 12.
6. D. Bandyopadhyay, *Does land still matter?*, Economic and political weekly, Vol. 43, issue 10, 8-3-2008.
7. Nirmala deshpande, *Vinobanchya Sahavasat*, p. 5.
8. C. Rajagopalachari in '*The Revolutionary Bhoodan*', pp. 37-38.
9. D. Bandyopadhyay, Chairman of Bihar land Reforms Commission (2007) has written in *Mainstream*, Vol. XLV, no. 30, 14-6-2007 (www.mainstreamweekly.net accessed on 5-6-2009) on what he calls 'Sordid tale of Hathua Raj', accusing the Hathua landlord of deliberately hiding the details of the gifted lands. Kumar Shubhamoorti,

Chairman of the Bihar Bhoodan-Yagna Committee, however, told the author that the landlord himself did not know the details and his descendants had, even after so many years, shown readiness to obtain and give details of which they themselves were unaware.

10. Babulal Gandhi, *Bharatatil Bhoomiheen ani Bhoodan*, pp. 130-33.

11. T.P. Singh, *Bhoodan and Gramdan in Orissa*, p. 50.

12. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 16, p. 148.

13. Ibid., p. 86.

14. J.B. Kripalani in 'The Revolutionary Bhoodan', pp. 19-20.

15. *Sarvodaya*, July 1953, pp. 782-83.

16. Vinoba, *Mohabbat ka paigam* (Abridged), p. 61.

17. Suresh Ram, *Sant Vinoba ki samyayogi sadhana* (Hindi) (Allahabad: Lokshakti Prakashan, 1971), p. 193.

18. See note 38, Chapter 5, Part 1.

19. Literally, setting in motion the wheel of *dharma*, or righteousness. The term is used in connection with the beginning of teaching by Lord Buddha after attainment of enlightenment.

20. *Sarvodaya*, August 1952, p. 5.

21. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 8 (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1962), p. 157.

22. See p. 27.

23. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 1, p. 205.

24. Chandil Sarvodaya Sammelan (1953) *Vivaran*, p. 53.

25. *Bhoodan as seen by the West*, p. 21.

26. Ramvruksha Benipuri, *Vinoba ke saath do din* (Hindi) (Patna: Bihar Bhoodan-prapti Samiti, 1954), p. 18.

27. 'Bhoodan as seen by the West' and P.D. Tandon (Ed.), *Vinoba Bhav: the man and his mission* (Bombay: Vora and Co.).

28. Daniel Hoffman, *India's social miracle* (Healdsburg, U.S.A.: Naturegraph Co.), p. 119.

29. Ibid., Introduction, p. 7.

30. Lanza Del Vasto, *Gandhi to Vinoba—a new pilgrimage* (London: Rider and Co. 1956), p. 201

31. Satish Kumar and E.P. Menon, *Bina paise duniya ka paidal*

safar, p. 82.

32. *Pandharpur Sarvodaya Sammelan (1958) vivaran*, p. 39.

33. *Ibid.*, p. 41.

34. Kaka Kalelkar, *Vinoba aur Sarvodaya Kranti* (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1970), p. 122.

35. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 7-2-1964.

36. Ramchandra Rahi told this at the seminar on gramdan at Gujarat Vidyapith, Ahmedabad in June 2008.

37. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 15, p. 93.

38. *Bhoodan-Yajna* (Marathi), 12-2-1953.

39. Vimala, *Bhoodan Deepika* (Hindi) (Abu: Vimal Prakashan Trust, 1991), pp. 20-21.

40. *Sarvodaya*, July 1952, Annexure, p. 24.

41. *Sarvodaya*, March 1954, pp. 481-82.

42. *Bhoodan-Yajna* (Marathi), 17-1-1957.

43. *Sarvodaya*, August 1953, p. 37.

44. *Presidential address to the 15th Annual Conference of the Indian Society of Agricultural Economics*, pp. 232-33.

45. *Ibid.*, p. 235.

46. *Bhoodan*, Vol. 1, No. 38, 2-1-1957, p. 6.

47. *Bhoodan*, Vol. 2, no. 41, 22-1-1958, p. 1.

48. *Sarvodaya*, July 1953, p. 790.

49. Savanarayandas, *Vinoba ka Vihar-parva*, pp. 31-32.

50. Babulal Gandhi, *Bharatatil Bhoomiheen ani Bhoodan*, p. 121.

51. K.R. Nanekar and S.V. Khandewale, *Vidarbhatil Bhoodan*, p. 52.

52. Kanti Shah, *Vinoba: jeevan aur karya* (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1979), p. 97.

53. K.R. Nanekar and S.V. Khandewale, *Vidarbhatil Bhoodan*, p. 52.

54. Babulal Gandhi, *Bharatatil Bhoomiheen ani Bhoodan*, p. 121.

55. Vinoba, *Bhoodan prashnottari* (Hindi) (Banaras: Uttar Pradeshia Bhoodan Samiti, 1954), p. 14.

56. P.S. Appu, *Land Reforms in India*, p. 188. B.S. Minhas has reached the same conclusion in *'Planning and the poor'* (New Delhi: S. Chand and Co., 1974), p. 118.

57. *Sarvodaya*, August 1953, pp. 31-32.
58. B.R. Misra, *V for Vinoba* (Calcutta: Orient Longmans, 1956), p. 34.
59. *Kaladi Sarvodaya Sammelan (1957) Vivaran*, pp. 182-83.
60. *Bodhgaya Sarvodaya Sammelan (1954) Vivaran, Annexure*, p. 104.
61. *Sarvodaya*, July 1954, p. 743.
62. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 19-6-1959.
63. *Sarvodaya*, November 1952, p. 303.
64. Cited in Kusum Deshpande, *Krantichya watewar*, Preface, p. 3.
65. *Kaladi Sarvodaya Sammelan (1957) Vivaran*, pp. 195-96.
66. Suresh Ram, *Sant Vinoba ki anandyatra*, p. 50.
67. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 16, p. 285.
68. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 3, pp. 267-68.
69. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 29-4-1966.
70. Hallam Tennyson, *Saint on the march* (London: Victor Gollanz Ltd., 1955), p. 83.
71. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 15, p. 67.
72. *Ibid.*, p. 90.
73. The village where Lord Krishna lived in his childhood. An ideal, self-sufficient village is likened to Gokul.
74. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 26-10-1970

4. Gramdan: Getting off the Ground

1. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 15-11-1963.
2. Talk at Gandhigram, 30-11-1956.
3. *Bhoodan*, Vol. II, no. 14, 17-7-1957, p. 6.
4. Suresh Ram, *Toofan-yatra*, p. 130.
5. *Ibid.*, p. 142.
6. Dharendra Majumdar, *Gramdan—shanka aur samadhan*, p. 135.
7. The account is based on Shrikrishnadutt Bhatt, *Chalo chale Mangaroth*. See pp. 44-45, 48, 54-56, 66 in particular.
8. *Ankho dekha haal* (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1971), pp. 43-53 and *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 1-10-1973.

9. *Bihar men gramdan andolan* (Patna: Bihar Sarvodaya Mandal, 1959), pp. 1-13; *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 27-2-1959; *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 17-3-1961; *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 17-8-1962.

10. Vasant Vyas, *Madhya Pradesh ka gramdan Mohazari* (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1966).

11. Harivallabh Parikh's '*Kranti ka arunadaya*' gives a lively account of the work done during 25 years. Here Vasant Vyas' '*Gujarat ke gramdan*' (Hindi) (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1967) has also been referred to.

12. '*Ankho dekha haal*'; Yadunath Thatte, *Akili ki kahani* (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1962); Suman Bang, *Uthali matituni mandire* (Pavnar: Paramdham Prakashan, 1969); '*Bihar men gramdan andolan*' and '*Gramdan nirdeshika*' (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1965) are some of the books that give accounts of this transformation.

13. *Bihar men gramkosh* (Jaipur: Kumarappa Gramswarajya sansthan, and New Delhi: Gandhi Peace Foundation, 1972).

14. *Ankho dekha haal*, pp. 30-33.

15. Ibid., pp. 82-86.

16. *Hathal* (Jaipur: Kumarappa Gram-swarajya Sansthan, 1968), p. 67.

17. Ibid., p. 56.

18. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 1-10-1973.

19. For the detailed account, see Avadh Prasad and Gopinath Gupta, *Rajasthan men gramdan* (An unpublished report from Kumarappa Gram-swarajya Sansthan).

20. *Bhoomi-kranti*, 1-5-1961.

21. Biswabandhu Chatterjee et al., *Gramdan and people* (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1969), p. 28.

22. Erica Linton, *Fragments of a Vision* (New Delhi: Prithviraj and Co., 1972), p. 79.

23. Ibid., p. 14.

24. Ibid., p. 129.

25. Vasant Vyas, *Andhra ke gramdan* (Hindi) (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1965), p. 48. Vyas' other books are: '*Tamil Nad ke gramdan*' (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1965), '*Gujarat ke gramdan*', '*Koraput ke gramdan*' (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1966) and '*Madhya Pradesh ka gramdan Mohazari*'.

26. Sachidanand, *Sarvodaya in a Communist state*, p. 162.

27. Ibid., p. 163.

28. T.K. Oommen, *Charisma, stability and change*, p. 35.

29. Ibid., p. 180. That Oommen did not even have his facts right can be seen from many of his statements. For example, he states that interim Congress government was set up in Hyderabad after merger with India in 1948 (p. 28), but the Congress government was formed in the state only after the elections in 1952.

30. J.S. Sharma, *Vinoba and Bhoodan: A selected descriptive bibliography* (New Delhi, Indian National Congress, 1956), p. 79.

31. Sachidanand, *Sarvodaya in a Communist state*, p. 168.

32. The account is mainly based on Annasaheb Sahasrabuddhe's '*Koraput men gramvikas ka prayog*' (Hindi) (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1961). Its English version had also been published under the title '*Report on Koraput gramdants*' (Sevagram: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1960).

33. T.P. Singh, *Bhoodan and Gramdan in Orissa*, pp. 10-11.

34. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 26-1-1970.

35. This was a pun on the surname of Annasaheb Sahasrabuddhe; 'Sahasrabuddhe' literally means 'having a thousand intellects'.

36. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 3-3-1967. However, only 5 out of 299 workers had higher salaries; so that was not really much of an issue.

37. Annasaheb Sahasrabuddhe, *Report on Koraput gramdants*, p. 21.

38. T.P. Singh, *Bhoodan and Gramdan in Orissa*, pp. 121-24.

39. The information is based on *Samyayog*, 15-7-1973, 15-8-1973, 20-12-1974 and 21-9-1980 and on the discussions with the villagers in these two villages.

40. Anil Agarwal and Sunita Narain, *Hirvya khedyancha desh* (Marathi) (Pune: Parisar Prakashan, 1992), pp. 29-30. For English quotation, article in the Action Framework B-2/1 has also been referred to.

41. *Ankho dekha haal*, Preface, p. 10.

5. The State, Politics and the Movement

1. Letter of Laxminarayan Bharatiya to Vinoba, dated 4-2-1952. The letter is with the author.

2. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 3, p. 122.

3. Mridula Sarabhai's letter to Vinoba. The letter is with the author.
4. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 1, p. 118.
5. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 30-12-1955, p. 6.
6. Cited in J.S. Sharma, *Vinoba and Bhoodan*, p. 38.
7. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 22-10-1965.
8. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 26-11-1965.
9. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 16, p. 97-98.
10. *Sarvodaya*, April 1950, pp. 131-32.
11. *Sarvodaya*, August 1951, pp. 845-47.
12. *Rajniti se Lokniti ki ore* (Wardha: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1957), p. 67.
13. Ibid., p. 99.
14. Sarva Seva Sangh Minutes Register.
15. *Unguturu Sarvodaya Sammelan (1961) Vivaran*, p. 111.
16. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 10-1-1964.
17. Sachidanand, *Sarvodaya in a Communist state*, p. 167.
18. G. Ostergaard and M. Currell, *The Gentle Anarchists*, p. 128.
19. Ibid., p. 235.
20. Ibid., p. 236.
21. Ibid., p. 238.
22. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vo. 15, p. 377.
23. Vinoba, *Swaraj and Lokniti*, pp. 59-60.
24. Vinoba, *Bhoodan-Ganga*, Vol. 4, p. 118.
25. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 27-2-1959.
26. A prominent Hindu religious fair, held periodically at some pilgrimage centres, wherein millions congregate to take a dip in the holy river.
27. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 16-12-1960.
28. The reference is to a mythological story. King Kansa, bent upon killing child Krishna, sent Pootana, a female demon. She came to Krishna's place as a young woman and offered to breastfeed him with the intention of killing him by her poisonous milk. Krishna, however, saw through her intention and sucked her hard, drawing her blood after the milk and thereby killed her.

29. *Bhoodan-yajna*, 9-2-1962.
30. Vasant Bombatkar, *Shidori* (Marathi) (Wardha: Vasant Bombatkar), p. 107.
31. Suresh Ram, *Toofan-yatra*, p. 83.

6. Leadership and Organisation

1. *Sevapuri Sarvodaya Sammelan (1952) Vivaran*, p. 54.
2. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 15-1-1965.
3. G. Ostergaard and Currell, *The Gentle Anarchists*, pp. 215-16.
4. Donald Groom, *With Vinoba* (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1969), pp. 49-50.
5. Kumar Prashant, *Shodh ki manzilen*, p. 147.
6. Sachidanand, *Sarvodaya in a Communist state*, p. 200.
7. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 16, p. 399.
8. Ibid., pp. 398-99.
9. Sachidanand, *Sarvodaya in a Communist state*, p. 200.
10. Dharendra Majumdar in Banarasidas Chaturvedi et al (ed.), *Lok-kranti-pathya*, p. 22.
11. *Vedchhi Sarvodaya Sammelan (1962) Vivaran*, p. 117.
12. *Ajmer Sarvodaya Sammelan (1959) Vivaran*, p. 179.
13. T.K. Oommen, *Charisma, stability and change*, p. 67.
14. Suresh Ram, *Sant Vinoba ki Anandyatra*, p. 71.
15. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 16, pp. 389-90.
16. For a detailed discussion, one may profitably refer to pp. 303-09 and pp. 383-90 in the abovementioned volume.
17. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 1-2-1971.
18. *Pandharpur Sarvodaya Sammelan (1958) Vivaran*, p. 173.
19. Sarvanarayandas' letter to Kanti Shah dated 21-2-2001. The author has a copy of this letter.
20. Vidyasagar's letter dated 27-5-2003 to the author.
21. Kameshwar Bahuguna's letter dated 12-6-2003 to the author.
22. G. Ostergaard and Currell, *The Gentle Anarchists*, p. 331.
23. Ibid., p. 118.
24. Ibid., p. 320.

7. Gramdan: Retrospect and Prospect

1. Foreword, T.P. Singh, *Bhoodan and Gramdan in Orissa*, p. 7.
2. Indian Journal of Agricultural Economics, Vol. 12, 1957, p. 1.
3. Ibid., p. 10.
4. Pyarelal, *The Last Phase*, Vol. 10, p. 770, 771, 774 accessed from www.mk gandhi.org on 18-8-2016.
5. Indian Journal of Agricultural Economics, Vol. 12, 1957, p. 10.
6. Sugata Dasgupta, *A great society of small communities*, p. 35.
7. Sarvanarayandas' letter to the author, dated 8-4-2001.
8. From a report reproduced in *Bhoodan*, Vol. II, no. 5, 15-5-1957, p. 6.
8. Sugata Dasgupta, *A great society of small communities*, p. 56.
10. Erica Linton, *Fragments of a Vision*, Preface, p. 2.
11. Vinoba, *Maharashtrat Vinoba*, Vol. 1, p. 38.
12. See for example, Siddharaj Dhaddha's speech, *Sarva Seva Sangh Rajgir adhiveshan (1969) karyavahi*, pp. 31-32. We find two articles questioning chemical inputs, way back in 1955 in the journal 'Sarvodaya' (January 1955), even before the appearance of the 'Green Revolution'.
13. From the report of discussions in the meeting. The unpublished report is with the author.
14. Jhaverbhai Patel in *Sarvodaya*, September 1949, p. 101.
15. See, for example, Annasaheb Sahasrabuddhe in *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 1-6-1962. The celebrated 'Chipko' movement was organised and led by Sarvodaya workers. Demonstration of veracity of this contention is provided by a gramdan village, Seed, which is well documented. See for example, Anil Agarwal and Sunita Narain, *Towards Green Villages*.
16. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 15, pp. 502-03.
17. *Balia Sarvodaya Sammelan (1966) Vivaran*, pp. 72-73.
18. *Sadhana*, 12-4-1980, p. 30.
19. Jayaprakash Narayan, *Prison Diary* (Bombay: Popular Prakashan, 1977), pp. 21-22. This factor ultimately led to a search for alternative strategy, a strategy involving struggle.
20. Ibid., p. 22.
21. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 16, p. 230.

22. Sarva Seva Sangh Minutes Register.
23. In Banarasidas Chaturvedi (Ed.), *Lok-kranti Patheya*, pp. 54-56.
24. A.V. Sahasrabuddhe, *Report on Koraput gramdams*, p. 16.
25. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 8-7-1960.
26. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 29-10-1965.
27. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 18-2-1966.
28. For example: Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 16, p. 242.
29. *Pandharpur Sarvodaya Sammelan (1958) Vivaran*, pp. 40-41.
30. Erica Linton, *Fragments of a vision*, p. 258.
31. *Ibid.*, p. 254.
32. *Bhoodan-Yajna*, 5-4-1971.
33. In the chapter on agriculture, p. 44.
34. *Bhoomi-kranti*, 23-12-1963.
35. T.K. Oommen, *Charisma, stability and change*, p. 82.
36. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 16, pp. 211-12.
37. Vinoba, *Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 15, p. 451.
38. Kanti Shah, *Bhoodan-Yajna ka lekha-jokha* (Unpublished paper presented at Pavnar, 15-11-2001), p. 9.
39. During a discussion on 'Hind-swaraj' in 1982. Nageshwar Prasad (Ed.), *Hind swaraj: a fresh look* (New Delhi: Gandhi Peace Foundation, 1985), p. 246.
40. *Nakodar Sarvodaya Sammelan (1972) Vivaran*, p. 35.
41. *Bhoodan*, 13-11-1957, pp. 6-7. The article is reproduced from *Manchester Guardian*, 31-10-1957.
42. Sugata Dasgupta, *A great society of small communities*, p. 39.
43. Jayaprakash Narayan, *Meri Vicharyatra*, p. 127.
44. Kanti Shah, *Vinoba: Jeevan aur Karya*, p. 149.
45. Cited by Kanti Shah. *Vinoba, Vinoba Sahitya*, Vol. 15, Preface, p. 19

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